Dragon Raja II

The Mourner's Eyes

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English Translation Working Draft

This working draft contains the prologue and Acts One through Seven. The remainder of this volume is in progress.

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Prologue

Darkness in the Torrent of Rain

A Dark Rainy Night

But Chu Zihang did not want to forget, because he was the only person in the world who still remembered that man. If he forgot too, it would be as though the man had never existed.

The man had once said that if he died one day, only one thing in the world could prove he had existed: Chu Zihang, who carried half his blood.

Chu Zihang stood at the window in a daze.

Rain rattled against the glass. The playing field was a blur of white.

The afternoon had been bright and sunny, but as the dismissal bell rang, leaden clouds swept in from the southeast and the sky darkened within minutes. Then thunder exploded, and millions upon millions of tons of water fell on the earth as though a reservoir in the sky had opened its gates.

Tire tracks crisscrossed the soccer field, its turf churned to pieces. Private cars were normally forbidden on campus, but in such terrible weather the parents worried about their children getting wet. Several forced the iron gates open, and all the cars swarmed inside. Half an hour ago the field had been as crowded as a market: cars parked every which way, hazard lights flashing a confusion of yellow, everyone leaning on their horns and shouting their children's names. In the downpour, students unable to find their families' cars wandered around like headless flies.

Now everyone had been collected. The classrooms and playing field were empty, and the sky-blue flag of Shilan High School fluttered wildly in the storm.

Like the dispersal of a crowd when the music ends.

He was alone in the classroom, beneath pale lights, while outside was as dark as midnight. On a day like this, people should go home early.

He took out his phone, dialed, switched on the speaker, and set it on the desk, watching it in silence.

After several rings, the call connected. "Zihang, it's raining where you are too, isn't it? Oh, Mom's shopping at Jiuguang Department Store with her friends. It's pouring here, and we can't get a cab. We're having coffee and waiting for the rain to let up. Get yourself a taxi home, or call your dad and ask him to send a car. Be good, Zihang. Mommy sends you a kiss." A crisp kissing sound came through the phone, and she hung up.

Chu Zihang put away his phone. He hadn't said a single word, nor had he planned to. He had called only to let his mother know he was all right, so she wouldn't worry and could keep enjoying herself.

Adults could be foolish sometimes. When a child reached out to comfort one, she thought he was asking for food.

There were no taxis outside. In rain this heavy, drivers didn't want the business and had gone home early. If there were no cars at Jiuguang, it was the same at school, but his mother wouldn't think of that. His grandmother said his mother was an innocent little girl, without a care in the world. Chu Zihang

didn't want to call "Dad" either. "Dad" was a very busy man who wouldn't remember the small matter of sending a car for his stepson on a rainy day. But if reminded, he would certainly send a driver. "Dad" was a fine, responsible, well-mannered man who loved his beautiful wife, a former dancer, and treated her son well for her sake. He often said, "Zihang, if you need anything, just say so. I'm your father, and I'll fulfill my responsibilities to you."

Having a wealthy "Dad" who wanted to fulfill his responsibilities sounded rather good.

But Chu Zihang didn't think he needed it.

The classroom door stood open. Cold wind and fine rain blew in, chilling him to the bone. Chu Zihang pulled his jacket tighter, stuck his hands in his pockets, and resumed staring into space.

"Chu Zihang? Let's go together. The rain won't stop—the forecast says it's a typhoon, and the weather bureau issued a warning!" A girl peeked in. Her long hair fell clean and straight, with a silver Hello Kitty clip at the end. Her delicate face was slightly flushed, and she lowered her eyes, too shy to meet his gaze.

"You don't know me? I'm Liu Miaomiao..." Receiving no answer, her voice grew softer and softer, like a mosquito's hum.

Actually, Chu Zihang did know Liu Miaomiao. A year below him, she was famous at Shilan High. She had passed the tenth-grade piano examination in her second year of middle school and played a solo at every annual celebration. Several boys in his class competed for her attention in secret; he could hardly have avoided knowing who she was.

"I'm on cleaning duty today. I'll leave in a while." Chu Zihang nodded politely.

"Oh... then I'll go first." Liu Miaomiao spoke softly and withdrew her head.

Through the window, Chu Zihang watched her family's driver open an enormous black umbrella over her. She took off her strappy sandals, and the driver crouched to help her into rain boots. Sheltering under the umbrella, she picked her way toward a black BMW whose "angel eye" headlights shone through the rain.

"Hey! Liu Miaomiao! Give me a ride!" a younger boy shouted from under the eaves.

"Walk, Lu Mingfei! My house isn't in the same direction as yours!" Liu Miaomiao didn't turn around.

Actually, Chu Zihang's home wasn't in the same direction as Liu Miaomiao's either. His was in Peacock Residence in the east of the city, hers in California Sunshine in the west, opposite directions altogether. Yet she had offered him a ride.

The younger boy squatted under the eaves and watched the BMW glide silently into the rain. Its taillights flashed, its engine roared, and it was gone. He stood, head drooping to one side, and walked slowly along the eaves. Watching his retreating figure, Chu Zihang suddenly thought he might give him a ride. But the boy ducked his head, wrapped his coat over it, and darted into the rain like a stray dog. He ran so fast that before Chu Zihang could call out, he had splashed away into the distance.

Zigzag lightning flickered in the clouds, and thunder burst overhead. The rain grew heavier. Liu Miaomiao was right: this was no ordinary rain, but a typhoon. Suddenly Chu Zihang very much wanted someone to pick him up. Otherwise he would have to splash through the cold rain like that younger boy. He took out his phone and typed: "It's raining hard. Can you come pick me up?" He read it over silently, made sure the tone was right, and sent it.

For the next several dozen seconds he counted his heartbeats. Thump-thump... thump-thump... thump-thump...

"Sure, sure, no problem! Wait at school. I'll be there in a bit!" The reply came. That person always sounded so cheerful.

Chu Zihang deleted both messages; it would be awkward if "Dad" saw them. He picked up the bucket at his feet and threw all the water onto the blackboard. Water streamed down as he seized an eraser and scrubbed hard.

On his third pass, a low horn sounded outside. He turned. Through the rain, xenon headlights cast two dazzling beams that made him squint.

It was a pure black sedan. In a triangular frame on its hood, two overlapping M's formed a mountain. A Maybach 62.

Maybach was Mercedes-Benz's top marque, apparently several times more expensive than "Dad's" Mercedes S500. Chu Zihang wasn't much interested in cars. The man inside had boasted all this to him.

The wipers swung back and forth like a deranged metronome, clearing layer after layer of rain from the windshield. The middle-aged man inside waved to Chu Zihang, his face blooming with a smile. Chu Zihang couldn't understand why he always looked so happy, as if nothing ever troubled him. Shouldering the Hermès bag "Dad" had bought him in London, Chu Zihang locked the classroom, checked the door, and walked to the edge of the eaves. He hesitated a moment before the downpour. The man hurried out, opened a huge black umbrella, and came to meet him, as attentive as Liu Miaomiao's driver. Chu Zihang didn't look at him. He pushed the umbrella aside, walked through the rain to the car, opened the rear door himself, and climbed in.

His attempt at ingratiation unanswered, the man paused, then climbed back into the driver's seat. He closed the umbrella and passed it to Chu Zihang in the back. "Stick it in the door. There's a hole just for umbrellas."

"I know. You told me." Chu Zihang put it away and turned to the window. "Let's go."

"Your clothes are wet, right? Want me to turn on the rear-seat heating? Once you try it, you'll know—comfortable as hell!" The man began boasting about his car again.

"No need. I'll change at home."

"Oh, okay." The man cleared his throat and spoke to the center console. "Start!"

The screen lit up, a cold blue light flashed across the dashboard, and the savage 5.5-liter turbocharged V12 began its self-check. Not a vibration could be felt inside; even the engine's deep growl was shut out.

"A nine-million-yuan car, no key. Only three voices in the world can start it: mine, my boss's, and guess whose?" The man looked immensely pleased.

"Not interested." Chu Zihang's face was expressionless.

Again the man's warmth met a cold shoulder, but he wasn't discouraged. He shifted and accelerated briskly. The Maybach roared forward, sweeping in a great arc across the field and cutting through the rain like a blade as it drove through Shilan High's gate. The guard stood ramrod straight in his booth, chest and belly thrust out in respect for the luxury car and the wealth it represented.

Chu Zihang couldn't see what there was to respect. On a rainy day like this, all you needed was a car to pick you up and someone who remembered to come. Whether it was a Maybach, a Mercedes S500, or a QQ made no difference.

"Such heavy rain, and your mother didn't think to pick you up."

"Lucky I didn't get the car washed this morning. An eighty-yuan touchless wash would have been money down the drain."

"That guard at your school wouldn't let me drive in. I told him I was picking up my son, and he'd get soaked in rain like this if I couldn't go in. Took no end of arguing. Finally I told him this car cost nine million, and nobody stops me driving into city hall, so why should Shilan High be so damned strict? He backed down right away. Ha ha!"

The man chattered on as he handled the wheel with a flourish.

Chu Zihang hadn't answered him once since getting in. He turned on the radio; the announcer's voice gave him more peace than the man's.

"We now bring you an emergency typhoon warning and traffic update. According to the municipal weather station, Typhoon Dandelion, number 0407 this year, made landfall on the city's southeastern coast this afternoon. Heavy rain and force-ten winds are expected. All organizations should take precautions. Due to the intense rainfall, provincial and national highways through the city will close in two hours. Winds are high on the elevated roads and visibility is below thirty meters. Drivers still on the road should take alternative routes."

He looked out. Visibility really was terrible: beyond fifty meters everything dissolved into a white haze. The raindrops were so dense they seemed to smash one another apart in the air, falling as a spray of foam. The sky was black as ink; occasional bolts of lightning struck straight down. Few cars remained, all creeping carefully with headlights on. When two met, their drivers sounded their horns hard, like beasts encountering each other in a forest, baring their teeth and growling a warning.

Traffic slowed to a crawl, one car feeling its way behind another. Horns shrilled ahead like boiling kettles, and countless red brake lights pierced the rain. There seemed to be a jam.

"You want my V12 to crawl like a turtle?" the man muttered. He swung the wheel and forced his way into the emergency lane.

It was a beautiful cut, like a sharp blade slicing through water, severing the stream of traffic behind them. The driver of an Audi braked hard, locked wheels skidding across the road. Without braking, the Audi would have hit the Maybach from behind, and the Audi driver would have been entirely responsible. Repairing the Maybach would cost as much as an Audi. The braking opened a one-second gap in the traffic, and the man squeezed into it.

"Do you know how to fucking drive? Rushing to a funeral?"

The man winked proudly at Chu Zihang, ignoring the Audi driver's shouted curses. The luxury car, more than six meters long, was like an iron catfish in his hands, flicking its tail at just the right moment and swimming freely through traffic. Who knew how many drivers rolled down their windows and cursed after he overtook them? A chorus of sharp horns followed. But there was little they could do: the car overtaking them was an ultraluxury vehicle with sports-car performance, and its driver was clearly skilled.

The man grinned broadly.

Chu Zihang couldn't see what he was so happy about. Would it kill him to follow the traffic slowly? He simply had to show off his car and his tricks. He was a professional driver; of course he should be good at driving.

"Damn it, we're really stuck!" the man swore.

Two cars had scraped each other ahead. Their drivers stood under umbrellas, spitting as they shouted. In weather like this, traffic police couldn't arrive quickly, and each blamed the other. Dozens of cars were blocked. Several drivers got out and told the arguing men to move their vehicles, only for another argument to break out, with pushing and shoving. Everyone else pressed their horns impatiently.

Chu Zihang wanted to cover his ears. What a mess. The whole world was a mess.

"Are they idiots? What's there to argue about over two lousy little cars? Insurance pays anyway," the man grumbled. "I've got things to do after I drop off my son..."

He craned his neck and looked around, his gaze settling on a branch road in the rain. An entrance to the elevated highway, just a step away; its sign was hidden among a willow's wildly thrashing branches. It was odd. The trapped cars should have poured onto an empty road, yet not a soul was there. Something stirred in Chu Zihang, a strange feeling that only they could see the road, or else everyone else knew it was impassable. His biology teacher had said animals had an instinct for finding their way: wild camels in the desert knew which paths were wrong and had no springs, and wouldn't take them even if driven.

"That road should lead up to the elevated highway, though it's probably closed now," the man said, even as he pointed the car straight toward it.

Closer up, the sign read "Elevated Highway Entrance..." followed by its number. Chu Zihang looked, but a sheet of rain burst against the windshield at that moment, and he couldn't make it out.

The Maybach climbed the ramp. The elevated road stretched ahead like a gray rainbow, disappearing into the white rain.

"What if it really is closed and we can't get down?" Chu Zihang asked.

"If we can get up, we can get down." The man wasn't worried. "At worst I'll offer the cop at the exit a cigarette."

"The radio said the wind's strong and visibility's poor up here. It told drivers to take another route." Chu Zihang was uneasy. He didn't know how fast the wind outside was blowing, but it shrieked like a whistle.

"It's fine." The man patted the wheel. "What's a little wind? Tiny cars have to worry about that. Know how much a Maybach 62 weighs? Two point seven tons! Even a force-twelve wind can't budge it! Your dad's driving and this car together are rock solid. Relax!"

The Maybach sped along the empty elevated road, throwing up sprays of water as tall as a person. The man turned on the stereo without asking and played "Daily Growing" by the Irish band Altan:

The trees they grow high, the leaves they do grow green,

Many is the time my true love I've seen,

Many an hour I have watched him all alone,

He's young but he's daily growing.

Father, dear father, you've done me great wrong,

You have married me to a boy who is too young,

I am twice twelve and he is but fourteen,

He's young but he's daily growing.

"Good, isn't it? Everyone said it was a great disc, so I bought it. It's about a father's love!" the man said.

Chu Zihang didn't know whether to laugh or cry. "Can't you hear? It's a conversation between a girl and her father, not a boy. It's not appropriate for me."

"Boy or girl, what's the difference? It's a father's love either way." The man waved it off. "You understand it? I hear your English is top-notch at school, that you won a competition... But your mother never told me. What's the song about?"

"A father marries his twenty-four-year-old daughter to a rich fourteen-year-old boy. She doesn't want to; she worries she'll be old by the time her husband grows up. But her father says his arrangement is right. He's married her to a wealthy young man, so she'll have someone to rely on when he's old," Chu Zihang said. "Later the boy dies before he grows up. The girl grieves terribly and weaves him a flannel shroud in a green graveyard."

"What the hell kind of song is that? No fun at all. The girl's husband dies before he even does anything?" The man really was not a sensitive creature. Chu Zihang had known since childhood that his biological father was as rough as they came.

"Let's just have a chat, father and son." The man turned off the stereo. "Did I tell you about our company's new building? The boss put in a steam room and gym, free for us to use. Everything in there is so damn fancy..."

The man had failed in life because he talked too much... yet if he hadn't talked so much, he might have failed even worse, Chu Zihang thought.

His gift of gab was how he had charmed Mom until she married beneath her. Everyone at Shilan High agreed Chu Zihang was handsome enough to live off his looks, thanks to his mother's genes. In her youth she had been the star of the city dance troupe, dancing Silk Road Flower Rain like a flying apsara from a mural, with suitors as numerous as fish crossing a river. Somehow this man had fought his way through the field. Every day he drove to the troupe's gate to pick her up after work, using nothing but his mouth to weave a beautiful future and charm her senseless. On a drive to Hangzhou she had absentmindedly agreed to marry beneath her, and on that same trip had conceived Chu Zihang. Only after pressing her fingerprints onto the marriage certificate did she learn the car wasn't his: he was a driver for his work unit.

His politics teacher was right: the economic base determines the superstructure. A man like that couldn't support the superstructure of a beautiful wife. His mother had always been absentminded and wasn't greedy; the man was simply too hopeless.

And so, snap, it fell apart.

At the divorce, the man thumped his chest and promised his former wife he would earn money every month to support her and their son, show her he could make something of himself, and come back to propose once he had succeeded. Full of grand ambition, he promptly quit his stable job at the state enterprise to find more profitable work. After hanging around the labor market for three or four

months without a single offer, he finally realized all he knew was driving. Shamefaced, he found a driving job at a private company. The boss of the Black Prince Group liked his gift of gab and put him behind the wheel of the Maybach. A driver needed to talk smoothly, so the boss could leave him to boast about things the boss couldn't conveniently boast about himself.

The car was better than before, but his pay had hardly changed. After his own expenses, he couldn't even support a cat.

Fortunately, Chu Zihang's beautiful mother finally did something for herself. She had no intention of waiting for him. After several tearful days, she left Chu Zihang at his grandmother's, bought new cosmetics, put on alluring makeup, and went barhopping with her friends. In less than a month, she brought Chu Zihang a new dad. Having learned from experience, she chose carefully this time: a man one in a thousand. "Dad" owned three companies, was divorced once, and had no children. When he proposed, he swore he would never have children of his own and would raise Chu Zihang as his son.

With a rich dad and beautiful mom, talented and capable himself, Chu Zihang seemed exceptionally fortunate to his classmates. They had no idea his private life was far more exceptional than they imagined. But he couldn't take credit for it; his biological parents were the exceptional ones.

"Want to watch a DVD? I've got Shrek 2, though it's a bootleg filmed in a theater." The man stopped chattering, perhaps embarrassed at getting no response.

"No." Chu Zihang hesitated. "The three of us are going to see it this weekend."

The three meant Chu Zihang and his rich dad and beautiful mom. The man had nothing to do with it.

That was "Dad's" rule. Busy with work, "Dad" gave his clients every meal from breakfast to late-night snacks. But after one divorce, he had recognized the importance of family, so he permanently marked one weekend day on his schedule for them. Their usual activities were shopping, a movie, and a lavish dinner, followed by a discussion of Chu Zihang's studies. "Dad" followed his schedule strictly: never one day less or one day more of family time, just as he appeared in the company's main conference room at nine every Monday, rain or shine, for the weekly meeting with senior executives.

How did a stepson with a face that rarely smiled deserve the same treatment as executives earning a million a year? It was all thanks to Mom.

"Is the air warm enough in back?" the man asked again.

"Enough. Stop talking like a chauffeur!" Chu Zihang was irritated.

You're my father! Do you understand? he wanted to ask the man. Do you?

Under the visitation agreement you only get one day a month, and even then you're often too busy. Even when you come, what can you say to me while you sit in someone else's house? Actually, of course, you can talk plenty: you sit on the horsehair sofa "Dad" bought for 170,000 yuan and praise how fancy it is! Why did I ask you to pick me up? Because no one else would? Because if you picked me up, we could talk! If you can't say anything profound, just ask plainly, casually, how I've been, whether I'm happy... Don't hold an umbrella over me, so attentive. I don't care about that. Do you want to kneel and change my rain boots like Liu Miaomiao's driver? I don't need a chauffeur. We already have one at home... You're my father. Do you understand?

"What's shameful about being my son's chauffeur?" The man shrugged. His skin was as thick as a city wall, or his nerves slower than a turtle's. "When you were little, you rode me like a horse."

Something in Chu Zihang's heart twitched, as though it had cracked and released bitter water. He was tired and didn't want to speak. He leaned back against the leather seat and stared out the window.

He always said things that hurt so calmly... Couldn't he stop bringing them up?

Many years ago... in that shabby little room of barely a dozen square meters, the man crawled around while a boy rode on his shoulders shouting "Giddyap!" and a beautiful woman fussed over the gas stove... The images flickered in his mind like a film played by a battered hand-cranked projector.

The sky slowly darkened and the streetlights came on. Through the layers of rain, their light was as faint as fireflies.

"How's your mother lately?" the man asked, breaking the silence.

"Same as before. She gets up in the morning and plays with the cat, shops in the afternoon, and goes drinking with her friends at night. When they're having fun they come back together and talk until late, then sleep until noon. Anyway..." Chu Zihang hesitated. "Dad is always out entertaining clients and has no time for her. He thinks it's good that she amuses herself."

The words were a little hurtful. A down-on-his-luck man asked after the woman he had once loved, and she was happy, having forgotten him altogether.

Grandma said Mom had been a carefree girl since childhood, but being carefree and beautiful meant she could live well. Mom had long since put her unhappiness behind her. She regarded "Dad" as her first husband: married happily in their youth, with an outstanding son like Chu Zihang. In Chinese, perfect; in English, perfect.

People had to accept reality. The man's image had been erased from the limited memory in Mom's head.

Calling another man "Dad" in front of him was not easy for Chu Zihang either. A moment ago he had tactfully said "the three of us." But once the word was out, it wasn't so awkward. He had promised "Dad" to call him Dad, not Uncle, Four-Eyes, or Side Parting... even though in Chu Zihang's mind "Dad" was a four-eyed fellow with a side part, or a side-parted fellow with glasses. But Chu Zihang was stubborn about keeping promises, whether people were watching or not.

After all these years, surely the man was used to it. He hadn't tried hard to win custody of his son back then, anyway.

"Take good care of your mother," the man said.

In the rearview mirror, his still handsome but somewhat aging face showed little expression.

"Mm. Like you said, I make sure she drinks milk before bed. If she's talking with her friends, I warm it and bring it to her."

It was the only thing the man had asked Chu Zihang to do. Strange: he had lost the woman, yet still remembered a cup of milk. Since childhood Mom had needed a glass of warm milk with half a spoonful of sugar every night, so she wouldn't wake repeatedly. By now she had probably forgotten that years ago the man had warmed it for her. Before him, Grandma had done it; after him, her son did.

A fortunate woman always had someone to warm her milk.

"Shilan High is damn impressive! Seventeen students got into Tsinghua and Peking University this year. Work hard, son! Don't disgrace me!" The man made a show of concern for Chu Zihang's studies.

"Dad says I'm not taking the domestic entrance exam. I'm going abroad for college. I'm taking the TOEFL next month," Chu Zihang replied coldly.

Disgrace him? When had he ever really cared? He only ever talked.

Last year a coproduced movie had filmed locally, and Chu Zihang had been chosen as an extra. Hearing about it, the man had sworn he would visit the set.

"My son's making a movie! I'll bring tea and water. If I drive this car there, I'll look spectacular, won't I?" He patted the wheel, beaming.

So during breaks Chu Zihang kept looking, consciously or not, toward the parking lot. The spectacular Maybach never appeared. But "Dad's" Mercedes S500 was always there, with the driver, Old Shun, wearing huge dark glasses and a neck thicker than a man's head, looking every bit a bodyguard. He called Chu Zihang "young master" in front of everyone and behind their backs, making people stare.

And then there was that disastrous middle-school entrance ceremony. It fell on "Dad" and Mom's wedding anniversary, when they were going on vacation to northern Europe. After much thought, Chu Zihang called the man and asked him to come. The man was happy but hesitant: what about your mother and stepfather? After a long silence Chu Zihang said, just say you're my uncle. The man didn't feel slighted at all. He chuckled and said, then remember to call me Uncle; don't let it slip... In the end Chu Zihang was the only student with no parent standing behind him at the ceremony. He stood in the most prominent place, first in line, as the principal awarded him the new-student scholarship. He ranked first among Shilan's incoming class and had wanted to surprise the man.

"Oh, I really didn't forget, but that day the boss suddenly said an important client was coming and wanted a bath, so I had to drive them there. Who knew they'd bathe until the next morning..." Later the man scratched his head and mumbled his explanation.

Chu Zihang had a vague idea what sort of person the man's "boss" was, and what sort of place he meant by "a bath."

A classmate had told Chu Zihang, "I saw your Maybach parked outside a bathhouse last time," then lowered his voice. "Isn't that a place where people do bad things?"

Obviously. At the entrance, decorated like a Roman palace, seven or eight heavily made-up hostesses wore skirts almost short enough to reach their waists and necklines nearly low enough to fall below their breasts. Men of every kind climbed out of luxury cars and marched in, bellies thrust forward. Chu Zihang had passed once and glanced from a distance, imagining the man's boss and clients reveling inside at night while the man leaned against his beloved Maybach, smoking, the smoke spreading into the dark.

Chu Zihang didn't blame him much. The man was simply who he was and lived the life he lived, very far removed from Chu Zihang's.

"Going abroad isn't good," the man mumbled. "It's not fashionable anymore. China's developing so fast; opportunities are everywhere. If you ask me, go to college here, study finance, and have your stepdad use his connections to find you a job..."

It was as though a needle pierced Chu Zihang's chest. He shuddered with pain. "Have your stepdad use his connections"... Couldn't a person have some dignity? Did he have to be so shameless?

"Shut up!" Chu Zihang growled.

"What?" The man hadn't heard clearly.

"Shut up." Chu Zihang was like a young lion with its fur on end.

"What a rude child. I'm doing this for your own good." The man stared. "You should listen to adults..."

"Is listening to you any use? If I listen to you, will I find a girl and marry her without getting divorced? Will I make it to my son's graduation on time? Will I pick him up and drop him off at school on time? If I listen to you, all I'll do is ask my stepfather to use his connections!" Chu Zihang stared into the man's eyes in the rearview mirror, hoping to see disappointment or anger.

Every word struck at the heart.

Many people thought Chu Zihang couldn't even swear, much less speak with cutting bitterness. Even when fouled on the basketball court he never lost his temper, only raised a hand for the referee. But who couldn't say cruel things, when anger lay buried like needles in the heart? Now he was furious and wanted to stab the man hard with those needles. The words came out without thought.

"You're still young. Family matters... you'll understand when you're older." The man was clearly at a loss. He reached out as if to pat Chu Zihang in the back seat, but didn't dare; he drew his hand back and scratched his head.

It was always the same answer: "You'll understand later," "You're too young," "It's not what you think." Bullshit! When those two fools divorced, Chu Zihang had been small. He had cried as though the world were ending, and the man comforted him with "It's not what you think," "Mom and Dad just won't live together," "I'll still take you out on Sundays." Chu Zihang believed him; he believed home was still the three of them. Then he followed Mom into their new house and saw a gentleman with side-parted hair, a bathrobe, and two hairy legs politely open the door. Not knowing who this stranger was, Chu Zihang was so shocked that he shoved his ice cream into the man's face.

All these years later, the little kid had grown up, and they were still lying? To hell with that!

"Enough! Just drive, and stay out of my business! When we get home, don't come in. 'Dad' might be unhappy!" Chu Zihang clenched his teeth and turned away.

"What kind of thing is that to say? I'm your real father. If he's unhappy, let him be unhappy. Who the hell is he..." At last the man sounded wounded in his pride.

"He isn't my real father, but he comes to parent-teacher meetings. He takes me to amusement parks on weekends. He knows my final grades. At least he buys me a schoolbag for my birthday!" Chu Zihang slammed the Hermès bag against the seat. "Do you even remember my birthday?"

"Of course I remember!" the man protested, red-faced. "You're my son. Your mom and I made you together... As soon as we heard she was pregnant, we counted the days, when you were conceived and when you were due, waiting eagerly. You little rascal wouldn't come out; you stayed two months extra! How could I forget? Haven't you had health class? Men deserve credit for making babies too. Aren't you smart because I made you well?"

Chu Zihang was so angry he nearly laughed. How could any man be so shameless?

"Was it hard? Marrying a beautiful woman and having her give birth... was that such an achievement?" His voice shook. "I've had health class! The woman carries the baby for ten difficult months. What does the man do? What was hard for you?"

The man wilted, his voice sinking. "I'm not discussing health class with my son..."

"Was it hard after I was born? Did you ever look after me? Why exactly are you my 'real father'? Just because you and Mom 'made me together'? As though you manufactured some product? Tell me what 'real father' actually means." Chu Zihang's mood was as bad as it could get, and the anger he had suppressed flared again.

"A real father means... you... carry my blood." The man chose his words carefully. "You're my legacy in this world, don't you understand? You're half of me... I know I haven't looked after you much these years, and I'm sorry, but what father doesn't care about his child? Our blood connects us, we..."

"Live and prosper together, too!" Chu Zihang sneered.

The man fell silent, and so did Chu Zihang. Only thousands upon thousands of raindrops drummed heavily on the roof. The air inside seemed to grow much colder all at once, beyond the reach of the heater.

After a long time the man sighed slowly, sounding like he was repeating an old saying. "That's why I say you're young. You don't understand. When you have a child of your own, you'll see. Having a child is like giving half of yourself to that child. It's as if you can sense where he is, like telepathy. You'll always care about him and think about him. It comes naturally, for no reason at all. Besides, everyone dies. When I die, everyone else will forget me, but you'll still be in this world, and half of you is me. It's as though I've left something behind."

"You only know how to make a child, not raise one. If someone else raises him, he'll grow less and less like you!"

"I... I wanted to raise you too," the man said haltingly.

A low laugh came from the stereo. Chu Zihang started, unsure whether it was static or the CD player accidentally turning on. The laughter was deep, immense and solemn, as though echoing inside an ancient bronze bell. He had been watching the man's face in the rearview mirror. Suddenly it changed: blue veins sprang up at the corners of his eyes like restless little snakes. His usually slack face tightened, like red-hot iron quenched in ice water.

Chu Zihang had never seen that expression on him. He was a different person altogether, his abruptly narrowed pupils betraying immense terror.

Someone tapped softly on the car door.

"In rain this heavy, who's outside?" Chu Zihang turned and saw a black shadow cast on the window. Had the elevated road been closed, and traffic police come to check? He reached to lower the window.

"Sit back!" the man barked.

A vast terror suddenly engulfed Chu Zihang. He glanced at the speedometer: 120 kilometers an hour. Who could run after the Maybach on the elevated road and reach out to knock at the same time?

The knocking grew urgent. There was not one figure but three, five, more and more gathering outside, staring down at Chu Zihang through the rain-streaked windows. A dazzling mercury-colored light shone from outside, turning both their faces deathly pale. The man turned to Chu Zihang and struggled to keep his voice from shaking. "Don't be afraid... son!"

The knocking became the piercing scrape of sharp things across steel and glass. Chu Zihang thought they must be the shadows' nails.

"Where are we?" he screamed.

The man reached back, seized his wrist, hauled him bodily from the back seat, and threw him into the passenger seat.

"Buckle up!" he said quietly. All fear had vanished from his face, which was hard as cast iron.

He floored the accelerator. The Maybach shuddered and surged forward. Within seconds it reached 180 kilometers an hour and continued accelerating, because they had failed to shake the shadows. Mercury-colored light came from every direction, revealing countless dark figures surrounding the car... standing silently... like a crowd of death gods around a dying person's bed. They opened their eyes together, golden pupils blazing like torches. Chu Zihang curled up, clutching his head in pain.

Pain tore through the depths of his brain. Tangled blue-violet lines twisted like countless snakes, like hieroglyphs on an ancient tablet come alive and dancing like spirits. Images he would never have dared imagine in his worst nightmares flashed before him: a young man with a golden eye split open in his forehead lay on a black stone throne, a long bone sword in his chest; girls writhed on a carved stone altar, screaming in pain as if labor were beginning; black wings rose against the sunset, blotting out half the sky; a woman bound to a bronze pillar slowly opened her eyes, white hair flying as two streams of foul blood ran down her face...

It was like watching snakes dance in the primeval darkness, telling him a lost history in a strange language.

"It's spirit vision. Your bloodline is being awakened. Such a strong reaction—I don't know whether it's your luck... or your misfortune." The man gripped Chu Zihang's hand. "I always hoped this day... would come later."

After an unknown time, Chu Zihang slowly lifted his head, as if waking from a nightmare as long as a lifetime. The feeling was hard to describe: like a nearsighted man putting on glasses after years without them, the world suddenly became extraordinarily clear. Sight, hearing, even smell awoke. He looked blankly at the man, who gently stroked his head, in a gesture that might have been care or sorrow.

"What's happening? Are we going to die?" Chu Zihang asked.

"Son, welcome to"—the man drew a deep breath—"the real world."

"The real... world?"

"Don't tell anyone what you just saw, or whatever you see next. No one will believe you; they'll think you're crazy," the man said. "I think living in an unreal world is happier, so I always wanted you to learn all this later. I kept trying to stay away from you so I wouldn't drag you into it. But when I got your text today... I couldn't stop myself from picking you up... Well, it's no big deal. If a father wants to make an impression on his son, he has to act like a man. I never had the chance before." He licked his lips. "Are these guys giving me a stage to show off? Not bad!"

Chu Zihang didn't understand. He thought the man must have been scared out of his wits. Why was he talking nonsense?

The Maybach had reached its top speed, 275 kilometers an hour, the tachometer needle jumping into the dangerous red zone. The man floored the accelerator, gripped the wheel, and stared ahead. There was only mercury-colored light; nothing was visible, as though they were racing toward a silver

sea. Pale handprints without palm lines struck the windshield with loud bangs. Shadows pounded the windows on every side, hard enough to break blast-resistant glass.

The man pulled the black umbrella from the door.

Was he going to get out and talk to the shadows with an umbrella at a time like this? Chu Zihang stared, then saw clearly: it wasn't an umbrella but a sword, a slender Japanese blade in a black sheath, with no guard. It was a devotional sword. Chu Zihang had read a book called Knowledge of Japanese Swords: in Japan, swordsmiths omitted the guard only on two kinds of sword, those carried by poor ronin and ceremonial swords dedicated to the gods. Sacred swords were never used for cutting, so a guard was unnecessary. The sword's elegant, antique-style sharkskin sheath showed it was a decorative craft object.

The blade slipped from the sheath, its gleam clear as water.

Chu Zihang was dumbfounded. What was happening? Wasn't the man a driver, a loser who should be carefully ferrying his boss around? Yet now he held the sword, eager to act, radiating an edge sharp as a spear... with a decorative sword?

"Sacred sword Murasame, the cursed blade destined to kill the Tokugawa family. Heard of it?" The man laid it across the steering wheel. "The original was destroyed long ago. They recast it in regenerated metal and enshrined it at Gion Shrine for ten years."

Veins bulged on the man's wrist. Reversing his grip, he thrust straight into the left door. The long blade pierced the cast-aluminum door and lodged there, half its length exposed outside. He slammed on the brakes. The speedometer plunged, the wheels skidding on the verge of losing control. Foul blood trailed a black ribbon a dozen meters long in the wind, then the rain washed it away. The shadows couldn't slow in time; those on the left were cut through by the exposed blade before they could even cry out. Simple, pure killing, as though they had struck its sharp edge at 250 kilometers an hour. Black blood splashed across every window on the left and even seeped through the cracks. Chu Zihang held his head and trembled uncontrollably.

Sacred sword Murasame—was it a decorative replica? It had been forged to kill! Its tough blade could cut through the bones of more than a dozen people without breaking. This way of killing... this man, and the whole world... had they all gone mad?

The man immediately floored the accelerator. Tires shrieked against the road: wheelspin, the power exceeding their grip. Even through the air filter came the smell of burning rubber. He jerked the wheel and the Maybach spun out, its heavy 2.7-ton body sweeping the shadows away and into the roadside barrier, which cracked under the impacts.

Black blood coated all the windows, only to be washed away by the rain.

It was hell.

As the car spun violently, the man pressed a warm palm to Chu Zihang's head. Chu Zihang suddenly remembered childhood, when the man, the woman, and he were still a family, and the man took him to ride a carousel, holding his head just as gently.

The car stopped, facing the opposite direction. The man floored it again, and the Maybach charged back the way they had come like an enraged stallion. A chilling sound came from under the wheels, like bones being crushed... The car kept shuddering as one shadow after another flew away. The man held the accelerator down, his face expressionless. In his hands the car had become a killing machine.

Chu Zihang couldn't believe such a useless man had suddenly become a demon who killed without blinking.

"Don't be afraid. Things like Deadpool... don't have civil rights," the man said hoarsely. "They aren't human, so the law doesn't protect them!"

One shadow wasn't thrown aside. Taller than the others, he was built like a giant. He braced both hands against the hood and was driven rapidly backward by the Maybach, his feet scraping shrilly against the road. In the rain his golden eyes seemed to burn. The scene belonged in a Superman or Spider-Man movie. For an ordinary person, such enormous friction would dislocate joints and break leg bones.

"Die!" the man growled. The Maybach drove the shadow into the barrier. He shifted into reverse, then forward, accelerated, and struck again, then a third and fourth time, until the barrier broke. Only then did the gold in the shadow's eyes dim like a lamp out of oil. Even so, he made no sound.

The man turned the car and accelerated away. Trembling, Chu Zihang looked through the rear window. The fallen shadows slowly rose, their golden eyes flickering as they silently watched the car recede.

"Those... who are they? Call... call 110!" Chu Zihang looked fearfully at the man.

"No use. Your phone probably has no signal," the man said softly.

"As for who they are... that would take some explaining," he added after a moment.

"Don't be afraid, son. A dad for one day is a dad for life. Your dad's still your dad, not a monster." One glance at Chu Zihang told him what the terror in his son's eyes meant.

"Don't worry, don't worry. Your dad is actually very capable. I just don't look the part..."

Apparently he was still the same man; at least he was just as talkative. But Chu Zihang could see he was far from relaxed. Sweat covered his face, his hands trembled slightly on the wheel, and he hunched like a shrimp, eyes fixed on the road ahead.

Sure enough, the phone had no signal. Chu Zihang turned on the radio; only static came through. GPS couldn't find a satellite signal either. Everything was beyond his understanding. How could so many strange people be on an elevated highway? It was covered in surveillance cameras, yet no road police came after such a serious accident. They seemed to have entered a space cut off from the world, containing only the elevated road, the storm, the shadows, and the Maybach.

"To put it simply, your bloodline is a little different from other people's." After a long silence, the man offered this rather unconvincing explanation.

"Don't look like it's the end of the world. A different bloodline is nothing to be ashamed of. Mine's different too. If you hadn't inherited it from me, you'd be perfectly normal."

He scratched his head. "Forget it. Let's not talk about it now. I'll explain properly when there's time... Actually, going abroad isn't bad. But remember, don't apply to a college called Cassell. It's full of lunatics."

"Say, will your stepdad leave you his fortune? Keep an eye on him. Don't let him take a mistress... or there'll be someone competing with you for the inheritance," the man said seriously.

"Have you seen Indiana Jones? The professor and his son are great! My lifelong dream is just like that: Dad driving in front, son behind him firing a machine gun!"

What went on inside this man's head? Even now he could chatter and grow animated.

They raced on for more than ten minutes. At their speed they had covered over forty kilometers. The shadows hadn't caught up, and the mercury light had vanished. Chu Zihang's pounding heart slowly returned to normal. Surely nothing in the world could run as fast as a Maybach at top speed. They should have left the shadows forty kilometers behind.

"Where are we going now?" he asked.

"I don't know. They're still here... they haven't gone... because the rain hasn't stopped. We have to find the exit." The man kept the accelerator floored. Chu Zihang could see he was no less tense.

The rain hadn't stopped? What did that mean? What did rain have to do with the shadows? His head was splitting.

A speed-reduction sign flashed past, announcing a toll station one kilometer ahead. Bright white lights emerged from the darkness. The man let out a long breath of relief.

"We should be back in a normal area. Get out after the toll station and see if a passing car can take you home. Your dad can give them some money." The man took out several banknotes for the toll, then pulled the sword from the car door.

"Where are you going?" Chu Zihang asked.

"They'll follow me. Don't worry, your dad really is capable, and this car—a nine-million-yuan Maybach—is no joke. I can outrun them."

At a time like this, he was still boasting about his car? Chu Zihang looked at him speechlessly.

"I was joking. Don't take it seriously." The man smiled. "But I really will be fine. I still have to attend your parent-teacher meetings. Don't worry... son."

The Maybach didn't slow. The toll station drew closer, its brilliant white light warm as an inn's lamp seen beneath the eaves by a traveler lost in night fog, making him quicken his steps, knowing he could lay down his worries once he arrived. Both Chu Zihang and the man gazed eagerly ahead.

The car abruptly slowed, brake pads squealing.

"No... something's wrong!" the man said hoarsely.

Chu Zihang sensed it too. The light ahead conveyed not only warmth but solemnity and grandeur, like... pilgrims approaching a temple.

Yes! That longing to draw near wasn't like seeing a lighthouse at sea. It was the reverent desire to worship a god, to approach the radiance of divinity.

But Chu Zihang believed in no god, none at all... until he saw that light.

They had stopped, but the light came toward them, threads of white radiating through darkness and rain.

Chu Zihang heard a horse neigh. He thought it must be an illusion. It sounded very much like a horse, but if it really was, what an immense creature it must be! Its deep roar was like thunder held in its mouth, lightning shooting from its nostrils.

"Listen to your dad. Don't get too far away from me, but don't get too close either." The man looked at him. "Like when I took you to fly a kite."

A kite never strays far from the person flying it, because a string connects them. When it does fly away, the string has broken.

Chu Zihang nodded.

"Buckle your seat belt!" The man pressed the accelerator with all his strength.

The Maybach surged forward at maximum acceleration, charging straight into the white light. The mist parted, and Chu Zihang suddenly saw what stood in the radiance...

His worldview collapsed. Everything he had believed was shattered. The world was nothing like he had imagined!

In the white light stood a horse as mighty as a mountain, draped in heavy armor inlaid with metal patterns, its white coat glowing like crystal. Eight powerful legs resembled the outriggers that steady a wheeled crane. Dark-gold horseshoes tore one wound after another in the hard road. A mask covered its face, and after each thunderous neigh, sparks of lightning sprayed from its metal nostrils.

A huge black figure sat astride it, encased in heavy dark-gold armor that glimmered under the rain. He carried a curved spear, its shaft arcing like a meteor across the sky. Behind his iron mask, a single golden eye lit the surroundings like a great lamp.

Odin, chief god of the Norse Aesir!

Chu Zihang had read his story in a book. Now he had come, just as in legend: riding the eight-legged Sleipnir, carrying Gungnir, a spear made from a branch of the World Tree, clad in dark-gold armor and a dark-blue cloak, one-eyed!

He should have existed only in words and murals!

The Maybach crashed into him. Sleipnir screamed, four front hooves rearing into the air. Rain from every direction gathered before Odin and struck the front of the Maybach. Chu Zihang could see nothing; it was as though a waterfall rushed toward them. The car's immense momentum dissolved within a few meters. Alarms sounded and airbags deployed, saving Chu Zihang's neck from snapping instantly.

The torrent pushed the Maybach back. Sleipnir slowly sank to its eight knees and stopped. Odin drove Gungnir into the wet asphalt, his divine horse his throne. Crowds of black figures emerged behind him like priests preparing for Mass. They surrounded the car on every side, all in identical black clothes, with identical pale faces and identical hollow eyes shining gold. The Maybach was completely surrounded. Apparently the gods' tactics resembled those of humans.

"Get out," the man said softly.

Chu Zihang moved mechanically, following him out. They stood side by side in the brilliant headlights, the man holding the long sword in one hand and drawing Chu Zihang close with the other.

"Don't be afraid... although I was terrified the first time I saw it too... But fear won't help. I didn't want you to see this, but since you have, don't miss the chance. Open your eyes wide!"

Chu Zihang gripped his hand. He had never felt the man so tall, as immovable as a mountain. Rain filled heaven and earth; beyond it lay limitless darkness. Beneath them stretched the broad elevated road, surrounded by transparent curtains of water, as though all the world's rain had gathered in this space, streams pressed together without gaps.

"You dare crash into the throne of a god!" Odin's deep voice came through the rain.

"I'm a driver. When you drive too much, your hand inevitably slips." The man spoke calmly. "I know what you want. Fine, I can give it to you."

He patted Chu Zihang's head. "Get the case from the trunk. Black, with a silver emblem."

There was indeed a black case in the trunk, its special leather rough and tough, with a silver plate engraved with a flourishing World Tree.

Chu Zihang handed it to the man, who weighed it, gave it back, and looked at Odin. "I'm ready."

"Then, human! Approach!"

"You've disobeyed me many times, but this time you must listen," the man whispered in Chu Zihang's ear. "Remember, don't leave me, but don't get too close. When I say 'run,' run toward the car. Don't look back, whatever you do. Don't look back!"

"Mm!" Chu Zihang trembled.

The shadows closed around them and carried them forward, whispering to one another in an ancient tongue, like singing and weeping. Chu Zihang couldn't understand a word, but the snakelike lines in his mind were waking, shifting endlessly. Suddenly he understood those eager voices of the dead:

"Human..."

"Humans again..."

"The child's bloodline..."

"Such mouthwatering fresh meat..."

"Thirsty..."

Chu Zihang covered his ears and looked around in terror. The shadows' faces were all alike, all expressionless, yet each bore too many stories of the past.

"I hear what you hear. Don't be afraid. Dad is beside you," the man whispered.

The man stopped about a hundred meters from Odin and a hundred from the Maybach behind them, exactly halfway between. Rain washed continuously over the sword in his hand.

"Even if I give you the thing, I don't think you'll let us go," he said.

He planted his feet wide, soaked trousers flapping in the cold wind, looking as swaggering as a street thug. But showing a thug's swagger before something like a god?

"I will promise you life," Odin said. "A god never lies to mortals."

"Life like these dead men?" The man pointed his thumb at the shadows.

"No. Your bloodlines are far superior to theirs. You will be much stronger."

"No room to bargain?"

"All who have been to this realm can return to it. Therefore everyone who comes here must be a servant of god."

"Son, they say you're a center on the city team, good at breaking through defenses?" the man murmured in Chu Zihang's ear.

Chu Zihang nodded nervously.

"Negotiations have broken down," the man said. "Give me the case."

He took it and gently stroked Chu Zihang's head. "Remember everything I told you. Every word." He suddenly slapped Chu Zihang on the rear and roared, "Run!"

Without thinking, Chu Zihang turned and ran madly toward the car. For a long time he had no longer believed the man's words, but on this rainy night, holding his warm hand, he had suddenly become a child dependent on his father again.

The man hurled the case toward Odin, like fresh meat thrown to draw wolves. Half the shadows rushed after it, half intercepted the man and Chu Zihang. Their forms distorted with speed, like long snakes springing from the ground. The man ran after Chu Zihang, but perhaps because he was middle-aged, he wasn't as fast; the distance between them widened. Watching his son's back recede, a smile touched his mouth. "Fast little rascal."

He spun, his sword carving a blinding arc and sending rain splashing outward in a circle.

Chu Zihang heard terrible sounds pursuing him: blood pouring from wounds, bones breaking beneath a blade, mingled with the storm.

He actually heard the shadows wailing: "It hurts," "It hurts so much," "It burns with pain"... desperate cries, as if from hell.

Thick, foul blood without warmth spattered his back, and even the rain could not wash it away. The man remained behind him. Chu Zihang gathered his courage and looked back. Like a lion the man swung his sword, and shadow after shadow split in its gleam.

A transparent curtain of air opened in the rain. A high cry burst from deep in the man's throat, as ancient as the shadows' whispers.

Where the curtain spread, time slowed. Wind and rain seemed to thicken, and the shadows slowed too, everything like a film in slow motion. Only the man was unaffected. He turned and swung his sword, stepping and sliding, water slowly splashing underfoot and the shadows' foul black blood slowly flowing out, all suspended for a moment in the air like ink drifting through water. Amid the ink, his flashing blade was a silver swallow in flight.

Chu Zihang had never imagined a man could look so magnificent, and this man was his father.

At last he threw himself into the car and shouted into the rain, "Dad!"

Suddenly he had a strange feeling... the kite string had broken.

It was the string between him and the man. For a very long time he had seen him only at long intervals, but there had always been a string between them. Now it had broken.

The man had not run back with him. After shaking off the shadows, he had turned and raced toward Odin!

The shadows with the case had counterattacked, and the man's domain expanded to cover them all. But Odin did not slow. He drew Gungnir and struck, lightning darting. Countless thrusts in an instant: each stroke of the legendary spear that always found its mark carried a dark-gold gleam. Arcs of light surrounded the man, attacking vital points from different directions like a dense meteor shower.

The man ignored the shadows. He dodged among the meteors, spinning with his sword, stepping on a shadow to leap high, and struck downward—at Odin, at the god's head!

Blood suddenly poured from his back. He fell among the shadows. The "meteors" he had dodged curved around like fireflies and struck him from behind. Odin withdrew Gungnir, and the shadows closed on the man step by step.

"Son! Drive away!" He turned sharply and roared at Chu Zihang, thick blood-red mist rising from his body.

Chu Zihang understood. The man wanted to draw every shadow surrounding them to himself. He was using himself as bait.

"Listen to me! Remember what you promised." The man's blood-red eyes stayed fixed on Odin, but he spoke to Chu Zihang. "If I die, you're all I leave in this world. If you die too, I'll have nothing left here."

"Son, trust your dad. If you live, we'll have a chance to meet again." He flexed his bleeding arm. "With you here, there are some of my big moves I can't use."

"That car's wonderful. It cost nine million! Something that damn expensive can't be stopped even by a god!"

Chu Zihang looked at the keyless console. He understood what the man had boasted about: three people could awaken the engine, and he was the third.

"Start," he said.

The engine roared.

"Well done, son!" The man raised his sword, his voice like thunder.

Chu Zihang reversed, the car flying backward. The man had secretly taught him to drive in this very Maybach; they had once sped along a country dirt road in spring with the sunroof open.

The Maybach struck a barely visible curtain of rain. Whirling wind battered its body, walls of water pressed in from every side. The twelve-cylinder engine roared at full power, but could not move the car out of that place.

"Hey! God! Open sesame!" the man roared, hurling his sword at the eight-legged horse's head. Gungnir struck again. The man leaped, surrounded by countless golden meteors.

The water wall's force weakened for an instant. The Maybach roared through it and plunged into the deep night.

Chu Zihang's mind was blank. He drove mechanically through the rain. At some point the stereo had come on again, and daughter and father were singing to each other:

Daughter, dear daughter, the match I made was right,

I married you to a wealthy family's son,

When I grow old, he will be the man you can rely on,

He is young, but he is growing.

Suddenly he understood the song.

Those were the words the man wanted to leave him. Whether he was a son or daughter didn't matter: the man had sent him into a wealthy family because he had no certainty about his own life. He wanted his child to live well and have someone to rely on.

This was a man who always lived a double life. Only rarely was he fierce and formidable; in most people's eyes he was a man of little ability. Yet he dared not show that fierce side to his son, so he could appear only as a driver, snatching time to collect him from school. That was all he could do. Many times he had waited outside the school in the Maybach, only to see the Mercedes S500 arrive and retreat with his head lowered. Believing his "daughter" had someone to rely on, he fled far away.

"You'll understand when you're older."

Now Chu Zihang understood. And the man... the man might already be dead.

What was death?

It was the end, a final parting, something irretrievable: a hand you could never hold again, warmth you could never feel, and "I'm sorry" you could never say.

Chu Zihang slammed on the brakes. Tires shrieked; the car stopped sideways on the empty elevated road in the rain. He opened the sunroof and leaned back, gasping like an asthmatic, looking up. It seemed all the world's rain poured through the opening, hard and cold against his face, but he felt neither cold nor pain. Only the man's voice and the song played back in his ears.

"Start! Start!" he suddenly shouted at the console.

The engine gave a low, feeble sound. The car had reached its limit and could not move again.

Chu Zihang flung open the door and ran into the wind and rain. At that instant he understood that he was truly about to lose the man. What the man would leave in the world, what he had promised him—all of it was forgotten. He had gone mad. He feared neither the shadows nor Odin nor Gungnir. He had to find the man.

In the downpour, a small figure sat on the Maybach's roof and watched him go, eyes faintly golden, humming the Irish folk song.

On July 3, 2004, Typhoon Dandelion, number 0407, made landfall in the city, bringing torrential rain and force-ten winds. The city was given three days off.

For the people of this coastal city, typhoons were ordinary, so no one panicked. Instead they happily enjoyed three unexpected days at home. Unable to go out, families sat together watching variety shows on television, and parents took the opportunity to make up for the time they usually couldn't spend with their children.

Naturally the typhoon caused trouble. Although the elevated road had been closed promptly, some drivers had still gone up. Eventually the wind grew too strong for them to drive, and police cars couldn't reach them. Officers phoned and told them to park against the barrier, close their windows tightly, and endure the night in the storm. Thanks to this, no cars were overturned, though their paint was scraped against the barrier and water got into their engines. In the morning the wind subsided and tow trucks went up to bring them out one by one. Every rescued person was overjoyed. A damaged car was nothing; insurance would pay. Having escaped death, everything was wonderful. At the exit they embraced waiting relatives, young people kissed, and older men and women wept. What a moving scene.

At last the families waiting at the exit left one by one, until only a boy remained. Without an umbrella, soaked through, he stood behind the crowd watching every car towed down. He seemed frozen, lips purple, trembling slightly, yet he did not move. Finally, when all the tow trucks had assembled and were about to leave, he approached the officer in charge. "Are there no more?"

"No more," the officer said. "Haven't found your family? Don't worry, we rescued everyone on the elevated road. Nobody was hurt. If you didn't see them, you must have missed each other. Go home and check."

Something faint in the boy's eyes seemed finally to go out. After a long silence he slowly crouched, both hands on the ground, saying nothing.

The officer couldn't see his face and thought he was crying. He wanted to pat his shoulder and comfort him. A boy didn't need to cry just because something had gone wrong; when in trouble, ask the police...

But he suddenly stopped. He did not dare approach. He could clearly see the boy's ten fingers, braced against the ground and curled into claws, digging deep into the asphalt. He had no time to wonder how a middle-school boy possessed such terrifying strength. He simply sensed, instinctively, the overwhelming waves of... sorrow erupting from that slender body.

On the night of July 12, 2010, rain fell on the city again, a fine, steady drizzle.

The World Cup final in South Africa: Spain against the Netherlands. The streets were empty, traffic lights changing lonely colors. All over the city, people gathered before televisions, drinking beer and shouting at good plays and bad.

Chu Zihang lay on his back in the dark, hands folded on his chest, staring at the enameled chandelier. Mom and her friends screamed in the next room; someone must have scored. They had already finished a case of beer. If they kept drinking, those beautiful, eccentric aunties would run into the garden in low-cut silk nightgowns, holding hands and acting crazy. But never mind; let them. A little madness once in a while was fine.

Mom had already drunk her milk tonight.

Chu Zihang was reciting his diary. It was written neither on paper nor in an electronic file, but in his mind. It contained many images, passing frame by frame: riding on the man's shoulders shouting "Giddyap!"; the only expensive toy the man had bought him, a model train set; and the scene the man himself would have considered the most spectacular of his life, standing with legs apart and holding a sword for worshiping—or killing—a god... Every night before sleep, Chu Zihang recalled them, every detail, until he was sure he had forgotten nothing.

Masashi Toyama, who taught Introduction to Brain Science, said human memory was unreliable, like a worn-out hard drive easily demagnetized. The past was like a picture drawn in sand. As time passed, wind blew the sand away, memory blurred, and finally everything became an indistinguishable haze. Toyama said this was a form of self-protection: imagine remembering every detail of the past forever. The saddest, most painful, most sorrowful images of your life would torment you constantly, and you could never escape the bad times behind you.

But Chu Zihang did not want to forget, because he was the only person in the world who still remembered that man. If he forgot too, it would be as though the man had never existed.

The man had once said that if he died one day, only one thing in the world could prove he had existed: Chu Zihang, who carried half his blood.

"Dad, it's raining again." Having recalled the final image, Chu Zihang spoke softly.

Rain rattled against the window. He slowly closed his eyes and fell asleep.

Act One

Birthday Cake Is the Grave of Youth

Birthday Cake is the Grave of Youth

Birthdays did not really matter to Lu Mingfei. Who would remember? His uncle and aunt? Don't be ridiculous. His parents? They were spectacularly unreliable. Was there anyone in the world who actually cared that Lu Mingfei had taken another step toward becoming a sleazy middle-aged man?

A birthday with no one to celebrate it with was just another ordinary day. He had had plenty of those.

He woke to cicadas shrieking their hearts out. The sunshine was almost poisonous, and the stuffy room felt like the steamer in Journey to the West in which demons cooked a fat monk.

Lu Mingfei waved a paper fan inscribed I COME BY MOONLIGHT—words that made him feel like a lecherous thief—and typed www.i-cassell-you.com into his laptop.

He entered the username Ricardo.M.Lu, a password that changed with the date, and authentication from a security USB drive. A tap on Enter refreshed the screen to the Cassell College Vacation Daily Report Form: a dark-green interface with clean, thin borders and more buttons than he could take in at a glance. Lu Mingfei fished a wrinkled little notebook from the pocket of his baggy shorts and began following its instructions item by item.

"Have you detected any unidentified dragons?"

Lu Mingfei checked No. Under a clear blue sky in broad daylight, where would dragons be running around? Coming home for summer vacation meant returning to the real world and severing all contact with reptiles.

"Have you used a Yanling?"

Another No. After the battle at the Three Gorges Reservoir, all his Yanling abilities had vanished again. He had risked a quarter of his life for them, only to get a single use and no after-sales service. Lu Mingze was a crooked businessman.

"Have you experienced any physical abnormalities?"

"Have you discovered any suspected alchemical equipment?"

No, no, no, no, no... This was Lu Mingfei's summer vacation after freshman year. He was doing his daily report.

The daily report was a Cassell College rule. During winter and summer breaks, students had to report online every day. Professors graded the reports: good ones raised a student's GPA, while lying counted as cheating on an exam. In a sense this was their vacation homework, that turd teachers left to spoil your happy days off and remind you they existed. It was like finally getting dessert after a meal, only for someone to sprinkle mustard oil over it. But at Cassell College the daily report was absolutely necessary, because its students were absolutely exceptional.

Cassell College was a private, elite institution for the privileged in the Great Lakes region of Illinois. None of those adjectives quite captured it. It was a paradise for monsters and lunatics.

A college for dragon hybrids.

The professors firmly believed that dragons had once ruled the world as an intelligent race. This rewrote evolution: humanity was no longer the sole pinnacle of the evolutionary tree. Before mammals produced humans, reptiles had given rise to a supreme intelligent species, the dragons. That history had been buried after humanity rose, surviving only in scraps and fragments of ancient myths. But the decline of the dragons did not mean their extinction. The Dragon Kings, bearers of the most sacred bloodlines, merely slept, and would one day awaken. They were unlikely to join the United Nations and build a better home with humanity. They intended to restore the theocratic age of reptiles.

They could do it, too. They were nothing like the monsters of knightly romances, clumsily flying about and stupidly breathing fire. They possessed a mysterious art called alchemy and the sacred power of words known as Yanling, which could even alter the laws of physics.

Most humans believed dragons were only myths because a certain group had long erased evidence of their existence: the dragon hybrids. Born of humans and dragons, they had human hearts and draconic powers. They kept the dragons' secret and bore the duty of guardians. Cassell trained the finest hybrids and sent them around the world to prevent the Dragon Kings' awakening and, when necessary, devise plans to slay them and send those unrepentant monarchs back to their long sleep.

Lu Mingfei had grown up under the red flag and in the sunshine, educated in materialism with all the proper beliefs. Though he sometimes indulged in wild fantasies, he had never imagined supernatural nonsense like dragons could have anything to do with him.

Yet Cassell College had come all that way to recruit him, singing the praises of his bloodline.

The courses were outrageous, and the textbooks even more absurd—more absurd than Japan's new history textbooks. There it was in black and white: humans had not struggled against nature for a million years before learning to use tools and fire; dragons had taught those skills to their servants. Attila the Hun was a dragon, which was why he was so powerful that no one could stop him as he fought his way to Rome. Chinese emperors had not been boasting when they called themselves descendants of dragons, because as far back as the Three Sovereigns and Five Emperors, every enlightened person fit to lead had indeed been a dragon hybrid...

After taking classes there, Lu Mingfei figured every historical event probably had something to do with dragons. Maybe, just as in Stephen Chow's version of The Deer and the Cauldron, the Qing dynasty had really fallen because the Red Flower Society severed its dragon vein.

Since everyone was a human-dragon hybrid, geniuses were everywhere and elites were a dime a dozen. Every genius and elite had a shocking side, and without strict discipline and management the consequences of letting them run wild were unthinkable. Compared with these hybrids, even Ultraman, Pikachu, and the Transformers might be nothing special. During summer break these people lived among ordinary crowds. If one of them accidentally unleashed a Yanling...

They had indeed learned painful lessons in that regard.

Fortunately, the college leadership were not elegant but useless intellectuals. Before the college was founded, the dragon slayers' organization had been called the Dragon Blood Secret Party. Anyone daring to call themselves a party had to be a scheming customer, no pushover; without an iron hand,

how could they command obedience? Principal Anjou therefore played his trump card: the daily report. Students complained, but it worked, reducing accidents that required the college to clean up afterward by as much as eighty percent. Of course, eliminating them entirely was impossible. Last year a student with a heroic streak had secretly taken alchemical equipment from campus to excavate a hidden dragon tomb in Egypt's Valley of the Kings, awakening a dragon about to emerge from its cocoon. He missed his return date and pursued it across thousands of miles, taking Star Alliance flights from Cairo to Istanbul, then New York and Cape Town. Finally, when he fired an alchemical missile at the dragon's seaplane, he shot down a new stealth drone the Pentagon was test-flying. The American stealth-aircraft industry interpreted the incident as proof that an adversary had mastered every technique needed to detect their aircraft and was making an unmistakable demonstration. They abandoned their existing research and threw themselves into a space-shuttle project for attacks from outer space.

The Board of Trustees punished the student severely, but Lu Mingfei had to admit that was how students at Cassell thought: anything went in the pursuit of dragon slaying. The plane had only itself to blame for crossing the senior student's missile trajectory at exactly the wrong moment.

"Mingfei! Don't get up and start playing on the computer first thing! Go downstairs and buy a bag of Cantonese sausage and a bunch of scallions, and check the front desk for any new packages while you're at it!" His aunt's voice carried so well it came through a twenty-centimeter load-bearing wall and left Lu Mingfei reeling. A demonic sound straight through the brain.

"Okay, okay! Just a second!" Lu Mingfei hurried to his feet.

His parents had gone abroad for work when he was little and never returned, leaving him in storage with his uncle and aunt. Only after enrolling at Cassell did he learn they were both distinguished alumni, traveling the world for the cause of dragon slaying and far too busy to look after their troublesome kid. Fortunately, that meant the college viewed him differently and classified his bloodline as S-rank. He was its only S-rank student, with an exclusive scholarship worth tens of thousands of dollars. Admittedly, nobody had seen anything extraordinary about him yet—in other words, everyone else at the college had a Yanling and he did not—but perhaps that could be explained by a modest, understated personality...

After years of swallowing insults in his uncle and aunt's house, he could finally hold his head high. Summer vacation was the perfect time to return home in glory!

He was no longer that troublesome kid. In his first semester's practical course, he had stabbed the King of Bronze and Fire, one of the Four Monarchs of the dragons, to death at the Three Gorges Reservoir... though one might suspect a little cheating.

By comparison, a student ID that doubled as a credit card with a hundred-thousand-dollar limit was nothing. Once you had saved the world, why discuss something as vulgar as money?

He even owned a car now. He had won a Bugatti Veyron in a bet... though he had smashed it up on his first drive and still couldn't afford repairs.

He had a boss, too. He had joined the Student Council under President Caesar Gattuso. Brother Caesar had very few virtues, only three. First, he could fight: with two modified Desert Eagles and Yanling: Kamaitachi, he had actually wounded the Dragon King Constantine. Second, he was rich; Lu Mingfei had won his Bugatti from him. Third, he was generous and grand, spending lavishly every birthday on a swimsuit-and-champagne party by the pool. Few people in the world caught Caesar's eye,

yet in front of every Student Council officer he had clapped Lu Mingfei on the shoulder and said, "Recruiting Lu Mingfei is our greatest achievement this year!" His next words were, "Even if he's good for nothing, I won't let our only S-rank fall into Chu Zihang's Lionheart Society!"

What an honor! How could Lu Mingfei not be proud? With that background and status, he had no weaknesses at all!

As the plane crossed the Bering Strait on its way home, Lu Mingfei practiced smiling. No matter how his uncle and aunt praised him, he must smile calmly, not grin and show his gums. That was the aristocratic Cassell style. The passenger beside him watched the boy smile faintly, compose himself, smile faintly again, then compose himself again, over and over as if practicing a secret martial art, and spent the entire journey in terror.

But when he stepped through his uncle's door, he was greeted not by flowers but by a heap of radish strips on the dining table. His uncle and aunt were sweating over a lively operation to pickle dried radish.

"Mingfei, you're back? Perfect timing! Go buy me half a jin of coarse salt!" His aunt was delighted to see him.

"Okay, okay." From habit, Lu Mingfei put down his luggage, took the two and a half yuan in change, and headed downstairs.

Only outside did it hit him. Damn it! He was practically a successful man now. Did he really have to buy salt himself? Shouldn't his precious hands be reserved for saving the world?

He returned with the salt and helped his aunt cut radishes. Just as he was preparing to describe his year in America with suitable restraint, she spoke first. "Mingfei, let me ask you something..."

He had not yet realized this was the prelude to Cheng Yaojin's three axe blows.

"You've been in America a year. Have you saved any of your scholarship?"

The first blow turned him to stone. She had struck his weak point. On paper he was rich, but the college had strict rules: to collect his scholarship he had to pass every test, submit papers on time, and earn excellent grades. Apart from his practical course, his results were miserable. In twelve months he had received only four months' scholarship money, and his credit card was now thousands in the red. Some of his swagger deflated, and he unconsciously put more effort into cutting the radishes.

"People say American girls are very open. Have you found a girlfriend?" The second blow followed hard on the first.

Lu Mingfei's head dropped. That question really hurt. How could he put it? The figure that kept appearing and disappearing in his heart was... He couldn't very well confess, "I think my boss's girlfriend Nono is great, and she's been good to me, but I'm rather like a toad gazing up at a swan, and I'm still single."

"Did you see your parents?" The ultimate finishing move.

Lu Mingfei had almost forgotten what they looked like. In a whole year he had received only two letters from his mother, Qiao Weini. Even on the emergency-contact form when he enrolled, he could only put his uncle and aunt. His impressive parents, his dashing parents, his busy parents, the parents who supposedly loved Lu Mingfei so deeply, were occupied with some great enterprise to fight dragons and save the world. They had no time to come back and see him.

In his heart they were as distant as a myth.

You couldn't always ask someone else to say "I love you" for you, could you? Even if you wrote it a thousand times in letters, one day you still had to say it yourself. Lu Mingfei wanted his parents to prove their sincerity one day, with something dramatic: suddenly appearing before him, travel-worn, suitcases in hand, standing amid steam from a train or the rush of air behind a plane, gazing silently at their troublesome son and saying in trembling voices, "You've... grown so much?"

Right? That would be moving! Then he could resist the urge to crouch on the ground and bawl, and say casually, "You're back."

Come on, heroes! Prove to the unlucky kid you brought into this world that you would cross mountains and oceans just to see him and say a sentimental "I love you"!

But so far, to Lu Mingfei, his parents were merely signatures at the ends of letters, definitions in a figure of speech, and two splendid names in an alumni directory: Lu Lincheng and Qiao Weini.

Lu Mingfei fell silent. His knife struck hollowly against the chopping board.

His aunt understood at once. With a contemptuous smile she said she'd known his parents were unreliable. She had hoped they might recommend Mingze, but fortunately she'd had the foresight not to wait. If she had relied on them, would Mingze ever have gotten into Austin University?

His cousin Lu Mingze had just received his acceptance from Austin University, and the whole family had celebrated. After spending a year in the shadow of "even a loser like Lu Mingfei got into an American university," his aunt could finally hold her head high. Her back straightened, her legs stopped aching when she walked, and she could speak without running out of breath. An American university acceptance letter worked like a calcium supplement for her.

"Don't cut the strips so thick! The salt won't get in!" his aunt barked.

"Mm-hmm." Lu Mingfei was sweating buckets.

"Apply to our Austin University. It's a famous school, everyone's very friendly, and the professors are especially nice..." Lu Mingze's voice came from the inner room. Wearing a headset, he was chatting on QQ voice with his feet on the desk and the air conditioning turned up high. Cool air bathed him, and a girl's soft admiration at the other end sent him floating, lending his voice ever more dramatic rises and falls. He was 160 centimeters tall and weighed 160 jin, but when it came to chasing girls he was far more reliable than his cousin. He had heard his cousin was still single; if he got a girlfriend first, he would be what his mother called a winner in life.

Actually Lu Mingze had no real need to look down on Lu Mingfei. With Austin University behind him, he felt superior to his cousin from head to toe in every possible way. But since he was so outstanding, he might as well show off without shame.

To the clatter of the keyboard, Lu Mingfei packed the radish strips into a pickle jar, rubbed coarse salt over each layer, and sealed it. Salt seeped into his skin, leaving it dry and rough.

"Carry the jar out to the balcony! Look how clumsy you are. You didn't learn to cook in America either, did you?" His aunt pointed.

Among the most invincible creatures in the world were middle-aged women: sturdy, practical, and sharp-eyed. With only three questions they could reduce a swaggering brat to his true form. To a middle-aged woman, if you had no parents, girlfriend, or money, what were you showing off for? However capable you were, however many dragons you'd killed, it meant nothing. Even if you were

great enough to master Star Platinum, you still needed a reason to throw a punch, didn't you? You had nothing, not even a reason to throw a punch... Were you supposed to fight for eternal justice?

What nonsense.

"Hurry up! How long have I been calling you? Lazy and poor go together, ever heard that? If you're lazy, you'll be poor!" His aunt grew sharper still.

Lu Mingfei hastily clicked Send and rushed out. His aunt's demonic voice boring through his brain... even a hero like his uncle, who had practiced the Golden Bell Shield for twenty years, couldn't withstand it.

"Ricardo.M.Lu, you have one unread message." A window suddenly appeared on the screen.

Ricardo:

According to your enrollment information, you were born on July 17, 1991, and turn nineteen today.

On this important day, on behalf of Principal Hilbert Jean Anjou and all the professors of the academic board, I wish you a happy birthday.

Thank you for attending Cassell College and sharing these wonderful times with us. It is an honor to grow together.

Yours sincerely, Norma.

PS. Under college rules, a student celebrating a birthday may collect one birthday cake from the cafeteria. Since you are currently on summer vacation in China, your complimentary birthday cake has been canceled. Furthermore, the summer term begins July 20, 2010. Your transcript shows D grades in two courses last semester, meaning you did not pass. I regret to inform you that you must attend remedial classes and retake the examinations during the summer term. I have booked your flight back to campus. Please be ready to depart at any time.

"Birthday?" Lu Mingfei stared. Since coming home, he had spent his days serving at his aunt's command and his evenings playing StarCraft. The days had blurred together, and he had completely forgotten.

He was nineteen, just like that? Time really flew. Think of what heroes had accomplished at nineteen... Zhou Yu and his sworn brother Sun Ce had already established a base in Jiangdong and married the Qiao sisters, with territory and women to call their own... And this was how his own nineteenth birthday arrived?

"What the hell? What kind of congratulatory email is this? It's just telling me my free cake is canceled and I failed classes!" After reading the PS twice, Lu Mingfei finally caught on.

Birthdays did not really matter to Lu Mingfei. Who would remember? His uncle and aunt? Don't be ridiculous. His parents? They were spectacularly unreliable. Was there anyone in the world who actually cared that Lu Mingfei had taken another step toward becoming a sleazy middle-aged man?

A birthday with no one to celebrate it with was just another ordinary day. He had had plenty of those.

His phone chimed. A text had arrived.

"Happy birthday. Chu Zihang." As concise as that senior student's expressionless face.

Someone actually remembered his birthday, and that someone was Chu Zihang.

Chu Zihang was president of Cassell's Lionheart Society, the Student Council's sworn enemy, while Lu Mingfei was a new Council member. It was like Lu Su waking on his birthday to a card from Cao Cao: bewildering and full of conflicting feelings. Lu Mingfei had no idea how Chu Zihang had gotten his number. He certainly hadn't saved Chu Zihang's, and the senior had spoken fewer than a hundred sentences to him altogether. Was this an attempt to win him over? But would the stone-faced senior, who would cut down anyone who stood in his path, really resort to such tactics?

While Lu Mingfei was speculating, another text arrived.

"Lu Mingfei, is this your number? I'm Chen Wenwen. The Literature Club is having lunch at Sophie Lad Pizza at 11:30 today. Come along if you get this."

His heart rippled... No, a colossal meteorite had struck the middle of the Pacific, raising towering waves!

The sudden message was like Chen Wenwen's invitation to join the Literature Club years ago: casual, unexpected, and delightful. That had been a summer too. Cicadas screamed their hearts out, the sunlight outside was blinding, and the shadow of the eaves lay sharp as a blade across the ground. He had leaned against the windowsill, bored out of his mind, while Chen Wenwen, in a blue-and-white cloth dress and low-heeled sandals, moved lightly past as though walking on tiptoe along a road at night.

"Are you Lu Mingfei? Do you like reading?" Chen Wenwen had stopped abruptly.

He had looked up in surprise. Her eyes were like water, rippling faintly as they reflected the sun.

"Pathetic," Lu Mingfei muttered. Chen Wenwen had a boyfriend now, and the whole affair had left him miserable... Yet remembering that instant when he looked up still stirred him.

"Sure," he replied.

"Mingfei, you haven't left yet?" His aunt burst in.

"I'm going, I'm going!" Startled, Lu Mingfei snapped to attention.

"Good thing you haven't." She waved what she was holding: a cracked toilet seat. "Your uncle cracked it sitting on it. Go to the building-supply market and buy a new one, beechwood, something decent. Your uncle and I are taking Mingze to buy a suit for going abroad, to wear at the graduation ceremony! Don't dawdle. Buy the seat and have the property management people install it. We'll be back at four thirty this afternoon. Steam the sausage, clean the scallions, and cut some radish for soup!"

Having issued her orders, his aunt turned and left. The outer door slammed, and a few minutes later his uncle's little BMW drove away downstairs.

Lu Mingfei's head ached. What a busy birthday: the Literature Club gathering, his aunt's many errands, and a family dinner that evening to celebrate Lu Mingze's departure for study in America.

Eleven time zones away, at Cassell College in Illinois.

Late at night the central control room on the library's second floor was ablaze with light. Manstein stood before a giant 3D projection: a virtual globe five meters high floated before him, spinning rapidly to whatever location he wanted with a light wave of his hand. It felt like a god manipulating his creation, a thrilling sense of command and power. If politicians knew such an advanced projection system existed, they would scramble to buy one and indulge their urge to direct the world: cosplay Hitler if they liked, Genghis Khan if they preferred, like the old teacher in From the Herbal Garden to

the Three Flavor Study reciting of an iron scepter wielded in splendid command and golden cups emptied without drunkenness.

But Manstein was not enjoying himself at all. Manstein wanted to die.

Seven or eight red lights flashed at once on the ghostly blue globe, alarms rising and falling. The control room was filled with rapid keyboard clatter, printers hissing, and mechanical cipher machines clicking as they translated coded messages. His head was ready to explode. Day or night, the atmosphere was always like this; tonight Manstein was the unlucky professor on duty.

As many as seventy experts and interns worked there, each facing several terminals at once. The college secretary, or rather the supercomputer named Norma, gathered information relevant to the college from across the world, but people still had to analyze it and make decisions. The central control room was the college's think tank.

"Executive Department agents intercepted a smuggling plane over Peru. We found priceless Egyptian alchemical equipment dating from 700 BC in the cabin! They have the situation completely under control," an intelligence officer shouted hoarsely through his headset. "But they shot the plane down... They're making an emergency landing and requesting rescue!"

"Please sign this reimbursement form. Our agents in Greece are waiting for the funds!" A female secretary hurried up in clicking high heels and handed Manstein a bill.

"Seventy thousand dollars?" His eyes bulged. "For a sum this large they need to submit a formal report!"

"There's no time... They're dealing with the mob."

"We're a college! We're educators! What are we doing dealing with the mob?" Manstein exploded.

"Several recent serial murders are suspected to involve a death servitor. The mob knows something, and our agents in Greece believe it must be captured before the police get involved." The secretary caught her breath. "It's urgent. They called directly for money. Both sides reportedly have their fingers on their triggers while they wait. If the money doesn't arrive... the other side may think they're being cheated and open fire!"

Manstein was about to say more when an anxious financial expert rushed over.

"OPEC announced an increase in crude oil prices five minutes ago!"

"What the hell do crude oil prices have to do with me?" Manstein glared. "I didn't buy oil futures."

"But the college did... a huge position, using over 1.2 billion in reserves. If we don't sell in time, we'll suffer enormous losses."

"How enormous?" Manstein covered his face.

"Conservatively, possibly two hundred million..." The expert wiped cold sweat from his face.

Manstein felt one breath away from spraying blood all the way to the ceiling. He signed the secretary's bill with a flourish, turned to the financial expert, and ordered, "Sell! Sell everything!"

He couldn't be bothered about Greece's seventy thousand dollars. Tonight a word from him moved hundreds of millions; was there any point getting angry over a mere seventy thousand? What a wretched night, and he alone had to hold it together. Normally three professors shared a shift: tonight it was his turn with Guderian and Schneider, director of the Executive Department. The scatterbrained Guderian was plainly unreliable, so when he said he was used to going to bed early and didn't want

overtime, Manstein agreed to cover for an old friend. But Schneider, famed as an iron-willed enforcer, had let him down too, saying he had an important academic paper to revise and asking Manstein to cover. Manstein knew that although Schneider was a butcher—he regarded everyone in the Executive Department as butchers, crude people who knew only knives and guns—he had always wanted more publications so he wouldn't fall behind the other professors academically. So he agreed.

But the whole world was unsettled tonight, and not one piece of good news had arrived to lift his spirits.

"The Equipment Department has achieved tremendous success testing a new alchemical weapon in the Sahara!" An intern sprang from his chair and raised his arms in triumph.

His wild delight caught on. Everyone knew the department was preparing a secret weapons test deep in the Sahara: a superweapon that might tip the balance between humans and dragons. It had succeeded! Everyone raised their arms and cheered, as if NASA had just announced a successful moon landing.

Manstein perked up and started toward the intern's terminal. Then a piercing alarm swept through the control room. It was a high-level warning. He turned to see a rapidly flashing red light expanding in the heart of the Sahara on the globe, threatening to engulf the entire earth!

"What happened? Didn't you say it was a tremendous success?" he roared at the intern.

"A minor problem... The Pentagon's spy satellite Tungusta happened to be passing over the Sahara and observed our test. It mistook it for... a nuclear explosion. According to our inside source, the CIA has reported it to the president. Since the test site was in Libya, the ambassador there will probably issue a stern diplomatic note very soon... accusing Libya of conducting a secret nuclear test..."

Manstein slapped himself hard. I knew it, he thought. When has that bunch of lunatics in the Equipment Department ever brought good news? But did they have to make it this outrageous?

"What alchemical weapon could possibly be mistaken for a nuclear explosion?" the duty professor cried in anguish, his voice echoing through the library's marble corridors.

"A tactical missile fitted with an alchemically refined silver warhead... Combined with refined mercury, niter extracted from Vesuvius's volcanic ash, and the blood of a holy infant, the explosion can lethally poison dragons in its central zone."

"What use is that? How many dragons will wait in the middle of the desert for you to bomb them? What if one is in New York? Kill thousands of people along with one dragon? Those ingredients can kill humans as well!" Manstein collapsed into his chair. "I need to make some calls to deal with this... I need a little time..." Then he sprang up again, slamming both palms on the desk. "Executive Department, send people immediately! People! Fly them to the Sahara and clean up the site before the Pentagon gets there!"

A tremendous roar drowned him out. The floor shook violently and the lights went out, then came back on. Manstein fell, rolled to his feet, and rushed to the window. A column of dark-blue flame shot into the night sky from the direction of the Ice Cellar, the storehouse for alchemical equipment. The things kept there could destroy the earth several times over!

"Something's happened!" He lunged for the central console and grabbed a hammer to smash the glass covering the red lever for the campus-wide alarm.

Then the red telephone on the console rang. He hesitated, but answered it first. The line went directly to the Ice Cellar; he wanted to find out what was happening. Intruders? An accidental explosion?

"Hello? Who's on duty tonight?" asked a casual voice.

"Manstein, head of the Discipline Committee! What's going on?" The tone infuriated him. He recognized the Equipment Department's spokesperson. The weapon-obsessed lunatics rarely appeared in person and entrusted their communications to this unreliable representative.

"Just a routine experiment, a tiny bit of open flame. Everything is under our control," the spokesperson said calmly. "No need to make a fuss. We're calling to notify you that the Equipment Department has an experiment in the Ice Cellar tonight."

Manstein's eyes blazed. "Under control? Your Sahara experiment..."

"All departments in position! Hydrogen flame ready. Let's do it again..." someone called through the receiver.

"Again? You lunatics won't stop until somebody gets killed, will you?" Manstein roared, but only a busy signal answered. The spokesperson had already hung up with brisk efficiency.

He slowly replaced the receiver and sank weakly into his chair. What could he do? Some departments at the college could not be offended, and Equipment was one of them. Even knowing their reckless experiments might bring the sky down... no one wanted their new equipment to explode for no reason on the next assignment.

Quick, sharp footsteps approached and the control-room door was shoved open. Schneider was dragging Guderian along. These two disloyal fellows had left Manstein to take the blame alone; ordinarily they would hardly return out of kindness. Guderian had apparently been dragged from his nest and was still wearing a Pikachu nightcap. Entirely in keeping with his taste.

"What is it?" Manstein snatched off Guderian's cap and tossed it aside, but addressed Schneider. Guderian looked sleepy, with an expression that said this had nothing to do with him and he wanted to go back to bed.

"We lost some information in China." Schneider's voice was low and hoarse, always enough to make a listener's skin crawl.

"Tsk!" Manstein scoffed. What was one lost document in China? One of them had gone to sleep in a Pikachu cap, the other had used a paper as an excuse, and he had been left alone for twelve hours. In that time he had cleaned up after seven Executive Department teams around the world, authorized as much as $120,000 in expenses, prevented a gunfight, and was dealing with an imaginary nuclear crisis... And now they rushed in to tell him some information was lost?

Schneider slapped a file onto the desk. The dark-red stamp on its cover brought Manstein's overtime-muddled brain awake as if someone had poured cold water over it. It showed a great serpent holding its tail in its mouth to form a circle, its scales distinct, with two bold black letters in the center: SS.

"Top classification..." Manstein said softly.

Cassell missions, like bloodlines, were divided into grades. In descending priority they were A, B, C, D, E, and F. Special missions beyond those grades were designated S-rank. S-rank missions were rare; Operation Bronze against the Dragon King Norton at the Three Gorges Reservoir had been one.

SS was an exception among exceptions, not necessarily more important than S but extraordinarily special. Such missions came directly from the Board of Trustees, bypassing Principal Anjou.

The nuclear crisis had just been classified A-rank and had already reached the diplomatic level, yet the mission involving this information was SS. What could be so deadly important that even the trustees hidden behind the scenes couldn't sit still? Some scandal involving the trustees?

"Yes. Something the board wants." Schneider nodded slowly.

Manstein nodded and clapped his hands. "Ladies and gentlemen, give us the room."

Everyone else stood and filed out. As the financial expert passed Manstein, he asked quietly, "Sell in stages?"

"That's not important now. Decide for yourself." Manstein waved him away, leaving the 1.2-billion-dollar transaction to the expert. Only one thing mattered now: an SS-rank mission. Once one appeared, everything else gave way.

"You can't leave!" He caught Guderian trying to slip out at the back of the line and pulled him back.

"You said you wanted to talk alone," Guderian said, scratching his head. "I don't understand those things you're discussing anyway."

"But you're a professor on duty." Manstein sighed. "None of us can decide an SS-rank mission alone. With the principal away, the duty professors decide together. You have to be here."

Only the three of them remained in the vast control room. The doors closed tightly. No one dared eavesdrop on a secret mission from the trustees; the college might have a free atmosphere, but its rules were strict.

"What is it?" Manstein asked.

"You're better off not asking," Schneider said. "You weren't supposed to know anything about it. It was handled directly by the Executive Department. We only had to tell you because something went wrong."

"With a mission classified this highly, the Executive Department should have given it everything. How could there be a problem?"

"We did give it everything. We made detailed plans, obtained the information, and sent our best man to escort it back to campus personally. But it was lost on the way." Schneider gestured. The projection changed to a building with a turtle-shell-shaped glass dome, like an airport waiting hall, except it had been completely deformed. Its high-strength aluminum-alloy beams were twisted like pretzels. A simulation showed the disaster: as the ground shook, every beam twisted inexplicably, as if turned by giant hands, and thousands upon thousands of glass panes broke loose and fell straight down.

"I've seen that hall. It's the South Railway Station!" Guderian said suddenly.

"Yes. You saw it in Lu Mingfei's hometown. It was still under construction when you went for the interview, and began trial operations this summer. Its glass dome consisted of 3,200 high-strength panes, and its aluminum frame was designed to withstand a magnitude-eight earthquake, using the most advanced building technology. But this morning, Beijing time, it was destroyed in a magnitude-three quake. All 3,200 panes fell vertically, like 3,200 blades cutting at once." Schneider paused. "And our man was waiting for a train there with the information."

"He died?" Manstein asked.

"Cut to pieces," Schneider said quietly. "It was Raymond."

They had deployed Agent B007, Raymond, which showed how careful the Executive Department had been. A 2006 graduate of Cassell's mechanical engineering department, B-rank, Raymond possessed Yanling number 28, Blazing Sun, radiating light up to 4,000 lumens within his domain. The light could not kill, but his domain was a giant incandescent bulb fifty meters across. Anyone approaching him effectively entered the bulb and couldn't open their eyes. Though not a high-level Yanling, it was considered absurdly powerful, a game-breaking ability. Yet Raymond had died, and Blazing Sun had been useless, because his opponents had no eyes: 3,200 panes of glass falling from the sky.

"The casualties must have been terrible," Manstein said.

"Besides Raymond, only three people were injured. The station was still in its trial period, with few departures and few passengers waiting."

"Was he attacked by one of our kind? A building designed to withstand a magnitude-eight quake collapsing in a magnitude-three one is impossible to explain," Manstein said.

"I know. In China they call that tofu-dreg construction," Guderian interjected.

"If you don't understand, stop squawking!" Manstein snapped. "A magnitude-three quake wouldn't even bring down a condemned building!"

"We don't know. I've never heard of a Yanling like that," Schneider said. "What Yanling could destroy an aluminum-alloy hall large enough for thousands of passengers? That kind of force is almost comparable to Rhine."

"We don't have time to send an investigation team, do we?" Manstein said.

"No investigation team. Send someone to recover the information directly. The board's deadline is seven tonight, local time." Schneider checked his watch. "About eight hours."

"Who can we send? Who's nearby? Dispatch someone local."

"People in other cities can't make it. Railways and airports are closed until nine tonight against aftershocks," Schneider said. "The campus maintenance staff could drive there; they have a group vacationing in China."

Manstein pictured those men with steel-hard arms and stone-slab chests and shook his head. "Maintenance can assist, but the agent should have a bloodline advantage."

"Then we can only call on students: A-rank Chu Zihang and S-rank Lu Mingfei. Both have an unquestionable bloodline advantage," Schneider said. "Their homes are local, and they're on summer break."

Even in this serious, tense moment that admitted no levity, Manstein gave a rueful smile at Lu Mingfei's name. A bloodline advantage? He had one, certainly; S-rank marked the highest bloodline. But...

"That's right! With Mingfei there's no problem! He's S-rank!" Guderian looked as though he'd found treasure in a garbage heap. As Lu Mingfei's adviser, he had always had confidence in his student.

"I really don't know where your confidence comes from. Your S failed two courses last semester; the transcript has already gone to the academic board." Manstein shook his head. "An S-rank who can't even use a Yanling. Without a Yanling he has no innate ability. As a hybrid he's useless."

"Send Chu Zihang," Schneider said. "He has successfully completed many missions."

"As head of the Discipline Committee, I'm responsible for student discipline, and there are things I remember very clearly. Your student Chu Zihang is a confirmed devotee of violence. His record contains twelve disciplinary citations for violent tendencies during missions!" Manstein shook his head again. "Put an ungraduated violent offender in charge of an SS-rank mission?"

"The Executive Department is itself an organization of violence!" Schneider was just as protective of his own student.

"I know you're the chief thug," Manstein said. "But no. Chu Zihang can't be in charge alone."

"We have no choice," Schneider said. "I know my student. Chu Zihang is suited to working alone."

"He doesn't have to go alone. Mingfei will support him!" Guderian seized the opportunity.

Manstein looked straight into Schneider's iron-gray eyes. "A top-level mission needs a top-level team. Chu Zihang does have a bloodline advantage, but he isn't good enough to carry out a mission of this level by himself. At most he can be one member of a team!"

"I head the Executive Department. This is its mission, and Chu Zihang is my student. Do you understand?" Schneider was just as forceful.

"There's Mingfei..." Guderian watched their gazes strike sparks.

After several seconds, Schneider and Manstein both realized neither could overwhelm the other. They turned simultaneously and paced apart in agitation.

"Mingfei..." Guderian looked from one to the other.

"Chu Zihang as agent! Lu Mingfei assisting!" Schneider and Manstein turned and spoke at once. At last they had compromised. They had no choice: time was running out, and no one could afford to offend the trustees.

"Norma, inform the board of the team roster," Schneider said, thrusting his fingers into the projection and moving them rapidly to summon information. "We're drawing up an operational plan and will report to them promptly."

"Understood." An elegant female voice came from speakers on all sides.

"The board has replied. The team is to be adjusted: S-rank Lu Mingfei is appointed agent for this mission, with A-rank Chu Zihang assisting him. Chu Zihang is to follow Lu Mingfei's direction." Several minutes later, Norma's voice came again from overhead.

All three duty professors froze. For a long time the control room was silent.

"My God! The board really does recognize Mingfei's talent!" Guderian pressed both hands to his chest in delight.

Manstein and Schneider both raised hands to their foreheads, perhaps checking for fever and wondering whether they were hallucinating. They knew exactly what the college's only S-rank Lu Mingfei was: a "gifted student" struggling on the verge of remedial exams; a loser who would have been demoted without the principal's unconditional protection; an unpredictable wild card who lost his nerve when needed and stunned everyone when he wasn't supposed to appear. Put someone like that in charge? Let him command the elite of the elite, Chu Zihang, president of the Lionheart Society, who had completed twelve missions without a single failure? How was that different from asking Cassell's number-one loser Fingel to solve the Sahara nuclear crisis? Were they trying to destroy the earth?

Morning sunlight poured through the skylight onto the empty basketball court. A ball struck a bright patch with a soothing thump, thump. Chu Zihang was alone, dribbling, crouching, breathing deeply.

An electronic whistle sounded across the court. Chu Zihang moved, driving forward with the ball, leaping like a hurricane, and dunking! His body blurred with speed, and the ball struck the floor so rapidly it sounded like automatic gunfire.

The ball never reached the floor. Chu Zihang landed first and caught it, then immediately turned, drove toward the other basket, and dunked again! The hoop gave a tremendous crack, as though it might break.

He repeated the cycle, the electronic scoreboard rolling upward. It was a basketball game with one player, but both sides' scores rose in turn.

The final whistle sounded, and the scoreboard reached 50–50. His shoes hissed sharply against the floor as he slid into the center circle and slowly straightened. Only then did the ball land with a thump at one side of the court.

Until that moment he had not shed a drop of sweat. A few seconds later it poured out as though a sluice had opened, soaking his jersey.

This was the basketball court in Chu Zihang's home; he was doing his morning exercise. In middle school he had played center on the city's youth team, but after his bloodline awakened, most human competitive sports became dull. Greater muscular strength, superior agility, and bones able to bend beyond ordinary angles meant playing basketball against normal people was now like golf: pure recreation. Few people at Cassell liked basketball. Even the girls could leap and dunk easily, making the game uninteresting. Intellectual contests such as go and sports such as downhill skiing, which tested agility and courage, were popular. No one wanted to play games won simply by brute strength.

So he could only play against himself, turning an enjoyable sport into monotonous morning exercise. Caesar always mocked his taste in sports. Caesar naturally preferred Cassell's classic pastime of sailing: noble and carefree, well-shaped arms drawing substantial ropes, cold water splashing against a bare chest as the boat sped across great lakes and oceans.

Chu Zihang kept playing basketball. He had never been an interesting person anyway.

That man had been the first to teach him basketball. That alone was enough reason to keep playing for life.

Chu Zihang jumped out of his red jersey and went into the shower. Even showering followed a procedure: exactly three minutes, one minute hot, one cold, one warm. The hot water drove out the remaining sweat; the cold tightened muscles and skin; the warm rinsed him clean before he left. While Caesar and the Student Council officers soaked in a petal-strewn whirlpool bath drinking beer, they often joked that if they were living in decadent ancient Rome, Chu Zihang was a medieval ascetic.

Caesar was not quite right. Chu Zihang did not enjoy hardship; he simply wanted to remain as precise as a machine.

Cold water flowed over his raised muscles like streams through mountain rocks. Muscles and tendons overheated by exercise slowly returned to normal. He breathed in and out rhythmically, slowing his heartbeat and blood flow. His physical training specialty was tai chi.

Then his phone, sealed in a waterproof bag, rang. He never let it leave his side, even in the shower.

"I have a mission for you." His adviser Schneider always spoke in commands, blunt as a club descending on one's head.

"I'm listening." Chu Zihang quickly dried himself.

"Urgent mission, SS-rank. Recover important information before seven tonight. Norma has emailed you the detailed instructions." Schneider paused and lowered his voice. "Exercise restraint... Don't make the scene too big. Avoid casualties as far as possible. Don't be like those lunatics in Equipment..." A faint explosion came through the receiver, and Schneider's voice filled with anger. "They're dismantling the campus!"

"SS?" Chu Zihang was uninterested in the Equipment Department's lunatics. It was the mission's classification that surprised him. The highest he had previously taken part in was A-rank.

"You heard correctly. You were originally scheduled to return to campus today, weren't you? Norma has booked you and Lu Mingfei on tonight's UA836 nonstop to Chicago."

"Lu Mingfei?" Chu Zihang was taken aback.

Schneider paused. Even a man as hard and blunt as he found this arrangement difficult to announce and had to choose his words. "The agent in charge is S-rank Lu Mingfei. Your job is to assist him. You are to follow his instructions."

Chu Zihang was confused. What did that mean? An emperor summons his great general and says he wants him to go north against the barbarians with Chief Palace Eunuch Lu. The general naturally knows Eunuch Lu is there as an overseer: the general does the fighting, the eunuch takes the credit, and the general can only thank the emperor and obey. That would be normal. What was abnormal was the emperor saying, I'll give Eunuch Lu armor, a sword, and a fine horse so he can charge in front, while you run logistics behind him... Wasn't that a plan to get Eunuch Lu killed?

"Understood." Chu Zihang's tone remained calm. He was not one to argue.

After hanging up, he opened his wardrobe. A long black tennis bag lay in the corner. He unzipped it to reveal a sword hilt wrapped in black rayskin, pressed against a racket. He took the hilt and drew the blade an inch. Iron-blue light flashed, and a chill ran swiftly up his wrist.

The sacred sword Murasame, the demon blade said to produce spring rain after killing, washing away the blood. Someone had cast this nonexistent sword from regenerated metal and enshrined it for ten years to cultivate its murderous aura.

"Did you get your Birkin? I've been on the waiting list for two years. Do you think they only sell them to VIPs?"

"I did. Last time I went to Europe, I bought tens of thousands of yuan worth of little things at Hermès, and the clerk quietly told me they had one in stock. I grabbed it without thinking. But it's alligator skin, and the pattern isn't very pronounced."

"Show-off! You're lucky to get one. When are you going to lend it to me?"

"Give me a kiss, pretty lady, and I'll reward you."

"Drop dead!" A woman curled up on the sofa kicked at the woman opposite with bare feet, which the other caught.

Four women of auntie age giggled, their hair disheveled, makeup smeared, rolling around on the sofa in silk nightgowns and drinking black tea to recover from their hangovers. Last night's three

bottles of cognac had been powerful enough to knock them all out, and they had slept in this state at Chu Zihang's home until the sun was high.

"It's nearly noon. What are we eating?" Someone suddenly felt hungry.

The door opened silently and a tall, slender boy walked in, glancing at the cans scattered across the floor and the four women who had been famous throughout the city for their beauty when young. He frowned. "What a mess. Couldn't you ask Auntie Tong to help clean up?"

"Oh, Zihang, you're so handsome! Come sit with Auntie a while," Auntie Shanshan said happily.

Chu Zihang wore faded blue jeans and a white T-shirt, simply dressed, with the black tennis bag across his body and the scent of freshly washed sandalwood in his hair.

He was no longer a little boy, but a genuine male. The beautiful aunties had no notion of being modest around him: graceful legs sprawled as before, slim waists twisted as before. They had watched him grow up. His mother had been the first of their circle to have a child, and the aunties adored this toy fallen from heaven. His early memories were traumatic: at two or three, enveloped in perfume and powder, scarlet lips all around, aunties competing to carry him and long elegant hands pinching his little bottom...

"I can't stay. I ordered food for you: two eel rice bowls and two teriyaki beef rice bowls," Chu Zihang said. "They'll be here soon."

"How thoughtful!" The aunties' eyes sparkled. Chu Zihang remembered what each of them liked to eat.

He looked at his mother, curled on the sofa under a thin blanket, and shook his head. "The air conditioning's too high. It's down to twenty degrees in here." He picked up the remote and adjusted it. "Air-conditioned rooms are dry. Drink plenty of water."

He went to the window and drew the curtains. "The public walkway is outside. People can see you dressed like that."

The nightgown sisterhood felt a little embarrassed. They nodded and tugged their gowns down over their thighs to show they accepted the correction.

"Going to play tennis?" his mother asked.

"Yes. I may be back late. I'm meeting some high-school classmates," he said. "I brewed your herbal medicine. It's in the refrigerator. Don't stop taking it once you've started, or the little bumps will come back on your face."

"Yes, yes! I remember, good boy. You're getting more and more naggy." His beautiful thirty-nine-year-old mother bounced up, mussed his hair with both hands, and planted a hard kiss on his cheek.

Naggy? Perhaps that came from the man's genes, Chu Zihang thought.

"As long as you remember." He turned and went out.

Later he understood why the man had always fretted about something as small as drinking milk. Perhaps he knew what had been lost could never be recovered and dared not ask for it, and only wanted to do something to show the past had not been an illusion, that he still had a connection to it.

It was a long thread leading back to the past. So long as it remained unbroken, perhaps there was still no despair, and he need not give up hope.

"I just can't resist a boy like your son, so poised and never smiling! My eyes are blinded by his radiance!" Auntie Shanshan announced.

"I can't help fangirling... He's too adorable! If I were twenty years younger, I'd carry him right out of your house!" Auntie Annie clutched her chest.

"As if you'd get a turn before me! Yingying, let Zihang be my godson!" Auntie EB shrieked.

"Dream on! How could my son be carried off by old women like you?" His mother's smug voice suddenly turned to giggles. "Oh, stop tickling, stop tickling! I was kidding, kidding! Shanshan, you can be my son's second mom from today, all right? Oh, I shouldn't have told you where I'm ticklish..."

Chu Zihang closed the door behind him, shutting out the women's clamor.

In the garage, beside the Mercedes S500, stood a new car, dark blue, long and low like a sleeping leopard: a Porsche Panamera, his "dad's" new toy. Dad had generously said Chu Zihang could use it whenever he liked. For one thing, Chu Zihang was a good driver, unlikely to damage it; for another, Dad was happy for his stepson to show their wealth and taste to classmates in his busy absence.

Chu Zihang sat in the driver's seat, lowered the sun visor, and studied his face in the mirror: clear lines, a broad forehead, straight nose, strong brows, and gentle black eyes, the face of a good student. He had been born looking like this. Even on a wanted poster, people would mistake his picture for an outstanding-student certificate.

He looked down and removed two soft black films from his eyes: Johnson & Johnson daily disposable cosmetic contacts, the popular Butterfly Black loved by fashionable girls. He closed his eyes, concentrated, and slowly opened them. Light flared in them like torches dropped into an ancient well!

He brushed back his hair and slowly, deliberately worked his facial muscles. The mirror now held another person: a face hard as a glacier, a flickering golden gleam deep in the pupils like will-o'-the-wisps. No one would willingly meet his eyes now. A savage, spear-sharp presence spread soundlessly; looking into those eyes was like having a gun with its safety off pressed between your brows.

Sometimes even Chu Zihang could not tell which was his real self.

He put on black sunglasses. "Start!"

The 4.8-liter V8 roared, the gears of the seven-speed PDK dual-clutch transmission meshing smoothly and delivering power evenly to all four wheels. The broad tires gripped the ground like a beast's claws curled before a pounce.

The roller door rose slowly. Sunlight poured over the windshield like a waterfall. Chu Zihang released the brake and floored the accelerator. The engine sang, and the Panamera pierced the brilliant curtain of light like a freshly sharpened sword.

Act Two

None of Our Young Classmates Are Losers

Every Junior Has A Good Time

The secretly circulated History of Shilan: Legends records that Lu Mingfei spent six years at school awkward, timid, and good for nothing. According to his cousin Lu Mingze, the legendary Lu had a pitiful background: his parents had abandoned him, gone abroad, and failed to show their faces for seven or eight years. Fostered at his uncle's house, he ate an enormous amount, a complete glutton... At Shilan High School, where outstanding people gathered, someone like him was a roadside weed, stepped on deliberately or otherwise by everyone.

At Sophie Lad Pizza, Lu Mingfei sat alone in a private room... carrying a toilet seat.

Damn it! Was this how you showed up to a Literature Club lunch? He looked like a foreign monk from the Western Regions arriving to wreck the place with some exotic weapon!

He had originally been in high spirits, but a courteous waiter stopped him at the door and knocked him senseless with one blow: "Out! Our restrooms all have squat toilets. We don't buy your toilet seats."

Lu Mingfei knew it looked bad, but what could he do? His aunt's orders outranked heaven. Even his uncle had to kneel on a keyboard if he disobeyed; who was Lu Mingfei to defy the decree? The building-supply market was some distance from his uncle's house, and after calculating every way, he had realized that buying the seat would leave no time to go home before lunch. He had to come straight here. Even then he had jogged all the way with the seat around his neck, feeling as if he wore the breastplate of a sacred suit of armor... and still he was the only one on time.

"Can't these people be more reliable?" The thought made him increasingly angry.

Apart from that, he was nervous. He hadn't seen a certain person in a long time and didn't know what expression to wear. People young and ignorant about love usually showed two symptoms: picking the least unfortunate-looking girl in class as their dream lover and even contemplating marrying her; and believing they could act convincingly before her, trying to produce a smile that would dazzle her without considering that nature had given them a bitter-melon face poorly suited to smiling.

Fortunately Lu Mingfei did not have a bitter-melon face. If he had to be compared to a vegetable, he was more like celery left too long in the sun...

The door opened, and in came someone short and plump, with a round belly no belt could contain.

"What's with that? Carrying a toilet?" The newcomer was startled by Lu Mingfei's appearance.

"Xu Yanyan?" He recognized him.

He was one of the twins in their class. At the Literature Club farewell, Zhao Menghua had declared his love to Chen Wenwen with an illuminated I love you display. Lu Mingfei had played the lowercase i; the Xu brothers had played the o. After a year apart they looked more like o's than ever.

Xu Yanyan looked him up and down. "Are you... all right?"

"I'm fine." Lu Mingfei was a little wooden, still rehearsing his long-awaited reunion smile in his head.

Nervous, Xu Yanyan perched on the edge of a chair and watched him from the corner of his eye.

Lu Mingfei was a legend at Shilan High.

As the city's foremost elite school, Shilan had no shortage of legends. Grade-ten pianists, grade-eight pipa players, and students who had passed College English Test Band Six were as plentiful as fish crossing a river. Each graduating class sent four or five scholarship students to America or Europe, and the school had supplied athletes to the national swim team and produced nationally ranked martial artists. One such fellow looked like a wandering hero, specialized in twin sabers, cut a dashing figure, and came from a wealthy family that chauffeured him in a Lexus. Whenever people saw him seated bolt upright in the rear of a luxury sedan, legs planted as though in a horse stance, two practice blades on his back and red tassels streaming over his shoulders... it was hard not to become a legend.

But once Lu Mingfei rose at Shilan High, every other legend paled.

The secretly circulated History of Shilan: Legends records that Lu Mingfei spent six years at school awkward, timid, and good for nothing. According to his cousin Lu Mingze, the legendary Lu had a pitiful background: his parents had abandoned him, gone abroad, and failed to show their faces for seven or eight years. Fostered at his uncle's house, he ate an enormous amount, a complete glutton... Naturally his grades were miserable, and he had a loose tongue; you never knew what nonsense would come out next. In class he either smiled dreamily out the window or sneaked naps in the back row, drooling all over his desk. No one attended parent-teacher meetings for him; presumably even his uncle and aunt couldn't bear the embarrassment.

At Shilan High, where outstanding people gathered, someone like him was a roadside weed, stepped on deliberately or otherwise by everyone.

His only talent was StarCraft. He made it work, mooching countless hours of internet access and drinks at cafés under the pretext of "teaching matches." Anyone wanting a few pointers only had to say, "Lu Mingfei, let's go to the internet café after school. I'll pay for your time and buy you a Nutritional Express drink," and he would sidle right up, shameless and ingratiating, without a shred of a teacher's dignity.

But legends are often made by a sudden, mysterious rise, blazing across the sky like a meteor!

Before his graduation, at the Literature Club farewell, everyone cheered when golden boy Zhao Menghua and beauty-ranked Chen Wenwen finally confessed and joined hands, while laughing at the legendary Lu for having once entertained improper hopes about someone...

An angel descended, bearing a sword!

A breathtaking young woman in the legendary Lu's service pushed open the doors, her beauty outshining the moon, bringing a whole company of pretty girls and an assortment of handsome clothes for him. She was all demure obedience before Lu Mingfei, and finally took his arm and whisked him away in a Ferrari.

Everyone talked about her beauty and presence: alluring and fierce, flowers and swords flying together. Shilan's boys were astonished and jealous; the girls felt that even all of them together could not match the grace of a single glance from her!

After that, Lu Mingfei shed his loser destiny and his life changed utterly. Soon news came that he had received the largest scholarship in Shilan's history to attend Cassell College, a private elite American university. Its admissions were so strict that all Shilan's top students had been rejected at interview, yet it seemed to beg Lu Mingfei to enroll. Later its principal sent Shilan's principal an enthusiastic letter thanking him for educating such a fine student. Comparing the letter's lavish praise with Lu Mingfei's transcript, which had crawled and struggled along the passing line, the principal felt his entire life had been an illusion.

Xu Yanyan secretly examined Lu Mingfei. After a year apart the legendary figure dressed just as before: a big white T-shirt, baggy shorts, and a pair of very unconvincing imitation Nikes.

As hopelessly uncool as ever.

Xu Yanyan decided to be cautious. With his stunning girl, Ferrari, and immense scholarship, Lu Mingfei had shattered countless people's confidence and risen to number one on Shilan's "This Villain Must Be Eliminated" list, an enemy every boy was entitled to kill. People could not bear seeing someone once beneath them rise to a height they had to look up at. But Xu Yanyan couldn't read him and dared not leap out and strike at once to rid the boys of this menace...

Xu Yanyan and Lu Mingfei had actually gotten along reasonably well before, but when someone in the group chat said Lu Mingfei was coming today, Xu's heart still skipped. Lu had been someone nobody respected, and Xu Yanyan had treated him coldly a few times. Now Lu Mingfei was a big shot, looking lost in another world and too indifferent to pay him attention. Who knew whether he held a grudge?

Lu Mingfei had not noticed Xu Yanyan watching. He was practicing his smile again, the corners of his mouth twitching stiffly. To Xu Yanyan it was a smile overflowing with indescribable murderous intent.

"Are you... fixing a toilet?" Xu Yanyan asked cautiously.

"No... I brought my own seat. It's more comfortable." Lu Mingfei didn't understand the question, but nonsense came naturally to his lips.

"Good for you." Xu Yanyan felt even less certain. A man with tens of thousands a year in scholarship money, a wealthy young master fixing toilets? Successful yet humble: a formidable rival indeed!

Another person entered, looking as though cast from the same mold as Xu Yanyan. He glanced at Lu Mingfei and also started. "Lu Mingfei? Are you... all right?"

"I'm fine, I'm fine." Lu Mingfei didn't understand why everyone asked.

The private room fell strangely quiet. Brothers Xu Yanyan and Xu Miaomiao spoke in low voices, stealing occasional glances at the legend opposite them. His gaze was vacant, he smiled from time to time, and he held a toilet seat. Though they couldn't read him, his murderous aura was unmistakable.

Fifteen minutes later people arrived in twos and threes. Every time the door opened a familiar face appeared, startled into asking if Lu Mingfei was all right, until he began to feel a little crazy himself and scratched his head with an embarrassed smile. Finally even Liu Miaomiao, the pretty pianist who rarely took part in Literature Club activities, arrived. The gathering had become a small class reunion. The room grew lively as everyone exchanged news, and fewer people paid attention to Lu Mingfei.

"What's on special?" Xu Yanyan studied the menu.

"Who cares? Zhao Menghua said he's paying for everything today. A fully loaded surf-and-turf pizza each and unlimited cola refills!" Xu Miaomiao announced.

"Country bumpkin! If Young Master Zhao's paying, why pizza? I'll have black-truffle meat-sauce pasta with Caspian caviar!" someone said.

"Keep pretending! Caspian caviar? Do you even know where the Caspian is?" Xu Miaomiao jeered. "That stuff won't fill you up. What's the point?"

"I saw it was the most expensive... I'm sharpening my knife to fleece Zhao Menghua. Haven't you heard? His family's company is going public. It'd be a waste not to!"

"Young Master Zhao's more of a class enemy every day! He's about to overtake..." Xu Miaomiao glanced at Lu Mingfei. "...and become number one on the 'This Villain Must Be Eliminated' list!"

"The boss has always been the class enemy among class enemies," one of Zhao Menghua's followers chimed in.

Only Liu Miaomiao was quiet, sitting obediently with her hands on her knees and smiling with pursed lips. She had always been a pretty girl who spoke softly and seemed a little delicate, looking a year or two younger than the others, with long fair hands, grade-ten piano skills, and sweet, well-behaved eyes. The boys in Lu Mingfei's class had split into three camps: one supporting the "Little Celestial Princess" Su Xiaoqiang, another declaring Liu Miaomiao much prettier than Su, and the rest under Chen Wenwen's banner.

Lu Mingfei let his thoughts wander through his school days. Chen Wenwen had still not arrived.

"You're at Fudan?" he tried, making conversation with Liu Miaomiao.

He had once been a stalwart champion in Chen Wenwen's camp, dismissing Liu Miaomiao as a little kid. In truth he admitted to himself that she was pretty, but he couldn't stand seeing boys flock around her like male attendants to a little goddess. He had even heard two of her admirers confide in each other: "I guess I won't get to marry Liu Miaomiao in this life. I'll let you have her!" The other had thumped his chest and said, "Don't worry. I'll treat her well!"

What kind of brotherly loyalty was that?

But Liu Miaomiao had been nice enough to Lu Mingfei, willing to talk to him. Once, bored, he asked how she practiced piano. She said it was hard work and you had to train finger strength from childhood. Then she played several measures powerfully with one hand against the window, making the glass tremble. Lu Mingfei couldn't produce that effect. He remembered the beautiful patterns of light and shadow her long, slender fingers left on the glass, and never called her a little kid again.

"Mm." Liu Miaomiao nodded.

She wore a Dai-style tube skirt dyed with blue silk-tree blossoms and a white camisole, her hair in a high ponytail. She even had light makeup on. In less than a year the little kid had blossomed; sleazy middle-aged men would probably turn to look if she walked down the street now. A year had passed and everyone seemed to have changed a little. None of their young classmates were losers.

Lu Mingfei glanced at the mirror. The fellow in it looked unlucky, his messy head like a clump of chicken feathers. He wanted to cover his face. Who would have thought Cassell's elite education could produce something like this? He had once read in Zhiyin that whether a person could become an aristocrat depended on their surroundings before age thirteen. Sure enough, a bumpkin was a bumpkin

for life. Even if he drove his Bugatti Veyron here, he wouldn't have Caesar's aura of a crown prince arriving.

Head drooping, he stood to escape the noisy room and wander outside. He pushed the door open. Bang.

Outside was an enormous face with a red mark down the middle, struck by the edge of the glass door.

Zhao Menghua, today's host and benefactor, stared at him as though he'd seen a ghost, unable to understand how Lu Mingfei could remain so calm after hitting him. In the past Zhao had paid for drinks and internet access while Lu flattered him; they had worked together beautifully. Now Lu Mingfei's eyes were vacant, as though he saw no one or his mind was far away.

"I'm fine, I'm fine," Lu Mingfei said hastily, coming to himself. Habit had taken over: those had been his first words to every classmate today.

"I... I'm not!" Zhao Menghua clutched his head.

In the past Zhao would have exploded, but for the moment he didn't dare. He couldn't read Lu Mingfei.

Zhao Menghua had been the city's top scorer in their year's college entrance exams and entered Peking University's Guanghua School of Management. His family had connections, and a place as a Yale exchange student in his junior or senior year was already arranged. Everything was wonderful; he should have been a legend himself. But their year had produced Lu Mingfei, a dark horse as black as a lump of coal, who stole all his glory. Shilan's old principal had no idea what Cassell College was, but when he calculated Lu Mingfei's scholarship at roughly 300,000 yuan a year, he was astounded. When the entrance-exam results were posted, Lu Mingfei's name appeared above top scorer Zhao Menghua, on a line of its own, truly outshining everyone! Zhao gazed up at the huge red notice while the crowd discussed the legendary Lu Mingfei. Him? That lowercase i? Zhao was so depressed he nearly spat blood.

Lu Mingfei went out, Zhao Menghua came in, and the door closed between them. Inside, a chorus called, "Boss!"

In the long corridor, fierce sunlight came from the right, erasing darkness layer by layer. Long shadows of windows and a person lay across the floor. The figure's long hair and skirt hem shifted gently in the breeze. Lu Mingfei slowly turned his head right and saw a white cotton dress and a book held in hands folded over it.

The corridor was long, but unfortunately it was empty. Nothing could obstruct their view of each other.

Silence.

"It's not like I'm meeting my first girlfriend. Why am I such a coward?" All the smiles he had prepared came to nothing. Seeing her again, he still didn't know what expression to wear.

"Chen Wenwen: Lu Mingfei's first unrequited crush, three years long, ended without result; she fell to Zhao Menghua."

If Lu Mingfei had a life file and reread it in old age, that would be all it said about Chen Wenwen. They had never held hands, seen a movie, or traveled together; he had never had the slightest chance. An unremarkable unrequited love. In the gradually fading memories, what sometimes flashed past was

the hem of a white dress on a bench on the first day of school and the light and shadow across the girl's face.

"Hi, Lu Mingfei," Chen Wenwen said.

"Oh, I'm going to the restroom," he said.

They passed each other.

Lu Mingfei wandered around the restroom and returned to find the pizza already served, everyone eating with enthusiasm. The splendid toilet seat lay on his chair, with Chen Wenwen seated beside it. He hesitated, but that was the only seat left. He sat down gingerly and forked a piece of pizza onto his plate. Chen Wenwen smiled and nodded; perhaps she hadn't slept well, for her complexion was poor. After two bites he looked up and realized Zhao Menghua sat opposite them.

"What the hell?" he muttered inwardly.

Chen Wenwen was Zhao Menghua's girlfriend. Naturally she should sit with him.

He worried they were playing another trick on him; it wouldn't be the first. Looking around, he suddenly realized they were seated this way because of him. No one had chosen the seat beside Lu Mingfei, and Chen Wenwen had arrived last, leaving her only that place.

"Should I swap seats with someone?" he asked Chen Wenwen awkwardly.

Chen Wenwen shook her head, busy texting. When she finished she placed her phone face down on the table and began drinking cream-of-mushroom soup. The bowl hid her face; Lu Mingfei couldn't even steal a glance.

Across the room Zhao Menghua's phone beeped. He read the new message, sent a brief reply, and also laid his phone face down.

"Boss, you've really made it!" A follower reached for Zhao's hand.

"Only just noticed?" Zhao shook it, a little uncomfortable. "Why are you shaking my hand? What's this about?"

"Who wants to hold a man's hand? I wanted to see your watch." The follower seized his wrist, revealing a heavy watch whose face shimmered faintly gold and blue. "Rolex?"

"Wow, a Yacht-Master! Caliber 4016! Boss, you're wearing a gold watch!" Some classmates knew their watches.

Everyone put down their pizza and gathered around Zhao's watch. The other side of the table grew lively; here only Chen Wenwen and Lu Mingfei remained among half-eaten slices.

Lu Mingfei wanted to look too. A good watch was always cool to a boy. Though he knew little about watches, he understood their great significance: like monkeys on South Pacific islands stuffing fruit into their cheeks to create a powerful jawline and attract females. Expensive male adornment. Caesar often wore a Patek Philippe, occasionally switching to a Zenith or Glashütte.

But Lu Mingfei didn't move, because Chen Wenwen hadn't. If he joined the crowd, she would be left alone. She was still texting.

The conversation grew livelier. Several boys wore watches and showed them off, also discussing how so-and-so had bought a Jeep to drive around campus, how another had failed three courses because he took golf lessons, and how another never lived in a dorm but rented a serviced apartment for twelve thousand a month. These subjects were far removed from poor Lu Mingfei. Those people

were distant too. The closest person to him now was Chen Wenwen, right before his eyes and as far away as the horizon.

She did not spare him even a glance, texting on and on.

How awkward. Suddenly he missed Fingel. If his useless senior were here, he clearly wouldn't be embarrassed... He'd seize the opportunity to drag the lobster pizza over to himself! Lu Mingfei felt a sudden delight and quietly pulled the whole freshly served lobster pizza close. Smelling the melted cheese, he felt better and laughed without thinking.

The laugh sounded so lewd and sleazy that everyone turned at once. The room suddenly fell quiet.

Lu Mingfei ducked his head.

Chen Wenwen pressed Send.

Zhao Menghua's phone beeped. "You have a new message."

Lu Mingfei knew whom she was texting. Suddenly it all became clear, a startling discovery: so this was the great advantage of having a girlfriend! Even if you didn't sit together at dinner you could text, talking slowly in a noisy crowd... whether to go out this weekend... whether yesterday's beef-noodle shop was good... a great comic you'd read lately... the flower you'd planted in the botanical garden last year had sprouted... Beep, back and forth.

However noisy the surroundings, the two of you still had a world of your own, quiet enough to hear a flower seed lost in the shade beneath a window last spring begin to sprout.

How literary. Literary enough to make a person sad.

Lu Mingfei's battle-tested eyes were blinded by envy, jealousy, and resentment. Why hadn't he noticed before? Oh, so that was it. He never knew how close other people were in private... He was always an idiot. His thoughts ran wild, and he grinned silently. Sometimes when he didn't know what expression to wear, he smiled like a fool.

Zhao Menghua retrieved his Rolex and put it on. "Eat, everyone, eat."

Liu Miaomiao sat nearby silently looking at her phone. Everyone else returned to their seats, chewing pizza and cursing some professor for being such a maniac.

The atmosphere was strangely stifling.

"I'm going to the restroom." Lu Mingfei stood.

At the waiter's "squat toilet," Lu Mingfei held a wad of paper and assumed the standard squatting position, but he was actually thinking. Suddenly many things tumbled through his mind.

On Nono's birthday, her official boyfriend Caesar had been leading the Student Council's lovely girls in white lace dresses around campus with submachine guns to slay a dragon, while Lu Mingfei and Nono watched the stars by the cold spring on the hill. Nono had placed her phone on a rock, waiting for someone's birthday wishes. He had sat beside her, kicking the icy water, feeling in tune with the red-haired little witch. Later he had given her a sky full of fireworks. His heart had stirred with foolish hopes.

One afternoon he and Chen Wenwen had classroom-cleaning duty. She sat on the teacher's platform with a faint smile, head bowed over her phone. He happily waved his mop and ran around, because in a world the size of the classroom only he and Chen Wenwen existed. He felt incredibly close to her, as if even holding hands wasn't impossible. Foolish hopes stirred.

At the Literature Club graduation gathering, he and Chen Wenwen returned from booking movie tickets and walked beside the river. She texted with her head down, her sleeve brushing his shoulder. A little deer bounded in his heart... No! Hundreds of two-and-a-half-meter stags with huge antlers crashed exuberantly around his chest, making his nose threaten to bleed and his face glow. He felt the moment belonged to him and Chen Wenwen and wished the road could stretch to the edge of the sky... Foolish hopes stirred...

Damn it! Was "foolish hopes stirring" all worth writing in the history of his love life?

Every time his hopes stirred, the other person had been sending or awaiting a text. A young hero and heroine ride one horse across a vast grassland, sky wide, clouds low, a lone goose calling in the west wind; he in white, she in red, and he wishes the moment could last forever. Meanwhile the heroine's lips move as she uses a long-distance voice technique to exchange love songs with her boyfriend far to the south. What kind of crap plot was that? What garbage writer would create such a pathetic male lead?

But if Lu Mingfei lived in a book... the book had been written by a garbage writer... and he was that utterly pathetic male lead.

No, not the lead. Just passerby A, B, C, or D.

Sometimes he thought Nono and Caesar didn't talk much and didn't seem particularly close... and foolish hopes stirred. But they were boyfriend and girlfriend, for heaven's sake. When Nono and Caesar were alone together... did they hold hands? Hug? Kiss? Damn it, Boss Caesar looked every inch a handsome, debauched, sex-starved devil!

The saddest thing in the world was secretly loving a girl while she happily shared her life with someone else. While you walked alone in moonlight, thinking of her in literary sorrow, under that same moon she held someone's hand, leaned into someone's arm, and kissed someone's lips... The air was full of the hormones of mutual desire...

Lu Mingfei picked at a crack in the floor tiles in grief and indignation, convinced no one in the vast world was sadder than he. Then he remembered he was in a restroom, and that crack in the tiles... A wave of nausea abruptly halted the melancholy literary mood in his head.

A text chimed. With the finger that had picked the tile crack held up delicately, Lu Mingfei extracted his phone and opened it.

"Happy birthday, wishing you a happy birthday, happiness every day of your life, never mind how you spend your birthday... I've learned Zheng Zhihua's 'Happy Birthday.' It's the first Chinese song I can sing. The attachment is my recording, your birthday present. As you know, your senior is dirt poor, so let's skip gifts that cost money." Sender: Useless Senior.

That was his roommate Fingel. Lu Mingfei had given him that name in his contacts as revenge: Fingel listed Lu Mingfei as Idiot Junior.

Lu Mingfei was touched. It was rare for anything in his useless senior's shaggy head to remember his birthday. The emotion didn't last long... because he couldn't resist opening the attachment. Fingel sang in German-accented Mandarin, wildly off-key being a perfect description, but he put force into every word and had clearly made an effort. Only... wasn't this "Happy Birthday" that song by the old-school literary singer from the 1980s?

"Your birthday reminds me of a friend from long ago. It was a cold winter, and he wandered the streets. I thought he wanted to beg for something, but he always shook his head..." Fingel sang on with extravagant feeling.

Was a song this miserable really a birthday greeting? It sounded more like something to play at his grave. Lu Mingfei covered his face and sighed deeply.

He closed the attachment, pulled up his baggy shorts, and stood. Looking up, he saw a line of neat writing on the partition: "I'm very boyish... seeking a lesbian... phone 138XXXXXXXX."

"Someone looking for a lesbian in the men's room?" He stared.

Wait!

His head buzzed. Something was wrong! Seeking a lesbian in the men's room plainly defied ordinary logic, but with a different way of thinking... everything made sense!

Damn it! Depressed when he came in, he hadn't checked the sign on the door!

Holding up his shorts, half squatting, legs weak, he couldn't stand up. No way. The wrong room again? Once was an accident, twice was natural absentmindedness, three times... that was a hobby!

He rapidly considered countermeasures. There was no time for hesitation. Only a few meters separated the stall from the door; if no one noticed, he could sprint out in three to five seconds. He tried combing his hair forward to hide his face. The look might barely pass for... a tomboy?

He pricked up his ears. It was quiet outside; apparently still safe. Relieved, he fastened his shorts and loosened his ankles as though preparing for a hundred-meter sprint.

"Did you tell her or not?" A girl's voice came from the corridor outside.

"It has nothing to do with her. Why should I?" a boy answered impatiently.

"If you don't tell her she'll find out sooner or later. Can you avoid seeing each other forever?"

"You know what she's like. She's exhausting, moping all day. What good would telling her do? She'd cling to me as though I owed her something."

"Don't talk about her like that... When you were together, didn't you say she was pretty nice?" The girl's voice grew quieter.

"How was I supposed to know what she was like at first? Oversensitive for no reason, playing gloomy one moment, pitiful the next, then unbearably bossy, as if the world had to revolve around her. Whoever wants to cater to her can do it. I'm done!"

"If we broke up someday... you wouldn't talk about me like that too, would you?"

"Come on, you're different from her. I'd never say that about you. I tell everyone how great you are... Damn, wrong answer. That day will never come. We won't break up! I'd have to hit my head to break up with you." The boy laughed ingratiatingly.

"Stop it! Why are you all over me?"

"Pretty skirt... Did you buy it in Yunnan?"

The jumbled sounds of kissing, fabric rubbing, footsteps, and soft murmurs faded away. Lu Mingfei turned to stone, his head buzzing.

Zhao Menghua and Liu Miaomiao had just passed along the corridor outside.

"Kissing and groping right there. Did they think I didn't exist?" Lu Mingfei muttered.

Of their three class beauties, Chen Wenwen, Liu Miaomiao, and Su Xiaoqiang, Zhao Menghua had hooked two: when the class flowers bloomed, he was the one smiling among them... A real winner in life. Once Lu Mingfei understood, righteous indignation filled him! Not just for himself, but for all the boys in class. There were already more boys than girls, and Zhao was taking more than his share! What was this? A waste of resources!

He was also a little dazed. The world changed so quickly. It was as though you looked up and everyone had gone far ahead, leaving you, a little kid, standing where you were.

He pushed open the stall door and walked out, then abruptly stopped.

In the mirror above the sinks he saw Sadako: white dress, black hair hanging over her face. Both hands were beneath the faucet, but the water wasn't running. She stood frozen in the posture of washing them.

At that moment he would rather it had really been Sadako, slowly crawling out of the mirror. At worst he could have screamed, "A ghost!"

But it was Chen Wenwen.

"I-I... came into the wrong restroom..." he explained. Only after speaking did he realize how irrelevant that was.

As though she hadn't seen him, Chen Wenwen turned on the faucet, wet her hands, and patted water onto her face. Her phone lay on the sink. When she reached for it, she fumbled; it clattered to the floor and slid across the tiles toward Lu Mingfei.

He slowly bent to pick it up, looked at her expression, and carefully offered it back. His curiosity was too strong. His eyes darted to the messages on the screen. Chen Wenwen used an iPhone too; its messaging system displayed all the texts with one person like a chat log, stringing scattered memories together.

"You're not wearing the bracelet I gave you last birthday..."

"Did you get my text just now? The one about the bracelet..."

"Got it. I'm not wearing it today. Too hot."

"Yes, it's too hot. I couldn't sleep last night, kept thinking about the past. I could only sleep an hour or two at a time. Did you sleep well?"

"All right. Drink a glass of milk before bed and you'll sleep."

"Do you still think about me?"

"Don't overthink it. We're still classmates."

"Last night I dreamed I was rowing down a river. I texted to ask where you were, and you said you were waiting on the bridge ahead. I rowed forward, but there was fog everywhere and I rowed a long time without seeing a bridge. I texted again and you said you were still waiting on the bridge. I wondered if it was behind me and rowed hard back, but the current was too fast, so I kept going forward... Then I woke up."

"Don't overthink it. Calm your mind and you won't dream."

"Do you understand what the dream means?"

"Yes, but I don't want to hear it. There's no point. Saying less is better for both of us."

"You don't want to hear me anymore. Do you have a new girlfriend?"

"Stop asking! We're at a gathering today. Let me eat in peace! You keep texting, and Lu Mingfei beside you can see!"

"Don't be angry. If you've found a new girlfriend, I'll wish..."

That final text was unfinished. Now there was no need to send it.

Want to wish them well? Easy: go out at once, buy flowers, rush in, and give them to Liu Miaomiao, saying, Little sister, you're wonderful; I can rest easy knowing Zhao Menghua is with you... But was that really what she wanted to say? Bless them? Bullshit. Even Lu Mingfei, whose romantic experience was a blank canvas fit for the most beautiful picture, wouldn't fall for it!

His face twitched. He didn't know what expression to wear.

Actually he had reason to smile smugly. The girl you once liked gave you a polite rejection and threw herself into the arms of a glamorous young prince, and now he'd dumped her. If the petty heart inside you didn't laugh a little, who would believe it? Karma never failed! Ha ha ha! Shouldn't you kick her while she was down, saying, "You thought I was a loser, but my feelings were sincere and dependable. What did that playboy have apart from money and looks?" Or you could be more gentlemanly and say considerately, "It'll pass. Who hasn't had their heart broken?" while secretly exulting, That's for kicking me aside!

But Lu Mingfei only scratched his head and sighed.

He was too timid, so timid he scarcely had a vengeful thought. In a dream Lu Mingze had asked, "Don't you want revenge on the world?" Lu Mingfei had never really thought about it. Not only that, he constantly handed out sympathy, even to Chen Wenwen, who had given him the polite rejection.

Reading the messages, he felt that Chen Wenwen was exhausted and had used all her strength. Her face was wet and pale, so tired it hurt to see.

"Don't look," she said softly, taking the phone from his hand and switching off the screen. "It's all right."

"Oh, okay." He nodded quickly.

Chen Wenwen lifted her long white skirt to wipe her face, arranged her hair, took a deep breath, and straightened her chest. A resentful woman? Not at all. She looked more like Joan of Arc going into battle.

"Don't say anything. Promise." She looked at Lu Mingfei in the mirror.

She had always spoken to him like that. In the Literature Club, when she assigned him something such as arranging the venue, she would say, "Make sure it's arranged. Promise," as if his promise could really guarantee anything.

"Mm. I promise." As before, he raised his hand.

They returned to the room, where a fresh round of pizza had arrived. Everyone was cheerful. It seemed the party was livelier without the two of them.

Lu Mingfei ate absently, watching the people around him. They all seemed different now. He noticed details: Zhao Menghua took two slices and tore one off for Liu Miaomiao; she absentmindedly drank his cola; the boys who used to praise her beauty no longer stole glances at the slender legs beneath her skirt; Zhao and Liu sat close together and far from the others.

Suddenly he understood. When it came to feelings he was a complete idiot. He had never understood other people's looks. Everything he thought he knew was wrong.

Zhao Menghua glanced at Chen Wenwen opposite him, a strange light flashing in his eyes. He cleared his throat and reached into his pocket like a leader about to make a speech. Liu Miaomiao hurriedly pulled at him under the table, but he shook her off.

Lu Mingfei suddenly felt uneasy. He didn't know what Zhao intended, but instinct told him it would be idiotic, stupid, and had to be stopped, even if that meant pouring a glass of cola over his head.

Damn it, why was his glass always empty at moments like this?

Zhao stood with a blue velvet jewelry box in hand and looked around the table. "Since everyone's here today, I'll announce something..." He glanced down at Liu Miaomiao, who instinctively avoided his eyes, cheeks flushed as though she had drunk a great deal.

He opened the box. Inside was a Tiffany platinum wire ring. "Nobody's allowed to pursue Liu Miaomiao anymore. Anyone who does answers to me... We're getting engaged. This is the engagement ring."

Everyone fell silent. Though they knew about Zhao and Liu, engagement... in freshman year? What grand family still played the engagement game?

"Boss, your family actually lets you get engaged?" a follower asked.

"Hell, my mom kept saying if I thought she was right, I should make it official. Mom bought the ring herself. What? Got a problem? I'm telling you so nobody tries to pursue her without knowing and runs into a wall." Zhao grinned and surveyed the table, his eyes not pausing on Chen Wenwen.

"Of course it's fine! So that's why we're having lunch. If I'd known, I'd have bought a present," the follower said quickly.

"Zhao Menghua, you're ruthless. Engaged as soon as you win her over, leaving us brothers no hope at all," someone congratulated him with a mournful face.

"Then we should order a few beers."

"Bumpkin! For something this big it has to be champagne. You think Zhao Menghua can't afford it? If we don't fleece him now, when will we?"

"Come on, put the ring on her! Pictures! Can we post them in the alumni group?"

"Happy now? I've told everyone." Zhao grinned at Liu Miaomiao. "Now you're tied to me for good... marry a carrying pole and you have to carry it around..."

"Stop it..." She lowered her head and pinched his waist.

"Ow, look, she's hitting me..." Zhao laughed and teased his girlfriend—no, now his fiancée.

While the room buzzed with celebration, outside everyone's gaze, a person silently crumbled, as though consumed by fire until only ashes remained.

"Hey, man, you..." Someone stood, the corner of his eye twitching, and stared at Zhao Menghua. "Have you no decency?"

The room fell dead silent. Everyone looked at Lu Mingfei as though they had seen Godzilla.

Lu Mingfei understood why Zhao had done it. He had to give his current girlfriend an assurance. Anyone who landed Liu Miaomiao would be so happy he'd parade around campus banging a lunch basin and blowing snot bubbles, wishing everyone knew he had claimed that flower. Zhao had been

fairly careful today, holding back because Chen Wenwen didn't know yet. But Liu had a knot in her heart, and Zhao had to make a gesture. By evening news of the engagement would spread across the school; everyone would know what a devoted boyfriend he was, and from then on Zhao and Liu would be bound together openly and properly.

But Lu Mingfei had something to say. He wanted to say... She already knows, she's been struggling to hold herself together and can't much longer, she won't text you anymore or nag you... What are you showing off for with your arm around your new girlfriend? We all know how cool and handsome you are, big brother! Of course you won't lack girlfriends! Your life must be wonderfully happy, with a girlfriend to eat late-night snacks with, unlike a loser like me... Oh, right, nothing to do with me... In short, all those thousands of words came down to one sentence:

"You're already happy... just leave her a way to live!"

Lu Mingfei delivered his bold, powerful speech in his head, but not one word escaped his mouth.

He glanced at Chen Wenwen, who was close to falling apart, and sighed. He knew her personality: if he said those things, she would suffer most.

So he could only puff out his cheeks and glare at Zhao Menghua with eyes that were neither quite timid nor quite arrogant, so much white showing around the irises. In high school his homeroom teacher had once said before the whole class, "Lu Mingfei, are you really that useless? Are you a dead weight? You alone dragged our class average down half a point. You're unbelievable." Lu had answered with the same stare, impossible to tell whether it was stupidity or defiance, and made the teacher's heart race.

Lu Mingfei was confident that stare was still quite lethal... Apart from that he didn't have much killing power.

Actually, playing the brave young defender was not for him; this was the situation he handled worst. He instinctively feared awkward scenes. Watching Tom Hanks in Cast Away, for example, Hanks lived like a savage on an island for years after a plane crash, yearning to return to his wife and child. After endless hardship he finally got home, emotions surging at the door—Hanks didn't yet know his wife had remarried, but Lu Mingfei watching did. So he would urgently change channels to avoid embarrassment that had nothing to do with him. He couldn't bear the door opening and Hanks seeing his wife approach in tears on a strange man's arm. Even a movie scene was unbearable.

But this time his brain had overheated and he had run right into the scene himself, playing a passerby with a sense of justice. Really, what the hell did any of it have to do with him?

Zhao Menghua's face twisted, his brow knotted as though the god Erlang's third eye lay hidden there, ready to open and stare the damned monkey before him to death.

"None of your damn business!" He spat the words like a deadly dart from an outlaw's mouth.

"You're right," Lu Mingfei said.

Zhao froze. He had prepared several more concise and vicious replies for when Lu finished talking tough. But Lu Mingfei had readily admitted it.

Yet Lu didn't move away, still holding that wide-eyed stare.

"What do you want?" Zhao stepped forward.

"Nothing." It was true. Lu hadn't had time to think. Given a minute to consider, he might well have retreated.

Zhao nearly broke down, veins jumping in his neck, but several friends held him back. "We're classmates... Forget it, forget it."

Zhao took a deep breath, glared at Lu, and forced out through his teeth, "Pay the bill! We're leaving! What are we eating for? I've lost my appetite! I'll take you all somewhere else for Italian tonight!"

Lu Mingfei breathed easier. Good. Let it end here, leaving room to retreat. Hybrids were supposed to have exceptional physical abilities; Caesar's beautiful Student Council combat squad could take on 200-pound wrestlers in high heels and evening gowns. But that advantage had never appeared in Lu Mingfei, and he had yet to take a fighting class. If it came to blows, two of him would be no match for Zhao. He glanced at Chen Wenwen. She stared blankly into a corner, as though the scene had nothing to do with her.

"The emperor isn't worried, but the eunuch is..." Lu Mingfei muttered inwardly.

The bill came. Zhao pulled several notes from his wallet and tossed them onto the tray, then thought better of it, took one back, and pointed at Lu. "This one pays for himself! Nothing to do with me!"

"Fine, I'll pay for myself." Lu wasn't afraid of that; instead, his spirits rose.

A Cassell student ID was also an American Express credit card with a hundred-thousand-dollar limit! Though he was penniless, he could borrow from an American bank by swiping it! Without thinking he took out his student card. Nicknamed the black card, it had a matte-black surface stamped in pure silver with the college emblem, the half-rotten World Tree. With the gesture of an emperor handing out a tip, he held it between two fingers and passed it to the server.

"We don't take library cards..." The young waitress spoke timidly.

Dark lines covered Lu Mingfei's face. "Get the card machine... I'll show you..."

Someone drew a sharp breath. The back of the card bore both the Citi Bank and American Express logos. Shilan students considered themselves worldly and knew what an American Express black card meant. The highest black card had no spending limit and was called the Centurion; only a very small number of credit cards were permitted to be pure black.

The waitress quickly brought the terminal. Lu entered his PIN with an air of surveying all beneath him, spinning the pen in his palm as he waited for the slip to sign.

"Fake. Declined," the waitress said in her local accent, the words sounding like "tragedy."

It really was a tragedy. The terminal displayed PAYMENT DECLINED.

Sweating coldly, Lu swiped the black card he carried everywhere, the symbol of his incomparable S-rank status, again and again. It was refused each time, as though the mighty organization in North America had abandoned him.

Someone laughed, and sneers rose around the room.

"Pay cash," someone said mildly.

The door opened and air stirred, like breaking the clay seal on a jar to let in a cool breeze. The young man entering placed several large notes in the black billfold and returned it to the waitress. "Keep the change."

Only a class enemy could utter such punchable words; normally anyone hearing them ought to give him the finger. But this boy spoke with natural detachment, without a trace of showiness. No one

noticed how he had suddenly entered, without a sound. He wore faded jeans and a white T-shirt, enormous sunglasses, and no expression on the half of his face visible.

Such a figure looked ordinary enough to be found on any street, nothing remarkable. But Liu Miaomiao suddenly stood, staring at him, tense.

Lu Mingfei also sprang up, tense. But his tension was different from hers. His instinct was that something had happened; why else would these human-dragon hybrids come looking for him during summer break? And he knew exactly why this fellow carried a tennis bag. Whenever he appeared with any long object, you had to be careful: repeated experience showed he would inevitably draw a blade from it.

"How much longer until lunch ends? The college has something for us to do. I'm here to assist you," the boy told Lu. "Waiting for you to start, boss."

Boss? This fellow called him boss? Lu thought he was hearing things. Don't joke! Since when was he this man's boss? Boss Caesar had wanted to take over the Lionheart Society for years, only to be repelled head-on by this harmless-looking fellow.

Yet it didn't seem to be a joke. This man supposedly had no sense of humor whatsoever.

"Chu Zihang. We're all alumni." The boy briefly removed his sunglasses, then put them back on.

This time everyone turned to stone.

For Shilan students three years above or below him, "Chu Zihang" was a symbol, always far out of reach.

You knew his name and had seen him, but couldn't quite remember his face, because you rarely had a chance to get close.

At graduation he spoke for the student body in a sea-blue uniform, head lowered over his notes and bangs hiding his face. On the basketball court he played center, devastating opponents and leaping to dunk; by the time the ball landed he was already turning back toward midcourt, not even high-fiving teammates. At the Spring Festival show he played a cello solo of the theme from Schindler's List. While the audience remained immersed in the music, thinking his talent belonged on the national gala, Chu Zihang had already packed his cello, bowed, and left the stage, leaving only a slender back.

In Liu Miaomiao's memory, every time she saw Chu Zihang it was raining.

Beyond the eaves rain fell in curtains, mist drifting between the strands. Chu Zihang stood under the roof in a brown denim overshirt, a scarf tied at the collar, hands in his pockets. A bag hung from one shoulder, bulging with what was obviously a basketball. He bent slightly like bamboo in the wind, its joints firm. Faint daylight haloed his dark silhouette.

Liu Miaomiao walked forward surrounded by girls from her class. It felt as though hundreds of little frogs had been stuffed into her heart, jumping furiously. She talked and laughed with the girls as they approached that figure. Each step closer seemed long, so long that time nearly stopped. At last she stood behind him. Chu Zihang politely shifted aside and nodded. She noticed his bangs were wet from the rain, hanging over his eyes.

Time resumed its normal pace. Chu Zihang and Liu Miaomiao passed each other.

After walking a long way, she suddenly turned her head and asked, "Can you see if I have a pimple?" Her classmates leaned close and said no. She said good, it had felt itchy, and quietly withdrew her backward glance.

Through layers of rain Chu Zihang still stood there. Liu Miaomiao had always thought he liked rainy days. Whenever it rained, he seemed so absorbed that she wanted to brush his soaked bangs aside and see his eyes.

Chu Zihang had used his life to define one word: awesome.

So awesome that even a meteoric force like Lu Mingfei could only prostrate himself beneath Brother Chu's slim-fit jeans. The true hidden number one on the "This Villain Must Be Eliminated" list would always be Chu Zihang.

For Liu Miaomiao and many girls at Shilan, Chu Zihang taught them the meaning of an unrequited crush. But he seemed unaware of his mastery in this field, and people misunderstood him. His face was simply expressionless, yet many thought he was pretending to be cool. He didn't like rainy days at all; he stared into space when it rained because he wondered whether that Maybach might come to pick him up again...

Chu Zihang attracted countless admirers but was dense to an extraordinary degree. He was like one of the Easter Island stone statues gazing out to sea; blossoms falling on him were utterly wasted.

Why must he be eliminated? If the many Shilan boys dating girls in their class discovered the same man's shadow had already invaded their girlfriends' hearts, it would be strange if they didn't want to destroy him!

"Thanks, thanks. You're a real friend, senior." Whatever the circumstances, Lu Mingfei was grateful for Chu Zihang's sudden appearance. "I'll pay you back when we get home."

"It's nothing. You're the boss today; you make the calls," Chu Zihang said calmly.

Lu stared. The act was getting more convincing. Who was he to deserve this? It would be an honor to polish the president's shoes, and he dared call himself boss in public? But Chu looked as if to say this was a fact not worth discussing, so he could only keep quiet.

The crowd murmured in amazement. They had known Boss Lu was astonishing, but not that he was so modest, displaying only two parts of his twelve-part greatness. Even Chu Zihang called him boss; surely he had built a vast empire in his year in America. How gracious of him to condescend to eat pizza with his old classmates. That also explained his lack of cash: underlings always paid, so why would the boss settle the bill himself?

"The car's waiting outside." Chu held the door and gestured for him to go first.

Chu's icy expression made Lu uncertain what was happening. The courtesy lay somewhere between a bodyguard addressing his boss and the CIA addressing a terrorist with nowhere left to run. He realized refusal wasn't an option and walked out with his head down.

Chu followed without missing a step, their footsteps echoing down the hall. Lu thought of the people watching him from behind, eyes full of envy and resentment, but he didn't feel honored at all.

Damn, what rotten luck. It wasn't his business, so why had he stepped in? And once he did, even his credit card had proved as useless as he was. The president had rescued him, but what did that amount to? Every scrap of face Lu Mingfei had ever enjoyed had been provided by his seniors. Not once had he stood up and been impressive on his own. He was like a little kid beaten up in a fight, face covered in snot, who went home to fetch his big brother. Others feared you a little, but never respected you, because even with a fierce, stone-faced fighting brother and a gorgeous, long-legged sister, you were still a little kid with snot on your face.

You are incapable. You are useless.

Chu Zihang opened the Panamera's door. Pure white leather racing seats welcomed the honored guest.

Suddenly Lu Mingfei stopped, turned, and ran back!

The people talking at the door to the private room backed away in alarm and made a path. Lu had returned at a hundred-meter sprint, bristling with murderous intent.

He walked up to Chen Wenwen and reached out... seized the toilet seat leaning against his chair... and dashed out of the door.

Chen Wenwen said nothing, gently brushing her long bangs aside.

"Headquarters has assigned a mission. You're the agent and I'm assisting, so you're the boss today. It's not a joke." Chu handed Lu an iPad and skillfully steered one-handed as the Panamera joined the stream of traffic.

Lu Mingfei could hardly believe his ears. A mission with him in charge? What task could he excel at enough to have Chu Zihang assist him? Unless they were going as a team to challenge the Deyun Society at comic dialogue, with Lu as the funny man and Chu as his straight man...

But the iPad ran a Cassell-developed interface directly connected to Norma, and his name was plainly listed under AGENT. After reading the details, Lu Mingfei felt lost in a fog. Was this a criminal investigation? But Field Investigation seemed to be a junior-year elective. He was a complete novice in that area... apart from watching Detective Conan movies.

The air conditioning raised goosebumps on his skin. He glanced timidly at Chu Zihang; the hard profile was expressionless and showed no intention of explaining to the person in charge what to do.

His courage failed. He sank into the seat and stared blankly out the window. He was in a bad mood. When Chen Wenwen had brushed back her hair, he had seen her dreadful face. Ugly—she had never looked so ugly, tears clinging to pale skin, eyes swollen... like a little goldfish. Where was the girl of his dreams? Once she had sat at one end of a bench in a white cotton dress reading Duras's The Lover, her spotless fairy aura seeming to banish sunlight and dust alike. Every fairy, apparently, would one day fall for an idiot and knit him sweaters, loving and resentful, and from then on her life was a downhill road of no return. At such a time a toad like Lu Mingfei, who had never tasted swan flesh, ought to clap in delight, but for some reason his heart clenched and he suddenly grew irritable.

"I listened outside the room for two minutes."

Lu Mingfei nearly jumped out of his skin. Chu had spoken without warning. The flat statement sounded like a threat: I know what you did last summer.

Would the president take an interest in his useless junior's petty gossip and silently listen for two minutes? For a man with Chu Zihang's rigorously organized schedule, what could possibly be important enough to stop him for two minutes?

"You should inform your card issuer of your travel plans. Otherwise, if they see the card used in another place, they'll suspect theft and temporarily freeze the account," Chu said. "I know you liked Chen Wenwen at school."

Lu Mingfei's heart lost its rhythm and his face flushed purple. Even when Fingel exposed his feelings for Nono, he hadn't reacted so strongly.

Nono's beauty was dazzling and sharp, an angel bearing a sword, sometimes madly loyal to her friends. Any man ought to like Nono; Lu suspected Fingel liked her too. He had never imagined Nono dumping Caesar and falling into his arms... All right, given their relative strength, Nono would take him into hers. It was pure admiration: a lovely lady, a worthy gentleman's desire, and a loser's desire too. Nothing to be ashamed of, as long as Boss Caesar didn't know.

But Chen Wenwen was different. Chen Wenwen was a secret. When he had been innocent and still capable of embarrassment, he had thought marrying her would be the happiness of his life. He never tired of sitting beside her on a bench reading all afternoon, running Literature Club errands at her heels like an eager little dog. Back then he had never liked anyone else, wasn't thick-skinned, and had experienced nothing momentous. He was an uncool boy weaving a future with this girl in his heart. If she had nodded, he would have impatiently placed his whole life in her hands for her to command... But she hadn't chosen him.

He always wanted to find a hollow tree and bury that story in it, because it was embarrassing, or... because the feeling of loving someone like that was so tender that if people knew, they might touch it and break it.

"You... you..."

"Probably the whole school knew," Chu added.

"Senior, don't make it sound so scary. The whole school? Our high school banned dating!" Lu felt as if struck by five thunderbolts. "If everyone really knew, wouldn't the dean have dragged me off to confess my wrongdoing?"

"He didn't because he knew you had no chance. He didn't need to concern himself with your fantasies."

"But surely not the whole school?"

"Someone else liked Chen Wenwen and told people you liked her as a joke. So the whole school knew."

Lu stared. "Zhao Menghua?"

Chu did not answer.

Lu sat stunned for a long time, suddenly very tired. Nono had said everyone had played him at the Literature Club farewell. But he hadn't wanted to believe it. He thought he had hidden his feelings well; a few people making fun of him wouldn't matter as long as Chen Wenwen wasn't one of them. He would rather she had never known he liked her and therefore chosen Zhao. But if even Chu Zihang could recount his romantic history in detail...

He was that i, lowercase, a very small "I"... but with no love and no you.

"I don't mind you standing on the seat, but at this speed it's unsafe," Chu said.

Only then did Lu realize he had somehow crouched on the luxurious leather seat, arms around his knees, chin resting on them—a posture somewhere between an elderly northern Shaanxi farmer on a field ridge and a stray dog taking a rest. He hurriedly jumped down, wiped at his shoeprints, and smiled awkwardly.

"It's all right. You weren't saying anything, so I was finding a topic to talk about," Chu said coldly.

Lu was dumbfounded. Huh? What did that mean? Was this merely the president's icebreaker, like the table-tennis diplomacy that opened relations between China and America? He hadn't had time to

wonder why Chu had turned to Chen Wenwen instead of discussing the mission. Was this heart-souring subject merely the stone-faced senior's friendly small talk to break the silence between them? Damn! Table tennis would have been better!

"I'm not Conan..." Lu tried to discuss business.

"Chen Wenwen knew you liked her but pretended she didn't. She wasn't good to you and treated you as a follower. Yet you still stood up for her?" Chu cut off his topic like a blade.

Lu was unaccustomed to such forceful questioning and froze.

"Because she's vulnerable now and you pity her?" Chu shot him a cold glance.

"She was never bad to me. I liked her; that had nothing to do with her." Lu grew anxious.

"Zhao Menghua was unhappy because Chen Wenwen was his girlfriend. She still loves him, and psychologically he still feels possessive toward her. He can discard her, but he doesn't want anyone else standing up for her." Chu raised an eyebrow. "Why did you?"

The cold, pressing tone was like a knife digging into his heart. Lu suddenly grew angry. He didn't want to discuss this, but Chu insisted. What did Chu Zihang want? He was only a senior, only president of the Lionheart Society. Lu Mingfei was an underling of Student Council President Caesar, with no connection to the society. Why must he report his romantic history to its president? They were only doing a mission together; afterward they would go their separate ways! What was Chu trying to ask? Did he only want Lu to admit he was an idiot? That girl had set him up and embarrassed him publicly, yet now he insisted on standing up for her?

"All right, I know what you're going to say. I'm an idiot. I'm useless and still try to play the hero, but I... I can't stand seeing someone treated unfairly." Lu turned hard toward the window, raising his voice. "Anyway, senior, you'd never be treated unfairly! You've been outstanding all your life. You don't understand!"

The Panamera braked suddenly, tires screeching against the road, and stopped dead in the middle of the street.

"Get out," Chu said.

"What?" Lu was bewildered. The sudden stop had almost given him a concussion. What had he said wrong to be thrown out? Could it be... the president had secretly loved Chen Wenwen for years too, and hearing his rival pour out his heart had made him sulk?

"Get out and wait for me. I have something to do. I'll be right back." Chu was expressionless.

Sitting in someone else's luxury sports car, arguing was pointless. Lu obediently got out and stood by the road. Chu shifted into reverse and floored the accelerator. The Panamera accelerated backward into traffic with smoke rising from all four wheels, retracing their route.

Lu stared. He had never seen anyone drive so outrageously. He didn't know this was a driving style inherited in certain families.

Sunlight stung the skin, hot air rising in wisps from the asphalt. Chen Wenwen trailed far behind the group. Through the heat the boy's back ahead of her looked distorted.

Everything was distorted.

"Hey, sister-in-law, do you eat foie gras?" someone called.

"No, it's too salty. I'll have a salad. You eat what you like," Liu Miaomiao answered absently.

"Boss, it's burning up. Why are we wandering outside? Let's get ice cream at Cold Stone," another said.

"Save room for dinner." Zhao Menghua's voice came faintly.

The conversation was distant, yet seemed close to her ear.

Sometimes people couldn't help listening closely to words that pierced the heart. Perhaps their brains had short-circuited...

Chen Wenwen looked down at her white sandals. Again and again, her slender fair feet emerged beneath her skirt as she shuffled forward.

When she was still with Zhao, he had come to school to see her and they had walked under the lights after dinner. She had walked with her head down then too. Students passed on their way back from evening study, and whenever someone called, "Chen Wenwen, is this your boyfriend?" her face burned, as if it were embarrassing, yet she felt so happy. Zhao would throw an arm firmly around her shoulders and grin as he greeted them.

Now she still couldn't lift her head. Not from embarrassment, but because it felt so heavy it might break her neck.

Zhao Menghua was annoyed. Since leaving Sophie Lad Pizza, Chen Wenwen had followed them, inexplicably refusing to leave.

What was the point of clinging now? It was over, and she was acting like a resentful wife. Zhao didn't think he had wronged her. It was just a breakup, wasn't it? Before splitting up they had had a terrible fight. Zhao had gritted his teeth and said they should break up, and Chen Wenwen had actually bitten her lip and agreed. Startled, he had said, "If you dare agree, don't regret it!" and stormed out. A few days later he happened to sit beside Liu Miaomiao at a gathering and suddenly felt glad he had broken up. He muted his phone throughout because Chen Wenwen kept texting him, dozens of messages in a day.

He wanted to turn and tell her, Aren't you annoying? I told you not to regret it if you dared agree! Playing the tragic victim afterward is pointless.

But Liu Miaomiao was beside him. Being too harsh to an ex would make his new girlfriend think him ungallant, so Zhao endured it. He liked Liu: she was pretty, agreeable, and from a good family; unlike Chen Wenwen, she didn't argue with him and made him look good before his friends. Conveniently, their fathers were golfing partners. On hearing that her son had a new girlfriend, his mother had clapped delightedly and said, "Good breakup! You and Chen Wenwen weren't suited!"

Zhao agreed. Watching Chen from afar, he had always seen her reading quietly, untouched by dust, eyes lowered, utterly lovely. Only after winning her had he learned the more literary they were, the more annoying, oversensitive about everything.

Chen Wenwen also thought she and Zhao Menghua weren't suited.

They had not seen each other for nearly two months. He didn't answer her calls, and emails sank without a trace. Late at night she stared at his QQ status. One weekend he'd gone rafting, the next to an amusement park, the next hiking on Fragrant Hill... Every weekend he had something to do. With whom? She didn't know.

She sat by the library's floor-to-ceiling window. Outside the light was dim and wind stirred the dense green leaves. She remembered The Lover and Marguerite Duras, imagining the girl on the Mekong River slowly turning gray.

Suddenly she burst into sobs, frightening the elderly librarian so badly his chronic leg pain flared up.

Actually the story of The Lover was nothing like hers.

The only thing they shared was being unsuited. The white girl and wealthy Chinese young master in The Lover had parted forever because they were unsuited too.

She had come today to see Zhao. That hope had overcome her heavy hesitation. She had put on light makeup so she would look healthier and he wouldn't worry. She had invited Lu Mingfei because everyone else at the gathering was one of Zhao's friends, which frightened her a little. She hadn't imagined getting back together with Zhao; she only wanted to see him casually.

Then why had she burst into tears?

Why was she still following them?

She knew doing so wouldn't make Zhao look back. She knew his character better than anyone... But if she left like this, perhaps she would never see him again, and all those memories would be gone. In memory they walked side by side beneath streetlights along the school river road; now the lights had gone out. In memory they got meals together in the cafeteria; now the food had spoiled. In memory she had bought a Hello Kitty charm and insisted on hanging it on Zhao's phone. By now, she thought, it must have been torn off. The little pink furry cat lay in a garbage heap somewhere in the world beneath all kinds of filth, but it couldn't even cry, because it had no mouth...

She regretted it. She should never have bought that Hello Kitty. If she hadn't, the kitten would still be lying obediently in the display case waiting for someone to take it home.

Why make that innocent little cat so miserable because of a relationship that wasn't right?

That poor... little cat...

At last tears spilled from her eyes, falling onto the scorching concrete tiles and rising as a faint wisp of steam.

"Hey! Hey!" Xu Yanyan nudged Zhao in the waist with his elbow. Out of the corner of his eye he had seen Chen Wenwen stop, tears streaming, and felt a little pity.

"Will you stop bothering me?" Zhao forcefully knocked his arm away.

He wished he could strike Chen Wenwen instead. She was too annoying! He couldn't bear it. What did she want? If she hadn't come today and they met alone another time, he would have patted her shoulder and comforted her. But she insisted on coming; if she came, she shouldn't cause trouble, and she'd even brought Lu Mingfei. That boy was really stubbornly devoted to her. Now she had made everyone part on bad terms. What more did she want? His new girlfriend Liu Miaomiao was beside him, and he had to take his friends out for Italian that night to recover his standing. He hadn't invited Chen Wenwen. Who did she think she was, following along?

Suddenly a deep, powerful engine sounded. Before Zhao could look up, hot wind cut past as though it might slice his hair. A dark-blue shape flashed beside him; brakes screamed, and the Panamera stopped sharply beside Chen Wenwen.

The lunatic was driving backward!

The window lowered. Chu Zihang's face, half hidden by dark glasses, was icy enough to play a killer utterly loyal to his boss in any Hong Kong film. He said, "Lu Mingfei says he'd like to take you to dinner tonight."

"Yes, you." He nodded to the bewildered Chen Wenwen. His handsome, thoroughly masculine face seemed to say, It's that simple. I've delivered the boss's message.

His seriousness, commanding presence, coldness, and nosiness combined perfectly. This was probably an invitation no one could refuse. Imagine someone admired you and invited you to an intimate, elegant dinner for two, but delivered the invitation so forcefully that you felt if you said no, the messenger would pull a Desert Eagle from the glove compartment and shoot you between the eyes...

"He reserved a table at Aspasia tonight." Chu drew a business card from the compartment and handed it to Chen. "The address is on here. Seven thirty."

She stared at the black card. Aspasia. She had vaguely heard of this fashionable Italian restaurant, luxurious to an almost unimaginable degree. Could this really be the timid boy's doing? Such unmistakable commanding presence... Boss Lu stood tall and firm!

Nearby the Shilan boys stared, jaws nearly hitting the ground. Given the temperature of the pavement, one might soon smell roasted jaws. Zhao clenched his fists. He had a premonition that an opponent he had never respected was about to crush him again...

"Are you refusing?" Chu frowned.

Could anyone refuse that tone? He was plainly growing impatient. Surely his Desert Eagle was itching to come out of the glove compartment. Even Zhao felt refusing would be courting death.

Chen lowered her head, smoothed the fine hair by her ear, and sniffed. "All right."

The window rose and the Panamera sped away, arriving and departing in a rush. Its four exhaust pipes again left Zhao's ears ringing.

Act Three

Reward

Reward

Cassell College did not belong to ordinary people. Nono had said it was another path through life: take that fork, and the door to your old life closed. You could only go forward... never return to the world of humans.

With a blade already in your hand, prepare to fight.

Have a golden insignia pressed onto your collar, arm yourself with the immense overdraft on a black card, command those imposing men as Commissioner Lu, and ride in this luxurious car to the most expensive dinner with the girl you once secretly loved.

The Panamera turned onto the elevated road. Its two occupants once again had nothing to say.

"You're really good at driving, senior," Lu Mingfei said awkwardly, trying to break the uncomfortable silence.

Five minutes after leaving him by the roadside, Chu Zihang had returned to pick him up. Since then he hadn't mentioned Chen Wenwen, as if that conversation had never happened. Lu Mingfei thought he must have misunderstood him and regretted his earlier impatience. To complete this mission, wouldn't he need the president's help as his "assistant"? If Chu Zihang angrily abandoned him, Commissioner Lu's assignment would be a total disaster.

Chu Zihang hadn't said a word about the mission details, as though he were simply a chauffeur. But he drove well, using manual mode, shifting gears with swift, decisive movements. There was beauty in the way he held everything under control, as if a flock of butterflies might fly from between his fingers.

"My dad taught me." Chu Zihang seemed surprised Lu Mingfei had brought it up. After a pause he added, "Happy birthday."

"Oh, oh." Lu Mingfei hurriedly nodded and bowed. "Your text moved me so much I practically bubbled over."

"You're replacing a toilet seat on your birthday instead of going out to eat?" Chu Zihang glanced at the thing on his lap.

"My aunt didn't give birth to me. It's normal for her not to remember." Lu Mingfei wasn't complaining; he really thought so. He apparently had never celebrated a birthday. You couldn't blame the government for a hard life. Who told him to have unreliable parents?

This topic was a hundred times better than the previous one, and the two seemed to get along a little more easily. "How do you usually celebrate your birthday, senior?" Lu Mingfei asked.

Chu Zihang thought. "House party, cake, presents, a garden party, photos, dinner, travel... About the same every year."

Lu Mingfei stuck out his tongue. What more could you want, brother? Launch a spacecraft to the moon for your birthday and write HAPPY BIRTHDAY, MASTER CHU ZIHANG on its surface?

"Do you like Italian food?" Chu Zihang asked.

"Never tried it." Lu Mingfei shook his head.

"Cheese, pizza, fried chicken, steak, pasta, that sort of thing. Italian food was the predecessor of French cuisine. It emphasizes natural flavors, and uses olive oil, black olives, dried cheese, tomatoes, spices, and Marsala wine for seasoning. Its air-dried meats and sausages are excellent."

Lu Mingfei didn't know what this had to do with anything, so he nodded. "I like meat."

"Mm." Chu Zihang nodded and connected the car's Bluetooth. "Aspasia restaurant? I'd like to reserve a table for two tonight..."

"I'm very sorry, sir. The restaurant has been booked for a private event tonight." The female manager's voice was gentle but firm.

"Fully booked?" Chu Zihang frowned. "Can you add a table?"

"I'm very sorry. The Black Prince Group is holding a wedding banquet tonight for Mr. Chen's son. We can't accommodate individual guests." The manager left no room for negotiation. "I'm terribly sorry. Please try another restaurant."

Chu Zihang held the phone in silence. The Black Prince Group was a major local taxpayer and a government-supported company. Its boss was a prominent figure whose portrait often appeared on the evening paper's front page, someone even the new mayor sought out. Naturally, none of that intimidated someone with Chu Zihang's elite Cassell education, a man whose face radiated authority once he took off his dark glasses. The problem was that Boss Black—as Chu Zihang always called the group's owner for short—was a major client of his father's, and the families visited from time to time. If this got back to his parents... Chu Zihang scratched his eyebrow, a little intimidated. Everyone had a weak point, and he was no exception.

"Senior, why insist on hanging yourself from this one crooked tree?" Lu Mingfei suggested quietly. "Can't we pick another restaurant?"

"I'm booking for a friend. It's already arranged, so it would be awkward to change." Chu Zihang thought for a while.

A figure sprang to mind. He wasn't the only person at Cassell who radiated authority, nor the most lawless. To suppress a local strongman, you needed an unreasonable dragon from out of town!

He dialed another number. "Fingel, are you at your computer? Post a reward on the Night Watcher forum for me. Yes, using the ID Murasame. I'll text you the details..."

The Night Watcher forum had originally been Cassell College's internal message board, a place for students to gossip, ask about class schedules, and rate the pretty girls in the current class. Gradually it grew popular, becoming a self-service guide to life at Cassell. Early in the morning a tarot master posted fortunes for the day; in the morning someone asked for lecture notes; at noon someone cursed the cafeteria's increasingly awful pork knuckles; in the afternoon someone who had just woken up organized that night's party; and after dark the anonymous boards filled with proud young men and women pouring out their love stories behind masks. Then the News Department was formally established. Its head, Fingel, was the undisputed king of campus paparazzi, claiming the righteous principles of a journalist: anything reasonable ought to be exposed to sunlight. Thus professors' scandals, unofficial histories of the Dragon Blood Secret Party, even Principal Anjou's large travel-expense bills could all be found there, provided you were willing to dig through the posts.

By then every Cassell graduate kept their old ID and remained a regular. Some had joined archaeological teams digging up dragon ruins in the middle of nowhere, others the Executive Department on secret missions in Europe. But whenever they had a free moment and internet access, they connected to the Night Watcher forum first, to feel the warmth of home and... the spirit of gossip.

It was late at night in America, peak traffic. More than ten thousand people were posting across the boards, white instant messages bouncing up the dark interface one after another.

Suddenly an inconspicuous white message turned red! This was rare: ordinary users couldn't do it; only an administrator working behind the scenes could. Then the red message rose above all the others and was pinned to the top!

A stream of data burst from Norma, the intelligent core at North American headquarters, crossed the undersea cables of the Pacific, and rushed to tens of thousands of clients worldwide. For a moment, people before more than ten thousand screens held their breath. What kind of news warranted this? Previously, only gossip on the level of an actual photograph of the department head's first girlfriend seemed to have received such treatment.

"REWARD: A table for two at Aspasia restaurant tonight at 7:30 p.m. (coordinates: 119.28439° E, 26.08774° N), reservation under Lu Mingfei. The person posting this reward offers one promise in exchange."

The posting ID was Murasame.

That ID appeared on the Night Watcher forum about as often as a South China tiger. But everyone knew whose it was. Chu Zihang, president of the Lionheart Society, was openly posting a reward to the Dragon Blood Secret Party worldwide.

Seven time zones away: Portofino, Italy.

At seven in the morning, sunlight covered the Gulf of Genoa, surrounded by mountains. Seagulls gathered and flew low, waiting for little fish to leap among the waves. On a clear morning, the sea was their abundant table.

Among the gulls was a black-and-white hobby falcon. Unlike them, it had not fixed its sights on little fish; it soared and waited for a cod or eel to surface.

A blurred shadow grew clearer. Something was rising from the seabed, and it was certainly big. The predatory bird's blood heated. It folded its wings, extended its talons, and plunged toward the water like a dive-bomber.

The surface broke. The prey leaped half a meter out of the water and caught the falcon's talons in a tenth of a second. The bird beat its wings in terror, unable to escape. It had judged wrongly: this was neither eel nor cod. It had no business being in the depths of the Gulf of Genoa. How could a human reach the seabed without diving equipment?

"Shh." The young man smiled coldly and laid a finger against his lips. He was actually speaking to the falcon.

A faint gold flashed in his eyes, like reflected sunlight. The falcon stopped struggling and perched quietly on the back of his hand. One instant of eye contact, and it was tamed.

"From now on you're my falcon. I'll call you Antony, after an ancient Roman general. It goes rather well with my name," the young man said. "Oh, I'm Caesar Gattuso."

He waved. Antony obeyed, beating its wings and circling overhead. Caesar swam backstroke toward shore like an arrow cleaving the water. On the empty beach stood a tiny motorcycle, only a little over half a meter tall. Though short, it looked every inch a proud Harley cruiser; the rising tide had covered its wheels. Caesar swung aboard and turned the throttle. It roared cheerfully, kicked up a person-high spray, and charged onto the road. The road climbed around the mountain. Plain houses with pink and yellow walls and deep green woods flashed past. Looking back, he saw yachts gathered in the bay below, white wind pennants streaming from their masts.

Caesar held a white bath towel high overhead. Antony understood at once, descending to follow the motorcycle, wings beating as it soared now above and now below the towel, like a warrior following his master's warhorse.

Caesar put on sunglasses against the increasingly fierce sun, a faint smile on his handsome face.

This was his summer vacation, utterly different from the life of the S-rank loser Lu Mingfei. He spent the hottest weeks in Portofino, in a permanently rented suite at the hilltop Splendid Hotel. The little town attracted wealthy Italians and luxury goods, yet remained simple and natural. It was also a superb diving harbor, with red coral and ancient shipwrecks beneath the water and schools of fish swimming leisurely above them. He knew it as well as his own garden.

The Splendid had once been an old monastery. Its pool and restaurant lay among ancient trees, like a garden suspended in the air when seen from below. Caesar entered the lobby bare-chested, and his secretary handed him a phone.

"Your classmate is calling. He seems to be an officer of the Student Council."

"What is it?" Caesar asked casually, holding the phone between neck and shoulder. During the vacation he had left several capable officers on campus, so any news would reach him promptly. Caesar wasn't used to losing control of a situation.

"Big news! Lu Mingfei is taking someone out for authentic Italian food tonight. He can't get a table and is looking for help."

"Who is this?" Caesar paused. The voice was familiar, but not one of those he'd left behind.

"Your loyal lackey Fingel!" The voice was exceedingly ingratiating.

"What does that have to do with me?" Caesar frowned.

Fingel was indeed in the Student Council, but unless he surfaced on his own, Caesar would never remember he had such a subordinate. The fellow had repeated so many years that his original file couldn't be found, and he hadn't reported for duty once since Caesar took office. He was a thoroughgoing drifter.

"But Chu Zihang posted a reward!"

"Chu Zihang?" Caesar's face grew serious.

"Chu Zihang says whoever helps Lu Mingfei get a table at Aspasia tonight can ask him to do one thing within his ability, as long as it doesn't violate morality. Basically, they get a promise from him and can come to him when they have a problem."

"A considerable reward." Caesar pondered for a moment.

The game of posting "rewards" was common at Cassell: helping one another in an exchange of equal value. Caesar had posted one himself when courting Nono, asking people to send her postcards from their hometowns over vacation. Each said, "My hometown is a beautiful place. I hope one day

you'll visit it with Caesar Gattuso." The postcards piled up on Nono's desk like a little mountain, and Caesar sent each sender a new-model PSP as promised.

Compared with Chu Zihang's present reward, however, a few hundred PSPs were nothing. A promise from the Lionheart Society's president could be worth very little or an outrageous amount. You could ask Chu Zihang to bark like a dog, or to give up the presidency. Caesar believed Chu Zihang kept his word. Only such a man was worthy of being Caesar Gattuso's enemy. He was beginning to find this interesting. Lu Mingfei's reservation had nothing to do with him, but... everything involving Chu Zihang did!

"Trying to win people over on campus?" Caesar raised an eyebrow. "Ridiculous! Lu Mingfei is a Student Council member. He's mine. If he needs anything, he should come to me, and I'll help him!" He smiled coldly, radiating authority. "Tonight I'll have Lu Mingfei dining at the best table in the best Italian restaurant he can reach, served by the finest chef and the finest waiters. Everything must be perfect!"

"Brilliant, boss!" Fingel praised him. "But Chu Zihang named Aspasia, and there aren't any tables left."

"That three-Michelin-star restaurant?" Caesar frowned. "I've eaten at its Rome branch many times and never once had to wait."

"Apparently it's booked out for a wedding banquet."

"It's not as if China has no other good restaurants. They can simply get married somewhere else." To Caesar the matter was simple. It was trivial to him; his precious brainpower needn't be wasted considering the bride and groom.

"It's tricky. The people who booked it have considerable influence."

Caesar frowned. "Considerable influence? Politicians?"

"No, a local listed company. Their son got a girl pregnant..."

Caesar lost interest. "Only a business owner. I understand. Someone will take care of it; they're professionals... You're surprisingly eager to help your roommate. You owe Lu Mingfei a lot of money, don't you?"

Fingel sounded sheepish. "I've eaten a lot of his late-night snacks without paying..."

"Then I'll repay the favor for you." Caesar hung up.

He handed the phone to the butler beside him. "Call the Mint Club for me. Once it's arranged, text my classmate. His name is Lu Mingfei." He thought. "The message is: 'Happy birthday, with best wishes from Caesar Gattuso.'"

"Using Mint? The cost won't be small. Isn't that rather elaborate for a classmate?" the secretary advised tactfully.

"Do you know Zhou Enlai?" Caesar asked.

"Yes. He was a very famous diplomat."

"I just read his biography. Some of it is quite interesting. Chinese people care a great deal about details. Mr. Zhou could clearly remember all sorts of information about someone he'd met once, and greet them the next time, making them feel deeply honored. He even bought a shirt for a cleaner whose clothes his car had dirtied. It's a leader's philosophy: attend to details concerning your subordinates."

Caesar dried his wet blond hair, voice firm. "It strengthens a team's cohesion. That's an important lesson I've learned these past few days."

Had Lu Mingfei been there, he probably would have reminded him that this important lesson came from material fit for a middle-school textbook.

"But... all this seems like a roundabout way to ask for your help." The secretary smiled. "Like a little trick."

Caesar raised an eyebrow, looked at the secretary intently, and smiled too. "Yes, Chu Zihang's little trick. I saw it, but it's one I have to fall for because," he said slowly, "Chu Zihang has put himself on the line. I don't need his promise, but I don't want someone else to get it and make some bizarre demand that turns our competition into a mess."

"I understand. I'll arrange it." The secretary bowed slightly. "Young master, it's almost time. Please get ready. The trustees are on their way."

"The main courses haven't been served yet. Why should a side dish like me hurry? I'd still like another swim."

"In your uncle's eyes, you're the main course at today's meeting."

Caesar turned to the young secretary with a subtle smile. "Parsi, don't say that to me again. First, I'm not a dish for a chef to decide about. Even if I were, neither you nor Uncle should expect to be my cook."

"Sorry, young master. I'll be more careful." The secretary withdrew submissively.

Chu Zihang's and Lu Mingfei's phones rang at the same time. Both had received texts. Chu Zihang glanced at his and silently closed it; Lu Mingfei stared in astonishment.

"Happy birthday, with best wishes from Caesar Gattuso."

The second birthday greeting on his nineteenth birthday came from Caesar Gattuso. Lu Mingfei was dizzy. What had he done to deserve birthday wishes from the presidents of the Lionheart Society and the Student Council? Zhou Yu and Cao Cao had fought each other to the death on the Yangtze, yet both wished the same person a happy birthday. Who could earn such an honor? Probably... Jiang Gan.

The world was strange. Some people saw him as a lump of crap; others saw him as a treasure.

"Where are we going now?" Lu Mingfei leaned back and looked out the window.

"You're in charge of the mission. You decide."

"Senior, don't mess with me, okay? We'll go wherever you say. Once we get there, you do your thing... I'll... help dust your car." Lu Mingfei looked miserable.

"Then the ruins of South Railway Station. We don't know who took the documents, so we'll look at the scene first," Chu Zihang said.

Lu Mingfei looked out. The collapsed, tortoise-shell-shaped aluminum-alloy dome of South Railway Station came into view. This branch of the elevated road led straight there. So from the beginning they hadn't needed him, the nominal person in charge, to do anything at all, right? The car had been heading straight for the station. Thinking that made him feel pretty useless... but since it was true, he didn't mind admitting it. Senior Chu Zihang certainly had his measure.

"How long will it take? I'm afraid I'll get home too late... and the toilet seat won't get installed." Lu Mingfei was worried.

He imagined his aunt rushing home sweaty and hot, making for the bathroom, and finding no toilet seat, so she had to squat on the rim. Her rage would turn into a sonic boom and kill him, wouldn't it?

"I've arranged it. You're the commissioner; just complete the mission. I'm responsible for assisting, and I'll take care of your toilet seat," Chu Zihang said mildly.

"You'll call the maintenance guy who fixes the drains in our building?" Lu Mingfei thought that sounded sensible.

Chu Zihang froze. Evidently it hadn't occurred to him that a call to the building management would fix the toilet. Young Master Chu was hardworking at home too, but he'd never repaired a toilet. His family had plenty of housekeepers and drivers.

"Don't worry. I've arranged for professionals," Chu Zihang said.

Lu Mingfei relaxed. Chu Zihang was clearly an extreme perfectionist. If he said professionals, they had to be professionals, capable of going to heaven or underground, let alone fixing a toilet.

The car stopped five hundred meters from South Railway Station, where yellow tape blocked the way. Under the blazing sun, the once beautiful building looked like a work of postmodern art: only a vast, twisted aluminum-alloy frame remained, desolate in the extreme. Cicadas screamed, and crows perched on the frame croaking hoarsely. The municipal government's press conference explaining the "shoddy construction" was being held that afternoon at the city hall auditorium. Reporters had all rushed there, leaving discarded sheets of notes scattered on the ground. Police and security guards sheltered in the shade, fanning themselves with their caps.

"Whoa... Was the earthquake that strong? I didn't feel a thing!" Lu Mingfei exclaimed. Only standing before the ruins could you truly understand the immense force that had destroyed the building, and in turn feel how small you were.

Like two ants arriving before the shell of a sea turtle that had died thousands of years ago.

"It's hard to imagine. Its mechanical structure was very stable, designed to withstand an earthquake of magnitude eight. The aluminum frame was heat-treated to eliminate internal stresses. This morning's small quake was magnitude three; theoretically, it shouldn't even have been damaged. Yet it collapsed, and not a single pane of glass remained intact." Chu Zihang spoke quietly. "I imagine Raymond felt as if the sky was falling."

"Follow me. Don't say anything careless." He opened the car door.

A security guard was already shouting. "Move the car! Move the car! It's closed ahead!"

"Damn, the sky really did fall." Lu Mingfei sucked in a breath.

Chu Zihang gave the guard two packs of cigarettes and said they were seismology students who wanted photographs for a graduation thesis. The guard let them in. Now Lu Mingfei stood among shattered glass, looking up at the sky. The twisted aluminum beams possessed an extraordinary beauty.

Chu Zihang crouched and gently wobbled the shards embedded in a wooden bench. They had sunk deep; anyone standing in that rain of glass could hardly have met a good end.

"Blood." Chu Zihang pointed to a patch of ground. "Raymond was standing here."

"Senior, what can you possibly see in all this broken glass?" Lu Mingfei followed him like a little attendant.

"You can't see it, and neither can I," Chu Zihang said. "But someone can. It's an ability to reconstruct what happened through observation. You know the person who has it."

He put on a baseball cap with a high-resolution camera fixed to the brim and connected to his phone, then started a 3G video call.

"Nono? I need your help," Chu Zihang said.

"Norma has already assigned the task, so I understand. I need you to walk Raymond's route again. I'll try to reconstruct the scene." Chu Zihang switched on the speaker, and Lu Mingfei heard Nono clearly.

Lu Mingfei was wondering whether to greet the little witch when she said, "Who's on your left?"

He started. He hadn't appeared in front of the camera at all.

"Lu Mingfei. He's the commissioner on this operation; I'm assisting him," Chu Zihang said. "How did you know he was here?"

"I saw his reflection in the broken glass in front of you, though his image was small," Nono said. "Tell him to move farther away. He'll interfere with my judgment standing there."

Lu Mingfei had to retreat to a distant corner. The little witch's ability to catch details while profiling was extraordinary. He'd seen it before and didn't mind, but she hadn't shown the slightest intention of wishing him a happy birthday, treating everything as business. It was a little depressing.

Chu Zihang walked through the enormous space, every detail captured by the camera transmitted to Nono. At this moment he was Raymond, entering South Railway Station before its collapse, carrying important documents, surrounded by danger and unsure where the enemy was hiding.

"Stop. He should have paused here," Nono said. "He'd just entered the station. He wasn't familiar with the new building, so he would have stopped to read the signs."

Chu Zihang turned his head slowly, scanning the entire station.

"Good. Raymond's Yanling wasn't visual, so a sweep would probably take three or four seconds. He was noticed at this point," Nono said confidently.

"Now forward. Stop. Turn your head. Raymond would have looked back here to check his surroundings. It was his habit and also followed the college's reconnaissance procedure."

Chu Zihang turned and looked around as instructed. Watching the little witch and Chu Zihang play this crime-scene game from his corner, Lu Mingfei felt a little envious. Chu Zihang was a great player, expressionless and calm, doing whatever she told him. Somehow that even made him a little cute. In Lu Mingfei's place he'd be pulling complicated faces and saying "Really?" and "No way," which wouldn't look cool at all. But he couldn't imitate Chu Zihang's bearing, so all he could do was envy him.

"Raymond found nothing suspicious at the observation point and continued fifteen meters to the ticket gates. Here he discovered that the station was about to collapse," Nono said.

"Are you sure this is the spot?" Chu Zihang asked.

"Yes. He couldn't have been where he died when he realized it was collapsing. He died close to the benches, and with his training he'd certainly have hidden beneath one, but he didn't. That means he saw the danger where he couldn't take cover, then ran toward the benches, trying to escape it, but was too late. The most reasonable nearby position is where you're standing now," Nono said.

"Good." Chu Zihang nodded.

"The conclusion is clear. No one could have snatched the documents from Raymond in so short a time. They were lost after his death, within the next few minutes."

"Why within a few minutes?"

"Someone stepped in Raymond's blood. Your camera caught the footprint just now. It's blurred, which means it was made when the blood had only just flowed. There are lots of footprints at the scene, but only this one approaches Raymond. He was an experienced commissioner and wouldn't have dropped the documents even while seeking cover. So this person stole them from beside him within minutes of the collapse," Nono said. "And judging from the footprint, this was a human with an unsteady step. A pure human would be nervous in a place like this, so they'd have to flee by the nearest exit. C2, right beside you. We should find more information there."

"Understood."

"Now imitate that person's actions. Run to exit C2, but don't use your top speed; he couldn't run as fast as you," Nono said.

Chu Zihang started running at a moderate speed. Fully immersed in the situation, he naturally glanced left and right as he ran, like a nervous little thief who had stolen something.

Was the college's SS-rank mission really only because a petty thief had stolen the documents?

He stopped abruptly in front of exit C2. Outside was the parking lot, and the camera revealed two deep black tire marks. You could imagine how panicked the driver had been: a tremendously powerful car, its tires softened by heat, and the person who stole the documents pressing hard on the gas in their nervousness. Only that would leave marks like these.

"You boys all know cars, so you don't need me for the rest." Nono giggled through the phone. "You've worked hard, Mr. President. I'm taking your girl into the mountains to play."

Chu Zihang paused and nodded slightly. "Thank you."

"Oh, one more feeling, though it isn't very reliable. Just for reference," Nono said. "There was a third person there, standing right where you are now, without moving. They watched from Raymond's death through the theft, and the little thief evidently saw them too. The thief had blood on his feet, and the trail of footprints bent here, which means he saw something that surprised him. It should have been a person."

"What kind of person?"

"I don't know. They left very few traces, so that's why I say it isn't reliable. Looking at all the images you've sent, I just have a feeling that a blurred shadow was watching it all."

Chu Zihang was silent for a moment. "Understood."

"Let's go." Chu Zihang approached Lu Mingfei. "That's about it. I think we can solve this tonight."

"Good, good!" Lu Mingfei nodded.

"There's still some time. Aren't you meeting your cousin, uncle, and aunt tonight? Go back first. I have something to do, so I won't take you for now."

Lu Mingfei thought there weren't any taxis to be had here, but couldn't very well say it. He just kept nodding. "Then I'll meet up with you tonight."

"Let's meet after the mission. I'll arrange a car to pick you up. We'll work in two different places. I have a little more experience, so may I temporarily handle the operational details for you, Commissioner?"

"Sure, sure! The capable should do more!" Lu Mingfei thumped his chest. "With you handling it, I'm not worried!"

Cassell College headquarters, central control room. It was midnight, the easiest time to get sleepy. Guderian was sprawled on the table, fast asleep. Manstein and Schneider, eyes red, leafed through a thick stack of lists and crossed off names one by one.

Manstein glanced at his sleeping friend, frowned, and rolled up a tissue to put beneath his open mouth so his drool wouldn't wet the lists.

"Found it," Schneider said quietly, pushing the list across the table to Manstein.

"The tire marks Chu Zihang found were made by a large-displacement SUV, twenty-two-inch oversized wheels and 285-millimeter-wide Bridgestone tires," Schneider said. "Only modified Hummers or Escalades use those tires. This is the most suspicious name on the owners' list."

Manstein glanced at it. "I know that name."

The Escalade Schneider had underlined belonged to Millennium Labor Services, registered at Runde Building.

"Right. Those people are hunters," Schneider said. "The group calls itself the Three Young Masters. The leader is Tang Wei."

"Some inexplicable things are getting mixed up in this," Manstein said. "A real nuisance."

At Cassell, carrying a gun into the mountains to shoot pheasants didn't make you a "hunter." The word referred to a particular group: a loose organization hired to solve problems. Its members included desperadoes, artists, avant-garde young creatives, and gangsters, a complicated mixture. Their jobs weren't to rescue an elderly neighbor's kitten from a tree, of course, but work on the border between legal and illegal. Usually they weren't hired to murder or commit arson, but they stole, robbed graves, and looted artifacts. A substantial number of these jobs involved dragons, such as stealing alchemical implements from tombs.

They came from everywhere to enter this dangerous and disreputable line of work for one real reason: the "call of blood." Most had some dragon ancestry.

The college had noticed this hybrid organization twenty years earlier, but had never fully understood it. Nor did it want to recruit the scattered bands, as their bloodlines were usually not very pure. It still kept watch, however. Executive Department members stationed around the world registered every hunter they found, and the files already contained several thousand.

Serious research into the organization had begun only last year. Before awakening as the Dragon King, the elder of the King of Bronze and Fire's brothers had been a hunter operating in New York, essentially a petty hoodlum.

Even so, the college had avoided direct contact with hunters, whose minor activities rarely infringed on its interests.

This time was different. Apparently some ruthless figure had emerged among these half-skilled hybrids of low blood purity, capable of bringing down Executive Department commissioner Raymond and trying to take the documents wanted by the Board of Trustees.

"Only four hours remain until the trustees' deadline," Schneider said. "No time for an indirect approach. Act directly."

"Use force?" Manstein frowned. "China is a country governed by law..."

"Human laws don't fully apply to us, do they?" Schneider said. "Both sides are hybrids. Just warn Chu Zihang not to hurt anyone uninvolved."

"You should know your student isn't a precision sniper rifle, skilled at picking off individual targets. He's practically... a shotgun that fires as soon as it lands! I'll say it again: his mission record is poor. He's already caused the college a lot of trouble." Manstein lowered his voice. "If we hadn't kept a lid on it, the trustees would have heard long ago!"

"What's wrong with it? He has a hundred-percent success rate. His methods are just a little too forceful sometimes."

Manstein sighed. "Listen, Schneider, I know you value Chu Zihang, but don't let personal feelings affect your judgment. What's that saying? Impulse is the devil! Remember the bronze city mission? If we'd known Ye Sheng and Aki were a couple, we wouldn't have put them on the same team. We might have saved at least one."

"Right! Good point! Mingfei and Nono have no feelings for each other, so their mission was a great success!" Guderian woke at precisely the right moment, found an opportunity to boast about his student, and immediately brightened.

"The whole campus knows who Lu Mingfei has a crush on," Schneider said coldly. "Except perhaps Caesar."

"Stop! We don't have time for gossip!" Manstein grew angry. "And don't drag my student into this too!"

"Sorry, I forgot Nono is your student now," Schneider said.

The three stared at one another. The central control room fell deathly quiet except for the ticking of the old wall clock. Time passed, second by second.

After a long hesitation, Manstein handed Schneider a list. "To tell you the truth, I've already contacted the trustees directly. They seem to have begun doubting Chu Zihang's abilities. Besides appointing Lu Mingfei commissioner, they immediately dispatched the people on this list to assist them. They're driving to meet Lu Mingfei and Chu Zihang now. They're elite veterans with many years of experience. The recovery plan must also be approved by the trustees and directed remotely from here."

Schneider scanned the list and started. "Why send these people? They're far too conspicuous!"

"The trustees understand that, so they ordered them to dress in plain clothes and keep a low profile."

Schneider was silent for a long time. He gave a long sigh, rose, and walked toward the door.

"Hey, Schneider, don't be so stubborn." Manstein stood and raised his voice. "Not everything depends on an excellent bloodline, right? Don't assume only your own student is the best."

"Once the trustees have decided, the Executive Department can't overturn it. Do as they say. Those politicians only know how to issue orders; they don't understand operations at all. Those people can't help Chu Zihang." Schneider looked back from the door. "Worse, Chu Zihang can't work with other people at all! Every mission he's undertaken, he's actually completed alone!"

On the twenty-first floor of Runde Building, heavy velvet curtains covered every window, shutting out the light. At the center of an enormous conference table stood a red tea-light holder containing a lavender-scented candle. That little light couldn't illuminate the huge, luxurious conference room or the client opposite. He sat between light and shadow, looking thin, with tousled red hair, a deathly pale face, a red-and-white striped shirt, and a yellow vest.

"Whiskey on the rocks? Camus XO? Or... would you like a Chicken McNuggets meal?" Tang Wei turned a glass of Yamazaki whiskey in his hand, unable to resist a joke.

Because the client opposite was Ronald McDonald.

Tang Wei had faced all kinds of clients: burly men with blue dragons tattooed on their backs and Chairman Mao quotations on both arms; obvious success stories with fat bellies and glamorous women in black stockings and miniskirts on their arms; even someone who came in, poked two holes in the conference table with two fingers, and said, "I've trained in the two-finger technique, brother. I advise you not to pull any tricks!" Tang Wei had thought he'd seen enough not to be shaken by anything, but the sight of Ronald McDonald as a client still filled him with respect.

Tang Wei had grown up poor. As a child he'd stared up at McDonald's big sign, swallowing hard.

"Camus XO, on the rocks," the client said in a deep voice.

Sipping the expensive Camus, the client opened the case he'd brought. Inside were neatly stacked high-denomination U.S. bills. The case held exactly $2.5 million.

"The goods," the client said simply.

Tang Wei lifted the case at his feet onto the table and opened it. Inside was a sealed paper bag, its seal printed with an emblem: a great, half-decayed tree. Tang Wei was about to cut it open with scissors when the client said, "That's enough. Don't."

He pushed the heavy case toward Tang Wei and raised his eyes. The moment Tang Wei met them, he nearly jumped to his feet.

Damn, he doesn't have severe hepatitis, does he? That was the first thought to surge into Tang Wei's mind. Otherwise, why were his eyes so yellow? And shining gold...

In each golden eye seemed to be an unfamiliar symbol, slowly rotating backward. The symbols drew Tang Wei into staring hard, even as he realized he shouldn't. The sight made him dizzy, like looking into a kaleidoscope.

"What the hell!" Tang Wei shouted inwardly. When he recovered from the momentary fright, he was drenched in cold sweat. The client still sat quietly across the table, with his rightful fee in front of him: $2.5 million in cash.

"The Three Young Masters are very efficient. I'm pleased." The client picked up the tea-light holder and blew the candle flame into his glass of Camus. The strong grape brandy began to burn quietly, a dark blue flame floating above the ice-filled liquor. He swirled the glass and swallowed liquor, ice, and flame in one gulp. Nodding with satisfaction, he rose to leave.

"Hey, you forgot the goods!" Tang Wei said.

"A courier will come at seven tonight. FedEx. Just give it to him." The client left without looking back.

Tang Wei drank his whiskey in a daze and failed to notice that the wall clock seemed to have gained a few minutes.

"Boss, got the money?" As soon as the client left, Tang Wei's underling darted in.

Tang Wei patted the case proudly. He'd checked the bills: the full amount, all genuine. He'd never expected to get the money so easily. It was almost too comfortable.

"Wow, now I've seen everything! A job from Ronald McDonald!" The underling was full of curiosity.

"What the hell do you know?" Tang Wei rolled his eyes. "He didn't want to show his face. If he'd come dressed as Zorro, security would have grabbed him on the first floor."

He couldn't help admiring the client's ingenuity. Disguised as Ronald McDonald making a promotional visit, he'd come all the way to the office without anyone suspecting him. One brainless young woman at the company had even followed him, asking whether he'd brought a delivery.

"So we get a bonus this month?" The underling gazed at the case full of dollars, delighted.

"Get lost! Don't be so uncultured. In our line of work, we stay cool!" Tang Wei chased him out. "Have the brothers keep a good watch tonight! Someone's picking up the goods. Put extra men on every floor. We'll enjoy dividing the money once we've handed them over!"

On the surface Tang Wei ran a major labor-placement business and drove an imposing Cadillac Escalade SUV. In fact, he considered himself a blue-collar worker. He was a hunter.

He knew there were many others like him around the world, taking jobs for substantial rewards on a website called the Hunter Market. Clients from all over uploaded assignments and solicited capable hunters. Registered members confident they could do a job could reply through the site's mail system, attaching a résumé. This was called "bidding," and the client chose among the hunters who applied.

Tang Wei knew these jobs usually involved strange and supernatural things; crawling in and out of ancient tombs was routine. But you couldn't make money without hardship. He had a talent for this line of work. His company was a hunters' company, and his men all had skills. For each job, the underlings and the company split the proceeds fifty-fifty.

The work was thrilling, dangerous, and profitable. The only problem was that Tang Wei didn't know whether he belonged to the underworld or the legitimate world, and he had little confidence in the Hunter Market site that had made him rich.

No one could say what the site really was. It didn't even have moderators, only an administrator named Nido who rarely appeared. Break the rules and you'd receive a warning email from him, that was all. Tang Wei's ID was 3rd_young_master: Third Young Master.

The always-dark site was like the ruined tombs they often had to "visit" for jobs, with clients and hunters drifting and trading like midnight ghosts. You didn't know what was hidden deep in a tomb, but wandering those boards you felt that someone in their depths was watching your every move. Each extra word you typed, each extra minute online, let someone—or something—in the depths of the tomb learn a little more about you.

By comparison, a client who came to pay in person dressed as Ronald McDonald was almost amusing.

This job had earned Tang Wei more easily than any he'd ever done. He'd originally planned to send his men to seize the packet by force, but an underling had returned delighted. "We got there just in time for the earthquake! South Railway Station collapsed! The falling glass really sliced that guy up. I

risked my life to grab the case and run... It was dangerous, but all it cost was gas there and back! Boss, you need to give me a bigger bonus this time!"

Such damn good luck, and $2.5 million just like that? It was enough to make him wonder if he was dreaming.

Tang Wei touched the bills, took out his phone, and dialed. "Hey, Dad, it's Tang Wei. Wait for me to come home for dinner tonight... Mm... Did your passport application come through? Damn it, call and hurry them up. The lawyer's waiting to file the immigration papers!"

He was planning to take his father and run. He'd applied for Canadian investor immigration. In a few months he would close the company; this was actually his last job. He intended to settle his father in Canada first, hire a few housekeepers to look after the old man, and then travel the world. First stop: Vietnam. His brothers said years of war had left the sexes out of balance, and beautiful Saigon girls by the handful had trouble finding husbands, all wearing those fitted Vietnamese dresses, áo dài, slit high up the sides. A wonderful country full of beautiful legs. On reflection, though, the Sino-Vietnamese battle of Laoshan had been in 1984. However war-torn and unbalanced the sexes had once been, girls unable to find husbands since 1984 would now be middle-aged women with wrinkles and yellow teeth...

Whether or not that dream country of beautiful legs existed, Tang Wei would close his Hunter Market account and stay away from supernatural affairs from then on.

He glanced at the wall clock. Two and a half hours until seven thirty. Two and a half hours until he washed his hands of the business for good.

Chu Zihang stood below Runde Building in a FedEx uniform. The sun sank gradually westward, stretching his shadow long.

His sunglasses reflected the Escalade parked before the main entrance, with its enormous twenty-two-inch chrome wheels.

A BMW 320, loaded down with shopping, drove through the sunset.

"Mingze, once you're abroad, don't rush to find a girlfriend. Your parents won't be there, so don't spend all your time playing," Aunt lectured Lu Mingze in the back seat.

"I know, I know. Will you stop nagging?" Lu Mingze texted without looking up.

"He's grown up and sensible." Aunt was pleased.

"You believe him? Your son might bring home a foreign girl." Uncle looked forward to his son bringing glory to the nation in romance.

"No foreign woman is coming through our door! All you do is watch Hollywood movies and think American women are pretty. Let me tell you, their skin is rough. Close up it's all pores, and their blond body hair is an inch long..." Aunt spoke as though she'd inspected a foreign girl's thighs with a magnifying glass. "Once Mingze gets his Harvard doctorate, plenty of female classmates will want him. Whatever happens, he'll do better than your brother's boy! Just look at that timid Lu Mingfei. He's got an American scholarship, but he didn't even know to buy me a gift when he came home..."

"Didn't he bring you deep-sea fish oil?" Uncle tried to say a few words for Lu Mingfei. He was one of the Lu family, after all.

"What's that worth?" Aunt snorted. "He gets so much American money every year!"

Aunt had always resented Lu Mingfei's damn good luck. At first she'd hoped he would open a path abroad for Lu Mingze, but after swallowing her pride and calling him several times to "find Mingze some connections and help out," Lu Mingfei had only vaguely agreed, with no good news following. It wasn't that he hadn't tried. Cassell was essentially a research center for abnormal humans, but Lu Mingze was too normal.

Aunt had finally called Professor Guderian herself. He'd told her bluntly there was no chance. "Although your son's grades really are better than Mingfei's, ma'am, you must understand: Mingfei is a genius! Do you know what a genius is? An incomparable, irreplaceable, outstanding individual born among us only by chance and opportunity! Edison said genius is ninety-nine percent perspiration and one percent inspiration..."

Aunt suppressed her anger. "I know you Americans emphasize hard work! Our Mingze works hard. More than ninety-nine percent perspiration: he puts a hundred percent perspiration into studying! Definitely more sweat than Mingfei sheds."

Lu Mingze really did sweat more than Lu Mingfei. Aunt wasn't making that up. Mingfei weighed 130 jin at 178 centimeters, Mingze 160 jin at 160 centimeters. If they slept in the same room and Mingfei sweated more, it could only be a feverish night sweat from physical weakness.

"But Edison hadn't finished. He also said that one percent inspiration is more important than all ninety-nine percent perspiration!" Guderian was animated on the phone. "If Mingze is already a hundred percent perspiration, where is the one percent inspiration supposed to go?"

"So Mingfei has inspiration?" Aunt raged.

"Mingfei is inspiration from head to toe!" Professor Guderian said excitedly. "I'm counting on him to help me become a full professor..."

Aunt slammed down the phone. For several nights she tossed and turned, unable to understand how Lu Mingze, whom she'd borne with immense effort, could be inferior to listless Lu Mingfei. Thinking about it brought tears. She shook Uncle awake and told him how hard life had been since she married into the Lu family. Everyone said Lu Mingfei's mother, Qiao Weini, was learned and well brought up, and that she and her husband got along so well. It was as if Qiao Weini were a swan and Aunt a toad... no, an ugly duckling... In any case, they were bullying her to death!

Resolving to turn her pain into action, Aunt rose early and stayed up late for a year, driving Lu Mingze to study like a donkey. At last the acceptance letter arrived from overseas. Her day to lord it over everyone... no, to hold her head high had come. She immediately picked up the phone to call Lu Mingfei's parents. Only then did she discover they had no telephone number for them. All these years they'd kept in touch only through letters written in fountain pen on white paper, and not one had ever had a return address!

The pain of wanting to show off with no one to see was like eating abalone alone, with no audience!

The family of three squeezed into the elevator with bags and bundles. Aunt had even bought Lu Mingze toilet paper.

"I'm exhausted," Uncle groaned. "What's for dinner?"

"I told Mingfei to slice the radish, steam some sausage, chop scallions, and soak the rice noodles. Doesn't Mingze like crossing-the-bridge rice noodles? Tonight it's pork ribs stewed with radish, rice

noodles in the rib broth, Cantonese sausage, and I bought salmon to slice into sashimi for our son." Aunt stroked her son's round face lovingly.

"Don't always make Mingfei run errands for you. Isn't he going back to school tomorrow? He needs time to pack too," Uncle said.

"So what? Going to college means he can't do a few things for me?" Aunt rolled her eyes. "Never mind all the years I raised him."

The aging elevator creaked up from the underground garage to the first floor and stopped. As the doors opened, a sweat-soaked fellow rushed in and frantically pressed a floor button.

"No manners!" Aunt snorted, looking elsewhere so the fellow could hear her but couldn't accuse her of insulting him.

The fellow snapped to attention.

"Lu Mingfei?" Aunt recognized him and flared up. "Where have you been playing? I told you to steam the sausage and buy and install a toilet seat. Didn't you hear? All you know is play! Just like your parents! Where's the seat? You didn't buy it? You go out and all you do is play with classmates? You're so grown up and still don't appreciate how hard adults work!"

Lu Mingfei immediately wilted. Aunt had guessed correctly. He'd just returned. Chu Zihang had dropped him at an intersection not far from the complex, and he'd run all the way, hoping to get home before his aunt and uncle. He hadn't expected to meet them face-to-face in the elevator.

All his life he'd been afraid of Aunt. He hadn't been that frightened even before Norton. What was a Dragon King compared with her? Even if that Yanling: Torch Dragon went off, at worst he'd be blown to ash holding a nuclear bomb. He wasn't Caesar, with a fortune and a beautiful girlfriend to make him reluctant to leave the world. But Aunt was different: waves of brain-piercing demon sound rose higher and higher, and her middle-aged, plump face wore an expression of pity for his misfortune and anger at his lack of ambition. It made life worse than death.

"Fixed, fixed! The toilet's fixed!" Lu Mingfei remained at attention.

He could only gamble on Chu Zihang. He'd said he'd send professionals to take care of it. The Lionheart Society's leader was no ordinary man, and his word carried weight at the college. A little follower like Lu Mingfei had to trust the bosses' power.

"Then why are you running, like you desperately need to take a dump?" Aunt was still displeased.

"I, I, I..." Lu Mingfei kept sweating.

He didn't really know why he was so timid. Even if Aunt threw him out, it wouldn't be a disaster. At worst he wouldn't come back for summer vacation, and could hang out with Fingel.

Perhaps he was simply used to cowering.

The elevator opened. Lu Mingfei carried the bags and followed Aunt carefully, praying everything would be done as Chu Zihang had said when they opened the door. Today was important: dinner was the "family celebration of Lu Mingze going abroad to study." He'd bought his cousin a gift too, a universal power strip with a transformer. A useful little thing; Aunt probably wouldn't have thought the voltage in America differed from China's. Last year Lu Mingfei had suffered in the waiting hall of Chicago's train station, unable even to charge his MP3 player. With this, Lu Mingze wouldn't have to go through that.

"Did you slice the radish?" Aunt felt for her key.

"S-sliced it." Lu Mingfei stammered. He had told Chu Zihang he still had to slice radish, steam sausage, and chop scallions, but had emphasized the toilet seat. He wasn't sure the young master had paid attention.

The door opened... The house was full of white radish slices, neatly stacked, each one centimeter thick. The knife work was exquisite, like a Japanese chef slicing raw fish, with bright green chopped scallions sprinkled on top. The dining table, coffee table, refrigerator—every flat surface in the living room was covered with radish and scallions. All the lights were on, making the slices shine translucently. Aunt was so careful about the electricity bill that she never allowed two lights on in one room.

The steady, forceful chopping from the kitchen suggested dozens of knives rising and falling together, as though a class of chefs were practicing knife skills inside.

A deafening hammer drill sounded from the bathroom. Tiles broke, cement cracked, and the entire wall shook.

The family was stunned. Lu Mingze had been exchanging affectionate texts with a younger schoolmate; in his distraction he dropped his phone, and the battery flew out.

An imposing figure emerged from the kitchen: 190 centimeters tall, shoulders fifty centimeters wide, more than two hundred pounds, his gaze sharp as lightning behind dark glasses. The burly man surveyed them with authority. His left hand held a bucket full of radish slices; his right carried a U.S. military standard M9 bayonet. The gray titanium blade had blood grooves on both sides, a genuine deadly weapon, now decorated with a few delicate pieces of scallion.

"Robbers!" Facing the thug, Aunt lost her breath and nearly fainted.

"There's money in the desk drawer. Take it yourselves!" Uncle raised both hands.

A second thug appeared in the kitchen doorway, wearing only a tank top that exposed bulging muscles, a black military cap, and holding a U.S. military standard Ontario cavalry saber.

"Commissioner Lu?" The thug removed his cap, revealing a splendid bald head with a terrifying skull tattoo on its scalp.

Lu Mingfei didn't answer. He only wanted to cover his face and say he didn't know the man. But he did... These people had once belonged to the Navy SEALs, throat-cutting thugs, but they were retired now and simply maintenance workers at the college.

Cassell College, Maintenance Department!

A burly man carrying the hammer drill came out of the bathroom, his military boots leaving clear prints on the solid wood floor Aunt had carefully polished. He approached Lu Mingfei, removed a large cigar from the corner of his mouth, and smiled with pure manly pride on a square face like RoboCop's. He extended a hand. "Hello, Commissioner Lu! Following your assistant Chu Zihang's arrangements, we've installed the toilet seat. Please inspect it!" He gestured toward the bathroom. "Quality guaranteed! Repairs are our specialty!"

"'Professionals,' all right..." Lu Mingfei pressed a hand to his forehead.

A club boss really was dependable! He'd sent first-rate people, with PROFESSIONAL written all over their faces! But... what was their profession? Killing? Holding terrorists overhead and snapping them in two? Charging through a hail of bullets with a submachine gun in each hand? This was China. Why had these thuggish maintenance men appeared here?

"We took annual leave over the summer and came to China as tourists. We'd planned to visit Guanyin on Mount Putuo tomorrow, but came immediately when we got the call." The leader seemed to read Lu Mingfei's mind.

"Won't you try sitting on it? We bought a top-quality teak seat." The man was puzzled by the commissioner's complicated expression.

"No need..." Lu Mingfei waved weakly.

"We also steamed the sausage and sliced the radish and scallions," the man added.

"But you didn't have to... slaughter all the radishes, did you? And the scallions... Were you making chili sauce, chopping that many?"

The man looked surprised. "The assignment didn't mention chili sauce. To be honest, cooking isn't among our specialties. This is our first time handling this kind of work, so it's a little unfamiliar. Please point out anything we did badly, Commissioner. During reconnaissance and search... I mean, after entering the apartment we looked around and found big bags of radishes and bundles of scallions on the balcony. We guessed it was time-consuming work requiring several people, so we called in the Maintenance Department. Everything else was fine, but the knives weren't handy. Fortunately we all carried our own." He felt he should mention another achievement. "We also cleared the drain while we were at it."

"Look what you've done, Lu Mingfei! You resent me giving you orders, don't you? Showing off for me, are you? How dare you... how dare you turn my home upside down!" Aunt finally understood. Her shrill demon voice could split clouds and stone.

"I... I didn't mean to..." Lu Mingfei murmured like a mosquito.

Disturbed neighbors poked their heads through the door, trembling as they peeked at the room full of thug-like men. They heard they were "friends" of the child the Lu family had taken in.

The burly man immediately grew alert and raised the hammer drill as though it were a loaded Desert Eagle.

"No, no!" Lu Mingfei hurriedly held them back. Their Chinese wasn't very good, and they couldn't understand the neighbors' chatter. They only felt the situation was out of control. They stood shoulder to shoulder, knives in hand, eyes cold, shielding Lu Mingfei in their midst.

The commissioner was the highest authority on an operation and had to be protected first.

"You look down on Mingze! You can't stand me giving you orders! You're so important now, bringing a whole gang to make trouble. Well done! Your family has walked all over me for a lifetime! Go ahead and bully me! I'm not as well educated and gentle as your mother, and Mingze doesn't have your grand style, your American professor backing him... I... I raised you for nothing!" Aunt no longer cared about losing face before the neighbors. Hair disheveled, she cursed him.

Lu Mingfei lowered his head and looked at the floor, feeling incomprehensible gazes on him from every direction. Though the workers didn't know what they'd done wrong, they roughly understood what he meant. They stood in a row behind him, lowered their heads together, and accepted Aunt's scolding alongside him.

Lu Mingfei felt dazed, yet suddenly things seemed clear. So... he and Aunt had never lived in the same world at all. In the world Aunt imagined, he was ruthless and scheming, looked down on Lu Mingze, had an American professor backing him, and possessed status and influence... Apparently he'd

always stood above her. Perhaps he'd been too timid before and should just have stayed that way, never lifting his head. Only keeping his head down and silently slipping along the wall was the life meant for Lu Mingfei.

He suddenly remembered it was his birthday! For the first time in his life people had texted him happy birthday, and someone wanted to dedicate an ill-timed birthday song to him.

Lu Mingfei suddenly laughed aloud. It was clearly inappropriate, but he couldn't control himself.

Uncle and Aunt looked up at him angrily, took Lu Mingze by the hand, and went into the inner room. The door slammed. Through it Lu Mingfei heard a shout: "Get out!"

Head lowered, Lu Mingfei was silent for a long time. Then he patted the Maintenance Department leader's shoulder. "Wait for me."

He returned to his bedroom and packed. Finally he put the multifunction adapter he'd bought for forty yuan on the old IBM laptop he and Lu Mingze had shared, on which he'd wasted so much time.

Lu Mingfei led the Maintenance Department's large contingent through the living room. On the floor were the groceries Aunt had bought, the bags for Lu Mingze's trip abroad, and a cake. He'd never had a birthday cake of his own. Though he was born in the summer heat, when cake wasn't appetizing, he still wanted a cake with his own name on it, even if only to smash it.

"Commissioner Lu, did we do something wrong?" a maintenance worker asked.

"No," Lu Mingfei said. "I know your toilet-repair skills. First-rate."

There was no right or wrong. Whatever he did, this family would never like him. Like a girl who didn't love you, so whatever you did was wrong.

Without love, everything was wrong.

A top-of-the-line black BMW stood at the entrance to the building. A uniformed driver in white gloves respectfully opened its door for him. "A table for two has been reserved at Aspasia. Dinner for you and Miss Chen Wenwen begins at seven."

Lu Mingfei stared. "Aren't we going on a mission tonight? What dinner? I don't know anything about that."

"According to your assistant Chu Zihang's arrangements, you're responsible for the most important part of the mission tonight: dining with Miss Chen Wenwen at Aspasia," the Maintenance Department leader explained. "He'll lead the support team."

"What support work?"

The leader smiled. "Probably leading a team into Runde Building to recover our lost documents."

"Oh, he thinks I'd be too much of a burden, right?" Lu Mingfei understood.

He looked up at the window that had once been his. A solitary light shone there. He suddenly understood why he cowered before Aunt: that three-bedroom apartment in an ordinary complex was like a home. He was different from the others at Cassell. He didn't want to be lonely; the impressive, sorrowful condition called blood sorrow had nothing to do with him. He wanted a home to return to, like an ordinary person.

But he should have understood long ago. Cassell College did not belong to ordinary people. Nono had said it was another path through life: take that fork, and the door to your old life closed. You could only go forward... never return to the world of humans.

With a blade already in your hand, prepare to fight.

Have a golden insignia pressed onto your collar, arm yourself with the immense overdraft on a black card, command those imposing men as Commissioner Lu, and ride in this luxurious car to the most expensive dinner with the girl you once secretly loved.

What you must pay... is only that little bit of warmth and softness in your heart, hardened into iron from now on.

The black BMW glided silently into the night. Lu Mingfei sat in the back seat, his back perfectly straight.

Act Four

Dance of the Flame Demon Blade

Sword Devil with Flaming Rage

Chu Zihang paused briefly and looked around, holding the sword across his left arm, its point sloping down as ink-dark drops fell slowly from it. More black shapes stepped out of the mist. He had no time to distinguish reality from illusion, just as on that night in the typhoon. Then he had been a frail boy; now he had set his dragon blood alight. Without hesitation, without asking why, he sent a storm of blades cutting through the fog once more.

What were his enemies? He needed only to cut them down!

Cassell College headquarters, central control room.

"Our opponents are hunters. Some may have dragon blood. Since this recovery operation is on Chinese soil and we don't want trouble with the police, we need to strike fast and finish quickly, so we're deploying a nine-person team. The Board of Trustees has approved the plan. We'll direct it remotely from here." Manstein glanced at his watch. "Forty-five minutes until the operation begins."

A three-dimensional model of the Runde Building hung projected in the air. Schneider walked slowly around it.

"Where's Mingfei?" Guderian flipped through the plan. "I don't see what Mingfei is responsible for."

"Coordinating command. A very important job," Manstein said. He had left Lu Mingfei out of the plan because his coursework showed so little training that he was incapable of taking on any assignment.

Guderian nodded in understanding.

"Our central objective is the twenty-first floor of Tower A, the headquarters of Millennium. The documents should be there," Manstein said. "The Runde Building has twin towers. The company owns the entire twenty-first floor of Tower A."

"It's only an office building. Isn't a nine-person team a little extravagant?" Guderian said. "You look as if you're planning to take the Pentagon!"

"If we were taking the Pentagon, we'd need seven more people," Schneider said expressionlessly. "Security at the Runde Building is tight. The developer contracted it out to these hunters, so their people are all over the building. They know their business can't stand public scrutiny, so this is how they protect themselves." He waved, and the model changed to a cross section. Every route was marked in red: stairs, elevators, fire escapes, even ventilation ducts. "Security controls every route. To reach Tang Wei on the twenty-first floor by elevator, you have to transfer once and pass four checkpoints. Worst of all, the bottom five floors are retail, and the crowds will slow us down. If the operation takes more than five minutes, the police will arrive, and the hunters will have time to move the documents."

"Five minutes?" Guderian asked, puzzled. "The elevator might not even get there in five minutes."

"We aren't taking the elevator," Manstein said. "We're taking a direct route!"

At 18:15, as the sun sank westward, Chu Zihang looked up at the building's glass curtain wall, where advancing clouds of dusk were reflected. Static crackled in his earpiece as campus headquarters reconnected with him across the Pacific.

"Have you read the operation plan?" Schneider's hoarse voice came through the earpiece.

"It's a low-difficulty operation. If the opposition has no one with a high concentration of dragon blood, I can do it alone. I don't need that support," Chu Zihang said. "The Maintenance Department people are too conspicuous."

"Obey orders," Schneider said. "We've told them to wear civilian clothes and keep a low profile. They'll meet you in thirty minutes. Another team has, as you requested..." Schneider paused. "Gone to Lu Mingfei's home."

"Understood."

"This is China. Don't mistake it for an unpoliced stretch of the West African desert and make too much noise!" Schneider lowered his voice. "There are problems in your past record. You know that yourself. Don't draw the college's scrutiny."

"Understood," Chu Zihang said. "But you are the college, Professor."

Schneider was momentarily at a loss. "All right! That's enough! This is a discreet operation: no helmets, guns, blades, tactical flashlights, and certainly none of the alchemical equipment supplied by those lunatics in the Equipment Department. To the police it shouldn't look like an organized break-in..."

"But a bank robbery," Chu Zihang said suddenly.

Schneider blinked. "Yes... it does look a little like one..."

At 18:30, Tang Wei was playing Plants vs. Zombies while waiting for the courier who was to collect the package. His nagging father was waiting for him to come home for dinner, and he was getting anxious. Tang Wei had once been a street thug, the sort of bully who would lift the skirts of girls passing him in summer just to look. But when his father got angry and came after him waving a spatula, he never dared fight back; he covered his head and ran. His underlings asked, Boss, what are you scared of? You're so tough, and you're a head and a half taller than your dad. Tang Wei smacked one of them on the forehead. "A dad's valuable because he's rare! You only get one. Break him and there's no replacement!"

Tang Wei picked up the phone. "Front desk? Has anyone come to collect the package?"

"No, Mr. Tang. It looks like rain. I doubt they'll come today," the receptionist said in a beguiling voice.

"It was sunny all afternoon. How can it suddenly be raining?" Tang Wei looked out the window. Clouds were slowly pressing over the city, black with the promise of a storm.

The sudden change in weather made him uneasy, as though something were about to happen. He logged in to the Hunter Market for one last look.

He entered his ID, "3rd_young_master," and password. When he pressed Enter, the page refreshed from top to bottom: black background, dark green lines, deep red type, like a door opening before him onto another world. Bored, he clicked through the sections, reviewed his mission history, and

considered posting a farewell in the chat area. His friends would probably send messages wishing the Third Young Master well in a lovely land full of beautiful legs and so on. So touching.

A notice flashed at the upper right: "You have one unread message."

The message contained a single word: "Byebye."

Someone had guessed he was retiring? Who was clever enough to read his mind? Tang Wei looked at the sender field... It was blank.

There was no sender.

At that instant, thunder shook the windows. They flashed deathly white as a vertical bolt illuminated the Runde Building. Tens of thousands of volts of static electricity made every lit window flicker. At last the rain came down.

Tang Wei began to tremble. He had the worst feeling imaginable: the message came from his client on this job, that very manly Ronald McDonald. And "Byebye" wasn't wishing him a pleasant boat ride down a Vietnamese river, admiring beauties.

The word could also mean farewell forever.

At 18:40, a black BMW glided along a quiet, tree-lined road. Rain poured down. Looking out the window, Lu Mingfei saw an old red-brick house by the lake, appearing and disappearing in the curtain of rain at the end of the road.

The old mansion was called Number One Lake Garden because it was the only numbered address on the entire road. Its heavy black wrought-iron gates stood open. The car drove straight through and stopped before the house.

The house was completely dark. Through the huge floor-to-ceiling windows he could see empty tables covered in checked cloths, but no one inside. The door was closed, and the only light burned above it. A waiter in white stood in the rain beneath an umbrella.

"Come on, they got it wrong, didn't they? The place is closed," Lu Mingfei muttered to himself. The driver had already opened his door.

"Aspasia has been reserved for a private party tonight, sir," the waiter said politely.

"Oh, great!" Already nervous and awkward, Lu Mingfei felt reprieved and turned to escape. But the waiter slowly pushed open the locked door. "Mr. Ricardo M. Lu, you are our only honored guest tonight."

Lu Mingfei's head buzzed. Only then did he realize the club leaders had even more clout than he had imagined: they had reserved the whole of Aspasia for him!

Soft music began. The waiter in white walked into the dark center of the old house and struck a match to light the floating candles on the table. In the warm glow sat Chen Wenwen, dressed in white, a white butterfly clip in her black hair.

Time seemed to race backward. Lu Mingfei returned to the afternoon four years ago when they had first met.

At 18:45, on the street outside the Runde Building, people ran in every direction through the downpour, holding all sorts of things over their heads, and the street suddenly emptied. Chu Zihang stood beneath an umbrella in the gloom, holding a long box marked "Flower Delivery." Head bowed, he watched huge drops strike the ground and shatter into transparent flowers.

A van marked "FedEx" pierced the curtain of rain and stopped in front of him with a shriek of brakes. The formidable support team headquarters had assigned to him jumped out one after another, moving as if cast from the same mold. Clearly they were well-trained elites.

"Civilian clothes and a low profile, just as promised. Refreshing," Chu Zihang remarked mildly.

The brawny maintenance men stood shoulder to shoulder as if awaiting inspection, though their clothes were somewhat unconventional. One wore an Adiwang pullover, another wide-legged Korean-style pants, and another oversized Double Star skate shoes. Their leader wore the green uniform of Beijing Guoan, apparently a devoted fan.

"Not appropriate?" The leader looked himself over. "I thought this was how Chinese people dressed."

"But our chest muscles don't look as if they're about to burst out of our shirts." Chu Zihang surveyed their bodybuilding-champion physiques.

"We can't exactly hide our muscles in our pockets..." The leader looked troubled.

"Never mind. It won't affect anything, except that tomorrow you'll make the evening paper's front page: 'Adiwang's American Muscle Men Brazenly Rob Office Building.' You should have read the plan. You have five minutes to prepare. Professor Schneider will send orders directly to your earpieces." Chu Zihang waved, carried the box toward the Runde Building, and smiled at the guards. "Hello. Courier service. Flower delivery."

At 18:50, Chu Zihang was in the high-speed elevator to the top floor, the numbers flying past.

At 18:52, Lu Mingfei gazed into Chen Wenwen's eyes across the candlelight as the waiter poured them rose-colored aperitifs.

At 18:53, Tang Wei hurriedly packed up his office. He didn't want to wait anymore. He could leave the delivery to an underling. On this damned rainy day, he wanted to get home early.

At 18:54, guards on every floor of the Runde Building received a call: post extra personnel in the rain and make sure the building was secure. All surveillance systems were switched on.

Manstein looked down at his carefully synchronized watch, headset on, all channels to China open. The second hand ticked forward.

At 18:55 Beijing time, Manstein said, "Operation commence," and started the stopwatch on his watch.

He knew the order would set a precision machine in motion: the nine-person team at the Runde Building. Each was a gear with a different function, yet each worked with the others. Every plan was different, every assignment decided in advance. If they followed the procedure, they would have the objective in five minutes.

The man in the Adiwang sportswear crossed the rain toward the building's front entrance. His very "localized" civilian clothes did nothing to hide the aggression of those enormous muscles. The guards stepped back and reached for their batons. Wherever these men went, they looked like a gang of thugs.

Adiwang spread his arms, blocking the guards' blows with his hard forearms, then grabbed two by the collars and hoisted them into the air. Alarms rang, startling the entire shopping area. Customers sheltering from the rain and doing a little shopping had packed the ground floor; now they all looked toward the entrance. Adiwang was already tangled up with a dozen guards. He sprinted between the luxury shops on the first floor, nothing able to obstruct him. A burst of speed carried him over a five-

foot display sign like a hurdler. The stunned guards could only weave around the crowd. Whenever he found he'd left them too far behind, he stopped, looked back, and gave them an idiotic grin.

The shoppers were baffled. Had a bodybuilding coach gone crazy? Was this a parkour show put on to entertain customers? Whatever it was, watching the fools chase one another was rather fun.

But soon they sensed something was wrong. Guards poured out of different exits and raced down the escalators. A burly man in a pullover and Double Star shoes ran up an escalator moving downward, taking several steps at a stride. Like a cannonball, he struck the guards and pinned them in the middle. The escalator went down, but the people stayed where they were.

The man in the green Beijing Guoan jersey took the emergency stairs to the second floor, kicked in the surveillance-room door, and shattered the control panel with one punch. He pulled out two wires and touched them together; the excess current burned the equipment out completely.

A professional robbery gang could hardly have done better.

"Everybody down! Hands on your heads!" Adiwang roared in less than perfect Chinese.

He had plunged into the crowd, with guards converging from every direction. He didn't want to fight them; in hand-to-hand combat, one shoulder throw would break their backs. The words came out instinctively. When he had served in the SEALs on counterterrorism missions, he had always shouted that at hostages before emptying his submachine gun into the terrorists.

The customers screamed, crouched, and put their hands on their heads.

"They're awfully cooperative, aren't they?" Adiwang was pleased by the Chinese public's counterterrorism awareness. On past missions in Europe, he had often encountered hostages whose legs went weak and who shook too hard to cooperate.

His satisfaction lasted only a second. He suddenly saw the pretty girl in front of him crouch and hold up the wallet she had taken from her bag as though presenting a treasure.

Damn it! They really thought it was a robbery!

The retail floors were in chaos. All the guards converged there, scattered in every direction by the huge men acting like a pack of fools. The ropes holding a wall of balloons on the first floor were untied, and the balloons rose slowly. From the second floor someone poured down paper-cut dandelions meant for the Qixi celebration, filling the air with little spinning parachutes. Someone hurled handfuls of glow sticks from a nearby display into the crowd. A giant ball of flowers was pulled from the center of the dome and burst in the air, thousands of silk flowers floating like a sea of blossoms.

The Maintenance Department elites were having a good time. This was a simple assignment: draw the guards into the shops and blind the surveillance system, leaving the rest to the man among them with the strongest bloodline. They only had to play with the guards for five minutes.

They didn't notice the van they had left in the rain shudder to life and roll slowly toward the front entrance. Its wipers were off, and rain on the windshield hid the driver.

On the roof, Chu Zihang stood in the pouring rain, holding the "Flower Delivery" box. The Runde Building was forty-six stories and 210 meters tall. Looking down from the edge of the roof, everything seemed so small that he felt far removed from the whole world.

Lonely. Vast and open.

Chu Zihang let his body tip forward and plunged straight down!

In complete weightlessness, he drew the sword from the box. Shreds of flowers flew, and the sacred sword Murasame shrieked as it cut the air.

On the twenty-first floor of Tower A, guards had blocked every entrance, from the stairwells to the elevators. At Tang Wei's order, they had all mobilized. Millennium was nominally a security company, and they were professionals: its eighty or ninety men were no pushovers. The building had called the police, so even armed opponents shouldn't necessarily have been able to fight their way up. The guards couldn't understand why Tang Wei was so nervous. Besides, the banks were all downstairs; on this floor there was only their security company, full of big men and the smell of sweat and cigarettes. Bank robbers shouldn't make it their first stop.

"Hey, hey! Someone's jumping!" one guard said, pointing out the window.

Most saw a figure flash downward. Then came the sharp twang of a steel cable tightening and the creak of turning gears. An enormous dark shape rose outside the window. A courier in sunglasses stood in the rain, carrying a long sheathed sword. He unfastened the rappelling clip at his waist and threw the bare flower stems into the wind.

This was his direct route. He had fallen wearing a rappelling clip, while the Maintenance Department had activated the suspended platform used to wash the glass curtain wall. As the platform rose and Chu Zihang descended, he used the clip to slow himself and landed safely.

It looked elaborate, but was actually simple and practical: the optimal route Norma had devised after analyzing the entire building. The disturbance in the shops concealed the purpose of the operation, allowed control of the platform, and kept the mass of guards downstairs occupied.

Four minutes and forty seconds remained. Chu Zihang only had to clear the floor and retrieve the documents within that time. In the underground garage, the Panamera was already running, a maintenance man at the wheel. The garage entrance had been blocked, causing traffic to jam on the western road in a sea of red lights. The eastern road had been cleared. Once Chu Zihang reached the ground, he could leave immediately by car.

The timing was entirely under control. The plan was flawless, every piece meshing with the next.

The guards stared as the courier pressed a device resembling a stun gun against the tempered glass. Current flashed, the whole pane began to vibrate at high frequency, and then it shattered.

Chu Zihang entered the twenty-first floor. The guards had no time to think; they drew their electric batons and surrounded him. The two in front stepped forward together and struck at his head. By the standards of a martial-arts school, they were excellent students, each capable of fighting three or five men. But that was against people, and their opponent now... could hardly be called truly "human."

Chu Zihang suddenly accelerated. Before the raised batons could fall, he was chest to chest with the two guards. He pressed his hands against their chests, paused an instant, and released his power. He had chosen tai chi as his martial-arts elective; its soft, yielding force sent two men weighing over 150 jin reeling into the walls on either side. He caught the next two by the neck and spun seemingly lightly. The rotation flung them away, each knocking down two more guards. The others were stunned. There had been ten of them; six were down in an instant, and their opponent had clearly not even begun to fight in earnest. His sword was still in its sheath.

An entire squad of guards crowded into the corridor. Their comrades, unaware of what had happened, had come as reinforcements, full of energy. What kind of petty thief was this? Robbing a

bank branch and frightening pretty girls was one thing, but invading a security company was asking for death.

Chu Zihang frowned slightly. This squad would cost him more time. Then he heard a distant chant, like the chanting of ancient monks. A domain unfolded without a sound. The skin of every guard present flushed red as though blood were seeping through it. Their hearts pounded, sending blood surging through their bodies, and in an instant their physical abilities multiplied. They didn't even notice the change, but threw themselves at Chu Zihang with all their strength.

Yanling: King's Attendants, sequence number twenty-eight. It strengthened the bodies of living creatures within its domain. In ancient times, dragons had used it to inspire the humans and even beasts loyal to them, strengthening them into an army.

The intelligence had been slightly off. Norma had not mentioned a hybrid like this in the security company. Twenty-eight was not a high sequence number, but this Yanling strengthened companions, and a whole floor of companions surrounded its user.

Hidden from everyone's view in the shadows at the far end of the corridor, a slender figure chanted softly, faint gold flowing in their eyes.

The storm raged behind him; crowds of guards filled the passage ahead. Trapped in the narrow space, Chu Zihang did not retreat. Surging forward, the guards leaped, driven by a dose of adrenaline that had instantly doubled in their bloodstreams. High-voltage batons crisscrossed the air, static breaking through it in fine purple filaments that linked one baton to another.

Their display was intimidating, but still not enough to threaten Chu Zihang. There was a fundamental difference between hybrids and ordinary humans, however much the latter were strengthened.

Chu Zihang sprang back to avoid the blows. He leaped through the floor-to-ceiling window into the storm, where one last foothold remained: the suspended platform. It bought him a few brief seconds to find a reasonable answer to this surprise. Against physically enhanced opponents, he would have to strike harder, but that would inevitably injure them, and when the enhancement faded, the injuries would remain in full.

Chu Zihang rubbed his fingers together. They were unusually damp. He had overlooked something strange: the humidity on the twenty-first floor was extraordinarily high. More precisely, the air was oversaturated with moisture, faintly white like thick fog. The dense vapor had turned the air into a conductor, allowing the batons to spark between one another. But even during a storm, the humidity inside a centrally air-conditioned building should not have been so high.

The guards did not pursue him. Instead, they stopped together and formed a human wall in front of him. For an instant their faces all looked identical.

Chu Zihang shivered. The scene felt familiar: surrounded by a crowd of identical, expressionless faces.

Then he caught a familiar scent: the scent of a cold rainstorm, unique, one he had smelled only once before, on that elevated road shrouded in sheets of water!

A car horn sounded below. Chu Zihang looked down. On the deserted street to the east, a rust-spotted Maybach, headlights on, was driving slowly toward Tower A of the Runde Building.

Terror exploded in his heart. The Maybach's engine roared as it drove straight into a load-bearing pillar on the side of the building. Its heavy body struck at over a hundred miles an hour; the pillar tore its front end in two, and the entire building shook. The suspended platform jolted. Its cables slipped off the gears, caught between the bearings, and were twisted apart. Chu Zihang lost his balance as the entire platform fell!

He understood at once why the guards hadn't pursued him. They had merely wanted to force him into a death trap. They had succeeded.

Portofino, Italy.

Amid whirling leaves, a silver Rolls-Royce climbed the winding mountain road into the Splendid Hotel and stopped beside a white building close to the cliff.

The detached building had walls of hard white marble and narrow little windows, like a tiny fortress. Its private parking lot was nearly full: a Lamborghini, a vintage Jaguar, an AMG-modified Mercedes. Surprisingly, an orange mountain bike occupied an entire space alongside the luxury cars.

The driver bent to open the door, shielding its upper edge with his hand so the honored guest wouldn't bump her head. A golden high heel touched the ground, followed by a slender, breathtakingly beautiful leg. Unlike the aristocratic lady the shoe suggested, the passenger was a young woman with features as exquisite as a sculpture by a Greek master. She looked twenty, but her eyes belonged to someone in her thirties. She wore the makeup of a European grande dame, a black veil, an expensive fitted skirt suit, and a fur stole. Her slender heels gave her a swaying grace as she walked, but her cold face carried the imperious air of a queen.

"The sixth trustee, and the last. Elizabeth Laurent, twenty-two. Her family owns one of Europe's largest syndicates, with interests in mining and finance. After her father died in a plane crash, she had to interrupt her studies at the Royal Academy of Arts to inherit the business." Not far from the white building, behind the blinds of a hotel suite, a secretary named Parsi explained patiently.

"A woman who thinks she's very beautiful." Caesar lifted a slat and peered out.

"Indeed. Her family was once famous among hybrids for producing beautiful descendants." Parsi smiled.

"Hello, Liza, my child! Welcome, welcome. Right on time." An old man strode out to meet her, arms open. "You've grown again. I still remember you in your Eton uniform."

"Thank you, Anjou." She embraced him and exchanged cheek kisses. "You haven't seen me in eight years, then. You look just the same. Time seems to have stopped for you."

"For an old man, the god of time takes pity and lets the clock run a little more slowly." The old man offered her his arm like a gentleman.

She took it and climbed the stairs with him, like a beautiful daughter entering society for the first time with her elderly but still handsome father.

Principal Anjou of Cassell College.

"There should be one more trustee," Caesar said.

"I've never seen him attend, and I don't know his name," Parsi said.

"He spends enormous sums on the college every year but never comes to exercise the power he's entitled to. Magnificent."

"The trustees don't invest in Cassell College for money. They are," Parsi said softly, "the secret party of dragon-slaying families!"

A secret organization that had endured for thousands of years, an elite legion of hybrids that had trained countless brave fighters under an iron code—the Dragon Blood Secret Party had, in the modern world, taken the form of a college board of trustees.

"They're also this generation's council of elders, aren't they?" Caesar asked.

"Yes. The board and the council of elders are one and the same. The trustees are the highest class among hybrids, the true holders of power. Principal Anjou is only the executive they chose."

"All I can do is wait here until they call me in?" Caesar sipped the strong liquor in his glass.

"They're looking forward to meeting you. They'll certainly summon you." Parsi bowed slightly. "That's why your uncle arranged this year's annual board meeting at the Splendid: so you could make your formal appearance somewhere familiar and meet the people who hold power among hybrids."

"People who hold power?" Caesar savored the words.

The building's doors slowly closed from within. Four heavy ancient locks clicked shut together, sealing it completely.

"Everyone is here, so I declare this year's annual board meeting open." Seated at the end of the long table, Anjou shook a small brass bell.

The place had once been used by ancient monks for austere religious practice, so it was unusually dark. Though it was daytime, a row of candlesticks stood on the table, illuminating the trustees' faces.

There were six in all, four men and two women. On either side of Anjou sat two men so old their ages could no longer be guessed. Both wore crisp black suits with dark red handkerchiefs in their breast pockets. One leaned on a cane; the other fingered a string of rosewood beads and muttered under his breath, looking somewhat out of place. Another man, perhaps in his thirties or forties, wore a bright yellow tracksuit, with a bicycle helmet beside his right hand. A trustee of an elite school like Cassell College had actually ridden a bicycle to the meeting. The trustee beside Liza was startlingly young, a girl of sixteen or seventeen. Her long pale-gold hair was piled on her head, and her still baby-fat face was serious as an exquisite doll's. A butler in white gloves stood erect behind her, head high and chest out.

"The same people are here as last year. The one who never attends is absent as usual, and the Gattuso family has again sent Frost Gattuso, my old friend, in his brother's place." Anjou indicated the old man with the cane beside him.

Frost Gattuso picked up the bell in front of him and rang it. "Is the Bronze Report ready? I'm eager to know the conclusion." Ringing before speaking was a board tradition meant to prevent interruptions.

"It's the stack of papers in front of each of you," Anjou said.

As one, the trustees flipped through the elaborate report to the last page. The conclusion read: "The Monarch of Fire & Bronze was terminated."

Though the college taught Chinese, the report was in English for the trustees from different language backgrounds. It meant: the King of Bronze and Fire had been killed.

The trustees were silent for a moment before this definitive conclusion. It was an epoch-making event, and the final report had taken half a year to prepare so there would be no mistake. Though they

had all anticipated the conclusion, seeing the words with their own eyes still required a moment of quiet acceptance.

Frost rang again. "No Dragon King in history has ever been confirmed dead. Anjou, you need to produce evidence."

Without a word, Anjou took out a prismatic crystal and slid it along the table. The trustees exchanged glances. At last the old man with the beads picked it up and squinted at it against the light. It was artificial quartz, bearing the logo of an optical-products company in Texas. Its slightly convex surface acted as a magnifying glass. At its center was a dark-red line as fine as a hair, like a thread of congealed blood. The old man's pupils contracted. His hand trembled as he passed the crystal on.

"The Philosopher's Stone," he said softly, ringing his bell. "A newly made Philosopher's Stone, indeed."

"The crystallized 'fifth element' of alchemy: the Philosopher's Stone, said to turn any metal into gold, also a medicine that grants eternal life, the most sacred thing in alchemy." Anjou nodded. "As you all know, we have lost the method of producing it. The last alchemist in history to succeed was Nicolas Flamel, at five in the evening on April 25, 1382. No one has succeeded in the six hundred years since. Our existing reserves all came from ancient tombs. But what you hold is a brand-new stone, however small. It was refined from the bones of a Dragon King. His name was Constantine."

"Constantine is my name. I have been to the mountaintop of flames, where I melted a sea of bronze and forged the name of a god." The girl softly recited the ancient scripture.

"Now he is dead, and the name of bronze can be written only on his gravestone." Anjou's voice was cold and stern. "A dead god is nothing but a pile of old bones!"

After a long silence, Liza rose and applauded. The other trustees rose and joined her. Anjou stood slowly to accept their praise. Bracing both hands on the table, he looked at the candles and spoke in a low voice. "This is an epoch-making breakthrough, but before we reached this glory, tens of thousands of our comrades died along the way. I propose a moment of silence for the fallen. Their sacrifice bought us this."

The trustees bowed their heads. The meeting room was utterly silent; faintly, waves could be heard rolling below the cliff.

When the silence ended and the trustees sat again, Frost rang his bell. "The King of Bronze and Fire produced a Philosopher's Stone only that big? And to kill him, you consumed a 2.75-gram stone ground into a bullet."

"We used only one finger joint from the Dragon King's remains to refine it. If we destroyed all the bones, the yield would be much greater, but we aren't willing to do that yet," Anjou said. "The stone's purpose is simply to prove that what we obtained was true dragon bone, not an empty shell. If Constantine had left an egg in a 'burial place' and could awaken again, we certainly couldn't have refined the stone."

"'A first-generation dragon cannot be killed' was an iron rule we believed," Liza said, ringing her bell. "Why has it now been broken?"

Anjou shrugged. "It wasn't an iron rule, only dogma. The dogma was that they were 'immortal'; they simply had never been killed. It's really very simple. Making an egg takes time. We don't know

how a Dragon King makes one for himself, but clearly it doesn't arise naturally. Kill him before he makes one, and his spirit can't transfer into it. Then he dies."

"A Dragon King can't be unaware of that weakness," the girl said, ringing her bell. "The first thing they do after awakening should be to make an egg."

"Exactly. Like an alchemist who can make an elixir of immortality, each time he rises from death he should first make another dose and keep it close," Anjou said. "But there are exceptions. First, when a Dragon King awakens, his power is incomplete at first, and he may not even have his memories. Like a hybrid, he needs time to discover his bloodline. Second, in a rage, a Dragon King will put revenge first. We used the death of the younger brother Constantine to enrage the elder, Norton. So although we haven't found Norton's bones, we have reason to believe he died too."

"Both twins of the 'fire' line among the Four Monarchs were killed," the old man with the prayer beads said thoughtfully, ringing his bell. "Are all Four Monarchs twins?"

"Possibly, but we still don't know whether twins have a special religious or genetic significance to dragons," Anjou said.

Frost rang. "Where are Constantine's remains kept now?"

Anjou raised an eyebrow and was silent for several seconds. "Somewhere safe."

"Somewhere you consider safe, or somewhere we all consider safe?" Frost's question seemed to lower the temperature in the room.

Anjou seemed too bored to answer. He shifted to a more comfortable position in his chair. "Only two people in the whole world can enter. It's safer than the World Bank's vault."

"Which two?"

"One is me," Anjou said mildly. "The other built the vault."

"There are seven trustees, and none of us knows how to build vaults." Frost looked straight into Anjou's eyes. "In other words, you're the only one among us who can reach the Dragon King's remains. Is that right, Principal?"

"Mm." Anjou answered absently, taking a Havana No. 1 cigar from a cedar box. He slowly smelled it, snipped the end, warmed the body with a long match, lit it, and took a blissful puff.

Anyone could see he wanted to end the subject. The room seemed colder still. Frost Gattuso, the family representative, wore an icy expression. He was an important man who managed the whole family's business in his brother's place. His importance rested chiefly on the Gattusos' donations: they gave the college more each year than any other family, with Liza's Laurents second.

"Anjou, we greatly admire your courage and achievements in the cause of dragon slaying. But you must understand that Cassell College does not belong to you, and neither do the Dragon King's remains. You are the man we selected to manage that enterprise. In other words, you are our professional manager," Frost said slowly.

"I think I've managed it rather well. If I'm a CEO, I've just submitted a splendid annual report: two Dragon Kings killed." Anjou exhaled bluish smoke. "Trustee, this hardly seems the best time to question my management authority."

Liza rang her bell. "I agree with Anjou. This is an era of outstanding achievement, and he has shown more than enough leadership."

Frost picked up a printed document and slid it down the table to her. "Being an expert dragon slayer and being a good manager are two different things. These are the facts we've collected. Over the past ten years, the college's administrative costs have climbed steadily, with vast sums wasted in strange places. Every year, for example, Principal Anjou announces a carnival called Freedom Day, when students may do as they please on campus so long as nobody is injured. It has become an armed showdown between the college's two major clubs, consuming huge quantities of alchemical ammunition and leaving enormous repair bills every year."

"In return the students agree to obey the rules the rest of the time and not fight with Yanling on or off campus. Youthful hormones need an outlet." Anjou shrugged. "It's a small part of the college's enormous expenses."

"Then your chartered flights around the world for vacations, also charged to the college, must be an even smaller part," Frost said coldly.

Anjou scratched his graying hair. "To be honest, that costs quite a bit more than Freedom Day..."

"Principal Anjou is very popular at the college. He even has a fan club whose members call themselves Team Anjou. To them, it doesn't matter whether the board exists; with a spiritual leader like Principal Anjou, exterminating the dragons is no problem."

"That's excessive praise." The old fellow held his cigar between his teeth, apparently modest but positively glowing with delight.

"The Executive Department's methods have grown increasingly outrageous—or you may call them brave. They look like thugs willing to sacrifice all humanity for the great cause of dragon slaying. Our brave young people tour the world waving weapons modified by the Equipment Department like mounted Western cowboys righting wrongs. They don't hesitate to start fights in the heart of major cities. Cleaning up after them costs tens of millions of dollars every year."

"It's all for our great cause."

"And every year the college holds a beauty contest called Campus Star, with Principal Anjou personally judging and dancing with the beautiful young freshmen. Every evening there are parties of all kinds. Students fill basements with soap bubbles, jump in wearing swimsuits, and dance Latin dances. The campus network has such a free atmosphere... someone even dug up gossip about a department chair's first girlfriend." Frost raised an eyebrow. "Is that also for our great cause?"

Everyone fell silent. The trustees passed the document around. It was detailed and well substantiated; under the principal's leadership, the college did indeed appear free and uninhibited... or rather, a carnival of demons.

It seemed hard to find words to defend him.

"You aren't thinking of firing me, are you?" Anjou asked leisurely.

Liza rang. "I think we can end this discussion. Compared with the great cause of dragon slaying, these are trifles! We needn't waste time on them. The board isn't a place for quarrels. Can you imagine the elders arguing over a few extra tens of thousands of gold coins a year back when we were still called the Secret Party?"

Frost rang. "We haven't said anything about firing anyone. My point is, Anjou, do your job, but don't assume the whole college should be under your control. It's time to hand the Dragon King's remains over to the board for safekeeping!"

"That's a fortune," Anjou said, continuing to smoke. "We don't yet know what those bones, still carrying a dragon's soul, can do, but at the very least they can produce the Philosopher's Stone. What does the board intend to do with them? Or... what does the Gattuso family intend?"

Frost tapped the table. "Watch your words, Anjou. I'm speaking for the board, not the Gattuso family!"

"You can fire me as the board," the old man said with a shrug, "but I won't hand the remains over to you. There's nothing to discuss."

The trustees were shocked. In their experience, Anjou might be excessively unconventional at times, but he was still a model old-fashioned gentleman. Hearing such blunt defiance from the principal made them wonder whether he'd lost his mind.

The old man fingering his beads frowned and rang. "Anjou, you've exceeded your authority!"

Liza rang. "Can we stop discussing this? Custody of the dragon bones isn't on today's agenda!"

The girl glanced back at her butler and rang. "I think Principal Anjou should be reminded that the Secret Party's wealth must be entrusted to the council of elders. Only the board has the authority to dispose of the bones!"

The middle-aged man, silent until now, looked from side to side and rang. "Let's not spoil the harmony..."

Frost rang. "This is no longer a question of harmony! Exceeding his authority! That's what it is!"

The air around the table grew so heated it seemed ready to ignite. Everyone tried to speak; everyone rang a bell. The clear sounds merged into a deafening, uneasy uproar. The trustees rose as one and split into two arguing camps. Liza clearly supported Anjou; the two old men looked stern; after each glance at her butler, the girl hurled forceful words at Anjou; and the middle-aged man kept chattering, "Stay calm"...

Suddenly a more furious ringing drowned out every voice, full of impatience and ferocity.

All eyes turned to the man ringing: Anjou. The old fellow had seized several bells around him and was shaking them furiously over his head, cigar clenched between his teeth as clouds of smoke poured out. He looked rather like some villain wielding a soul-shaking bell in The Investiture of the Gods...

Anjou threw the bells onto the table, leaned back, and exhaled at length. "All right. This subject won't reach a conclusion, so we can end it. You won't fire me for now, because you can't find anyone to replace me."

After a long silence, the trustees resumed their seats. Anjou had named the problem closest to their hearts. Supporters and opponents alike admitted that in Cassell's hundred-plus years, no one had appeared who could replace him. Behind Anjou stood the department heads, powerful supporters and elites among hybrids.

"Next item: the candidate for the Nibelungen Project." Anjou clapped his hands. "Allow me to introduce our A-rank student, an elite beyond question: Caesar Gattuso."

The door opened. Brilliant gold hair, sea-blue eyes, a pure-white dinner suit, and a violet silk handkerchief in his breast pocket: Caesar Gattuso appeared before the trustees in unapologetically flamboyant attire.

"So handsome!" the girl blurted out involuntarily.

The butler promptly put a hand on her shoulder. "Miss, composure."

Embarrassed, she resumed the solemn face of a trustee, her little face stiff with the effort.

Caesar nodded slightly to everyone and sat casually in the empty seat at the end of the table.

"No student has ever been invited to a board meeting in all these years. You're the first." Anjou glanced at Caesar, then turned to the trustees. "A brief introduction: he has just been reelected Student Council president unanimously, unprecedented in college history, though that has something to do with his turning the council into his personal fan club. His GPA is 2.7, rather poor, the same as former President George W. Bush's at Yale. Numerous tardies, two failed courses... Oh, he's one of the leaders in the armed battles on Freedom Day. He also received a warning for filling the swimming pool with beer in winter and holding a lavish beer-swimming competition, which cracked the frozen pool."

"I wanted champagne, but buying that much of the same brand at once was a little difficult." Caesar didn't mind the awful introduction; he merely supplemented the last point.

"The one main reason he can sit here as a candidate is that he killed the Dragon King Norton," Anjou said.

After a moment's silence, the trustees applauded politely. This single merit erased all the preceding shortcomings. Someone who could kill a Dragon King deserved a hero's respect and a seat among the trustees.

"Unfortunately, Caesar, I can't reveal the trustees' names to you," Anjou said. "Except one, of course: your uncle. Won't you say hello?"

Caesar seemed not to hear. From the moment he entered the room, he had not looked at Frost Gattuso, his own uncle. Nor had he ever told anyone that he belonged to a trustee's family.

"You didn't summon me here because the Gattusos sit on the board, did you?" Caesar looked at Anjou. "When I entered Cassell, I said it was my personal choice, nothing to do with the family."

"No. It's because of a project: the Nibelungen Project," Frost Gattuso said.

"Nibelungen?" Caesar repeated the name.

He knew it as the land of the dead in Norse mythology. In Wagner's famous opera The Ring of the Nibelung, the ring of that name represented power: whoever possessed it would possess the world. A family music teacher had taught him to appreciate opera since childhood, and he liked heroic themes.

"Before we disclose the project, we have a few questions," Liza said. "What do you think of dragon slaying?"

"Enormous fun." Caesar's answer was nonsensical.

The butler whispered to the girl. She nodded, fixing her dark-green, catlike eyes on Caesar. "Why slay dragons? Without following Cassell's path, you could still enjoy an aristocrat's life."

"Isn't human existence a matter of proving oneself again and again?" His ice-blue eyes met hers without flinching. "I haven't found a better way to prove myself."

"Good," Anjou said. "What is your goal for the future?"

"Wait for the next Dragon King to awaken and kill him." Caesar spread his hands. "I only hope he won't wait until I've died of old age."

"I like that lawless tone. Frost, you see, your nephew is actually more like me than you..." Anjou smiled. "Caesar, you faced Norton directly. Did you feel his overwhelming power?"

Caesar grew grave. After a pause he nodded. "Overwhelming power, an aura like the tide. Suffocating!"

"Yes. Nothing trains a dragon slayer better than experiencing a battlefield and smelling blood. You felt a Dragon King's power: absolute strength that numbers alone cannot oppose. We all have dragon blood; dragons are half our ancestry. Our bloodline makes us instinctively want to submit to them. Only the strongest will and finest blood can preserve dignity before a Dragon King and kill him! So Cassell must train not a crowd, but the elite of the elite, heroes among heroes, incomparable like Meinhard Cassell, the first president of the Lionheart Society." Anjou looked into Caesar's eyes, his voice low. "Because the worst time... is almost upon us."

"The worst time?"

"The Dragon Kings on the other three thrones of the Four Monarchs will all awaken. Myth foretold a collective awakening, and Norton's awakening proves the prophecy. You wanted to know when the next Dragon King would wake? Perhaps... today!"

"A collective awakening...?" Caesar drew a deep breath.

"So we can no longer wait. We must choose the finest bloodline among outstanding candidates and devote everything to training that person. He will be the Dragon Kings' mortal enemy." Anjou paused. "The world's savior."

"Me?" Caesar pointed at himself.

"Possibly you," Liza said.

"If devoting everything to my training means more classes and drills, forget it. I'm not good at that. My GPA's only 2.7, as bad as the former president's at Yale, as the principal already said." Caesar shrugged.

"No. What we intend to strengthen is your bloodline," Frost said slowly.

"Strengthen my bloodline?"

"Did you know someone can possess more than one Yanling?"

"No."

"Did you know some hybrids can attain the power of purebloods while remaining hybrids?"

"No."

"Have you heard of a 'hybrid monarch'?"

"Comparable to the Four Monarchs?"

"Perhaps even surpassing a Dragon King!" Frost enunciated every word. "That is the Nibelungen Project: strengthen the bloodline, break through the hybrid's limits and the theories in textbooks. Caesar, this is no fantasy. The Secret Party's council of elders can do it. It is a tremendous gift, and we are choosing one person to receive it. Acceptance means power, but also enormous sacrifice. You will face every danger and may even die. Are you willing?"

For once Caesar looked directly at his uncle. Frost's solemn face resembled a preaching pastor's. The room was dead silent; everyone watched Caesar.

Caesar licked his lips. "Why does this feel a little like... wedding vows?"

"Caesar!" Frost was furious.

Anjou laughed aloud.

"Great sacrifice, every danger, risking my life: none of that's much. If giving up those little things would put someone at the top of the hybrids, plenty at the college would accept." Caesar raised an eyebrow. "I'm only curious why you chose me."

"Because you're good enough," Anjou said.

"Why not Chu Zihang?"

"He lacks experience killing a Dragon King directly. In that respect he falls short of you."

"Why not Lu Mingfei?"

Anjou smiled. "Mingfei's still new. Many people think giving him S-rank was my mistake."

"But you value him. He shot a Dragon King and gravely wounded the target. When we faced Constantine, you used Yanling: Time Zero and handed him the sniper rifle. Without doubt you expected him to deliver the final shot, though he missed." Caesar's voice was cold. "You might casually give someone S-rank, but I don't believe you'd entrust your life to a useless nobody while fighting a Dragon King at close quarters."

"And your uncle insisted you were the best," Anjou said. "He said ability means not just bloodline, but organization and leadership. We need a leader people will follow as well as a genius. You're a brilliant leader among the new generation; not even Chu Zihang can match you there. Under you the Student Council has grown into a club able to rival the Lionheart Society. So we made you the Nibelungen Project's first candidate."

Frost had mastered his anger. His low voice was gentle. "Caesar, do you understand now? The family has always loved you selflessly... and placed its hopes in you!"

From Frost Gattuso, this was naked praise and support, a declaration of his determination to put Caesar on a throne. Yet the trustees were silent; no one objected. The candidates had been rigorously selected in advance, and Caesar truly was the best choice. Everyone acknowledged it.

Caesar kept his head down, playing with his fingers as he listened to his uncle finish.

"Uncle, have you ever lost the most important person in your life?" He slowly raised his head and asked the strange question.

"Oh, I forgot. A man like you doesn't have anyone important in his life. So you don't know that people who've experienced that often become particularly stubborn and resistant to certain things. Psychologists say"—Caesar smiled and pointed to his heart—"it's a mental illness."

"I refuse." Caesar rose and bowed. "If there's nothing else, excuse me."

Leaning against an ivy-covered marble column, Caesar leisurely drank an iced gin and watched the luxury cars leave the hotel gates one by one. Last came the mountain bike. Seeing its rider wiggle his rear as he pedaled hard, Caesar couldn't help laughing.

"Is it fun challenging the authority of the family and the trustees?" Frost Gattuso had silently appeared at his side.

"At Cassell I'm only a student. Trustees are exalted people we can't afford to offend. But I said 'I refuse' and made them end their meeting without a result, made you important people come for nothing, and made one of you wiggle his rear on the way home. I thought that was amusing," Caesar said coldly.

"Your childishness is truly intolerable to the family."

Caesar laughed softly. "You know, Uncle, I guessed why you wanted me when I went in. Though the 'hybrid monarch' surprised me, I was right that you meant to promote me. I've been holding it in and playing a game with you, wondering what expression you'd make when I said, 'I refuse.'"

Frost wasn't angry. He sighed quietly. "What put such a cruel streak in your heart? You're a genius the family rarely sees in centuries, first-rate in blood and talent. You want to be a leader too, and you've always worked hard. The family loves you and wants to help. Chu Zihang and Lu Mingfei may obstruct your path; we don't want that. You're the best; no one should be ranked above you. The family is promoting the Nibelungen Project to secure your future position."

"My bloodline? Uncle, you've forgotten something. I inherited only half of the Gattusos' noble blood. The other half came from a lowly name, lowly..." Caesar's smile vanished. "Gullveig."

"Still dwelling on your mother's death?" Frost shook his head. "It seems the misunderstanding between us runs deep. To the family, Gullveig's bloodline was indeed not noble. Her marriage to your father wasn't blessed by the family. But you're different. The entire family recognizes you as its descendant with the finest blood. Your talent has proved it."

"A lowborn woman marries a husband of noble blood, bears a child, and dies. His family despises her blood but accepts the child mixed with it." Caesar looked down and laughed. "It's like a story where nobody likes pigs because they're dirty, but when one dies, people cut off the tenderest pork chop. A chef carefully fries it with matsutake and morels, lays it on a spotless china plate, and serves it on a silver tray."

"Caesar, trust the family. Your mother's death had nothing to do with us. Her funeral was held at Westminster Cathedral, the pope himself presided, and the entire family attended. Her soul is at rest."

"Don't be ridiculous. We're a family descended from dragons; we don't believe in religion. A funeral conducted by the pope counts as compensation?"

"It was an honor in mourning. The family honored her in return for her contribution." Frost was deeply earnest. "Caesar, you are her contribution. Think: the only thing she left from her life was you. If her spirit lives, wouldn't she want to see you achieve a man's great work? The Nibelungen Project is the family's love for you, a gift without equal. Refusing it would hurt your mother too. She's watching you from heaven."

"No. She can't see." Caesar slowly lifted his head. His expression had changed. Few had seen the face he kept hidden: a cold, thin smile, ice in his eyes.

"When she died, she couldn't see or hear anymore. That was the price she paid to give birth to me." Caesar looked at his hand. "All I could do then was hold her hand." He slowly clenched his fist; his knuckles cracked softly. "I didn't dare let go, because I thought how terrible it must be... She couldn't see or hear. If no one held her hand, she'd feel that no one in the world wanted her anymore. She knew nothing of the honors the family gave her. The only connection between her and the world was the warmth passing from my palm." Caesar laughed hoarsely. "Uncle, I'll repeat what I told you: I'm Gullveig's descendant. I'm not that close to you Gattusos."

Frost watched him, seeming to see the sorrowful, surging force pouring from his body. After a long time, he sighed again.

"Caesar, look at the sea. The wind's rising. It's going to rain," Frost said suddenly.

Caesar followed his gaze to the rolling Gulf of Genoa. Dark clouds were gathering, heavy as lead.

"Before you came in, the family had a disagreement with Anjou," Frost said softly. "We have just killed the King of Bronze and Fire. In the face of such an epoch-making miracle, why argue? Because the waves are rising. A new era is coming."

"A new era?"

"Hybrids can kill Dragon Kings now. At last we see hope of ending the dragons' history. Afterward, hybrids will be the world's finest people, far superior to ordinary humans. With dragons gone, no one can stand against us. The world's order will be rewritten, as in the Age of Exploration, as in the Industrial Revolution. That will be the age of hybrids, and you will be their leader." Frost sounded like a poet singing of a glorious future. "The family is putting all its strength behind you now. Isn't that enough proof of our love? You will be the new era's... emperor!"

His voice held a faint temptation, like the serpent in Eden telling Adam and Eve, "Eat the fruit of that tree, and you will stand beside God."

Caesar turned his glass in his hand and said nothing.

"Think again, Caesar. If you're willing, the family will raise the Nibelungen Project at the next board meeting, with you as the sole candidate. Many people dream of this opportunity. Now the family offers it to you; please accept." Frost coaxed him patiently. "Don't miss the best moment. Understand that the family cannot absolutely control the board. Sooner or later the project must begin to oppose the Dragon Kings' collective awakening. If you give it up, Chu Zihang or Lu Mingfei will take your place. Opportunity won't wait forever for one person."

"Yes, I long to prove myself. I long for glory and power." Caesar lifted his head.

"Good. That's what we hoped to hear."

"But I'm different from you." Caesar turned and looked at Frost coldly. "I'll seize my own future with my own hands. Chu Zihang, Lu Mingfei, anyone else who might threaten me—I'll compete with them face to face! One day I'll have everything I want, not as head of the Gattuso family, but as Caesar. Just Caesar, like the man my Dictator was named for. Take back your gift. It's a little dirty."

A cold sea wind blew between uncle and nephew as they met each other's eyes, neither willing to show weakness.

At last Frost looked away. He sighed. "Hatred takes only an instant to build, but love takes many years. Caesar, you're still too young. One day you'll understand the family's love." He drew an envelope from his coat, the Gattuso crest stamped in red sealing wax. "I brought a letter from your father. I meant to give it to you at the celebration launching the Nibelungen Project... The family knows whom you love. Regrettably, her blood, like your mother Gullveig's, isn't noble enough. By rights, bloodline is the absolute standard when the family chooses a bride. But we don't want your mother's tragedy repeated, and we're willing to change the rules for you."

"If you're willing to accept the Nibelungen Project's gift," Frost said, looking into Caesar's eyes, "the family will make an exception and approve your engagement to Chen Motong. Your union will have the family's blessing."

Caesar stared. Slowly he finished his drink. "How generous..."

"You should understand how enormous the family's blessing on your engagement is. Do you still doubt us? The family blesses only its future head's marriage. You are that future head. Surely you don't want your future wife Chen Motong denied our blessing? How pitiable she would be!"

With a loud crash, Caesar's glass shattered on the ground, scattering pale pink shards.

"My engagement has nothing to do with the family. Now take your generosity and"—Caesar bit the tip of his tongue and spat one savage word with the force of someone hawking up phlegm—"get lost!"

A startling rage burst from his eyes. They even glimmered faintly gold, a sign that in a hybrid appeared only at extremes of emotion.

His dragon blood boiled fiercely!

In the distance, Anjou also drank gin, watching uncle and nephew with a faintly mischievous smile. Without Kamaitachi's hearing he couldn't make out their words, but their changing expressions were enough to make the drama entertaining.

At last Frost turned away in anger, leaving Caesar alone looking at the sea. His lowered eyes were shadowed, no longer pure ice blue but dark and deep like the sea under cirrus clouds.

"A family melodrama," Anjou said with a shrug. His phone rang. He answered, then frowned a few seconds later. "Chu Zihang's in trouble again?"

Runde Building, 18:57.

The headlights of the van marked "FedEx" suddenly came on. As their beams pierced the rain, its old engine made a dreadful noise, like an old man drawing a great breath into withered lungs, preparing to drive his stiff, aged muscles at any cost. The van burst through the glass curtain wall in a storm of shards and struck a wedge-shaped load-bearing pillar. The pillar stopped it and split its front end in two, like a sharp blade cutting into an enemy's skull.

Sparks flew from the engine, the radiator burst, and white steam filled the air. The entire building shook, but not as violently as the maintenance men's hearts. The windshield had broken. The cab was empty.

This was the van they had driven here. The key was still in one man's pocket, and they had left nobody inside. Yet while they threw the shopping floors into chaos, the driverless van had been silently circling the building, like a beast circling prey, seeking an opening.

Was this utterly lifeless van... trying to hunt humans?

Supernatural events were hardly unusual to maintenance men with dragon blood, and they immediately escalated their response. One drew a flare gun, knelt, and fired. A dazzling red signal flare shot through the glassless window into the van.

To these men a flare gun could hardly be called a weapon; they had once slaughtered enemies with submachine guns in both hands. This one was an exception. Its enormous recoil knocked a former SEAL who could bench-press 250 pounds flat on his back. The "flare" screamed through the entire vehicle, flew out of the building, and melted a twenty-centimeter hole in an aluminum-alloy sculpture in the center of the square.

"Can that... still be called a flare?" The maintenance man felt as if he had fired a miniature rocket.

But he ought to be used to it: this was the Equipment Department's style, perverse modifications, immense power, and... vague instructions. When the launcher was issued, the armorer had casually insisted that it be fired vertically to avoid "unpredictable" consequences. Now the man understood that it really was sound advice. Firing a rocket at any target would have "unpredictable" consequences.

Still, it had been fired. Surely not even a ghost could withstand a weapon from the Equipment Department? The men exchanged glances.

Everything seemed normal again. The van that had suddenly moved by itself had caused no trouble... Then a piercing metallic scrape reached their ears, like a steel cable... breaking.

Seconds later, a tremendous crash sounded outside the glass wall. The suspended platform, weighing hundreds of kilograms, smashed into the asphalt.

The maintenance men stared in shock. According to the schedule, Chu Zihang... had been on that platform!

Chu Zihang floated in the rain. The instant the platform fell, he had jumped with all his strength, head tilted back toward the sky. The whole sky was reflected in his pupils; from this angle every raindrop seemed to fall from one point at its center, all of them destined for his eyes.

Like a god observing the world from the air, he saw it with extraordinary clarity.

In an instant he underwent a transformation as though reborn. Blood rushed through his veins like a great river thawing from ice; every cell breathed recklessly and with all its strength, like a spring bud. Endless power passed silently along muscle and sinew.

He had used blood amplification.

This technique instantaneously increased bloodline purity through mental means. Before the industrial age it had been the deepest secret of certain families, allowing a hybrid body to gain power close to a pureblood dragon's. But it was also regarded as black magic and subjected to many restrictions. After the persecution of heretics in the dark Middle Ages, the secret ceased to be passed down. Not until the early twentieth century did the Secret Party's rising Lionheart Society rediscover it, quickly surpassing the older generation to establish itself as the new generation's leader.

And Chu Zihang was the current Lionheart Society president.

The records preserved by the society said a lion lay hidden in one's bloodline. If you were willing to untie the ropes binding it, you could gain its strength. And what bound that strength was yourself.

The Lionheart Society's original meaning was "the society that releases the lion's heart."

With a motion no human could possibly perform, Chu Zihang stepped against the glass curtain wall and used a moment's friction to check his fall. He threw away the scabbard and drove Murasame through the glass. The force of his descent left a smooth cut down its surface!

He exerted force with one hand and leaped back onto the twenty-first floor. Confronted by his sudden return, the guards showed no panic, as though they saw nothing astonishing in defying gravity. They tightened their grips on their batons; some unfastened iron chains from their waists. Chu Zihang looked around, eyes unfocused. He wasn't looking at the eager guards at all; those antlike things did not exist in his sight.

If a god looked down on the world, would he gaze at every passerby? It was like a child crouching beside a tree root, watching ants busily going in and out and poking a stick into their nest, without truly looking at any individual ant.

Once you possessed the power to reduce an individual to ashes with ease, you would no longer notice its existence.

His sunglasses had fallen during the descent. Blazing golden eyes lit the mist. The guards began to retreat; the majesty of those pupils opposed the Yanling controlling them. It was a gaze from on high, as though a hand gripped each heart and would crush it if the owner resisted and failed to answer.

The faint, dreamlike song suddenly rose, piercing the air like a blade, and the domain expanded at once. Bright beads of blood seeped from the guards' skin. Their bodies had been strengthened to the limit; their blood pressure was so high that capillaries burst. The Yanling overcame the authority of the golden eyes, extinguishing their fear. They leaped again, electric batons high overhead, spiderweb filaments of static entwining them. An attack without a blind spot closed in from every direction at once.

Yanling: Sovereign Flame opened its domain.

Enormous heat filled the confined space. In a few hundredths of a second, the temperature approached eighty degrees Celsius. The heat drove the fog away at once. In a spherical space two meters across, centered on Chu Zihang, the air became completely clear; outside the domain the fog remained, the boundary plainly visible. Guards fell on either side of him before a single baton could touch him. The sudden heat gave their bodies no time to react; their temperatures shot above forty degrees and their brains immediately shut down.

Metal clacked in the fog ahead: a gun being chambered. A guard raised an illegal imitation Black Star pistol and aimed at Chu Zihang's head. Chu Zihang's eyelid twitched. Suddenly he was before the guard, gripping his wrist. He squeezed silently, breaking both wrist bones. He threw the unconscious guard aside. His own hand had entirely changed shape: bones protruded, fine iron-blue scales covered its back, and sharp claws sheathed his nails. Several guards swept iron chains low along the floor, trying to break his shins. He didn't evade, allowing the chains to coil around his legs. They pulled in opposite directions to bring him down. Chu Zihang crouched, seized all the chains, and slowly dragged the guards back toward him. Their muscles bulged, their strength now comparable to bulls, yet he pulled those maddened bulls back by sheer force.

The chains suddenly became searing hot. The guards screamed and let go, but the skin of their palms had burned onto the metal. Sovereign Flame heated the chains until they glowed faintly red. Chu Zihang swung them like red snakes across the guards' backs, leaving black marks; faintly came the sound of bones breaking.

Seconds ago the place had been crowded; now everyone lay on the floor. The smell of burning and a faint scent of blood filled the air. Fog was everywhere, a white expanse hiding the end of the corridor.

The King's Attendants domain that had enveloped the guards suddenly collapsed. They awoke as if from a dream, their bodies completely unable to resist their injuries. Some howled; others fainted from the pain.

Dragging the red-hot chains among the wounded, Chu Zihang seemed like a flame demon emerging from an opened hell.

The guards crawled backward in terror. Chu Zihang still held an utterly aggressive stance, but everyone capable of opposing him had fallen. How could he attack further?

To swing those chains again could only mean slaughter!

He walked past them, chains scraping shrilly. His eyes held none of the howling men; he simply advanced down the vapor-filled corridor, still in a fully attacking posture. The guards stared, wondering whether he had gone mad. Ahead was only an empty doorway; nobody remained inside.

With a hiss, a cold curtain of water fell from above. The fire-safety system had begun spraying, alerted by Sovereign Flame's heat.

An empty corridor, bodies covering the floor, thick fog, water falling from the sky... Chu Zihang wiped his face. It felt like standing alone in a rainy night.

He advanced step by step. A red "Exit" sign flashed in the mist at the corridor's end. Thuds came from the door, as though someone were pounding madly to get out; at some point the pounding became deafening. He kicked the door open. Denser white vapor poured out. Under deathly pale fluorescent light stood those strangely familiar shadows whose faces one could never remember, silently greeting him with expressionless faces and whispered murmurs, exactly like the reception six years ago.

The guards couldn't see them, but to him they were exceptionally real. The twenty-first floor was full of people, walking slowly out of the fog toward Chu Zihang, their faces blank.

He removed the earpiece from behind his ear, threw it down, and crushed it underfoot, severing contact with everyone else.

What followed really could only be slaughter. That man had once said there was no need for mercy toward these things, because they could not even be called living people.

"Abort the operation! Withdraw personnel!" Manstein seized the microphone and shouted. "The police are almost here! No one can fall into their hands! Where is Chu Zihang? Where is Chu Zihang?"

On the globe projection, a red dot in East Asia flashed rapidly, alarms sweeping through the central control room. The operation there was sliding out of control. Manstein didn't know what had happened; an elaborately designed operation had been thrown completely off rhythm by a ghostly driverless van. They had lost contact with Chu Zihang, and no one knew what was happening on the twenty-first floor. The terrible cracking before communications failed was chilling.

"Continue the operation." Schneider suddenly reached over and seized the microphone, stopping him. "I know where Chu Zihang is."

Schneider brought up a login screen and entered a password. A cross section of the Runde Building appeared, with a rapidly blinking red dot on the twenty-first floor.

"That's Chu Zihang," Schneider said quietly. "He's all right, moving on the twenty-first floor."

"Thank goodness." Guderian held his chest and breathed out deeply.

Manstein stared. "What's he doing?"

"I don't know..." Schneider said.

At that moment in China, eighteen thousand kilometers away, Murasame, trailing flickering firelight, cut through the fog again and again, leaving transparent slashes in the air that crossed like a calligraphy practice sheet written with fierce strokes. Ink-black shadows rushed at him one after another, only to be swept into splashes of thick darkness by the blade, shattering in the mist into countless threads of ink. When black blood coated Murasame's edge, clear drops condensed on it and washed the darkness away. Chu Zihang paused briefly and looked around, holding the sword across his left arm, its point sloping down as ink-dark drops fell slowly from it. More black shapes stepped out of the mist. He had no time to distinguish reality from illusion, just as on that night in the typhoon. Then he had been a frail boy; now he had set his dragon blood alight. Without hesitation, without asking why, he sent a storm of blades cutting through the fog once more.

What were his enemies? He needed only to cut them down!

The ground-floor shopping area had completely changed. Some maintenance men helped guards evacuate frightened crowds; others fought a fire. A shop selling ZIPPO lighters had collapsed in the shaking, and lighter fuel had caught fire. Faced with a stranger disaster, the guards had no time for the American muscle men, who seemed merely a little crazy and out for amusement.

"Who's still on the twenty-first floor?" the Maintenance Department leader demanded in fluent Chinese, rushing up to a guard.

"No one! Everyone's evacuated to the twentieth!" the guard shouted. "We've checked every identity."

An inexplicable chill ran through the leader. If the twenty-first floor was empty, who was holding Chu Zihang up there? His suddenly quickened breathing before communications failed had given them a bad feeling.

"But he's never disappointed me. He'll bring back what we need." Schneider checked the clock. "He has more than two minutes. There's still time."

"Two minutes? According to plan he should already be in the descending elevator with the documents! Still time? The entire operation is out of rhythm! Call your student back!" Manstein was shocked and furious; Schneider's firmness and indifference were completely unexpected. He was violating Executive Department procedures, although the procedures existed to be violated. Manstein couldn't understand his confidence, as though everything were still under control.

"I can't call him back. I can't reach him either. The schedule is broken, so it's broken. He's already left your plan," Schneider said coldly.

"Left the plan?"

"He's still operating, but not along your planned track. He'll retrieve the documents independently. I told you sending him alone was enough. The team is an obstacle to him, not support."

"He... alone?" Manstein could hardly believe his ears. This was an SS-rank mission. Norma had repeatedly simulated the plan and excluded risks in advance before settling on a nine-person team. Each person had a duty; together they were nine components of a precisely coordinated machine running at high speed. Now one component had broken away and was trying to perform the entire machine's function independently. More ridiculous still, the man who had made that component firmly believed it could succeed. It was as absurd as a racing tire preparing to run an entire rally in place of the car, while its designer applauded the brave tire!

"It's not hard for him. I only hope he doesn't make too much of a mess." Schneider handed Manstein a stack of documents he had prepared.

Manstein opened them in confusion. After the first few paragraphs his expression changed; his pupils widened and glimmered faintly gold.

"His previous mission reports. The real versions. The ones you found in Norma were polished by me," Schneider said mildly.

After half a page Manstein closed the folder. Silent for several seconds, he drew a deep breath. "Schneider... do you know what your student is?"

"No, but he's very useful. He's still an intern, but he's the Executive Department's ace commissioner."

"But you don't trust him." Manstein stared into his eyes. "So you planted a transmitter on him. Does he know?"

Schneider looked out the window. "He doesn't. It isn't a question of trust. If you have a sharp knife, you always want to know where it is, so it doesn't accidentally cut someone."

"Where is the transmitter?"

"He had a tooth filled in the college infirmary. It was implanted in a molar then, covered by a titanium-alloy crown. Even X-rays won't show it."

"Even someone with that fine a bloodline gets cavities?" Guderian said.

"I was oddly relieved when I learned he did," Schneider said quietly. "It makes him seem human. Humans are supposed to be a flawed species: they get sick, feel pain, and grow afraid. They aren't perfect, but they're more real."

"What do we do now? Just wait? Three professors on duty are responsible for an operation, and all we can do is wait more than ten thousand kilometers away for your prized student to turn in a satisfactory answer?" Manstein frowned tightly.

"Ninety-five seconds left. He'll hand it in. He's always punctual," Schneider said.

"Dad, listen. I have... Do you have paper and a pen? If not, get them! Quickly!" Curled under his desk, Tang Wei clutched the landline. Only this heavy huanghuali-wood furniture could make him feel safe now; with his back against its thick panel, his heart was beating just slowly enough to avoid a heart attack.

"I have three bank cards, Bank of Communications, China Merchants, and ICBC. I wrote the numbers inside the blue photo album at home. The password is your birthday backward... Dad, don't interrupt. Let me finish. I'm busy and have to hang up soon." Tang Wei panted, fighting to keep his voice from shaking and giving himself away. "The deeds to our properties are at Auntie's. Six apartments and one shop, seven deeds in all, don't count wrong. I bought a three-million trust in your name; it matures in a year and a half. Don't forget your commercial insurance either, another three million... Oh, right, my watches and jade are valuable too, worth two million together. Don't throw them away." He wiped his face, but tears kept betraying him. "I'm fine, don't worry. Aren't we applying for visas? I'm telling you how much money we have so you can answer the visa officer... I'm really fine! Why don't you believe me? Can you stop fucking arguing with me? You've fussed over me since I was little. Do you have to do it now too...?"

"I have a visitor. I won't be home for dinner tonight." He hung up and pulled out the phone cord.

The office was dark. Sprinklers sprayed like mad; rain fell outside and inside the entire building, bitterly cold. The air-conditioning had stopped, the power had failed, and the building was paralyzed. Tang Wei was trapped in this office. A private elevator requiring a VIP card had once come directly here, but now it wouldn't respond no matter how often he swiped. This top-floor office was his real one, known only to a few trusted brothers. He had built a safe into the wall for cash, ledgers, and important things, including the paper envelope of documents. When bored in his twenty-first-floor office, he occasionally took the VIP elevator up to play games, so he kept many personal belongings here too.

Now Tang Wei thought he would die in this office.

He had sensed trouble from the moment that fearsome gang of American muscle men entered the shops. Then came the strange site message and someone breaking into the twenty-first floor, where dozens of his men were stationed—a heavily defended position, in military terms. But when he called down only half a minute later, no one answered. Tang Wei wanted to run, but it was too late.

He had always known a hunter's money wasn't easy. As the saying went, "Live by the underworld, and sooner or later you pay." He had done so many shady things over the years, digging up dozens of ancestral graves alone, that he wouldn't believe in no retribution himself. He wanted to go to Vietnam because perhaps it was far enough away that retribution, having no sense of direction, couldn't find him. He had earned enough and was supposed to retire tonight. Damn it, in a risky trade like this, "retire" was a taboo word. Countless masters died the night before retiring: Qu Yang and Liu Zhengfeng, the two old men who understood one another in The Smiling, Proud Wanderer, or Xu Wenqiang in The Bund, preparing to go to France to recover the girl he had lost...

Now retribution had come in overwhelming force. He had already called the police, hoping they'd hurry over and take him to prison for a good reeducation. At least he wouldn't die there.

He should have known the two and a half million dollars had come too easily. Money that easy burned your hands.

Fortunately he had laundered his earnings again and again and transferred them under various names to his father. If he really died, the old man would suddenly discover he was rich. A single old bachelor with tens of millions, perhaps a hundred million—who knew how many scheming women would try to seduce him for the inheritance? The thought saddened Tang Wei. When he was little, his mother had left father and son to go south and make money, never to return. His father was a worker who supported him through school on his small factory wage and night work guarding warehouses. Later he retired early to give Tang Wei his job, continuing to guard warehouses himself. Dad never remarried, though life was hard without a woman. It wasn't that he still loved the vanished mother too deeply; he'd told Tang Wei he liked women with fuller chests... But such women all demanded that Tang Wei be sent to Grandma's to be raised. Dad refused. My son can't be raised that way, he'd said. My son's a hooligan! They can't keep him in line; he has to stay with me!

So no woman would live with Dad. Tang Wei thought he should have tricked one into coming to cook and wash for them first; Tang Wei could have stayed with Grandma for a few months and then come back. Dad was such an idiot, determined to keep him close no matter what.

Because Dad was an idiot, Tang Wei had to be tough. There were only two men in the family; one of them had to be tough, or wouldn't everyone bully them to death? When Tang Wei made his first windfall as a hunter, he withdrew every cent in cash, stacked it before his father, and said, "Hey! How about that? Your son's made something of himself, hasn't he? Spend as much as you like! Take it!" Dad said tearfully, "Son, robbing banks gets you executed! Run, quickly, take all the money. I'll stay and hold off the police."

The memory brought tears streaming down Tang Wei's face. If only he'd found Dad a companion before he died; then he could go in peace. Unfortunately, none of the women Dad saw regularly met his standards: one had bags under her eyes, another skin too dark. Tang Wei would lose face among his friends with any of them as a stepmother.

After crying for a while, he remembered something. Even if his enemies knew about this office, the VIP elevator was out, cutting off the shortcut. They shouldn't be able to reach him before the police arrived.

He crawled out from under the desk, locked the office door, and shoved the desk against it. Feeling hidden in a relatively safe fortress, he breathed a little easier.

He turned his head, and his heart nearly jumped out of his throat...

A pitch-black figure clung to the enormous floor-to-ceiling window!

It was nearly two hundred meters above the ground. Who could climb a two-hundred-meter skyscraper in minutes? Superman or Spider-Man? Rain hammered the figure outside, spray surrounding him like a faint glow. He seemed to wear a suit of iron-blue scales.

Tang Wei screamed and lunged for the crossbow on the wall. He had brought it from America, supposedly for shooting fish, though it was really a weapon. Its compound bolts could pass through three meters of water and pierce a large fish; in air they could easily penetrate sheet metal. He pulled the string back with all his strength. He no longer cared about human life; the silhouette alone terrified him! He hoped the top floor's sturdy double-reinforced glass would hold the figure for a moment. He needed a few seconds more.

But the glass... began to melt! Dark-red currents appeared around the shadow, along with a transparent boundary that instantly turned the rain to white steam. Where glass met the boundary, it was like wax meeting fire. The shadow entered the office. Everything near him burned silently, dark-red currents snaking along the transparent edge. Firelight revealed his hideous face, bones jutting sharply at his temples and cheeks.

He was a demon burning with black fire! Tang Wei had robbed countless ancestral graves and encountered evil things more than once, but none was so terrifying. Beside this one, they were innocent, gentle little girls compared with a demon god.

At last Tang Wei cocked the bow and fired, opening his eyes as wide as he could. His pupils burned like a lizard's or snake's, or golden gas lamps. This was his greatest secret, the reason he could make a living as a hunter. When he concentrated fully, his pupils changed color. Until now, every uncanny thing had fled before those golden eyes.

The bolt tore through the air like silk being cut. At this distance, such a powerful shot could not possibly be dodged.

The other man didn't dodge. He raised a hand and waved it lightly; the bolt split in two.

He slowly raised his head. Gold ten times brighter than Tang Wei's shot from his pupils, dimming even the firelight. Tang Wei felt immense force thrust his gaze back. He fell to his knees involuntarily, trembling. The other's eyes were gold too, but possessed an overwhelming advantage in power. Tang Wei no longer dared meet them, and understood why some hunters trembled before his own golden eyes. It was like facing a demon god: radiating golden cracks formed intricate patterns in the pupils, seemingly able to rob a person of his mind.

A huge force slammed Tang Wei against the wall, feet off the ground. A hand like an iron clamp gripped his neck, his cervical bones on the verge of cracking. His whole body convulsed, but he had no room to struggle. The clamp tightened slowly; blood failed to reach his brain, his thoughts grew confused, his sight blurred. Though the other seemed surrounded by flame, Tang Wei felt no heat from

the hand. Those golden eyes filled his vision, slowly opening and closing. They could never be human eyes: not a trace of mercy. He observed the dying Tang Wei with indifferent curiosity, like a child poking an ant to death with a twig.

His neck bones made a strange cracking sound. Tang Wei had never imagined how terrifying it would be to hear his own neck break. He knew he was really going to die. Now he wished the other would be quick.

Because facing those eyes was more terrifying than death!

The other suddenly released him, letting him fall flat on his face. Tang Wei had barely recovered a little awareness and hadn't decided whether to be relieved when the man turned and picked up a heavy steel fire extinguisher.

"Is he going to smash me to death?" Tang Wei's heart clenched. He couldn't really say whether being strangled or smashed was better, but was it so hard to make it quick?

The other pressed the nozzle and sprayed Tang Wei vigorously, extinguishing the flames on him. Only then did Tang Wei notice that his clothes had somehow caught fire.

The man dropped the extinguisher and slowly backed away, each step leaving a black footprint on the carpet. The black-red currents around him gradually faded, and the hazy boundary vanished. The iron-blue scales on his skin retracted beneath it like insects withdrawing after poking out their heads. He was no demon god or monster, but a handsome young man, scarcely more than a boy. Soaked through in a FedEx uniform, he looked like a delivery boy collecting a package in the rain, except for the deadly blade in his right hand. Tang Wei stared stupidly for a long moment, then clutched his throat and coughed violently.

The boy sat on the couch, hands resting on the long sword, slowly regulating his breathing.

Tang Wei didn't understand what had happened. He stared at the boy, whose eyes were lowered. He had suddenly changed from a monster back into a boy, yet also seemed to have suddenly grown old.

"Is that your father?" He pointed to a photograph on the wall and asked softly. His voice was unexpectedly gentle, even courteous.

It was an old photograph enlarged to thirty-six inches and set in a rosewood frame. Tang Wei wore a black gown and mortarboard, arm around his father in bright sunshine. Dad's wrinkled face seemed ready to burst into flowers. It was Tang Wei's graduation picture. His university wasn't much, but after so many hard years Dad had raised him to graduation and was immensely proud, telling everyone at the factory and buying a suit especially for the ceremony. Tang Wei hadn't cared much about graduating, but Dad had rented academic dress, forced him to put it on, and paid for the picture. Red words on it read: "July 1994. My son Tang Wei graduates from university. From Father."

"Mm-hm!" Tang Wei nodded hard. "My dad. Looks like me, doesn't he? Big nose."

He realized the photograph was precisely why he had survived. But his father wasn't some powerful official like Li Gang, only an ordinary worker with few abilities. What power could he possibly have to make this killer hesitate? Could this be his long-lost twin? But were there twins more than ten years apart in age? Dad's illegitimate son? Could Dad have produced such a handsome illegitimate son? Tang Wei examined the boy while little dramas played out in his head.

"You do look alike." The boy nodded and checked his watch. "No more talk. My time is limited. You took something you shouldn't have."

Without a word Tang Wei opened the safe, took out the paper envelope, and offered it carefully with both hands.

"You haven't opened it?" The boy glanced at the intact seal.

"No, no. It's the client's property; how would we dare peek? It was supposed to be sent tonight, and then you came." Tang Wei bowed and scraped.

"Sorry for the financial loss." Carrying the envelope, the boy walked to the window.

He leaped out and vanished into the vast curtain of rain.

Tang Wei stood stunned for several seconds, then collapsed limply onto the floor. With shaking hands he took out his phone and called Dad. As soon as the call connected, Dad shouted and cursed in alarm and anger: Tang Wei had spouted all that ominous nonsense and hung up, then wouldn't answer when called back. He had frightened Dad nearly into a heart attack.

"What the fuck are you yelling about? The guest has gone. I'm coming home for dinner, so save me something hot." Tang Wei hung up impatiently. He leaned wearily against the bookcase and began wondering again whether Dad had secretly cheated behind his back.

The grandfather clock boomed, its chimes echoing around the office walls. Tang Wei shuddered, remembering the courier supposed to collect the mail at seven. The courier his employer mentioned was this boy, and in the intended ending he would be dead by now, except for that photograph.

At Cassell headquarters, the central control-room clock changed to 19:00. On the globe projection, the red dot in East Asia vanished at once. Schneider raised his head and slowly exhaled.

"Mission complete," Manstein said quietly. "Schneider, you were right. He's perfectly capable of doing it alone. He can't work with anyone... His bloodline is too strong."

"For a student who pursues 'the strongest,' only 'the strongest' earns a passing grade. Everything else fails." Schneider showed no relief. "That's also his greatest flaw."

"I don't want to congratulate you on such a fine student." Manstein was grave. "He's had another problem. One minute and fifty seconds after the operation began, he completely abandoned our plan. Though he retrieved the documents, we don't know what he did during those three minutes and ten seconds. And the many injuries he caused... Cleaning up won't be easy. I'm worried the bill will be enormous, but you know that's not the greatest trouble..."

Schneider nodded. "The mission report. He may have been on the edge of losing control this time."

"I can pretend not to know, but you must find a way to deal with it. You know the harm a dangerous bloodline can do us," Manstein said. "Don't let personal feelings cloud your judgment."

"Yes. Sometimes I'd rather he were like Lu Mingfei, with no particular ability," Schneider said softly.

"What nonsense!" Guderian protested. "Mingfei is inspiration from head to toe!"

"Ridiculous. What part did your star pupil play in this operation? He's having dinner with a girl!" Schneider and Manstein said together.

Act Five

Dandelion

Dandelion

He pushed open the door and looked up at the rain pouring from the sky. Pulling his collar over his head, he grabbed his suitcase and ran. The Panamera's door swung open and he dove into the passenger seat before looking back. Across the curtain of rain, on the other side of the floor-to-ceiling windows, the air-conditioning scattered the last tiny parachutes. Chen Wenwen stood amid the drifting dandelion seeds, as though she might float away with those soft white things. Looking toward him, she breathed a small patch of mist onto the glass and drew a smiling face in three strokes.

"Mingfei, is it hard, being abroad all by yourself?" Chen Wenwen asked softly, looking down at her plate rather than at him.

"It's all right, really. I have a senior roommate named Fingel, and a boss named Caesar. They're both great to me." Lu Mingfei's voice echoed through every corner of Aspasia.

Before the revolution the building had been a French merchant's house. Aspasia had renovated it after buying it, preserving the old elm floors but knocking out all four walls and replacing them with floor-to-ceiling windows. The rooms had been opened into one another and the upper floors removed, leaving an eight-meter-high vaulted ceiling. An enormous chandelier hung from wooden beams nearly a century old. The chandelier was dark now; the only light in the vast space came from the candles on Lu Mingfei and Chen Wenwen's table. Theirs was the only occupied table, too.

Boss Caesar—or rather, the Mint Club—had made a flamboyant gesture and booked the whole place!

Chen Wenwen wore the white dress Lu Mingfei knew so well, white lace-trimmed socks, and flat black leather shoes. Candlelight brushed her with a faint warmth.

Lu Mingfei wore formal black, with a Florentine-style shirt and mother-of-pearl buttons. The outfit had been waiting in the BMW's back seat, thoughtfully arranged by the Mint Club in keeping with Mr. Caesar Gattuso's usual standards of dress.

To their left stood an enormous antique ship, planted upright with its bow nearly touching the roof. It was a Ming dynasty wreck that Aspasia had salvaged and ingeniously turned into a wine cabinet.

On the right was a huge window, with a tree-lined road beyond it and a river beyond the road. Rain rattled against the glass.

Lu Mingfei had never eaten a meal so formally in his life. He sat bolt upright as though someone had shoved a rolling pin down his back, elbows raised, fork in his left hand and knife in his right, cutting his lamb chops with painstaking precision. He was afraid he'd have to pay for the clothes if he wrinkled them. There had been no ordering: their likes and dietary restrictions were already on file. The waiter said that after receiving the request, the executive chef had personally selected the finest ingredients. The cheese had aged five years in an Italian cave, the chops were guaranteed to come from

six-month-old Italian goats, and the fish had arrived fresh from Yokohama. Every dish was impressive. Lu Mingfei couldn't understand the strange names, but he got the idea.

Each course came with a different wine. Lu Mingfei had little interest in the sour, astringent stuff, but this was no time to embarrass himself; he wasn't eating with Fingel! Every bite and sip... was it food? No, it was sophistication! He ate with an air of refinement, feeling tremendously cool.

"At first I thought you were joking." Chen Wenwen took a sip of wine. "I looked up this restaurant online. They're applying for three Michelin stars, and the prices are frightening."

Lu Mingfei nodded with a flourish. "Authentic Italian food, a bit of a niche taste. It's normal for it to cost more."

His knowledge of Italian food actually began and ended with pizza. But with a boy and girl facing each other by flickering candlelight, whispering together, who would mention pizza? Wasn't it basically a meat-stuffed flatbread? He had to talk about respectable things like foie gras, white truffles, lobster, and Black Sea caviar.

"The wine is wonderful," Chen Wenwen said. "Mingfei, did you learn to drink red wine in America?"

"Oh... some are fuller-bodied, and some have a stronger fruit flavor. Drink enough and you learn to tell." Lu Mingfei licked his lips. They were drinking a 1997 Margaux.

Everything he knew about wine came from Fingel, who occasionally ordered a bottle of red to whet his appetite during late-night meals. But Fingel always chose table wine as sour as aged vinegar, with a standing in its French region much like cheap bulk liquor sold by weight at a rural Chinese supply cooperative. Lafite, Latour, Margaux, the great Bordeaux estates—Fingel never even looked at them. He couldn't afford them.

"I've never seen you in a suit. It fits you rather well." Chen Wenwen glanced at him.

Lu Mingfei's back stiffened a little more of its own accord. He had worn a Korean-style suit to the Literature Club's graduation party, playing the lowercase i for Zhao Menghua, but Chen Wenwen had forgotten. Of course, that suit couldn't compare with this one. This was Caesar's standard. Nono said Caesar was outrageously picky about clothes: he never wore anything ready-made, always ordering from a little tailor that kept paper patterns of his measurements for every age from five to eighteen. A phone call was enough to order a suit. It was practically the Gattuso family's own imperial workshop.

"If I'd known it was this sort of occasion, I'd have dressed more formally," Chen Wenwen added.

"You look great like that." Gathering his courage, Lu Mingfei surveyed her from the tips of her hair to her toes, delighted.

How could she not? In his memory, Chen Wenwen always wore this dress, so white it was almost translucent, sitting on a bench in the sun with a book. Without it she hardly seemed like Chen Wenwen at all.

Throughout high school, even when he managed to get very close to her, he had still felt as if he were watching from a distance. Boys of every kind had always surrounded her, all more accomplished than Lu Mingfei, making him ashamed to squeeze in. Now she wore the same white dress, a warm glow flowing over her skin, only fifty—perhaps forty—centimeters away. He could lift his eyes to meet her gentle gaze and smell the soft fragrance of her hair. He could study her freely, without restraint, like dissecting a little frog in biology class when the teacher made them examine it millimeter

by millimeter... And where were all those boys who used to surround Chen Wenwen? Ha! Not one could come between them. Tonight, at Aspasia... he'd booked the whole place!

Music drifted almost imperceptibly through the room. Lu Mingfei could barely contain himself.

"This song is nice." He began putting on airs as an art connoisseur.

"It's Dalida's 'I Found My Love in Portofino.' You like it too?" Chen Wenwen's eyes lit up with delighted surprise. "Lu Mingfei... you've changed."

He blinked and couldn't help looking down at his reflection in a sterling-silver spoon. Had he changed? Become suave? Was he no longer that shabby little loser? Could he now eat Italian food and appreciate Dalida too?

At last the great day had come: the turtle had turned over!

He had always hated the rich kids in class, showing off their family vacations abroad, their new houses, casually displaying the logos on their designer clothes, climbing into their family's fine cars on rainy days and waving goodbye to classmates miserably waiting under the eaves for the rain to stop... How vulgar! Yet the girls had no restraint; those young masters' airs always left them dazzled, eyes sparkling. But now that it was his turn to show off, he suddenly found it wonderfully comfortable, enough to make him float with bliss!

Lu Mingfei leaned over the table, bringing his face a little closer to Chen Wenwen's, so restless with excitement he was almost ready to take flight.

Chu Zihang reached out with a trembling hand and switched off the Panamera's engine. The headlights went out, leaving the garage in darkness.

He breathed deeply and silently, gathering strength. Only when he felt able to move again did he turn on the overhead reading light, remove his sunglasses, and put his black contacts back in. He got out, stripped off his FedEx uniform, and changed into tennis clothes, rubbing a little dust onto his chest. His head was covered in cold sweat, his hair soaked; that needed no disguise. In the mirror he did look as though he had come back exhausted from the tennis court.

As he crossed the lawn, concealed sprinklers rose from the ground and rotated, spraying him. The cold water made him feel weak; his vision blurred in waves. He had little strength left, perhaps enough to walk a few hundred meters, and had to use it carefully. It would be best if neither parent were home, so no one would stop him in the living room for a conversation.

Chu Zihang pushed the door open cautiously and paused. His mother was curled up asleep on the sofa. At this hour she was usually out at a bar, laughing and talking loudly over whiskey or brandy with her friends. For some reason tonight was an exception.

She slept terribly. Once asleep, the woman was utterly careless. Who knew how many times she'd rolled around? Besides boldly exposing an entire thigh, she'd wrinkled her silk nightdress until it looked like a rag. She held a thin blanket to her chest like a child sleeping with a doll. The air conditioner was still set to the temperature Chu Zihang had chosen before leaving, but that had been a sunlit morning, and now a storm had broken on the evening. He didn't know what expression to give a mother like this. Passing the sofa, he smelled a strong odor of alcohol. He tugged the blanket over her and went upstairs straight to the bathroom.

He bolted the door and checked the lock to make sure no one would burst in. Leaning against it, he breathed in short, silent gasps, pressing one hand to his waist while pulling off his tennis shirt with the

other. It was soaked with cold sweat. In the mere few dozen meters from the garage, the wound beneath the layers of tissue pressed to his lower right abdomen had begun to scab, only to split open again when he moved. A thin stream of blood ran down his body. He took the medicine box from a wall cabinet and found tetanus vaccine, iodine, and bandages.

He peeled away the blood-soaked tissues to reveal a crudely dressed wound. The dressing was so rough it was alarming. Chu Zihang had used clear packing tape—the kind used to seal cardboard boxes, complete with a company logo printed on it. It was all he could find at the time, so he had sealed himself up like a broken carton, as long as the blood didn't leak out where the Maintenance Department could see.

Gritting his teeth, Chu Zihang tore off the tape. Blood welled out. He blotted it with toilet paper and felt something inside the wound.

A sharp shard of glass, roughly an inch long, buried all the way in. When the suspended platform fell, his abdomen had struck the shattered glass curtain wall. Because he had undergone blood amplification in time, his dragon bloodline had made his body exceptionally resilient, and the rush of adrenaline had kept him from feeling pain. But when the effect wore off, the pain returned with vengeful force. His body was still human, after all.

Even through the tissue, touching the glass made him convulse. It seemed to have grown into his body, become one of his bones; pulling it out was like tearing out a bone of his own. He bit down on a rolled towel, took several deep breaths, and pulled hard... Tiny drops of blood spattered half the mirror.

The instant of agony nearly drained his strength, and darkness filled his vision. Half a minute passed before he could see again. He looked at the bloody shard and laid it gently on the edge of the sink.

After blotting the blood, he inserted a disposable syringe into the deltoid of his upper arm and injected the tetanus vaccine. Then he wiped the wound directly with an alcohol-soaked cotton ball. It was like cutting the wound open again, but there was no better disinfectant in the household kit. By the time all the cotton balls were red, the bleeding had stopped. He spread Yunnan Baiyao ointment on a piece of gauze, pressed it to the wound, and wound a bandage around his waist. He changed into a white shirt and tucked it into his jeans, concealing the bandage completely.

He studied himself in the mirror. Nothing looked unusual except that his face was a little paler.

He put all the bloody cotton, tissues, syringe, and glass into his tennis bag, wiped the blood from the floor, and checked every corner of the bathroom to be sure he had left no trace. He would never leave a trace. The Chu Zihang who lived in this house was someone else, unconnected to Cassell College: a good student, obedient, fond of basketball and books, with no bad habits or violent tendencies, whose favorite celebrity was even a wholesome role model, Wang Leehom. Sometimes Chu Zihang himself thought such a person was as pale and lifeless as a paper figure, but his parents were proud of their paper-perfect son.

If they saw these bloodstained things, they probably wouldn't be proud. They would think they had raised a monster.

No one liked monsters, and Chu Zihang didn't blame them, so he put on that pale, pleasing face. He wanted his parents to be happy; whether the person they saw was real didn't matter.

A packed suitcase and a laptop bag were always waiting in his bedroom, ready for departure at any time. Chu Zihang checked that his passport was valid, picked up his luggage, and went downstairs.

His mother was still asleep on the sofa, clutching the blanket tightly.

Chu Zihang took a cushion, tugged the blanket free, and slipped the cushion into her arms. She held it and slept on, breathing softly through her nose. He tucked the blanket around her on all four sides and sat watching her face. Apparently she hadn't gone out today and hadn't put on makeup. Without it she looked a little older, with fine lines at the corners of her eyes. A woman who had been too beautiful in her youth, showing her age after drinking, made a desolate sight.

It was hard to accept that such a woman was his mother. The most reliable thing he remembered her doing for him was giving birth to him. According to that man, she'd wanted to give up even then, saying childbirth would hurt and perhaps she should have an abortion. Unfortunately for her, she was eight months pregnant when she changed her mind, and the doctor warned her that an abortion then would be suicide. Thus Chu Zihang had survived. From the time he could understand speech, the woman had held him and said, Mommy suffered so much giving birth to you, so grow up quickly and take care of Mommy; Mommy works so hard, so grow up quickly and earn money to support Mommy; there are so many bad people in the world, so grow up quickly and protect Mommy... Mommy was so fragile, so tired, had suffered so much... Because Mommy had such a hard time, she missed parents' meetings, nobody packed his lunch for school outings, nobody picked him up in the rain. When he had a high fever... Mommy did stay with him, but she had no idea how to care for a feverish child, so she gave him neither medicine nor water. Instead she touched his little forehead and said, "Are you dizzy? Mommy will sing Zihang a lovely song!"

No one had ever promised to protect Chu Zihang, yet from childhood he had felt he must take care of many people.

Rain whispered against the windows. His mother turned over and kicked at him unconsciously; he tucked the blanket around her again. He probably wouldn't have a chance to say goodbye before leaving. That was his mother, careless and oblivious: once asleep, she slept like the dead, and waking her would only make her angry.

Aunt Tong, the housekeeper, came in, wiping her hands on her apron. "Zihang, are you going out?" She had seen his suitcase.

"Yes. The school moved up the start of the short term and told us to report back." He nodded. "I'm taking a night flight."

"Oh! Why didn't you tell your parents? The whole family could have dinner together and have the driver take you."

"I told them yesterday. 'Dad' has a business dinner tonight."

"Your 'dad' is dining with people from the land bureau tonight," Aunt Tong said. She meant that he had important clients to see and couldn't help missing the chance to see him off.

"It's fine," Chu Zihang said.

He had no doubt that if "Dad" had time, he would arrange to take him out to dinner. Dad was so successful in business because he handled every social obligation well. He handled Chu Zihang well too, never missing a gift or a courtesy, leaving no fault to find. But Chu Zihang didn't need to be

treated as an obligation, so he had deliberately announced his departure only the day before, when "Dad's" dinner with the land bureau could no longer be rescheduled.

"Don't let Mom sleep in the living room again. She'll catch cold," he said.

"No, no, she only just fell asleep," Aunt Tong said quickly. "She was in the kitchen cooking something and sent me to the supermarket for vinegar. When I got back, she was asleep."

"Cooking?" Chu Zihang stared. How strange. The saying "she wouldn't even right an overturned oil bottle" might have been invented for his mother.

"Oh no! She doesn't know how to use the stove. Something might happen in the kitchen!"

They hurried in and were hit by a burnt smell. Smoke filled the kitchen; the range hood wasn't even on. A little more and the smoke alarm would have sounded. Chu Zihang shut off the gas and opened every window. Once some smoke had cleared, Aunt Tong took a blackened pot off the stove. It was imported German stainless steel, polished daily until it could serve as a mirror.

"What is that?" Chu Zihang covered his nose. Everything in the pot had burned to charcoal; he couldn't tell what it had been.

He guessed Aunt Annie had taken his mother to another fashionable cooking class and inspired her to try her hand. Those classes were fun: a group of ladies carrying LV, Chanel, and Gucci bags were taught by a chef who played the master, making dishes like king crab with coconut and egg white paired with the Trimbach family's Alsatian Pinot Gris, or pork and green plums with tiger-paw mushrooms paired with a royal dry red from the Gigondas estate. His mother would come home and practice on Chu Zihang. Each time he faced an indistinct heap on a bone-china plate, he would try a little and suggest, "Mom, would you like to taste it too?" She would taste it and pull a long face. "What I made in class was clearly nothing like this!" Chu Zihang understood why. In class the ingredients were prepared for her and a chef stood behind her giving instructions in real time. Cook that way, and even an old man selling Shaanxi meat sandwiches could make authentic French food.

"It won't come clean. Throw the pot away too," he said.

"I understand! Your mother was boiling dumplings!" Aunt Tong slapped her thigh.

Chu Zihang blinked. Dumplings? Did she mean Italian pasta? "Matsutake pasta in broth with Riesling"? That had failed last time, and afterward his mother had sworn never to make it again.

"Dumplings before a journey, noodles on return. Your mother was making dumplings for you," Aunt Tong said. "She's from Shaanxi."

Chu Zihang touched his chest without thinking. Something deep inside twitched faintly. Flour lay scattered across the stainless-steel kitchen island, with a thick rolling pin lying across it... No wonder his mother had sent Aunt Tong to buy vinegar: it was for dumplings. Dumplings before departure, noodles on return; before a journey, you always ate a bowl of dumplings. No fashionable cooking-class chef would have taught her this. She could only have learned it from Grandma: handmade celery-and-pork dumplings paired with a selected 2010 Zhenjiang aromatic vinegar.

No wonder she hadn't gone out. He had thought it was because of the rain.

He fished a piece of wrapper out of the pot and put it in his mouth. The flavor was truly something. His nostrils filled with burnt smoke, as though someone had used him for a chimney.

"It's inedible. Better throw it out," he said, swallowing it anyway.

Washing his hands at the sink, he thought of that man again. His life had always seemed absurd: a complete loser, boasting about irrelevant things, smiling apologetically as he drove people around, watching his wife take their son and leave. Only at the end had he revealed his terrifying bloodline. With that man's blood, so much should have been within easy reach.

A dragon bloodline that stood above ordinary people and could kill as easily as cutting down straw dogs.

If he was that powerful, why hide his blood, humble himself to serve his wife and make her happy, and live a "normal" life?

What was a hybrid? A different kind of being, between human and dragon. Even if what you did concerned humanity's survival, you were not truly human yourself; when your blood burned, your pupils turned gold like a dragon's. Through golden dragon eyes the world looked entirely different. Dragons killed and judged decisively, strength determining rank. If their world had a ranking system like Blizzard's ladder, blood and death would constantly wash the board clean.

A king was always killed by a new king.

And yet did he still want somewhere to return to, even a doghouse? Did he want... a home?

"Aunt Tong, remember to remind Mom to drink milk every day." Chu Zihang opened the refrigerator and showed her a carton. "Buy this Sanyuan low-fat milk. She won't drink any other kind. Add a sugar cube, microwave it on low for five minutes, and make sure she drinks it before bed every night."

"I know, I know, same as always." Aunt Tong didn't quite understand this habit. Before every trip abroad he repeated the whole procedure as though entrusting her with some momentous responsibility.

"I'll leave the car in the airport parking lot, with the key and parking card in the glove compartment. Have the driver take the spare key and bring it back." Chu Zihang said. "I'm going."

"Zihang, aren't you going to say goodbye to your mother?"

"I'm not used to saying goodbye... Whenever she sees me off... she kisses me like crazy..." He picked up his suitcase and disappeared into the rain.

"Sir, would you like to come over and select a dessert wine?" The sommelier materialized behind Lu Mingfei like a ghost.

Lu Mingfei thought, Honestly... why appear like a ghost now and poke your nose in? But perhaps it was an Italian dining custom. He nodded politely to Chen Wenwen. "I'll be right back."

The sommelier led him into the shadow of the antique ship wine cabinet, pointing out little golden bottles of dessert wine while lowering his voice. "Booking the whole restaurant is quite a gesture. Is this a special occasion? Would you like to surprise the lady when dessert is served?"

"A surprise? Extra whipped cream?" Lu Mingfei didn't understand.

"Have you seen Spider-Man 2?" the sommelier patiently explained. "Spider-Man proposes to his girlfriend over dinner and has the waiter put the diamond ring in her champagne..."

"Soga!" Enlightenment struck Lu Mingfei like a revelation.

A sophisticated, romantic setting like this, a rainy night separating two people from the world, a fine Italian meal and a little wine, Dalida singing softly in the air, candlelight spilling over the girl's white dress—shouldn't he be itching to... no, shouldn't he let his feelings move him to say something

important? This was a stage made for a confession! The girl was watching him, eyes lowered, cheeks flushed. The spotlight was already on him, the microphone in his hand, the audience waiting to cheer. If he didn't say something earth-shaking, it would be a crime against heaven!

"I don't have a ring... And we're not at the proposal stage yet, are we?" He scratched his head.

"No problem, we're here to help! For example, we could decorate the cheesecake with the most important words from the time you met and came to know each other." The sommelier gave an emphatic thumbs-up. "Our service is first-rate!"

"Oh! That's a real bargain!" Lu Mingfei beamed, rubbing his hands, eager to try.

"Then what were the words that laid the foundation of your relationship?"

Lu Mingfei looked up at the ceiling. Candlelight illuminated his eyes, faint flames stirring in them, his face blooming with romance.

Pen and paper in hand, the sommelier held his breath and waited.

"There weren't any," Lu Mingfei sighed.

The sommelier pressed a hand to his forehead. Was this distinguished guest inarticulate, or simply too shy?

"Then put the Olympic rings on it!" Lu Mingfei suddenly said.

"Oh, yes." The sommelier nodded blankly.

Lu Mingfei returned to the table. Chen Wenwen was playing with the floating candle; she gave him a sweet smile and said little. He smiled back, finishing the last pieces of lamb while waiting for his Olympic cheesecake. What could the sommelier know about the twists of his thoughts? He was remembering the high-school sports meet in his second year. His event had been the five-thousand-meter run. Nobody had forced him to sign up. Chen Wenwen was running it too, and since boys and girls ran together and he fancied his endurance, he could show off in front of her. But who could have guessed? Chen Wenwen looked delicate, yet she had been on the track team in elementary school. At the starting gun she had shot away, running right behind Xu Yanyan and using him to block the wind. On the final lap she made her move and took second place among the girls. Lu Mingfei, meanwhile, was still a whole lap behind, shuffling along with groans. He had been knocked down at the start, scraped his knee on the track, and fallen into last place. The five thousand meters was the final event; only he remained on the track, and everyone else had slipped away after watching the race. Just as he was wondering whether to change direction and run straight for the exit, Chen Wenwen crossed the field and ran beside him. "Come on, come on! Nobody in our Literature Club can be left behind!" she had said. She'd worn a white T-shirt with the Olympic rings on her chest, so lovely he wanted to lean against her or something.

What a memorable event! He could count it as the beginning of their romance!

He slipped into a mood of predestined love, convinced that he and Chen Wenwen, not Zhao Menghua, had been exchanging meaningful glances all along. Every great lover had that potential: see a pretty girl and imagine fate had already bound you together, like Jia Baoyu's famous "I've seen this girl before." In short, he was lovestruck.

"Lu Mingfei, didn't that senior who picked you up last time come back with you?" Chen Wenwen asked suddenly.

It was like a bucket of cold water over his head. His lovestruck haze faded, and an image of the little red-haired witch rose in his mind, her silver four-leaf-clover earrings swinging beside her ears.

"She's probably on vacation with her boyfriend," he said quietly.

The little witch's image kept bouncing like a spring-loaded puppet. Oh, stop bouncing. This isn't your scene to be the heroine; Caesar is your leading man... Lu Mingfei's thoughts were a mess.

Could a person like two girls at once? He'd read a psychology article saying no: a man like Duan Zhengchun could not exist. If someone claimed to like two girls at the same time, he liked neither. So between Nono and Chen Wenwen he could only like one; the other was merely adolescent male hormones stirring. Which one, which one?

Lu Mingfei was nineteen and had been single all nineteen years. He wanted very much to like a girl seriously.

Yes, yes, Nono was wonderful. She drove a flaming-red Ferrari and wore a flaming-red bikini. Her rare A-rank bloodline made her exceptional even among hybrids. She was only twenty, but in high heels she could command a room like a little queen, drawing every eye. At twenty-five, who knew how magnificent she'd be? And her mind twisted and turned, a book you could never finish or fully understand but always wanted to read. If you were with her, you'd have something to do for the rest of your life: study her. You wouldn't have to worry about making a living in later years either. The little witch seemed to come from a distinguished family and was very dependable.

In short, everything about Nono was wonderful; beside her, Chen Wenwen was only an ordinary girl. But Nono was too far away. He was her little sidekick, always at her beck and call, and only Caesar was worthy of her.

Would you choose a goddess at the edge of the sky, or the girl right in front of you?

Chen Wenwen is looking at you! She's probably waiting for you to say something!

Stop thinking, brother! There's no future following the little witch! At best it's a toad's rhapsody about coveting a swan! How did the old saying go? A bird in the hand is worth ten in the bush! A little crow on the branch beats a golden phoenix in the sky! Think about it: say the words now and you might finally leave the ranks of the single! You'd have a girlfriend! You've never even put your arm around a girl's waist in your life! Never had a Valentine's chocolate of your own! Don't you want something this wonderful? Just say the words! Only a word from you! A natural eight-hearts-and-eight-arrows diamond necklace can be yours for 998 yuan! Limited quantities, hurry! Pick up the phone and order...

Something strange seemed to have crept into his thoughts... Back on track... Don't you want something this wonderful? Just say the words! You'd never again have to spend Valentine's Day watching Brokeback Mountain with Fingel! You might even get a first kiss as a bonus! Look at Chen Wenwen's lips, soft as petals in the candlelight, and dare say you aren't tempted!

Ten million little devils danced in Lu Mingfei's heart.

Damn it! It was settled! Youth was wasted if you didn't chase girls! What the hell was he waiting for? Wait any longer and the daylilies would go cold! Forget the decorated cheesecake. A confession needed only a mouth!

He jerked his head up and looked across the table. "I actually like..."

"Calm down. Don't spit food in my face." Across the table, Lu Mingze calmly cut a slice of tuna belly.

Not Lu Mingfei's plump, round cousin, but the devilish Lu Mingze who had bargained for his life. The little fellow's hair was meticulously combed. His formal black suit, stand-collar shirt, bow tie, and lace-edged handkerchief in his breast pocket matched the establishment perfectly, as though he belonged here for dinner and Chen Wenwen in her plain white dress was the one out of place.

Speak of the devil and the devil appears!

"I wasn't going to spit in your face," Lu Mingfei began, then suddenly raised his plate. "I was going to smash this over your head!"

"You struggled with yourself so long I got bored waiting, so I summoned you for a chat. Oh, and happy birthday, Brother." Lu Mingze raised his glass, took a sip, and suddenly frowned.

"Of the five great Bordeaux estates, Margaux is my least favorite. It's a Bordeaux vineyard, but its wine tastes a little like Burgundy." He sniffed the wine and shook his head. "The tuna belly is perfectly seared, though if I'd made it I'd season it with matsutake rather than truffle. Let me taste your lamb..."

Lu Mingfei shoved him away with a palm to the forehead and swallowed the remaining lamb in a few bites.

"So stingy. I only wanted a piece of lamb," Lu Mingze said.

"Just letting you have something go wrong for once, so you won't always be leading me around by the nose," Lu Mingfei grumbled.

"How could that be? You're my most important customer. Until you've used your three remaining summons, I'll serve you faithfully." Lu Mingze smiled. "But don't worry, we never force a sale. You didn't summon me this time. This is a voluntary customer follow-up."

"If there's nothing else, disappear! I'm having dinner with my first..." Lu Mingfei stopped. Chen Wenwen wasn't his "first girlfriend."

"The first girl you secretly loved," Lu Mingze supplied the correct definition.

"Get lost! Anyway, I'm eating with a beautiful girl. Could you please send me back to the real world? How can I have an appetite looking at you?"

"I like the atmosphere here." Ignoring him, Lu Mingze looked around. "The old ship harmonizes with the aged elm floor, but the designer has divided the space in a very modern way with marble and resin panels. Old and new fit together beautifully; it's private yet open. No wonder they charge so much."

"What are you going on about? What's it to you? If there's nothing else, please get lost."

"I especially like this table. It seems ordinary, but anyone sitting here can see in every direction, as though commanding the whole space." Lu Mingze pushed aside his plate and glass, rested his elbows on the table, and folded his hands under his chin, looking into Lu Mingfei's eyes. "This is a position of power and authority."

"Here we go again..." Lu Mingfei covered his face.

"You don't like it? But you've already felt the pleasure power brings, haven't you?" Lu Mingze smiled.

"What pleasure of power? It's the pleasure of chasing a girl. Has your brain overheated?"

"You've never felt this kind of control before, have you? That certainty of victory, holding something firmly in your hand without fear it will escape." Lu Mingze lifted his glass. "A bottle of the finest red wine and an ordinary one are made much the same way: grapes are grown, fermented in oak barrels, filtered, bottled, and sold. Yet the first costs thousands of times more. Many people can't tell the difference in taste without drinking them side by side, but still claim to love the art of wine and eagerly collect the most expensive bottles. Do you know why?"

"To show off their money."

"No, not just that. Tasting the most expensive wine makes them feel they possess power. So much invisible value attaches to an expensive bottle: the winemaker's care, the taster's praise, the fashionable crowd's acclaim. The bottle costs eight thousand yuan not because the wine itself is worth that, but because of those invisible values spreading out like a spiderweb. They are worth far more than the wine." Lu Mingze spoke softly. "When humans taste it, it's like sipping the essence of power, bright red, the color of blood."

"Could you please break the habit of never saying anything plainly?" Lu Mingfei was sick of the boy's mystical tone.

"You were happy just now. I could feel it," Lu Mingze said.

"All right, you're the roundworm in my belly. No objection. Next time I'll strain hard and pull you out..." Lu Mingfei said fiercely.

"You were happy because you used to look up to Chen Wenwen. If you were on classroom duty together and she smiled at you, it became a precious memory. But now it's different. You're in the seat of honor at Aspasia, drinking wine that costs eight thousand a bottle, eating food the executive chef spent the afternoon preparing. A luxury car is outside waiting to take you to the airport, and the waiter in the corner awaits your slightest signal, a snap of the fingers, for instance!" Lu Mingze held up a hand and snapped crisply. "A hot Earl Grey, please."

The waiter came silently to the table and poured amber tea into a glass, apparently unaware that the guest had changed.

Without looking at him, Lu Mingze waved him away coldly. The waiter bowed and vanished into the unlit darkness.

"That is power. It's the smallest kind, yet it still has power's intoxicating scent." Lu Mingze smelled his fingertips and glanced at Lu Mingfei. "You've caught the scent already, haven't you? Right now Chen Wenwen is prey within your grasp. You have power and no longer need to look up to her. Instead you compare her with Nono. There's nothing she does better than Nono; she's just an ordinary girl. But Nono is too far away, beyond your reach. The power you hold isn't enough, so you still have to look up to Nono, but not to Chen Wenwen. You could even bend down..." He paused. A tissue rose from the table without a breeze and drifted to the floor.

Lu Mingze bent slowly, picked it up, and tossed it before Lu Mingfei. "Pick her up. Forgive her for everything she's done to you."

Lu Mingfei looked at the tissue. His heart clenched. Blood soaked it, a vivid red heart so bright it seemed ready to drip onto the table.

"Do you... still want her?" Lu Mingze asked softly.

"Take that damn thing away!" Lu Mingfei burst out.

"It's ketchup... I got it on there by accident." Lu Mingze shrugged. "A joke... just a joke."

"Damn it!" Lu Mingfei touched his chest, breathing hard.

"Without power, anyone feels inferior, like a stag without antlers that has no place in the herd." Lu Mingze played with the sterling-silver knife, watching its light turn in his hand. "But for someone who holds power, the girl once beyond his reach becomes a clay doll in the dust, and the enemy who towered above him kneels and begs for mercy. That's power and authority. You can call it the devil, but everyone rejoices to obtain it. Once they've tasted it, they fall in love and long to hold more and more. Have you imagined that one day, just as you face Chen Wenwen today, you might consider bending down to pick up Nono? To the you of that day, she too would be only a clay doll in the dust. She could no longer tease you, no longer wear that proud expression. Even if she cried and begged, you wouldn't be moved. That kind of power... is within your reach, if you only want it."

Lu Mingfei shuddered violently, unable to control it, as if a cold snake had slithered across his chest. Though Lu Mingze was certainly mischievous, most of the time Lu Mingfei regarded him as being on his side, and deep down half doubted the contract that traded away his life. But as Lu Mingze spoke, uncanny golden light danced in his deep pupils, and a sneering demon hid beneath his mild tone.

Mocking the whole world, every person in it.

Could that day really come? Even if Nono cried and begged him, he wouldn't be moved? Impossible, right? With the little witch's stubborn nature, if she cried, the sun would rise in the west, the Happy Prince would damn well break his heart, and monks would return to worldly life. Could his own steadfast heart remain unmoved? Ridiculous! Even if he practiced some secret art of perfect detachment, could he become that cold? No, no, impossible, absolutely impossible!

"Pah, pah!" Lu Mingfei spat twice into his palm and held it out. "Come on! I've spat in my hand. Give me that power."

Lu Mingze paused, then smiled. "I can. You just have to beg me."

"Please, little brother, give me power. I really want to see what Nono looks like begging me." Lu Mingfei shamelessly put on a pleading face.

At last Lu Mingze was at a loss. He shook his head with a rueful smile. "Brother, you aren't truly begging."

"If you can't do it, why talk so big? Acting all impressive, having fun pretending to be grown-up?" Lu Mingfei rallied at once. "Pfft!"

He didn't want to take Lu Mingze seriously. The more seriously he considered the boy's words, the more frightening they became; only by dismissing him as a little brat could he feel at ease.

"But one day you will sincerely beg me, and then I will give you everything I promised... I'll go now. Brother, you're nineteen; please patronize my business as often as possible. A pleasure working with you." Lu Mingze hopped down from the chair. He was the size of an eight- or nine-year-old; seated, his feet couldn't even reach the floor.

"Hey, let me ask you. Who do you think is better... Chen Wenwen or Nono?" Lu Mingfei caught his arm.

"Nono," Lu Mingze said without thinking.

"Why?"

"I prefer a good figure to the literary type." Lu Mingze looked utterly serious.

Everything went black before Lu Mingfei's eyes.

"Oh, crap!" His heart went cold.

In the instant of darkness, the person opposite had turned back into Chen Wenwen. His mouth was wide open, looking as though he were about to lean in for a French kiss. She showed no intention of dodging, watching his eyes intently.

Damn it, what power did that little devil use? Jotaro Kujo's Star Platinum, which could stop time? He always chose such devious moments to pause it.

This time resumed the instant after Lu Mingfei said, "I actually like..."

The next words stuck in his throat. Lu Mingze's voice buzzed in his mind over and over. Every muscle in his body tensed, his face stiffened, as if he were about to launch a missile and discovered it was aimed at the wrong target, and wanted to swallow it back. But it was too late: "I actually like" was already out, Chen Wenwen had heard it... and that damned blush was spreading across her face!

"I actually... liked you," Lu Mingfei forced out with all his strength.

At last, at last he overcame the rhythm of the sentence and shoved in the past tense. He felt utterly drained. It had been a battle between heaven and man: in that single second, Lu Mingfei had beaten back the little soul wriggling inside him. One step forward was a pretty girl; one step back meant continuing his miserable single life in the autumn wind. The eager little soul shouted, I refuse, I refuse, I refuse... and was suppressed deep in his heart again.

In a setting like this, "I like you" was easy to say. Everything had been arranged for that sentence. He had drunk two glasses of wine, desire stirred in his heart, and a bold declaration would have been perfectly natural; even if Chen Wenwen refused, it wouldn't be too awkward. The wine and feast weren't innocent, and if she dared come alone she should have been prepared like Guan Yunchang attending the enemy's banquet armed with a single blade!

"I used to like you" was difficult. Why bring up something already over when everything was so pleasant? Did he want to put a period at the end of it all?

"I know. You don't have to say it." The blush faded from Chen Wenwen's face. She lowered her head and spoke softly.

Lu Mingfei coughed violently. That dangerous change of breath had nearly killed him.

He didn't know whether this counted as a victory over Lu Mingze. He didn't like what Lu Mingze said about power. Chen Wenwen was his classmate; he had liked her very much, and even now was willing to stand up for her. However he changed, he would never bend down and pick her up like a tissue. To Lu Mingfei, Chen Wenwen was Chen Wenwen. If she sent him for a Coke now as she once had, he would still jump up and run.

Some things... would never change!

Lu Mingfei gritted his teeth as though defying someone.

"Actually, I knew before too, but I pretended I didn't... I'm sorry I disappointed you," Chen Wenwen said quietly.

"It's all right, I don't blame you, really. Believe me." Lu Mingfei took a deep breath, arranging his words with care. "Before I met you, I didn't know what it was like to like a girl. Knowing you taught

me. Actually... high school was miserable for me. If I hadn't spent every day mooning over you... it would have been even worse, wouldn't it? I'm grateful you were there. Even though I missed my chance—no, there was never a chance—you can't regret it, can you? If you like someone for that long, they become tied to your past. If you regret having liked them, aren't you denying all the time you lived before?"

He had nothing more to say. He licked his lips and swallowed, embarrassed. "That was too literary. Bear with me."

"It's all right." Chen Wenwen lowered her head. "It was beautiful, like poetry."

"Like poetry?" Lu Mingfei wiped his sweat with a tissue. No one had ever praised him like that before, and he was a little lost.

But there was nothing left to say... Deadlock, absolute deadlock! Everything was on the table now, plain to see. Anything more would be superfluous. It was like the Japanese art of iaido: a sword was alive in its sheath, but once drawn, it was dead.

Should they continue talking about their old classmates? Would Chen Wenwen suddenly stand, burst into tears, and run away? Or would they clasp all four hands and say, ha ha ha, our old misunderstanding is settled, let's drink till we drop tonight? If Chen Wenwen could accept that last possibility... Lu Mingfei would be quite happy to oblige...

The door creaked open. A furtive figure poked his head in and edged inside, peering toward the only lit table, carrying something in his hand.

"What the hell! Brother, are you dropping in for a meal or a room at an inn?" Before a waiter could stop him, Lu Mingfei slapped the table. "Come over here!"

"An... interview." The man, who had REPORTER written all over his face, clutched a recorder, sweating at the opulent surroundings. He pointed to the camera operator behind him. "This is my younger sister... she does the filming... We're from a TV food show. We heard a gourmet had booked Aspasia tonight and the executive chef was cooking personally, so we came through the rain for an interview. Sorry to disturb you... I'll... I'll leave right away."

"You came all this way. Why leave? Sit down and eat with us!" Lu Mingfei quickly grabbed his sleeve. Brother, save me! Don't go! If you leave, we'll run out of things to say again.

"Oh, that's too kind. It's awfully expensive." The reporter was astonished to find the wealthy gourmet so young and hospitable. He rubbed his hands. "I couldn't impose on you for a meal, but could you say a few words to our viewers?"

"No need to stand on ceremony!" Young Master Lu warmly pulled the reporter into a seat, fetched a chair for the camera girl, and called to the waiter. "Chopsticks... no, two more place settings. The menu, the menu! We're ordering more!"

"Well, then... it'd be rude to refuse." The reporter was delighted. "Brother, how's the food here?"

Lu Mingfei recalled Lu Mingze's expression and smacked his lips. "The tuna is perfectly seared, but if I'd made it, I'd season it with matsutake rather than truffle."

"And does the wine suit your palate?"

"Of the five great Bordeaux estates, Margaux is my least favorite. It's a Bordeaux vineyard, but its wine tastes a little like Burgundy." Lu Mingfei pointed at the bottle and frowned.

"And the atmosphere?"

Lu Mingfei nodded slightly, showing his approval. "Mm... the antique ship harmonizes with the aged elm floor, but the designer has divided the space in a very modern way with marble and resin panels. Old and new fit together beautifully; it's private yet open."

"That's what I said!" The reporter slapped his thigh. "An expert is an expert! We've finally found someone who really knows food."

Wine was poured, dishes added, and everyone enjoyed themselves. Lu Mingfei and the reporter slapped each other's shoulders and called each other brother. Then he turned and saw Chen Wenwen smiling silently, her expression hard to read: calm, perhaps, or sad.

Brilliant lights flashed across the rain-spattered glass. The dark-blue Panamera stopped beneath a tree outside. Its window lowered and rose again; Chu Zihang nodded expressionlessly to Lu Mingfei.

"Oh, I have to go. Take your time, brother." Lu Mingfei wiped his mouth with a napkin, stood, and slung his backpack over one shoulder.

"Mm, I'll see you out." Chen Wenwen stood too.

When the door opened, cold wind rushed in. Rain filled the night, and a handmade black iron lantern cast a warm halo through it.

"You're a really good person," Chen Wenwen said softly behind him.

Lu Mingfei's heart jumped. He turned and nearly collided with her; she had followed closely, head lowered, as if too tired to do anything but rest it against his back. The warm scent of her hair filled his nose. That restless little soul inside him began muttering again: Idiot, idiot, you've said it now, and there's no chance left.

Lu Mingfei gave a crooked, bitter smile. "Don't hand me the good-guy rejection card whenever you feel like it... We're just classmates having dinner tonight..."

"Thank you. I know you don't like me anymore." Chen Wenwen shook her head. "But thank you anyway... I don't like you that way either... It's not that I don't like you, just not that kind of liking."

"Mm-hm." Lu Mingfei nodded, thoroughly confused.

"When I said you'd changed, I didn't mean money or taste or anything. I meant... well, you've grown up." She smoothed the hair beside her ear and raised her head, her eyes clear.

"You sound like my big sister..."

"It's wonderful." Chen Wenwen sighed very, very softly.

"That BMW will take you home." Lu Mingfei stuck out his tongue. "Don't stand on ceremony with them; it's paid for... To be honest, I'm flat broke in America. Chu Zihang was showing off. He arranged the restaurant, the fancy car, these clothes, all of it. I was fooling the reporter. The food and wine here are good, but they're really not to my taste."

"I guessed." Chen Wenwen smiled. "You weren't paying attention to what you ate."

"Mm... This is the only thing I prepared. It's for you." He hesitated, then pulled a handful of crumpled plants from his bag and laid them on the table. "Dandelions... I picked them on the way. But at this time of year the little parachutes have all flown away; I couldn't find any whole ones. It doesn't mean anything special, just a keepsake. I wanted to give you dandelions at graduation, so this makes up for it... I remember you picked a lot and put them in a paper bag of bellflowers. When you blew on them, it looked like snow."

Chen Wenwen looked down, holding the withered bouquet without speaking, and gently stroked its empty stems.

"Goodbye," she said.

"Goodbye," Lu Mingfei said.

He pushed open the door and looked up at the rain pouring from the sky. Pulling his collar over his head, he grabbed his suitcase and ran. The Panamera's door swung open and he dove into the passenger seat before looking back. Across the curtain of rain, on the other side of the floor-to-ceiling windows, the air-conditioning scattered the last tiny parachutes. Chen Wenwen stood amid the drifting dandelion seeds, as though she might float away with those soft white things. Looking toward him, she breathed a small patch of mist onto the glass and drew a smiling face in three strokes.

The Panamera raced along the airport expressway. Rain struck the windshield head-on and broke into sprays of water.

"Mission complete." Steering with one hand, Chu Zihang reached back and patted the sealed aluminum case on the rear seat, then handed Lu Mingfei an iPad. "I've finished the report. Just add your electronic signature at the bottom."

Too lazy to read it, Lu Mingfei scrawled something in the reporter field and handed the iPad back. "Senior, you never planned to take me on the mission, did you?"

Chu Zihang was silent for a moment. "You're not ready. I don't know why you were appointed commissioner, but you haven't had the necessary training and aren't capable of carrying out an operation."

Lu Mingfei leaned back, watching the rain pour outside, and sighed. "Hey... I know I'm useless, but you could at least spare my feelings... Just saying I'm not ready like that..."

Some lilting Irish music played on the stereo. Chu Zihang didn't reply, and Lu Mingfei couldn't think of anything to say either. They sat through the silence.

"About tonight... I won't tell Nono," Chu Zihang said suddenly.

"Thanks." Lu Mingfei scratched his head. "But senior, get this straight: Nono is Caesar's girlfriend. I'm single, and I'm free to eat with anyone I want. You make it sound like I've done something wrong..."

"But you don't want her to know." Chu Zihang's answer was as hard and cold as stone.

Lu Mingfei felt he really had nothing to discuss with the president. His way of speaking was like using a knife: the fewest words struck straight at the heart of the matter, hard and accurately, and then the blade was withdrawn. He couldn't be bothered with an extra word.

Chu Zihang was right. Lu Mingfei didn't want Nono to know he'd made a grand show of dining with Chen Wenwen, although he knew Nono wouldn't be angry even if told; at most she'd tease him.

"But Caesar made your reservation. I can't guarantee he won't tell Nono," Chu Zihang added.

Lu Mingfei nearly choked, just short of rolling his eyes. Hey, boss! You're messing with me, aren't you? Caesar is Nono's boyfriend. What wouldn't he tell her? Please, use some sense! All right, you've been single so long you probably don't know what boyfriends and girlfriends are like...

"The restaurant had a wedding banquet tonight and wasn't taking individual guests, but I'd already told Chen Wenwen and couldn't easily change it. It was no problem for Caesar. He's a Mint Club member, and that club can do almost anything."

"Caesar helped you?" Lu Mingfei was curious.

"I posted a reward on the Night Watcher forum. Anyone who could reserve a table for you would be owed a favor by me." Chu Zihang's voice was as level as the asphalt beneath the wheels. "Caesar would see it too, of course. He's the noble young master of the Gattuso family and wouldn't let anyone court his subordinates from a position above him. So he'd rush to take care of it first. Caesar is very possessive, not only of his subordinates but also of his enemies. He wouldn't let anyone else claim my reward and interfere in our competition. He considers me his enemy, so he wants to defeat me himself."

"So you tricked Boss? Senior, you're devious!"

"People who speak little are often devious." Chu Zihang's tone was mild. "Actually, I'm sure Caesar understood exactly what I was thinking, but he was willing to play along."

Lu Mingfei grinned. Worrying was useless now; he'd just have to wait for Nono to find out and tease him. Even if Chu Zihang had played him, he had been irresolute himself, unable to move when he saw Chen Wenwen. Then again, he had no reason to be resolute in the first place.

"Senior, you really have influence. Chen Wenwen actually agreed to dinner."

"I used your name, gave her the restaurant's card, and asked whether she would refuse. She said yes. That was it." Chu Zihang said, "I'm not good at invitations."

"Is that how you've always invited girls to dinner?" Lu Mingfei was speechless. "Like you're challenging them on their own turf."

Chu Zihang nodded.

"That works?"

Chu Zihang thought about it. "I don't remember anyone refusing."

Lu Mingfei sighed. "All right, you win... You don't know how ridiculous tonight was. A reporter from a food show came to interview me, and I fed him a whole load of nonsense."

"I called their show and said someone had booked Aspasia tonight for a dinner for two, with the executive chef cooking personally. They were curious and said they'd send a reporter. When the interview airs, Zhao Menghua will see it too. A man like him probably thinks, 'Even if I don't want it, no one else may touch it.' Imagine his face when he sees the show. Wouldn't that be fun?" Chu Zihang said.

Lu Mingfei glanced at him in surprise. With that cold, hard face, he didn't even smile while saying something so quietly malicious; there wasn't the slightest hint he thought it fun.

"Vicious! I'm impressed!" Lu Mingfei said.

The Panamera abruptly slowed. Chu Zihang wrenched the wheel and braked sharply at the side of the airport expressway.

"Hey, hey! I was only talking nonsense! It's raining outside, senior! I'll catch cold if you make me stand in it!" Lu Mingfei hurriedly said. Last time he'd been inexplicably kicked out of the car to bake in the sun for several minutes.

Chu Zihang waved a hand. "Wait in the car for me."

Lu Mingfei stared, his gaze falling on Chu Zihang's waist. "Holy crap... Senior, you're bleeding!"

A striking red stain spread across Chu Zihang's white shirt. Only now did Lu Mingfei notice that his face was pale as if dusted with powder—not because he was posing, but because he'd lost so much blood.

"It's nothing. The wound reopened," Chu Zihang said lightly.

He opened the door and got out into the pouring rain. He unbuttoned his shirt and tossed it into the car, then unwound the layers of gauze from his waist. Bare-chested, head lowered, he stood in the downpour and let it wash over him. His abdomen was streaked with blood, and the wound looked alarming.

"Huh? What's the point of a shirtless wet-body show now? We're on the expressway!" Lu Mingfei was shocked. "If you really want to look cool and outrageous... Senior, you could take your pants off too..."

But he soon understood. As the rain washed away the blood, faint white steam rose, like concentrated sulfuric acid mixed with water, or as if Chu Zihang's blood were burning oil. Water mixed with blood splashed onto the ground, leaving white spots. Lu Mingfei stared, reminded of the monster in Alien whose blood was strong acid. He had just been chatting with such a monster and riding in his car; he didn't know whether to be proud or scream.

Only when the blood had washed away did Chu Zihang return to the car. He dried himself quickly and took fresh clothes from his suitcase.

"Don't tell anyone. Consider it repayment for my favor," he said quietly.

"No problem, no problem!" Lu Mingfei nodded vigorously.

"Thank you." Chu Zihang started the Panamera. "May I ask a question? Do you like Nono more, or Chen Wenwen?"

"Senior, could you not be so nosy when you're asking someone to keep a secret?" Lu Mingfei made a miserable face.

"Oh, sorry," Chu Zihang said mildly.

The Panamera returned to the road. "I once read a book called Shanghai Fortress. It said there are twenty thousand people in the world you'll fall in love with at first sight, but you might never meet a single one in your whole life," Lu Mingfei said suddenly.

Chu Zihang blinked. "I didn't expect there to be so many..."

"I really liked Chen Wenwen in high school. If she'd liked me back, I probably wouldn't have come to Cassell to slay dragons, and I wouldn't have met Nono. Shameless as it sounds, I like Nono now, but I think I'm just mooning over her, like I did with Chen Wenwen." Lu Mingfei hung his head. "Who I like doesn't matter, does it? The question is who will like me."

"You're the only S-rank among us. You shouldn't think like that," Chu Zihang said.

"You all make S-rank sound impressive, but I can't feel it. You don't even bother taking me on operations," Lu Mingfei muttered.

"That's because you don't have enough experience yet. This world is ours, and yours too, but one day it will all be yours," Chu Zihang said softly. "That day you'll take the places of Caesar and me on the battlefield."

Lu Mingfei immediately imagined himself taking Chu Zihang's place before the three-nothings girl. She waved a hand and rolling flames swept over the three realms like a blazing red lotus, a furious tide of light surging toward him. He, an S-rank, waved a hand too... nothing. He could only say, "Hello, have you eaten?" Then the fire passed, leaving him standing in the ruins as a blackened human shape with only two pitiful eyes blinking... Though it was rather cute, when he pictured it.

"Senior, do you really think my bloodline is S-rank?"

"I don't know. You haven't shown a bloodline advantage yet." Chu Zihang was blunt.

Lu Mingfei sighed. "It's not that I don't want to be impressive. I used to show off in my fantasies. I'd daydream in class about how cool I'd be one day: the teacher is explaining English grammar when a beautiful girl comes in and says in perfect American English, 'Sorry to interrupt, but Sir Lu Mingfei, an urgent transoceanic call from headquarters. If you don't answer, North America will sink...' Then, in front of the whole class, I take the phone and rattle away in flawless French. From then on the teacher never dares punish me by making me copy vocabulary." He smiled self-mockingly. "But that wouldn't be me at all. It'd be somebody else with nothing to do with me."

Chu Zihang glanced at him. "What kind of person do you think you are?"

"Probably... the kind who sleeps in, plays games, spaces out and thinks about random things, reads magazines for free at the newsstand, and likes someone for three years without daring to confess... I know that kind of person isn't interesting. But that's who I am." Lu Mingfei hesitated. "Senior, do you know? When I first walked into Aspasia, I was bursting with happiness, imagining what I'd say if Chen Wenwen liked me because I rescued her and treated her to such an expensive meal, thinking I was incredibly cool."

"She watched you through the glass the whole time you left. I saw it in the rearview mirror," Chu Zihang said. "She did like you a little, didn't she? But you ran away."

"Yeah." Lu Mingfei nodded seriously. "Because then it wouldn't be me she liked. I didn't even know what Aspasia was. I don't have Boss's taste, much less a Mint Club membership. I can't afford to treat her to a meal that expensive; my credit card is still in debt. Boss was really the one buying her Italian food. Boss is wonderful, of course; any girl would like him, right? If I treated her, I could only afford ramen at a street stall... But the me who can only afford ramen still hopes someone will like him..." He scratched his head, suddenly embarrassed. "I'm making a mess of this... Senior, do you understand?"

The corner of Chu Zihang's eye twitched almost imperceptibly, and he fell silent. After a long time he reached out and patted Lu Mingfei's shoulder. "I understand... There used to be someone who could only drive a car, and hoped people would like the him who could only drive."

Lu Mingfei sensed his senior was showing him a little closeness, but didn't understand the deeper meaning, so he could only grin in response.

"What a person can accomplish doesn't depend entirely on bloodline, but on what he wants to accomplish. When I say you're not ready, I don't mean your blood or your ability. I mean you have no goal," Chu Zihang said. "There's no goal that would make you put everything on the line and use all your strength. Someone who can't do that is useless, even if his bloodline is stronger than all of ours."

"Who would I put everything on the line for..." Lu Mingfei muttered. He remembered seeing the sharp tail spike pierce Nono's chest underwater at the Three Gorges, her hair floating like thick

seaweed in a cloud of her own blood. His fingers had grown hot and he'd wanted desperately to draw that blade. The feeling had been wonderful. He too wanted another chance to throw everything away for someone in a flash of passion... but what right did he have to risk himself for anyone?

"Everyone has reasons to risk their life. You keep your life... to wait for the day you'll put it on the line," Chu Zihang said softly.

Only after speaking did he realize how sentimental it sounded. He and Lu Mingfei weren't close enough to bare their hearts; they were merely partners on one operation. He said no more, pressed the accelerator hard, and the engine revved. The Panamera became a dark-blue streak of lightning on the expressway.

The night sky was deep blue, and the glacier below it was black. It was nearly midnight. The moon had just risen over the glacier, turning ice accumulated over tens of thousands of years a luminous blue. Wolves howled from some unknown direction, startling sleeping birds into flight from the dark forest. The Hailuogou hot-spring resort lay in a hollow beneath the glacier.

Nono and Susie soaked in a square hot-spring pool. Under the lights, the water was a soft baby blue, fine wisps of steam rising from its surface. Nono lifted a long leg from the water, waving a razor in her hand.

"Please, you hardly have any leg hair." Susie took a cold can of Coke from a little wooden boat floating in front of her.

"I'm imitating Marilyn Monroe's pose." Nono ducked under the water and popped up beside Susie like a little fish. "Tell me, what's sexy about shaving your legs?"

"I'm not a man. Ask Caesar." Susie sounded languid.

"Caesar thinks a troupe of girls in white lace dresses is the sexiest thing. He's already recruited a whole group into the Student Council." Nono narrowed her eyes and smiled. "Do you think Chu Zihang would like it? Maybe I should make a show of shaving for him one day?"

"You should do it for Lu Mingfei. The recoil from his nosebleed would send him to the moon." Susie pinched her friend's nose. "You remember, don't you? It's Lu Mingfei's birthday. He's your only little junior. Did you text him?"

"I remember, I remember, but I'm hesitating a little." Nono put a white towel soaked in cold water on her forehead and looked up at the sky.

"Don't tell me you don't know he likes you?"

"Do I look that stupid?" Nono made a face. "I've been dating since kindergarten!"

"Kindergarten?"

"I'm the queen of all big sisters. I once stood at the front of my kindergarten class and pointed at all the little boys, announcing that from that day on they were all my boyfriends and had to obey me, and anyone who didn't would be kicked out!" Nono smiled, showing her lovely teeth, her sterling-silver four-leaf clover earrings swaying.

"What's it like, having a junior secretly in love with you?"

"Like an older man in kindergarten telling you what a pretty little girl you are."

"What do you mean?"

"The man says you're pretty, and the junior likes you, but neither of them really knows you. Next time the man sees another little girl he'll tell her she's pretty too, and the junior will end up with a younger girl." Nono shrugged and climbed onto a step beside the pool. Though she wore a swimsuit, much of her chest was exposed, and when the water ran off, a recently healed scar was visible. She had received it during the Three Gorges Reservoir operation, but no longer remembered what had caused it. The doctor had marveled that whatever huge, deadly weapon had made it, her survival was a miracle.

"Plenty of people have crushes on you, don't they? Does Caesar know? Isn't he worried?"

"Caesar is actually very perceptive. He can sense who likes me." Nono tilted her head, combing through her dark-red hair. "But he isn't worried, much less jealous. He thinks only he deserves me. Of course, if the one who liked me were Chu Zihang..." Nono's eyes curved like crescent moons. "Then Caesar might get serious about dealing with him. Thinking about it makes me want to seduce your Chu Zihang!"

"Chu Zihang can't be seduced. Even if you ran toward him naked through the snow, he'd think you had a fever and needed cooling down," Susie said mildly.

"Hey, I'm joking. Don't be possessive. I won't touch your Chu Zihang." Nono cautiously nudged Susie's shoulder.

"He isn't mine. You don't think he's my boyfriend too, do you? He's just a good friend. He's willing to do things for me only because he thinks I've helped him. That's how he is: anyone who helps him, he makes sure to repay. You helped him with your profiling today; maybe he'll take you to dinner when school starts." Susie smiled.

Nono sighed and patted her head. "That makes me angry enough to cry. What a jerk. When I get back to college, I'll teach him a lesson for you."

"He just doesn't have many feelings." Susie fell silent for a while, then, not wanting to continue the subject, turned and tapped Nono's nose. "Seriously, you've been dating Caesar almost two years. Are you going to marry him?"

Nono rested her chin on her hand and thought for a long time, then shook her head. "I haven't decided... I mean it. It's not that there's anything wrong with Caesar. He's very, very good to me, but I don't know why I should marry him!"

"I asked my mom that," Susie said. "Her answer was... because only after you're married can you register the children in the household records!"

Nono covered her face. "Your mom is amazing!"

"Maybe you don't need a reason. Keep it simple: you like someone, he's good to you, you want to stay with him forever, so you marry him and make him yours," Susie said.

"You like Chu Zihang. How long will you like him?" Nono asked softly, gazing at the night sky.

Susie looked up. Moonlight reflected in Nono's clear pupils, and her face was uncharacteristically blank. Knowing she had something on her mind, Susie grew serious too. "I don't know. Maybe once I find a boyfriend, I won't like him anymore."

"If Chu Zihang suddenly proposed and you married him, you wouldn't have another boyfriend. Would you go on liking him all your life?"

Susie thought for a while and shook her head. "I don't know. I've never liked anyone for a lifetime."

"You don't really know Chu Zihang, do you? Even though you remember perfectly whether he likes his eggs fried on one side or both."

Susie lowered her head. "He hasn't given me a chance to know him."

"Exactly." Nono looked down into Susie's eyes, very serious. "When you first begin to like someone, that's when you know them least. Take Chu Zihang: a handsome, cool guy with an expressionless face, but you have no idea when he's happy or sad. He's a book whose cover hasn't even opened for you. Yet you keep thinking about him, longing to open that book and read what's inside. Maybe one day you'll be together and you'll open it. It's so wonderful that you forget to eat and sleep, and want to take it even to the bathroom... But after one year, two years, five, ten, you've finished it and memorized every line and word. Will you still read it over and over? Or will you put it back in its cover and set it on a shelf? Books on shelves are rarely opened again."

Susie was silent for a long time, then reached out and touched Nono's cheek affectionately. "Doesn't it tire you, having so much on your mind all day? Caesar is already the ultimate boyfriend. What kind of person do you want to marry?"

"I've thought about it!" Nono's eyes shone. "The man I marry will make me believe he'll always be with me. As long as I want him there, he'll stay with me always and always. When I'm afraid, even if I can't find anyone else, I'll always find him. When I'm trapped in a nightmare, his name will be the one I call without thinking."

"Mm." Susie looked solemn. "In that case, a dog would do... You could name it 'Oh, how scary,' and when you have a nightmare you'd call, 'Oh, how scary!'"

"How dare you tease me, little lady?" Nono plunged into the spring and pushed Susie in too.

Steam hung thick as a curtain. The girls' laughter answered the distant howls of wolves. Nearby, a man selling cold beer, wrapped in an old sheepskin coat, glimpsed lovely curves flashing through the vapor and silently suffered a nosebleed.

Beep, beep. Nono's phone, sealed in a waterproof plastic bag, lit up with a text.

She emerged from the spring, shook the water from her hair, and opened it.

"Dear: This may seem sudden to you, but I've planned it for a long time. Please read this message patiently to the end..."

It was from Caesar Gattuso. Nono's eyes widened in surprise, and she exchanged a glance with Susie, who had leaned over to look.

Portofino, Italy. The Splendid Hotel.

Caesar leaned against a marble column, holding a glass of gin on ice. A single lamp above cast its light straight down around him. Night had fallen and a storm swept across the Gulf of Genoa. The hotel had brought its umbrellas and outdoor café seating inside, leaving him alone in the courtyard. Lights blazed behind him, an indoor band playing gentle blues, while wind and rain darkened the world ahead. From where he stood the pale-gray sea rolled as though an enormous sea beast were about to break the surface. Waves several meters high battered the cliffs below, while a distant lighthouse beam swept monotonously over the water.

Caesar made a call. "Caesar Gattuso. I'd like to know whether my account has been frozen."

His private banking adviser sounded alarmed. "How could that happen, Mr. Gattuso? You've always been among our highest-tier clients. Who would dare freeze your account? I just checked again and confirmed everything is perfectly normal..."

Caesar silently hung up, unwilling to listen further. Of course there were people in the world who dared freeze his account. His enormous spending came from family funds, and his father or uncle could suspend or permanently close it. He had defied his uncle so fiercely today, and the old man's face had been full of anger when he left, yet he still hadn't thought to freeze Caesar's account. For years Caesar had tested his uncle's limits, and however furious Frost Gattuso became, he had never punished his nephew. Seen from that angle alone, the family's love for Caesar was as vast as the Gulf of Genoa.

Caesar smiled silently. In truth, while spending the family's money freely, he was always prepared for the account to be closed. He knew the conflict between him and the family could not be reconciled. Ever since he'd announced he was considering changing his surname to "Gullveig," all his elders had flown into a rage. "How could you have such an absurd idea?" "That's a lowly surname!" "You may rebel against anything, but not your blood!" Caesar had looked at those angry old faces and found it fascinating.

If one day he lost that endlessly replenished account, he would say goodbye to his present life: luxury sports cars, top hotels, high society in its perfumes and fine clothes, even the light and warmth behind him. He would walk into the storm alone.

"I can't say I don't care at all." He stretched out his hand and let the rain fall into his palm.

There was still no reply. He dried his hand and reread the message he had just sent.

"...I once imagined that on the day I proposed, I would pretend to invite you on vacation to an uninhabited island. I'd have my friends wait on the beach across the water with thousands of fireworks. When you and I walked hand in hand to the shore, I would suddenly kneel and bring out the ring I'd prepared, while streaks of light flew across the night sky and reflected in the sea. But when the day suddenly came, I hadn't had time to arrange fireworks. I could buy a ring at once, but I couldn't get it to China. The Mint Club people say the earliest they can deliver it to you is tomorrow morning. But I don't want to wait. I want to say it tonight: Nono, I want to announce our engagement to everyone, in a grand ceremony or a simple one..."

"Wow! Speak of the wolf and it really comes! A proposal text! My face is burning!" Susie covered her cheeks and cried out.

"Hey... he isn't proposing to you..." Nono glanced at her. "Keep reading. I don't know why he's suddenly gone crazy tonight."

"A man who suddenly goes crazy is the most romantic kind! He must be an absolute Cancer!"

"No, he's a perfectionist Libra!"

Caesar tipped the last of his drink and its ice into his mouth.

"...But it's very likely our engagement won't have my family's blessing. The Gattuso family's chosen heir has his engagement decided by the family, not by himself. But I won't let them decide my future. My future will be brilliant, and I will share it with the brilliant girl I love. Her surname isn't special; her hair is dark red; she wears silver four-leaf-clover earrings; when she's angry she's as prickly and unapproachable as a hedgehog... But I want to live with her for decades more, perhaps a

hundred years. I truly have to thank my bloodline: it gives me more time in the life I have left to spend with her..."

Reading that far, Caesar smiled silently. He was beginning to admire his own literary talent. All that idle practice writing fiction online hadn't gone to waste.

"...It's such a lonely night. It's raining in Portofino, and Portofino is beautiful in the rain. I've always wanted to bring you here, but you haven't accepted my invitation yet. Much happened today; I'll tell you everything later. Right now I only want to say that tonight, more than ever, I wish you were beside me. Even if you merely sat silently watching me, or pulled a contemptuous face and mocked my weakness at this moment, I would still want to feel your warmth..."

He set his glass beneath the grapevines and walked into the rain, which instantly soaked him through. He mounted the little motorcycle and rode out through the heavy black iron gates.

"Wow, underneath it all he's a sensitive, proud little boy!" Susie shook a clenched fist. "'I'm happy even when you bully me' and all that!"

"Absolutely not." Nono stuck out her tongue, a blush rising to her cheeks. "Something probably upset him today. Most of the time he's still an overbearing, conceited guy."

"You're blushing, you're blushing!" Susie leaned over Nono's smooth back and pinched her cheeks.

"Hey, it's a love letter. Isn't it normal to blush reading one?" Nono reached back and pinched her nose. "If you're peeking at somebody else's love letter, be quiet!"

"All right, all right, I'll shut up. Look how ridiculously happy you are." Susie put her arms around her neck.

"...I have many, many friends, and know many, many girls. Ever since I was little I've wondered what kind of girl I would spend my life with. What a terrifying thing: only one chance to choose, and I must swear before everyone to love and protect her and never leave her. I thought I was already brave, but not brave enough to tell a girl in public that I would love her for life. Then I met you, and you gave me that courage. Yes, Nono, I love you, and I hope for the chance to love you all my life..."

The little motorcycle cut through the storm. Caesar's wet blond hair streamed into the wind like a battle flag, and Anthony the gyrfalcon flew beside him.

"...I know many people think I'm a spoiled playboy or a young emperor or something, but whether he's a playboy or a young emperor, when a man faces the girl he loves, he's only a boy. The boy who loves you is named Caesar, not Caesar Gattuso, just Caesar. There are things I can't tell you yet, but my family doesn't want you and me to become engaged. If I have to choose, however, I will take off the glittering coat called 'Gattuso' without hesitation. Would you accept that Caesar? Still Caesar, only apparently naked..."

The motorcycle stopped on the beach. Caesar ran into the cold surf, his powerful chest breaking wave after wave of the rising tide. He threw off his little white dinner jacket, kicked away his expensive crocodile-skin shoes, tied his hair back with the violet scarf, and dove into the water, swimming against the waves toward the deep sea.

"...Come, we will seize happiness and glory together. My life will be a great ship, and I want you standing with me at its prow. When that ship enters port we will astonish the world together. I will take your hand as we come ashore and say, 'This is Caesar's bride!'"

His arms stroked powerfully, fighting the cold waves again and again. Caesar felt like an arrow gliding through the water. Nothing could stop him: waves, family, even his father! Because he was sharp enough!

Caesar burst out of the water and looked back. He could no longer see the cliffs through the storm; he was nearing the edge of the harbor. Around him were only black, heaving waves. The lighthouse's white beam swept past, and a falcon's cry tore through the wind and rain.

"Anthony! Fly! Fly to..." Caesar raised his arm and shouted at the sky with all his strength. "The highest place!"

In the black sky torn by lightning, the falcon soared.

Thousands of kilometers away, at Hailuogou in China's Sichuan Province, snowflakes settled on the girls' bare arms and quickly melted into drops of water.

"It's snowing." Susie sank into the hot spring, watching the fine drifting flakes. "So beautiful. I never expected snow this time of year. It must be a blessing for you, though the proposal reads a little like a declaration of war..."

"Come conquer the world with me, woman!" Nono sank into the spring too, curling up with her mouth beneath the surface, only her blinking eyes showing, like a child.

"But it's really moving, as though he put all his strength into every word," Susie said softly. "If Lu Mingfei wrote it, it'd probably be something like, 'I don't mean anything special, I just thought if we have children it'll be easier to register them,' that sort of nonsense."

"Hey... where did that strange idea come from?" Nono said quietly.

"Dizzy with happiness, girl?" Susie said. "Say yes. Get engaged first, then after graduation you can have a grand wedding. I reserve the bridesmaid's job!"

"Oh, come on, I have to play hard to get a little! And look how sudden it is. I haven't even brushed my teeth... How can I accept a proposal like this?"

"Look at you, tail in the air!" Susie laughed and pushed her head under the water.

Caught off guard, Nono choked on a mouthful of water. Everything suddenly went black.

"Oh no!" She was still conscious.

Since the Three Gorges operation she had kept having dreams. The doctor said it was a minor aftereffect of prolonged oxygen deprivation underwater and would gradually heal. But Nono hated this "minor" aftereffect, because it was always the same dream.

In the dream all was a blue so dark it was nearly black. Light came down through the water overhead, its ripples reflected across her face. She floated amid endless waves, unable even to hear her own heartbeat. Figures seemed to move above the surface. She tried to rise but had no strength, unable to move a finger. They seemed to bend over her with grief-stricken faces. She felt as though she lay in a coffin, saying goodbye to loved ones through glass.

What a nightmare, how she hated it! Time didn't flow in the dream. It was so cold; she wanted fearfully to curl up but lacked the strength. It was so quiet; she wanted to talk to someone but couldn't speak. It was so hopeless. So this was what death was like.

Every time she woke she was cold all over. She didn't remember what had happened underwater at the Three Gorges, but she understood the dream was about death.

The moment she choked on the water she saw that almost-black blue again. She floated in endless waves, unable to move. The damned lack of oxygen had dragged her bodily into the dream!

She felt she was going to die...

Everything suddenly tore apart! Water, light, the almost-black blue, everything was ripped open by claws! As if the vault of heaven had split, an enormous face appeared in the gap, with golden eyes bright as day! That twisted, ferocious... child's face...

"Don't die!" he roared.

"Ricar...do." Nono called out the name.

More water flooded her throat. She kicked hard several times, found her footing in the spring, and gasped, her eyes filled with terror.

"Oh, sorry, sorry!" Susie hurried to help her.

Susie hadn't expected such an accomplished swimmer to come to grief in this little pool. Nono had clearly swallowed several mouthfuls, not just the first one; she'd swallowed more while struggling and calling out underwater. Susie hadn't heard what she said, but through the surface had seen the terror on her face. In all the time they'd known each other, she had never seen the little red-haired witch so shaken.

"I'm fine, I'm fine." Nono waved a hand and turned, forcing a smile for Susie. "I'm a little dizzy. I'll sit in the sauna."

Susie watched her white-swimsuited back disappear into the darkness, suddenly feeling as though she had become another person.

Nono was alone in the sauna. She ladled cool water over the red-hot stones; dense steam spread and blurred her vision.

The phone screen was the only thing she could see clearly through the steam. It displayed a multimedia message she had already prepared. She had hesitated to send it, thought it inappropriate, then couldn't quite bear to cancel it. So the message remained in her drafts, its fate dependent on her mood.

The message was a song: "Happy birthday to you, Ri-Ricardo, happy birthday to you, Ri-Ricardo..."

On the way to Hailuogou, the tune had suddenly occurred to her. She had recorded it for fun, thinking she'd send it to Lu Mingfei on his birthday and he'd surely grin like an idiot.

But... did it suggest something, however faintly? She rarely hesitated; she generally did whatever came to mind. And was there any need to hesitate? She couldn't possibly like Lu Mingfei. At most she pitied him a little. When they first met he was a genuine beaten dog, and the image of him crouching alone in a corner, gasping for breath, felt familiar. She had already been quite good to him; having a pretty senior looking out for him would make college easier. She hated seeing anyone helpless. As for his liking her, surely it would pass? Wasn't a junior supposed to learn how girls thought from his senior, then use that knowledge to charm girls younger than himself?

Just as the older men who praised her in kindergarten belonged with women their own age, a junior belonged with a younger girl.

She should have been happily bouncing around today, getting thoroughly drunk with Susie tonight. It was the first proposal of her life... So why had that childish face suddenly appeared? She'd never

seen him so frantic, furious, and ferocious. That wasn't an expression he should wear. Suddenly all her joy had faded, leaving her very, very tired.

She sat silently in the steam. Today was Lu Mingfei's birthday; in half an hour it would be over.

Lu Mingfei took out his phone and checked the time: 11:30 p.m. Rain streamed past the airplane window, and the city's scattered lights could be seen in the distance.

Chu Zihang handed him a small packet. "This route crosses the Arctic Circle. Ten hours; sleep and you'll be in Chicago." Then he briskly put in earplugs, covered his eyes with a mask, fitted an inflatable neck pillow, pulled up a blanket, and fell asleep.

Lu Mingfei opened the packet. Inside was an identical set. Chu Zihang had long since planned to spend the ten-hour flight resting; the man's life was precise as a machine.

"United Airlines Flight UA836 to Chicago is preparing for departure. Please switch off your mobile communication devices." A sweet female voice echoed through the cabin.

No new messages came. Lu Mingfei pressed the power button until the screen went black. What was the person he was thinking of doing at this moment? Better not wonder about what he couldn't know. Perhaps she was nestled beside someone, fishing on the sunlit Red Sea, while he thought of her on a dark rainy night. It made him seem so humble, wrapped in a gloomy, unpleasant haze, didn't it? Lu Mingfei put in his earplugs and eye mask. Darkness filled his vision, and the enormous roar of the engines was shut out; all he could feel was the acceleration and vibration of his seat. The Boeing 747 pierced the curtain of rain and climbed diagonally into the sky, skimming over the sleeping city.

"Good night," Lu Mingfei said softly, not knowing to whom.

Act Six

Beware of Fire, Thieves, and Your Senior

Beware of Your Senior

What a wonderful morning. Sunlight poured through the skylight onto Xia Mi. The slender, supple girl stood on one leg with the grace of a ballerina, reaching out to steal two cups of Coke for them. Lu Mingfei watched her long leg lifted into the sunlight, every line youthful and fluid, every inch of skin smooth as jade. For the first time he understood what the ancients meant by a perfect balance of flesh and bone.

"TRY A WEEK WITHOUT RAILWAY!!!" proclaimed a huge white banner hanging in the empty waiting hall of Chicago's train station.

Lu Mingfei lifted his face to the ceiling and sighed, his heart sinking.

They had flown halfway around the world to Chicago and hurried eagerly to the station, only to find a waiting hall littered with scraps of paper, placards, and drink cans. A few hours before they landed at Chicago International Airport, the entire Chicago railway workforce had finished marching in protest and gone home. They would not be back for a week.

They were on strike.

Lu Mingfei had grown up under the red flag of socialism and had always been generous with his praise of strikes. When his high-school politics teacher put a question about the strike movement on the final exam, he had even quoted Comrade Lenin with feeling: "How profound is the influence of a strike! Every strike powerfully turns the workers' thoughts toward socialism, toward the struggle the whole working class must wage to free itself from the oppression of capital!"

But supporting the Chicago railway workers out of his own wallet hurt. Cassell operated the CC1000 branch express itself, but without switch operators or a dispatch center, every train had to stop. They would certainly miss registration. Since the delay was beyond their control, their GPA would not be penalized, but the college would not pay for a week in Chicago.

"Then we'll stay in Chicago for a week," Chu Zihang said calmly. "If that's a problem for you, share a room with me. I'll pay."

A sneaky little thrill ran through Lu Mingfei. He had known his expressionless senior never quibbled over money. He had been waiting for exactly those words!

He hoisted his luggage. "Come on! Let's go get a room!"

A soft giggle came from overhead. "What do two grown men need a room for?"

Lu Mingfei jumped. He and Chu Zihang were clearly the only people in the hall. Could Lu Mingze have grown restless again? He looked up for the voice and saw the enormous white banner, ten meters wide and ten meters long, trembling slightly, as if someone were hiding behind it. A human shape moved left along the beam. A hand emerged from behind the cloth and unfastened the hook on the left. Then the figure moved right, and the hand reached out again for the other hook.

"Careful!" Chu Zihang said suddenly.

He saw the beam wobble. The person behind the banner lost their balance and pulled the whole sheet down. Just then a gust swept through the waiting hall, and the white cloth fell like a cloud. Chu Zihang and Lu Mingfei both lunged to catch the person: a fall from five or six meters up would break an ordinary person's bones. Lu Mingfei had barely taken two steps when the cloth came down over his head. He panicked, tripped, and fell flat on his face like a fallen angel. Chu Zihang was half a step slower, but he could see the figure wrapped in the cloth, and caught them securely.

The person was startlingly light.

"Who? Who are you? Are you trying to get yourself killed? You made me fall too!" Lu Mingfei scrambled up, rubbing his back and complaining without pause.

A head poked out of the white cloth and looked around. For a moment both Lu Mingfei and Chu Zihang fell silent. Chu Zihang gently set the person down and stepped back.

It was respect for a woman, and awe before beauty. A tomb robber crawling into Tutankhamun's burial chamber, confronted by that exquisite golden mask as if time itself had been sealed inside it, might likewise fall silent in wonder and hesitate to lift it, afraid of disturbing sleeping beauty, afraid she would grow old the moment she woke.

The girl regarded them curiously. In her clear eyes, both boys saw their own awkward, self-conscious reflections.

As a shut-in, Lu Mingfei kept a mental ranking of beautiful girls. Nono and Su Xiaoqiang tied for first. The little witch needed no explanation, and Su Xiaoqiang's nickname, the Little Celestial Princess, was well earned. Her mother was Portuguese, giving her the defined features of a European and the gentle beauty of an Eastern girl. Zero ranked second: Her Ice Queen Majesty's beauty hovered between girl and little girl, proud as snow and ice, though she was always so cold-faced that she seemed to think the whole world owed her millions of rubles. Liu Miaomiao came third, while Chen Wenwen was only fourth, even allowing for the likelihood that judge Lu Mingfei had awarded her extra points for personal preference.

Yet none of them could quite be called flawless. "Flawless" was not really a good word; every living thing had defects. A truly flawless face probably existed only beneath a sculptor's chisel.

But looking at this girl, you felt as though the sculpture had opened its eyes and come to life.

"Hi there, monster!" Lu Mingfei murmured.

He meant that only a monster could be that beautiful. His expressionless senior and the beauty herself could hardly be expected to understand a joke with such depth.

Chu Zihang nudged him with an elbow. "She's a fellow student."

The girl bared her teeth. "Not a monster. I'm a sweet, gentle girl!"

Lu Mingfei was delighted. Someone did understand his joke after all. Only then did he notice the black ticket held between her teeth: a special ticket for the CC1000 branch express.

"Chu Zihang, mechanical engineering." Chu Zihang reached out to help her up.

The girl emerged from the white cloth. She wore a plain white spaghetti-strap top with batik orchids, very short shorts, ankle socks, and sneakers. Her outfit was simple, with sunglasses perched on her head.

"Senior!" The girl sprang up. "I'm a freshman, Xia Mi."

"Hey, hey, don't block me." Lu Mingfei shouldered Chu Zihang aside. "I'm a senior too! Lu Mingfei, history."

"Oh, a humanities guy?" Xia Mi widened her eyes and looked him up and down.

For no reason Lu Mingfei felt inferior to Chu Zihang. Strictly speaking, Chu Zihang's department was called Alchemical Mechanical Engineering and specialized in alchemical equipment. Lu Mingfei's history department was really Dragon Genealogy, where he would study dragon family trees and dig deep into the dark side of their history. But none of that was easy to explain to this junior, still as blank as a sheet of paper. The mystery would be revealed at freshman orientation.

"What were you doing up there?" Chu Zihang asked.

"Taking down this sheet. We'd have to stay in a hotel for a week, and I'm out of money. I still have to save up for a lens for my camera. Nobody needs this thing anyway, so I can use it to pitch a tent near Central Park and sleep there for a week." Xia Mi plopped down amid the cloth and folded the huge sheet. Her hands moved quickly. Soon she had rolled it into an enormous bundle and slung it over her shoulder. "I'll be going, then. See you at college!"

"Can you pitch a tent in the park?" Chu Zihang asked.

"I'll tell them I'm demonstrating on behalf of the Chicago railway workers!" Xia Mi clenched her fist, earnest and blazing with civic spirit. "If our railway brothers aren't going back to work, I'll share their hardship!"

"Brilliant! I can go with you!" Lu Mingfei was delighted by her ingenuity.

Chu Zihang hesitated. "You don't have a Social Security card yet. It could be awkward if the police questioned you. If you don't mind, you could stay with us. We're going to..."

"Get a room?" Xia Mi spun around and stared at him.

Chu Zihang froze, taken aback by the fierce look in her eyes. He realized the invitation was inappropriate. They might be fellow students, but they hardly knew one another. Two boys inviting a girl to share a room, a Chinese girl at that—her parents would probably throw gas cylinders at them if they found out.

"A rich guy! I'm so happy! Please keep me!" The next moment Xia Mi was pretending to collapse against Chu Zihang's chest.

Chu Zihang stood there silently, wondering whether he had met a female Fingel or a female Lu Mingfei. Well, there was not much difference between the two species.

"Come on, come on, let's get a room! I'm starving." Lu Mingfei picked up Xia Mi's luggage. Compared with other students arriving in America, she had brought very little: one standard suitcase and a tote bag.

"Wait, wait, let me get another Coke," Xia Mi said.

"Buy one after we get to the hotel," Chu Zihang said.

"All you ever say is buy, buy, buy!" Xia Mi made a face. "I never said I was going to pay."

She fished a used paper Coke cup out of her bag and trotted to the entrance of a closed Subway. Standing on tiptoe, she squeezed half her body between the metal bars. With the cup in her hand she

could just reach the soda dispenser. A wonderfully refreshing sound of flowing liquid followed: the Subway staff had forgotten to unplug the machine when they closed.

Xia Mi sipped her Coke, looking pleased with herself. "I didn't arrive two hours before you for nothing. I've already scouted the whole place!"

"Wow! Doesn't that mean endless free Coke?" Lu Mingfei was overjoyed. "I'll get one too."

"You boys won't fit through. I'll get some for you." Xia Mi produced two more paper cups.

What a wonderful morning. Sunlight poured through the skylight onto Xia Mi. The slender, supple girl stood on one leg with the grace of a ballerina, reaching out to steal two cups of Coke for them. Lu Mingfei watched her long leg lifted into the sunlight, every line youthful and fluid, every inch of skin smooth as jade. For the first time he understood what the ancients meant by a perfect balance of flesh and bone. Watching her was simply an appreciation of beauty; he felt neither lust nor unbearable longing. He only wished the cups were bigger so she would take longer to fill them, and at the same time wanted to pull out his phone and preserve the moment.

It was as wonderful as the first time the guys had sneaked into a dance academy and watched the pretty girls practice through the glass, a sight to lift the heart.

Pretty little female thieves were truly one of the cutest species in the world!

"Drink the Coke I stole and you'll owe me a favor. You'll have to help me out later," Xia Mi said as the three of them dragged their luggage toward the exit.

"Of course! Your senior's got your back!" Lu Mingfei drank his Coke and thumped his chest.

Only a fool would fail to look after a junior like this. Here was that legendary, wondrous species, the junior girl! She was electricity, she was light, she was an awesome myth! She had come to rescue suffering seniors from their sea of misery! In every story about junior girls, they admired the knowledgeable, cultured seniors who knew all the rules for surviving campus life. Wasn't this how generations of seniors studying in America had got by? Drive a battered car to the airport to meet a junior, enthusiastically help her find a place to live, generously drive her to the supermarket, take her to an amusement park to expose the decadence of capitalism, and confess your love before she had fully learned her way around America and discovered you were just a loser! Generation after generation, the seniors had taken the juniors' share, leaving the younger boys to wait silently until they became seniors themselves and a new crop of junior girls descended from heaven.

Junior girls were like chives: every crop was fresher than the last!

"You're so kind, senior." Xia Mi smiled a smile that could win anyone's heart and make flowers bloom. Then her voice suddenly dropped, like an older sister offering a confidence. "Xia Mi, be careful he doesn't pick you up. Stay alert! Beware of fire, thieves, and your senior!"

In a guest room at the Hyatt Regency Chicago, Lu Mingfei lounged on the sofa watching television.

The famous hotel stood beside the Chicago River. Outside, white tour boats glided slowly past, a plump Black guide at the bow enthusiastically recounting the golden years of the city's founding to a group of foreign tourists.

"Senior, isn't this a little inappropriate? I absolutely support you paying for our junior's room," Lu Mingfei said, "but two guys and a girl in one room? Won't the Disciplinary Committee come after us?"

"The Disciplinary Committee doesn't care about that. Professor Manstein is probably arranging defenses for this year's Freedom Day," Chu Zihang said mildly. "I don't think it's quite appropriate

either, but she said if I paid for a separate room, she'd owe me too much, and she'd rather pitch a tent in the park."

He stood with his back against the wall, leafing through an old annotated edition of the Emerald Tablet, a reference work for Alchemical Chemistry III. The Emerald Tablet was an ancient text from 1900 BC, engraved on an emerald slab and discovered in a hidden chamber beneath a pyramid. Considered the foundational book of alchemy, it claimed as its author Hermes, the three-in-one god of Egyptian mythology. It contained only thirteen sentences, yet held all the truths of alchemy.

Water splashed in the next room. Xia Mi was bathing in the bathroom.

"It rises from earth to heaven and descends again from heaven to earth, receiving the power of the higher and the lower. Thus you shall gain the glory of the world and be free of darkness and ignorance," Chu Zihang murmured. This was Newton's translation of the Emerald Tablet. The scientist himself was also a well-known mystic, deeply interested in alchemy and the occult. In the Middle Ages theology and science were not so clearly separated, and alchemy counted as a science too.

Lu Mingfei was truly in awe of him. They had finally found a girl among the freshmen beautiful enough to be the campus belle, and they were even sharing a room. They ought to drink a few beers and get to know one another. Imagine it: their pretty junior bathing next door. Ah, "warm spring waters caressed her creamy skin." Back in class, the more the teacher explained the Song of Everlasting Sorrow, the more irritated he had become. Now, wiping away his drool as he imagined water dancing over his junior's lovely skin, he felt enlightened at last and understood classmate Bai Letian's poetic vision. Come to think of it, wasn't that line downright indecent? Recite it to yourself a few times and you could feel a nosebleed coming on... Yet Chu Zihang looked utterly unmoved, having wrestled with that dry reference book for nearly half an hour. Such meditative powers would be wasted on anyone but a monk.

"Senior, I know you're studying, but couldn't you find somewhere to sit?" Lu Mingfei could not understand why Chu Zihang kept standing against the wall.

"I'm practicing my standing posture at the same time. I stand for half an hour every night. It's very good for the spine. I suggest you try it," Chu Zihang said.

Lu Mingfei glanced at him. "Forget it. Fingel would die laughing if he saw." Such dull, strenuous self-discipline, with its faint air of aristocratic refinement, struck him as a little silly, though it suited Chu Zihang rather well.

"Newton's original says, 'It ascends from ye earth to ye heaven & again it descends to ye earth and receives ye force of things superior & inferior. By this means you shall have ye glory of ye whole world & thereby all obscurity shall fly from you.' It can also be translated, 'The One rises from earth to heaven, then descends again to earth, absorbing the powers of the upper and lower realms. Thus you shall possess the glory of the whole world and be free of ignorance.'" The bathroom door opened. Wrapped in a bathrobe, Xia Mi emerged, drying her long hair, and went to the wall opposite Chu Zihang. She too stood with her back against it. "The key to understanding the passage is what that 'it' refers to."

"It could mean the material used in alchemy: metal or another substance being scorched by flame," Chu Zihang said.

"It could also mean the spirit," Xia Mi said.

"There hasn't been much progress on the spirit interpretation since 1972."

"But a new paper on it came out just last year."

The two people standing against the walls exchanged questions and answers with easy fluency, while Lu Mingfei stared wide-eyed. He was like a toad listening to a sermon before the Buddha: he could hear profound truths but understood not a word, and wished someone would translate the mysteries into ribbits.

"Wait, wait, what are you talking about? Junior, why are you standing against the wall too?" Lu Mingfei could not take it anymore.

"The Emerald Tablet. Senior Lu, didn't you take Alchemical Chemistry? It's a surviving fragment of a draconic classic. It's just so obscure that no one's ever given it a definitive interpretation," Xia Mi said. "I'm waiting for my hair to dry and practicing my posture at the same time."

"What did you say?" Lu Mingfei was stunned.

What was going on? This junior had not even been through orientation. Wasn't she supposed to be a blank sheet on which the most beautiful picture could be painted? On hearing that a miraculous reptilian dynasty really existed in the world, she ought to scream in terror! Back then, Senior Lu Mingfei himself had screamed and practically wet his pants!

"Dragons, dragons, dragons," Xia Mi said three times.

"She was in the preparatory program. Prep students take the 3E exam early, so the existence of dragons isn't a secret to her. Her bloodline is A-rank, exceptionally good," Chu Zihang explained to Lu Mingfei.

"Preparatory? What program?"

"The college's secret branch in China. It selects high-school students with bloodlines from across the country for preparatory classes. The college gives them the 3E exam early. If their bloodlines are good enough, they go straight to the main campus after graduation. If they don't pass, the Gate to Cassell begins its closing sequence. They're treated as ordinary students and take the national college entrance exam when they graduate." Chu Zihang continued, "Xia Mi, born October 30, 1993, in Beijing, China. Female. Before the preparatory program she attended the high school affiliated with Peking University. Registered in Beijing. Family consists of her parents and an older brother."

"Hey!" Xia Mi glared. "Are you checking my household registration?"

"Norma sent the information from the main campus. We need to know who you are." Chu Zihang picked up his iPad from a little table. "Lu Mingfei, hand this to Xia Mi for me."

"Why am I the errand boy?" Lu Mingfei muttered.

"I haven't finished my exercise." Chu Zihang was still standing perfectly straight, now balancing a hardcover book on his head.

Four or five meters away, Xia Mi also balanced a hardcover on her head and held out her hand, waiting for Lu Mingfei to bring her the iPad.

"Are you two kidding me?" Lu Mingfei snatched the iPad from Chu Zihang and ran it over to Xia Mi, looking every inch an obedient little lackey.

The iPad held Xia Mi's file, thorough and clear down to the smallest detail. Cassell College's Intelligence Department was responsible for student records. Famous for CIA-like rigor, its people

made everyone's file read like a catalog of embarrassing secrets. Xia Mi's photograph brightened the document, a casual close-up taken with some small camera. Her hair was dyed dark coffee brown, she wore dark cosmetic contact lenses, and she was looking back against a sunset, a yellow bow in her hair flying in the breeze.

"You're so alternative!" Lu Mingfei commented offhandedly.

"You're the pig, and your whole family's a bunch of pigs." Xia Mi took the iPad and glanced at it. "I was cosplaying Haruhi Suzumiya at the anime club."

"They picked you to cosplay Haruhi Suzumiya?"

"I wanted to cosplay Asahina originally," Xia Mi said.

"Asahina?" Lu Mingfei grinned, delighted.

Asahina was the big-busted beauty in The Melancholy of Haruhi Suzumiya, always forced to dress as a bunny girl, a maid, or even a sexy frog. Imagining Xia Mi in the role, he felt another nosebleed threatening.

Xia Mi sighed and looked down at her chest. After a moment's silence, she said, "But they all disagreed. They said I didn't qualify..."

"I hate girls with big breasts the most!" Xia Mi suddenly looked up and shouted. "They bully people!"

The words came straight from the heart and rang with conviction. The room went quiet. No... it fell deathly silent.

"Well... my condolences." Lu Mingfei handed his discouraged junior an orange and patted the book on her head, like a compassionate monk comforting a young seeker short on natural gifts.

Then he burst out laughing, threw himself onto the bed, buried his head under the covers, and pounded the mattress. He could not hold it in any longer; bottling it up would have caused internal injuries. Suddenly the strike seemed wonderful, and the coming week stranded in Chicago would be even better, all because he had met this pretty, mischievous, delightfully goofy junior. She was both Lin Zhiling and a stand-up comedian!

"Laugh... laugh at your own sister." Xia Mi glanced at Lu Mingfei and curled her lip.

"If 'the One' means the spirit, then do the upper and lower realms refer to the different spiritual worlds of dragons and humans?"

"You can interpret it that way. It describes the process of a human evolving into a dragon and thereby reaching self-completion."

"Can humans evolve into dragons?"

"Some medieval scholars of the Emerald Tablet believed it was a work falsely attributed to a god, but that its author had 'approached infinitely close to godhood' and 'stolen the laws of the gods.' Fearing ordinary people would discover those laws, the author used secret language."

"The hieratic script of ancient Egypt?"

"Yes. Only priests knew hieratic script. Arabic replaced Egyptian as the common language of Egypt in the seventh century, so hieratic is hard to decipher. The Newton translation you're using could be full of errors..."

"The translation you just used says, 'The One rises from earth to heaven, then descends again to earth, absorbing the powers of the upper and lower realms. Thus you shall possess the glory of the whole world and be free of ignorance.' By your interpretation, if a human can evolve into a dragon, there would be no need to return to the human world. Since the author wanted to leave ignorance behind..." Chu Zihang pondered.

"Why leave cute girls behind?" Lu Mingfei interrupted, bored out of his mind.

It was a beautiful day: a luxurious five-star hotel, a comfortable big sofa, a complimentary fruit platter, a rich expressionless senior paying the bill, and a pretty junior he had just met. Yet the two of them stood against the walls to either side of Lu Mingfei, each balancing a book on their head like a pair of door gods. Worse still, after reading separately for a while, the two door gods had started arguing over how to interpret that Emerald Tablet. Both were damn academics, and Lu Mingfei did not understand a word, hearing only mystical phrases like "from heaven to earth" and "from earth to heaven."

"Then why must he 'descend again to earth'? Isn't 'from earth to heaven' the ultimate goal of all alchemy?" Chu Zihang had no intention of paying Lu Mingfei any attention; his mind was entirely occupied with the subject he was discussing with Xia Mi.

"From earth to heaven, from heaven to earth, how marvelous are all the things in the world, how marvelous..." Lu Mingfei suddenly remembered a children's song from a CCTV program he had watched as a child and sang it offhandedly.

Chu Zihang and Xia Mi stared at him speechlessly, apparently unable to understand his inner world at all.

"Between heaven and earth there hangs a scale, and the common people are its weight..." Just as Lu Mingfei realized he had gone off the rails again, Xia Mi suddenly began singing the theme from Prime Minister Liu Luoguo in the style of Beijing drum singing.

"Hey, what's going on? Weren't you having an academic discussion? How did we suddenly turn it into a medley of old songs?" Lu Mingfei said.

"I was playing along with you," Xia Mi said. "Do you know the theme from Barbapapa?"

"I think I remember it..." Chu Zihang tried humming the tune.

Later, remembering that warm, sunlit afternoon, Lu Mingfei felt that they had done nothing meaningful at all. Tour boats came and went on the Chicago River, The Simpsons played in reruns on television, and he sat on the sofa with a handsome boy and a beautiful girl standing straight on either side, hardcovers balanced on their heads. Sometimes they discussed scholarship, sometimes they sang back and forth. Sometimes Xia Mi told silly jokes, and sometimes Lu Mingfei explained the college's factions to her. An afternoon like that sounded like a waste of life.

And yet you always wished such afternoons could be longer, more frequent, and never end...

"Are you asleep?" Lu Mingfei asked softly, looking at the ceiling.

The person beside him was also looking at the ceiling, the blanket pulled up to the shoulders, both hands neatly tucked beneath it. "Not yet. I'm thinking."

"Sorry, sorry. Was I too loud turning over?"

"No. I'm just not used to sleeping with someone else. I'll fall asleep when I get tired. It's all right."

"You have an iPhone too, and there's Wi-Fi here. Since neither of us can sleep... how about a game of tile matching online?" Lu Mingfei suggested after a long silence.

"I don't know how to play tile matching, but we could play chess."

"You've never even played tile matching? Senior, your life is a tragedy..." Lu Mingfei turned his head and sighed at the handsome face and neat eyelashes beside him.

"Sorry," Chu Zihang said.

Lu Mingfei remembered the time during high-school military training when the boys had eavesdropped on the girls' late-night conversation. The subject had been: "What would I do if I landed Chu Zihang?" The aggressive faction insisted they would push him down. The literary faction wanted to hear him tell bedtime stories. The devoted-wife-and-mother faction wanted to feed their darling Chu Zihang baby until he was plump and healthy. The career-minded faction scoffed: "I'd let him follow me and live the life he wants! I'll support him!" In the end the sentimental faction won out when a girl said softly, "I just want to count his eyelashes one by one while he sleeps..." The boys listening at the wall all went weak at the knees.

Time had passed and things had changed. The girls from that conversation probably all had boyfriends now, while one of the eavesdroppers was sharing a bed and pillow with young master Chu.

"Damn it," Lu Mingfei muttered inwardly. "A whole week in bed with this young master? What have I done to deserve it? Hey, girls, jealous of me? Hey, girls, jealous?"

He muttered himself to sleep.

Chu Zihang turned his head. Xia Mi was already fast asleep. The curtains were open, and moonlight fell across her soft bangs. The blanket was wrapped all the way up to the back of her head, leaving only her small, delicate face exposed. Her long eyelashes cast two shadows on her cheeks. Something stirred in Chu Zihang's heart. Each lash could be counted distinctly, as though marking the passage of time.

At the college's main campus, in the central control room, an aluminum security case sat on the long table with a courier label from China attached. The last CC1000 express before the strike had brought it there.

Schneider shone a dark-purple flashlight along the edge of the case. Under the ultraviolet light a reflective security label appeared, like the marks used to authenticate banknotes. He nodded. "The seal is intact. The case wasn't opened on the way. What's inside is safe."

"This didn't need to come to the college. It could have gone straight to the Board of Trustees," Manstein said, frowning. "Now we have to wait for them to send someone to collect it."

"I told Chu Zihang to send it to us," Schneider said. "I'm still not entirely reassured. We'd better open it and have a look." He acted as soon as he spoke, picking up handheld hydraulic cutters and snipping off the lock with a snap.

"Hey!" Manstein shouted, trying to stop him, but it was too late.

"You work like a burglar breaking down a door. Don't you have a key?" Manstein said. "Leave it alone. It isn't what we're after. We've recovered it as the Board of Trustees ordered, so let them have it. Don't touch it. You'll only make trouble for yourself."

"It's simpler this way," Schneider said mildly. Sometimes Manstein had to wonder whether Chu Zihang had learned certain habits from his violence-prone teacher.

Inside the aluminum case was a sealed paper envelope with its seal intact. Schneider tore it open and emptied it onto the table. The envelope contained photocopied documents printed on transparent film. Schneider flipped through them at astonishing speed. His hands suddenly became extraordinarily nimble, nothing like an old man's. The sheets slid rapidly between his fingers as his eyes swept over them like a scanner, his iron-gray pupils contracted to pinpoints. Manstein had rarely seen him so intent.

"Hey, you! Are you crazy?" Manstein finally understood and shouted.

Schneider was not checking whether the material was intact at all. He meant to scan it before it was taken away, stealing a look at the Board of Trustees' top-secret SS-rank files.

"Do you know what this is?" Schneider's face was expressionless, and he showed no sign of stopping. "These are confidential Chinese police files from the past five years on 'unknown types of crime.' That means supernatural crime. This archive is like the US Air Force's Project Blue Book on UFOs. Of course, most cases simply involved methods too ingenious to solve, but some are connected to dragons."

"The Chinese police know dragons exist?" Guderian was shocked.

"No, but they know these events are beyond ordinary human understanding. Take this one." Schneider laid a sheet of film on the table. "On July 3, 2004, Typhoon Dandelion made landfall on China's southeastern coast, bringing three days of storms. During that storm there was an incident that was never explained. A Maybach sedan was abandoned on an elevated road, its body covered with inexplicable damage, as if it had been repeatedly stamped by machinery and then cut with a laser welding torch. The driver was not in the car. No one ever saw him again; he vanished from the world." Schneider spoke slowly. "That driver was Chu Zihang's biological father."

"No wonder the Board of Trustees didn't make Chu Zihang the commissioner..." Manstein understood at last. They had had no choice but to use Chu Zihang, yet they could not trust him.

Manstein turned and backed away step by step from the long table. "Schneider, I can't stop you from protecting your student, but I have nothing to do with this! You'll be punished under college regulations... no, under the Party's rules!"

He chaired the Disciplinary Committee and oversaw college discipline, but above college rules stood the rules of the Secret Party. Those rules derived from an ancient alchemical scroll, the Abraham Bloodline Covenant, a harsh code handed down from the Middle Ages. Schneider had violated the Council of Elders' secrets, an offense approaching treason in its gravity.

"No, this concerns you." Without looking up, Schneider handed Manstein an envelope he had prepared in advance. "See for yourself."

Manstein opened the envelope. Inside were student dossiers, each bearing a special red wax seal. The words on the seals read: "Nibelungen Project."

"Nibelungen?" Manstein had heard of this mythical "realm of the dead," but he did not see what it had to do with him.

Then his face changed. Turning through several dossiers, he saw the name Chen Motong.

"Why are you flipping through so fast? I saw Lu Mingfei..." Guderian craned his neck to look too.

"What does this mean?" Manstein asked quietly.

"The Nibelungen Project is a bloodline screening program led by the Board of Trustees. Officially, they select elites from students of A-rank or higher for special training. In fact, they have another purpose: to purge suspicious bloodlines among us. These students are all considered to have questionable bloodlines, including your student Chen Motong." Schneider pointed at Guderian. "And your student Lu Mingfei. Now, my old friends, do you still say this has nothing to do with you?"

"That can't be right. If we're talking about suspicious bloodlines, isn't your student Chu Zihang the most questionable of all? But Chu Zihang isn't in here?" Guderian said.

"Easy to understand," Manstein said quietly. "He's Chu Zihang's adviser. Even if Chu Zihang is under suspicion, his dossier wouldn't be sent to him. The people he's asked to investigate must have no connection to him." He already believed Schneider.

"What could be wrong with them? Aren't they all good students, excellent in conduct and academics?" Guderian was bewildered.

"Did you investigate them?" Manstein asked.

"The Board's orders must be carried out. I've already submitted my report. I gathered a little information and wrote something up. I said there was nothing suspicious about their bloodlines, but my conclusion may not be accepted," Schneider said calmly. "The two most unusual are Lu Mingfei and Chen Motong. They resonate with Draconic, but have no Yanling. Lu Mingfei in particular is the only S-rank student. In other words, his rank is as high as a trustee's, yet he has no Yanling. Anyone could easily grow suspicious of him."

"What exactly defines a suspicious bloodline?" Manstein asked.

"An excessive proportion of dragon blood. Generally, we believe that if a hybrid's dragon blood exceeds their human blood, they are closer to a dragon than a human. They are no longer one of us. But dragon blood can also be genetically recessive, and those recessive genes may awaken slowly. That can cause a hybrid to become progressively more dragonlike. Once they cross the fifty-percent threshold, they become the enemy," Schneider said. "The Dragon King Norton is a classic example. He was a pureblood dragon, but before his awakening he believed himself to be a human orphan."

"Is there any laboratory method now for measuring the genetic proportions?"

"No. We have to rely on analyzing their behavior. So you understand why the Board paid such a high price to steal this archive, and why the recovery operation was assigned such a high priority. Among the students investigated under the Nibelungen Project, Lu Mingfei, Chen Motong, and very likely Chu Zihang all come from China."

"They're looking into their family histories," Manstein said quietly.

"Mingfei... can't be a problem. How could he be dangerous? He's a complete coward!" Guderian stammered.

"Haven't you always said your student is inspiration from head to toe?" Manstein pushed him aside and looked at Schneider. "If the Board considers their bloodlines dangerous... what happens?"

"You know how the Board operates as well as I do." Schneider stopped what he was doing and looked up at Manstein, his iron-gray eyes filled with a bone-deep chill.

Manstein took a deep breath. "The iron-fist rule... purge them!"

"Kill... kill them?" Guderian's voice trembled. "Surely that isn't necessary... Couldn't we buy a little island in the Pacific, build a villa, send them there, and deliver supplies regularly?"

"A lifelong vacation in Hawaii? With treatment that good, I'd want a dangerous bloodline too," Manstein said with a bitter smile. "But do you think the Board is a group of philanthropists?"

"They wouldn't kill them, but historically they used lobotomy to purge people whose bloodlines were dangerous," Schneider said.

"What does that mean? I haven't studied brain science." Guderian stared.

Schneider hesitated. He did not want to bring up this history, but the Secret Party had endured for thousands of years, from the ancient age of blood sacrifice through the dark Middle Ages and the radical industrial era into modern society. Its history could not possibly conform entirely to today's moral standards.

"It's a form of brain surgery invented by António Egas Moniz, a Portuguese physician. Studying ancient Egyptian skulls, he found holes drilled into them and concluded the Egyptians had used brain surgery to treat epilepsy. He developed his theory and believed that removing white matter from the brain's lobes could treat all kinds of mental illness, including such unwelcome states as depression, agitation, anxiety, and paranoia. From 1930 to 1950, tens of thousands of these operations were performed worldwide. The patients really did become more docile and easier to control afterward, but often they sat in one place all day muttering to themselves like fools. He won the Nobel Prize in Medicine for it," Manstein said. "It's one of the most absurd Nobel Prizes in history, because the doctor completely misunderstood why the Egyptians performed the operation. In the age of the pharaohs, it was used to control hybrids. Removing the lobes also severed the 'spiritual resonance' most essential to their dragon blood."

"The Council of Elders knew what the operation did, so they sent suspected hybrids to psychiatric hospitals..." Schneider said. "They also paid to promote its supposed benefits around the world."

"Damn..." Guderian murmured.

"By now you should both understand. Some people at the college are suspected of being dangerous, and we are their advisers. If something happens to them, we'll have to bear some of the consequences too, so we need to take action." Schneider struck a match and set fire to the sheet about Chu Zihang. Amid choking smoke, the film slowly melted in the ashtray.

"Let me borrow a match," Guderian said.

"Don't bother. There's nothing in the film about Lu Mingfei. The Executive Department investigated his past; it was utterly ordinary. His first eighteen years were so normal they seemed like a failure. You might even suspect he had no bloodline at all and was admitted by mistake." Schneider shrugged.

"A genius must have something that sets him apart!" Guderian breathed a sigh of relief.

Another match struck. Both men turned to see Manstein expressionlessly lighting a different sheet of film.

"Mr. Chairman of the Disciplinary Committee, that's not your usual style," Schneider said with a cold smile. "Aren't you the one who values college rules and the Board's orders above all else?"

Manstein did not answer. He watched impassively as the sheet turned to ash in the tray.

Guderian saw the light. "Is it because of her mother? You were secretly in love with her mother back then, weren't you? You're an extraordinary man of loyalty and feeling." He was delighted, as if he had discovered a new continent, and used a new expression he had recently learned.

"Damn it! Nothing of the sort!" Manstein wanted to smash the ashtray into his face.

Schneider deftly gathered the remaining film, stuffed it back into the aluminum case, and clicked on a new lock he had prepared earlier. He let out a long breath and looked at Guderian and Manstein. "There. It's done. We're accomplices now. We should have a drink together."

"Wait! You destroyed the paper envelope with the Board's seal. That's too obvious!" Manstein said sharply.

"Simple. The hunters stole these documents, so they must have taken some of the contents." Schneider was confident. "That's what happened. Entirely reasonable."

"Some hunters with low-purity bloodlines—why would they meddle in our affairs? If someone hired them in secret, why would they open the documents? They're only people taking commissions to earn a little money." Manstein frowned. "They had no reason to do that."

"They're bad people." Schneider shrugged. "Bad people can do anything. They don't need a reason."

"Your logic is just like the Executive Department's methods... crude and direct..." Manstein murmured.

A gentle knock sounded at the door. The three exchanged quick glances. Schneider sprang up, grabbed the ashtray, dumped it into the wastebasket, and poured in a can of Coke. Guderian threw a thick dictionary on top, smothering the wisps of smoke. Manstein quickly rearranged his face into the stern integrity expected of the chairman of the Disciplinary Committee. He went to the door and opened it. Outside stood a smiling young man, his long golden hair covering half his remarkably delicate face.

He held out his hand. "Hello, Professor Manstein? I'm Parsi, secretary to the Board of Trustees. I've been sent to collect a case."

He looked into the central control room. An aluminum case sat on the long table. The imposing, cold-faced Professor Schneider of the Executive Department and Professor Guderian, whistling in apparent boredom, both seemed delighted to see him and waved. "Hi!"

"Damn it! Does he really have to whistle to show he has nothing to hide?" Manstein cursed inwardly.

Act Seven

The Feast of Dragons

Dragons'Feast

He slowly raised the lid, his voice full of mysterious enticement. "A weapon out of legend... a set of alchemical blades!"

A sharp, dark-golden light flowed through the widening gap. Lu Mingfei froze. Suddenly he felt that the thing inside the case was alive; he could hear a familiar breathing sound coming from within.

The lid opened. Alchemical blades? The Seven Deadly Sins! It was like meeting an old friend again.

Lu Mingfei opened his sleepy eyes. The room was silent. He turned his head. The sheet where Chu Zihang had slept was perfectly smooth, without so much as a depression, while Xia Mi's blanket was neatly folded, as though it had never been opened.

"Some friends," he muttered.

Had those two gone out to have fun first thing in the morning without even telling him? He stared at the ceiling for a while, then wondered whether Xia Mi might have a thing for Chu Zihang. Come to think of it, the beautiful freshman and the expressionless senior admired by everyone yet always single did make a good match. They even had common ground academically, which was to say neither of them spoke like a normal human being. Still, it wouldn't have hurt to take him along. He might always be a third wheel, but he was a considerate one: a good light bulb that didn't flash at random, just cast a warm glow on the couple beside him.

It was so quiet, as though he were the only person left in the world.

Lu Mingfei suddenly felt strange, uncertain where he was. There was no evidence that he was still dreaming or had woken up. On a morning like this, waking alone in an unfamiliar place was itself like a dream, wasn't it?

He had always had a weak presence, but never felt so unmoored. Lying on the soft bed, he seemed to float in the air. Aunt must really be angry this time. Would he go back to Uncle's next summer? If he did, Aunt would glare at him again. But if he didn't, where could he go? Stay on an empty campus? Everyone else would go home for summer vacation, leaving him all alone. Without Chu Zihang, Caesar, Nono, Xia Mi, and Fingel, he really was on his own. Was this what they called blood sorrow? Or the loneliness the devil version of Lu Mingze spoke about?

Thinking of Lu Mingze, he paused. Then he understood.

"Breakfast!" He clapped imperiously.

The door opened, and Lu Mingze pushed in a gleaming silver food cart. He was not much taller than the cart, but wore a proper white chef's uniform and a tall French chef's hat.

"I've just woken up and I'm terribly tired. His Majesty will dine in bed. Bring it over." Lu Mingfei put on a grand air, reclining against his pillows like a French noblewoman awakened from a springtime nap.

"Caviar with freshly toasted whole-wheat bread, raisin Danish pastry, chicken breast sautéed with lemon juice, and grilled Munich white sausage." Lu Mingze spoke with the exacting attentiveness of a butler. "To drink, would you prefer coffee, milk and cereal, or kiwi juice?"

"That's all? His Majesty's favorites are fried dough sticks and soft tofu pudding!"

"No problem." Lu Mingze lifted the silver cloche to reveal a set of white Chinese porcelain, four perfectly fried dough sticks, two bowls of silky soft tofu pudding, and several side dishes: Gaoyou salted duck eggs, Jinhua ham, Hangzhou vegetarian chicken, and Wangzhihe fermented tofu in chili oil.

As for the caviar, Danish pastry, chicken breast, and grilled sausage he had just mentioned, there was no sign of any of them.

"Are you messing with me? Four fried dough sticks and two bowls of tofu pudding, and you pretend to be a French chef?" That was what Lu Mingfei said, but he was happy. Once he returned to Cassell College he would have nothing but German food: endless sausages, sauerkraut, and pork knuckles.

"Our customer service is first-rate. A magic breakfast: if French breakfast had been what you wanted, that's exactly what you'd have found under the cover." Lu Mingze sat on the edge of the bed. "You only get two dough sticks and one bowl of tofu pudding. The other half is mine."

Lu Mingfei hesitated. "Am I eating in a dream? In reality, am I chewing on toads and drinking foot-washing water? It happens in Journey to the West: the White Bone Demon turns into a village girl bringing food, but the food is really toads, clods of dirt, and broken roof tiles."

"Of course not. You're a customer, and customers are the greatest. We devils always treat our customers well. We're businesspeople! Hard work brings prosperity!" Lu Mingze lifted a bowl of tofu pudding, blew on it, and took a sip. "Satisfied?"

"Satisfied, my foot! You've got too many tricks. I can't beat you, so I give up!" Unable to resist the fragrance of the fried dough, Lu Mingfei grabbed a stick and took a bite. It was superb, crisp and rich with oil. Even if it turned out to be a toad in the real world, he would accept it.

"Get to the point. I didn't summon you this time, so don't put it on my account," Lu Mingfei mumbled. A big spoonful of tofu pudding brought a hint of heat, and it tasted exactly like the breakfast stall outside his uncle's home.

Tofu pudding like this was reason enough to keep muddling through this lonely world!

"Of course. That was settled when we made the contract." Lu Mingze sounded magnanimous. "Something's going to happen today. I came especially to let you know, so you don't make a mistake."

"Something's going to happen?" Lu Mingfei frowned and picked up a piece of vegetarian chicken with his chopsticks.

"You have an important event coming up that will require money. I know you're a poor dog, so I'm going to lend you some."

"No!" Lu Mingfei refused without hesitation.

"No?" Lu Mingze was surprised.

"Borrow money from you? That means asking you for help, doesn't it? Asking you costs me part of my life. No deal! I don't need money for anything. If kidnappers came after me, I'd be better off summoning you to knock them all down. That would cost the same quarter of my life."

"It's a complimentary gift for a customer. No charge."

"You? So kind?" Lu Mingfei eyed Lu Mingze sideways.

"Me." Lu Mingze smiled. On the little devil's face, the innocent smile was like green leaves in the morning light. Even knowing how full of wicked schemes he was, you couldn't hate him when he smiled like that.

"In this whole world, I'm the only one who's always of one mind with you. Because... you're my brother." He actually reached out and gently touched Lu Mingfei's forehead.

"What are you touching me for? You've smeared chili oil on my face!" Lu Mingfei shouted.

But the instant Lu Mingze's hand touched his forehead, he felt an indescribable warmth. It was not merely the warmth of a hand that had held a bowl of tofu pudding; a tangible current of warmth flowed from Lu Mingze's palm into his body. The simple, natural touch felt as though it had happened thousands, tens of thousands of times in dreams: a hand touching his forehead, saying... Brother.

Looking back, this sneaky big boy had never harmed him once. Whenever he was at the end of his rope, with no answer from heaven or earth, and Caesar, Nono, and Chu Zihang could do nothing to help, only this devil version of Lu Mingze had stayed by his side. As long as he was willing to make a deal, Lu Mingze would help him, like the person closest to him in the whole world.

"This time's temporary Yanling is 'show me the money.' In StarCraft, entering that cheat code gives you ten thousand minerals and gas. This Yanling adds ten thousand US dollars to your assets, and you can use it repeatedly." Lu Mingze withdrew his hand.

"I reward my customers so often. Couldn't you summon me for something important once in a while?" He jumped off the bed and walked softly to the door, then turned back. "But I expect you will soon. Danger isn't far away. Stay alert and keep that phone with you at all times. Text me if anything happens. Oh, and someone left a note for you at the front desk. I brought it up on my way. It's on the cart."

He closed the door behind him.

The lock clicked shut. Lu Mingfei gave a start, and everything returned to normal.

It was still the same hotel room, with the same warm morning light coming through the sheer white curtains, but the details had changed. A depression where Chu Zihang had slept appeared beside Lu Mingfei; the blanket on Xia Mi's bed was a mess, not folded at all. Orange peels lay scattered on the table. Xia Mi's white cotton pajamas hung over the back of a chair, with a yellow sticky note attached: "Senior Mingfei, we had to go out on an errand. We ordered you a Chinese breakfast: fried dough sticks and tofu pudding." A cat's head was drawn in place of a signature. Xia Mi actually signed with a cat's head.

With those subtle changes, the dreamlike feeling, the sense of being a stranger to the world, vanished.

The food cart was still there. Soft, white tofu pudding remained in the bowl, sprinkled with fragrant chili-sesame oil, shreds of preserved mustard greens, shrimp, sesame, and dark vinegar. Half a fried dough stick lay on the plate, still steaming. This time Lu Mingze really hadn't tricked him.

Suddenly he felt like crying, though he didn't know why... and he also wanted to sneeze...

Lu Mingfei drew a deep breath and let out an earth-shaking sneeze, tears streaming down his face. If the tears had come from grief, his sorrow must have been as vast as the sea. But they didn't. They came from a streak of red sauce spread on the dough stick.

Blazingly hot bird's-eye chili sauce!

"Damn you! Who eats fried dough sticks with bird's-eye chili sauce? Lu Mingze, you're vicious!" Lu Mingfei wiped away his tears and imagined he could hear the sly little devil laughing triumphantly after going out the door.

"If I ever trust him again, I'm his son!" Lu Mingfei swore inwardly as he came out of the bathroom, wiping his mouth. Lu Mingze had spread the chili sauce as thickly as peanut butter. He had spent ten minutes frantically rinsing his mouth with cold water.

"If breakfast was a prank... then the money-making Yanling probably can't be trusted either, right?" Lu Mingfei thought. Besides, how was he supposed to use it? Shout "show me the money" into the air and have a courier deliver a package of cash? It could supposedly be used repeatedly. If he shouted it a hundred times, that would be a million dollars. Would an armored truck pull up outside the hotel?

A pale-yellow envelope lay on the food cart. In beautiful script it was addressed to "Ricardo M. Lu."

"Dear Ricardo:

This is a mission notice. Please go downstairs immediately upon receiving it. A black Maserati sedan will be waiting outside the hotel, with Illinois license plate 'CAS001.' The person in the car will explain the details of the mission."

The letter was printed on Hyatt stationery. If not for the seal at the bottom, Lu Mingfei would have assumed it was another of Lu Mingze's pranks. The security emblem was used exclusively by Cassell College; the last time he had seen one was on his disastrous transcript.

Lu Mingfei ran out of the hotel and immediately spotted the black Maserati parked at the curb.

It was a prestigious car sold alongside Ferraris. The long hood curved sharply, like a shark leaping from the water, while privacy glass blocked any view inside. Definitely a stylish toy. Lu Mingfei craned his neck, trying to see who was in it. He had heard the Executive Department paid very well, but who could be wealthy enough to drive a Maserati on a mission?

A tailored black suit? Gleaming Italian leather shoes? Hair so heavily oiled it could serve as a mirror? Dragons must be a terribly conceited race, if even their hybrid descendants loved showing off so much. Nine out of ten men and women at the college put on aristocratic airs. Even Chu Zihang drove a Panamera on official business. Or was it a beautiful woman? A qipao slit all the way to the top of the thigh, slender high heels, long waves of hair? No, that outfit belonged exclusively to female Nationalist spies... Lu Mingfei's imagination ran wild.

The car door popped open automatically and nearly hit him in the head. He ducked inside.

A tailored black suit, gleaming Italian leather shoes, hair oiled to a mirror shine, and a vivid red rose on the chest. If the man hadn't had a head of silver hair, he'd have looked like a thoroughgoing lecher! Add the silver hair and he was... an old lecher!

"P-Pr... Principal!" Lu Mingfei stammered.

"Hello, Mingfei. Let's work together wholeheartedly on this mission." Anjou smiled and raised his glass. The old man clearly knew how to enjoy life. A lilting aria played on the stereo; the slot that

should have held a Coke contained a bottle of ice wine instead. The sunroof stood open overhead, and delicate curls of cigar smoke drifted upward.

"You... got stranded in Chicago by the strike too?" Lu Mingfei felt a small, involuntary thrill. He wasn't the only unlucky one.

"You could say that, although I planned to stay here for two days anyway to attend an auction." Anjou handed him a beautifully printed brochure. "Sotheby's, one of the world's finest auction houses, is an important marketplace for art."

Lu Mingfei was bewildered. An auction? That was something rich young masters like Caesar played at. What did it have to do with him? The college's mission... could they be going to rob the auction house? Possible! The Executive Department was hardly made up of saints; they seemed to have broken plenty of laws and rules. Maybe the sports car was for a fast getaway. But if they really were robbing an auction house, shouldn't they send someone tough like Chu Zihang? Instead they were sending a man who was actually over a hundred years old with a novice? Granted, the old man's Yanling and fighting skills seemed no worse than a young man's, but what if a stray bullet happened to take out the principal...

He leafed through the brochure. China really had prospered: it was printed in Chinese too. A Qing Qianlong doucai tripod dish in the form of a mallow flower with floral motifs... a Song blue-and-white, underglaze-red high-necked vase with a low-relief design of the Music of the Prince of Qin Breaking the Battle Formation... a great Nanyang Dushan jade vessel depicting Vairocana Buddha with lowered hands... The elaborate names bloomed one after another, with startling prices beneath them.

"The items in the brochure aren't what interest us." Anjou waved his cigar. "This is a restricted auction: an auction of objects that the law permits to circulate only within certain limits, so only clients of particular standing are invited. But objects offered at such auctions often have obscure origins, and even major auction houses don't dare publicize them. They invite only discreet, trustworthy clients. In 2003 Sotheby's tried to auction six pottery figures from the tomb of Empress Dou of the Western Han. They were stolen relics, and it caused quite a stir. Since then, certain interesting objects haven't been printed in promotional materials. You have to attend in person to see what's revealed."

"So... we really are going there to bid?" Lu Mingfei relaxed. Watching Anjou wave his cigar, he had kept imagining the old man pulling a loaded Colt pistol out of the glove compartment, tossing it to him, and saying, "Today's job is up to the two of us!"

"Of course." Anjou looked surprised. "One goes to an auction to bid on things."

"Good, good. Please go on, Principal." Lu Mingfei nodded vigorously.

"Restricted auctions are where the college hunts for treasures. We often find obscure pieces. For example, we once paid less than four hundred thousand dollars for a brass blowtorch of unknown age. Do you know the kind?" Anjou gestured with both hands. "An alcohol blowtorch like chemists used in the century before last."

"I've seen one. Only the teacher was allowed to use it in high-school lab. It's like a little flamethrower."

"Quite right. Now imagine turning the blowtorch sideways..."

"Then... it's a flamethrower!" Lu Mingfei understood.

"Exactly! It wasn't an alcohol blowtorch at all, but a weapon made by a nineteenth-century alchemical technician. They usually called such things 'dragon's breath.' The fuel wasn't alcohol, but refined mercury-bearing nitroglycerin."

"Nitroglycerin... isn't that an explosive?"

"Correct. An explosive. It could project a cone of flame twenty meters long, with an explosive effect, while releasing enormous quantities of mercury vapor. A powerful weapon against dragons." Anjou nodded. "That's why I say it's a place to find treasures."

"And I'm going because..."

"You'll play a buyer new to the trade. There's an item we want you to bid on for us." Anjou handed him a wireless earpiece. "It's simple. Just follow my instructions. But remember, at the auction you and I don't know each other."

"I don't think I'm suitable... I don't know anything about auctions..." Lu Mingfei lost his nerve.

"That doesn't matter. The college will create all kinds of opportunities for you to learn." Anjou drew deeply on his cigar and was silent for several seconds. "You're the only S-rank student at the college now. You have a great deal to learn. While the Night Watcher and I can still protect this school, you must learn as quickly as you can... There's not much time."

"Not... much time?" Lu Mingfei heard a deep loneliness in the old man's words.

"At my age, how much longer do you think I can live?" Anjou shrugged. "I was among the earliest members of the Lionheart Society. Of course, if you'd lived through the entire twentieth century, you wouldn't care much about whether you died either."

"And yet... you smoke so much..." Lu Mingfei stammered. He had never imagined that someone as formidable as the principal could die. To any Cassell student, the principal and the Night Watcher were the foundations of the school. An old man who had lived 130 years and could still leap like a tiger with a folding knife and stab a Dragon King through the head was practically an ancient monster! And weren't ancient monsters supposed to live for a thousand years? Hearing one speak about a subject as serious as death was both funny and sad.

"The advantage of dragon genes is that most of us will never get cancer. Many fatal diseases leave us alone. If I die one day, it will be because every part of me has worn out... or because a Dragon King's Yanling blows my head apart." The old man casually flicked the cigar butt through the sunroof, gripped the wheel with one hand, and floored the accelerator.

The dangerous shark roared away, ignoring the changing traffic light and plunging into the stream of cars. Several vehicles behind it braked in panic, blocking the entire intersection at crooked angles.

"Hey, hey, hey!" Lu Mingfei hadn't even had time to fasten his seat belt and could only cling desperately to the handhold. The acceleration that car magazines praised so highly was torture now, like an immense force pinning him to the seat.

These Cassell College lunatics! No wonder the old saying went that when the upper beam was crooked, the lower ones would lean too. Compared with this, Chu Zihang merely reversed at sixty kilometers an hour. What a law-abiding driver!

Anjou drained his glass of ice wine with pleasure and kept accelerating. Evidently the old man drove fast as a matter of course.

Ice wine? Wait, no. Ice wine had no business here, did it? They were already going 120 kilometers an hour, and the old man driving had a stemmed glass in his hand? This was too much excitement. Lu Mingfei's head buzzed.

"Principal... driving after drinking, in China..." Lu Mingfei swallowed hard. "They revoke your license for that!"

"Same in America." Anjou shrugged. "But do you think they'd renew a license for a 130-year-old man? When I learned to drive, there was no such thing as a driver's license. That was 1899... yes, 1899. Cars had only been invented in 1885, a new toy that couldn't outrun a carriage yet. No Ford, no General Motors, no traffic rules at all!"

"Principal, you've... been driving without a license for over a hundred years?" Lu Mingfei's heart nearly leaped into his throat. A moment ago, passing another car, he'd been sure they would crash; the gap was so narrow it was like two Japanese swordsmen crossing blades, their quick swords flashing past each other in midair. "Principal, I'm still young! I want to live a good long life!"

"That's right." Anjou smiled. "You're still young. But remember what I just told you? I don't know how much time I have left..."

"Hey, please! Could you stop accelerating when you change the subject?"

"I haven't changed it. I mean... as an old man with one foot in the grave who loves driving fast, what do I have left to lose?" Anjou switched the gear setting to that damned super-sport mode and let out a whoop that would have sent a teenage girl's hormones racing.

The Maserati slowed and stopped at the curb.

"Ready? The mission is about to begin. Remember your identity? You're Lu Mingfei, an art enthusiast from China..." Anjou handed him a cigar sealed in an aluminum tube.

"I've memorized it. I'm Lu Mingfei, a nouveau riche bumpkin who's fallen for a girl at art school and wants to cultivate some artistic taste... Damn it, I've finally made it to an amazing auction, and I'm going to pick up some good stuff for my mansion with the water feature! I don't know how to smoke fancy things like cigars. I don't smoke cigarettes either." The mission plan had included his cover story, which Lu Mingfei now knew backward. He imagined himself an actor, trying hard to get into character.

"You don't have to know how. Just hold it in your mouth and draw. You're attending an auction; you need an expensive habit or two to show your worth. This is a Cuban cigar, fifty dollars apiece!"

"Very nouveau riche." Lu Mingfei held the cigar in his mouth like a grilled sausage.

"That's why I chose you instead of Chu Zihang or Caesar. You're better at playing a nouveau riche upstart."

"True. I'm a bumpkin."

Anjou handed him an envelope. "Your invitation is inside. Keep it safe. You need a two-million-dollar deposit in your account. Norma opened an account for you at a bank in Zurich and deposited two million."

"Wow! Two million!" Lu Mingfei imagined that if he looked in a mirror, dollar signs would be rolling across his wide-open eyes.

"It's mission funding. It will be withdrawn from your account afterward."

"I don't care if it lasts forever; I only care that I have it today." The ridiculous line rolled out of Lu Mingfei's mouth without passing through his brain. "But Principal, you're such a tasteful man, and clearly rich. Why not bid for it yourself?"

"An auction is a psychological game. Especially with rarities seldom seen on the market: no one can assess their value at once, and psychology becomes particularly important. An artwork's price depends on how many people want it. The more bidders, the higher the price rises. If an experienced buyer bids aggressively, many will follow, driving it up. And I am an experienced buyer. Almost everyone there knows me."

"So if you raise your paddle, it tells them the thing is valuable?" Lu Mingfei nodded. "In plain language, I'm a plant."

Anjou gave him a thumbs-up. "Exactly, you're a plant! I'll bid on a few small things for appearances, but I won't raise my paddle for the real target. I want it to seem an obscure item no one cares about. You will bid, and everyone will think that new rich upstart is spending his money on something useless, while you get it cheaply."

"Understood!" Lu Mingfei said. "By the way, Principal, do you know where Chu Zihang went? We also met a freshman named Xia Mi yesterday. We shared a room last night, and when I woke up they were both gone."

"Norma arranged another assignment for Chu Zihang. He's showing Xia Mi around Chicago and giving her pre-enrollment orientation at the same time. Usually a professor would do it, but since we have an extra seven days, we should make good use of them." Anjou thought for a moment. "I believe they went to Six Flags, the roller-coaster park."

"No way! I've never been to Six Flags either... I want to take a pretty junior on a roller coaster too!" Lu Mingfei failed to stop himself; his true feelings spilled out.

Anjou stared for a moment, then said awkwardly, "I'm the principal. I'm more important than a pretty junior... Students would firmly turn down a date just to have afternoon tea with me..."

"At your age, why are you competing with a girl for attention?" Lu Mingfei shrugged.

"Get out!"

"Hey... is this about a man's pride? Isn't that a bit much?" Lu Mingfei stared wide-eyed.

"You're a plant. Naturally you can't appear with me. Someone will pick you up here shortly. Remember to change: a full Armani outfit, the brand all wealthy Chinese bumpkins love. Walk with your chest out. You're a man coming here to spend two million dollars; look down on everything. Don't overestimate those well-dressed Sotheby's auctioneers. They're just people earning a commission." Anjou clapped him hard on the shoulder. "You failed two courses last semester..."

"Hey, Principal, that's unfair. Don't bring up a sore subject... How am I supposed to act arrogant when you remind me of that?" Lu Mingfei made a miserable face, and the cigar fell from his mouth onto the seat.

"I mean that as principal I have the authority to give you extra credit. If you perform this assignment beautifully, I'll give you passing grades." Anjou held out his hand. "Deal?"

"You can do that? Deal!" Lu Mingfei's fighting spirit blazed at once, and he seized Anjou's hand.

"I told you hanging around the principal had a brighter future than hanging around a pretty junior..."

"...You're not still bothered by what I said, are you?"

"Of course not. I'm always magnanimous..." Anjou took out a jet lighter and lit the thick cigar for Lu Mingfei. "Now smoke your Cohiba, wear your Armani suit, and go do battle in the arena of wealth, our young Chinese millionaire!"

The car door flew open. The principal lifted a foot and kicked the stunned Lu Mingfei out. The Maserati sped away in a cloud of dust.

"Hey! So violent? You really were embarrassed and angry, weren't you?" The young upstart Lu Mingfei pounded the pavement and shouted after the disappearing car.

His stomach gave an unhelpful rumble, wiping away his anger. Only then did he remember he'd eaten just half his breakfast. He got up helplessly, dusted himself off, and rolled his eyes toward the sky. It was clear and freshly washed, and a white-winged gull that had strayed from Lake Michigan into the human city glided among the skyscrapers.

Pennsylvania Avenue was a small road hidden in the busy downtown district, with the towering gray walls of skyscrapers on either side. The buildings dated from Chicago's most luxurious metropolitan era, the 1950s. Over the years their limestone surfaces had flaked away, giving them the forlorn air of fallen nobility. The tall buildings blocked out all sunlight, leaving a chill in the long, narrow street. At the end stood a massive square building, its high walls windowless except for a row of large ventilation fans turning slowly near the top.

The Chicago Civic Opera House.

It had once been a gathering place for celebrities. Sixty years ago, every night brought luxury cars and fashionable women. Courteous gentlemen escorted young companions to enjoy refined music, while attendants called out the names of distinguished guests.

But its glory had faded. Young people now went on dates to movie theaters or shopping centers downtown. The opera house belonged to the splendor of another age.

Today it had awakened again. A succession of luxury cars stopped at the entrance, red taillights flashing one after another. Heavy doors opened, and men in black tailcoats or evening suits stepped out, all wearing white embroidered shirts and metropolitan side parts slicked with enough oil to shine like mirrors. Hands in long white velvet gloves emerged from the cars, silver watches worn outside the gloves. The men took those hands and lightly helped out fashionable women wrapped in mink and veils, slender heels touching the pavement, calves drawn into graceful curves. White steam rose from sewer grates, and the men and women walking arm in arm toward the opera house formed a picture of Chicago in the golden age of 1950.

Outside the Civic Opera House that day, time seemed to have flowed backward sixty years.

A black Lincoln sedan drew slowly to the entrance. Its old-fashioned grandeur caught an attendant's eye, and he hurried down the steps. The window lowered, and a young, long-fingered hand with prominent joints held out a dark-red invitation.

"Mr. Ricardo M. Lu!" the attendant called the unfamiliar name as though welcoming a well-known count.

The driver got out, his back perfectly straight, dressed in black with gold-plated buttons. He respectfully opened the rear door. A young man with pale-gold hair emerged and swept a cool gaze over the passing guests. His upright figure stood in the wind like a spear planted in the ground. He put

on black sunglasses, hiding his handsome face, and pulled back his striped shirt cuff to glance at a fine IWC watch.

"This way, Mr. Lu. The auction is about to begin." The attendant bowed to the young guest of honor.

The guest waved him away coolly, turned, and went to a silver extended Bentley behind the Lincoln. Bending slightly, he opened its door. "This way, Mr. Lu."

The flamboyant display shocked every passing guest. So this imposing young man was... the one who opened the car door!

This time the first thing to appear was a thick Cohiba cigar, then an expensive custom Armani suit, then a snow-white lace cravat, then polished Ferragamo shoes. Surprise spread over every face as the honored guest finally emerged in full. He drew a breath, thrust out his chest, and looked down on the assembled company, a brown Burberry trench coat draped over his shoulders. He took a deep drag on the cigar...

Then erupted in violent coughing. The blond young man hurried over to pat his back. Around them came a ripple of snickers of uncertain meaning.

"Damn it!" Lu Mingfei cursed inwardly. There was nothing wrong with this outfit. What were they laughing at? He'd only choked on the cigar! Besides, hadn't his entrance imitating Mark Gor been impressive?

"They're laughing because you've put on every fashionable designer label at once. Your taste is too mixed. Ignore them. That's your assigned role." Anjou's low voice sounded in his ear. In his nervousness, Lu Mingfei had almost forgotten the wireless earpiece.

"What kind of lousy role is this..." A tiny microphone was hidden beside Lu Mingfei's jaw.

"Whatever you see, don't show surprise. Just follow along." Anjou was hidden somewhere out of sight.

Lu Mingfei followed the attendant through a dim passage, perfume drifting faintly in the air. The glints came from silver powder on the fashionable women's bare shoulders. The luxurious, unreal surroundings made him a little dizzy. Then the space ahead brightened.

Suddenly he emerged into a vast open space, as if golden light were shining from every direction.

The opera house spread out before him, a wave of splendor washing over him. Towering columns all around resembled the ruins of the Parthenon on the Acropolis, but painted a magnificent dark red. Beneath the domed ceiling, enormous crystal chandeliers banished every shadow. The dome and walls, golden in the light, were painted with the battles of Ragnarök. A wool carpet bore green mandala designs; brass plates marked the numbers on red velvet seats. A scarlet curtain hung over the stage, as though drawing it back would reveal a tragedy by some ancient Greek master.

He didn't have enough eyes to take it all in and didn't know where to look. Amid the endless crowd, he felt lost.

He found his seat, but not Anjou. Guests settled into the surrounding seats, exchanging brief greetings as though they all knew one another. The opera house was not very large, but all several hundred seats were occupied.

The lights went out one by one until only the huge branching chandelier in the center of the dome remained lit. As if a performance were about to begin, white-clad attendants passed through the aisles

ringing a string of bells, and the guests' conversations died down. The curtain trembled, and a man in a black tailcoat stepped out.

"Ladies and gentlemen, Sotheby's restricted auction, the 2010 Summer Chicago Cultural Journey sale, will begin in five minutes. I am your auctioneer. Please keep hold of your paddles and don't miss the things you desire, because every item we're about to offer is unique." He paused. "Now, night has fallen. Please close your eyes."

What was this? Lu Mingfei stared. Were they playing a murder game? Did they have to close their eyes at night and open them at dawn? The guests all closed their eyes and lowered their heads slightly.

"Day has broken. Please open your eyes!"

Everyone opened their eyes at once. For an instant it was as though the opera house had lit up again, but this time it was not crystal chandeliers illuminating the hall. It was hundreds of pairs of golden eyes!

Lu Mingfei felt his heart stop.

"Don't move or say anything. Don't look around," Anjou's voice sounded in his ear.

"But that's... that's... that's..." Lu Mingfei almost groaned.

"Yes, genuine golden eyes, every one. This isn't a masquerade. They're revealing their golden eyes to show their bloodlines. Everyone attending this auction is a hybrid, like you and me. This is..." Anjou paused. "A feast of dragons!"

Lu Mingfei was thankful there was still a chair beneath him. Otherwise he would have collapsed like an overcooked noodle and wet himself.

What kind of place was this? The hall was full of distinguished guests, every one a human-dragon hybrid! Gold cards, platinum cards, and black cards didn't signify status here. Everyone displayed golden eyes as proof of bloodline. But he... he was staring in terror, eyes almost popping out, red as a little white rabbit's.

A feast of dragons? A grand name for a bunch of half-dragons throwing a party in a dragon's den, right? There had to be a main course. Were these people vegetarians? He was the only little white rabbit here!

"May I get past?" a low, cool voice said beside him.

Lu Mingfei turned and sucked in a breath. A pair of golden eyes shone beside him like lamps. They belonged to a young man in his twenties who had arrived late. Before Lu Mingfei could look away, their eyes met. We're doomed! I've been exposed, he thought. If he'd known what kind of gathering this was, he should have brought gold cosmetic contacts. In this sea of golden eyes, he was like a green-eyed foreigner sitting in a Chang'an tavern at the height of the Tang dynasty. How could anyone fail to see he was different?

Sure enough, the man paused, and the light in his pupils grew fiercer, as if golden blades were gathering in his eyes.

Lu Mingfei went rigid. That piercing gaze! In an anime, it would surely come just before a devastating special attack!

"Very understated," the man said suddenly with an appreciative click of his tongue. The gold in his pupils dimmed slightly, and he held out a hand in friendship. "Romario Townsend. Call me Roma."

Understated, my ass! It's just that I can't make my eyes turn gold, brother! Lu Mingfei shook his hand nervously.

"Ever since auctions like this began, people have lit their golden eyes to show off the purity of their bloodlines and put pressure on others when they meet their gaze," Townsend said, sitting beside Lu Mingfei and lowering his voice. "Eventually everyone started doing it, and it turned into a masquerade. But it's hard not to follow the crowd. Bloodline is what matters here, as if without golden eyes yours won't even be recognized." Townsend scoffed. "I think your way is better: natural, relaxed. We're here for things we like, after all. Spending money should be fun. Keeping golden eyes lit for hours always leaves you exhausted afterward."

"Roma... you don't suspect I'm human?" Lu Mingfei ventured, thinking, Damn it, I am human, but please don't suspect it.

"How could you be?" Townsend dismissed the idea. "The screening here is strict. I haven't seen you before. New to the trade?"

"Oh, yes. My family's in building materials in China, and because I like..." Lu Mingfei hurriedly retrieved his cover story.

"The building materials business is very profitable in China!" Townsend exclaimed again. "My family's always been in construction too, but the golden age of North American construction is past. We can't possibly compete with Chinese real-estate developers."

"Oh, come on, you imperialist countries..."

"But I hear in China you can even withhold workers' wages. How can we compete with that?" Townsend spread his hands.

Damn it! Lu Mingfei cursed inwardly. Word about migrant workers' unpaid wages had reached Lake Michigan. What a disgrace to the nation!

"Don't say too much. The more you say, the more likely you are to make a mistake." Anjou's voice sounded in his ear. "Now it's time for a lesson from the principal himself."

"You've always thought Cassell College was the only place where hybrids gather? Let me correct that. It's only one of them. You come from China, Caesar from Italy, Chu Zihang from China, Zero from Russia... Hybrids are spread across different parts of the world. Through marriage, dragon blood has traveled to every corner. We don't know how many hybrids exist worldwide. Those selected for Cassell College are only a tiny fraction. The others have their own ways of life, but because of their bloodlines they are drawn to one another and form a hidden sub-society within human society. What you're seeing now is hybrid society. It has its own rules.

"Cassell College grew out of the Dragon Blood Secret Party, whose aim is to destroy all pureblood dragons. But not every hybrid shares that ideal. More of them remain outside the war. They hate dragons, but don't consider themselves on humanity's side either. They believe their bloodlines are superior to humans', and call themselves a 'third race' between humans and dragons. Because of their blood, they age more slowly than ordinary people, and their aesthetic tastes lag behind too. Some of these people may already have been active in the middle of the last century. The flamboyant style of old Chicago is still fashionable among them.

"Some of their families have lasted for thousands of years, accumulating astonishing wealth and power. But because their positions differ, they won't necessarily support us. In any case, this is hybrid

society: all kinds of people with all kinds of ideas, who need to communicate with one another. Auctions are one way they socialize. Do you remember what dragons' greatest obsession is said to be?"

"Stealing princesses?" How should I know, Lu Mingfei thought. Maybe you just like playing the villainous boss, kidnapping princesses in fairy tales and getting speared to death by knights.

"No. According to legend, dragons love collecting precious metals and gems, and sleep sprawled on gold," Anjou said. "There's a basis for that. Dragons developed alchemy, and alchemy is the pinnacle of craftsmanship. Dragons are often obsessed with art. Attila, king of the Huns, for instance, was buried sealed in three coffins of gold, silver, and iron, each elaborately carved and set with gems. Hybrids inherited this obsession. Half the top collectors are hybrids, though you won't find their names in collecting magazines."

"So they're artists too." Lu Mingfei calmed down a little. He was already in the dragon's pool and tiger's den, but he at least understood the words accept your fate.

"The paddle in your hand is number seventeen, your birthday. All you have to do is raise it and bid in the most leisurely way possible. Ordinarily the increments don't need to be high, but a powerful buyer can intimidate others through sheer presence. When you think you need to win in one stroke, don't be afraid to make a large jump bid. It shows you're determined to have the item. Anyone bidding against you may hesitate: if they continue, the price could be driven too high, and they won't want to pay it. And if you're a plant for the auction house or another seller, they'll have fallen for it."

"Presence is such an elusive thing..." Lu Mingfei whispered.

"Actually, in the way you young people put it..." Anjou chuckled. "Just act like a pompous badass."

"Our next lot is a Qing Qianlong yangcai gourd vase with brocade-ground decoration and a longevity-and-ruyi motif. This porcelain from the Qianlong reign of the Qing dynasty represents the height of the ceramic art of its time, made for the imperial household by the Imperial Workshops. It left China after the Boxer War of 1900. A similar piece sold in Hong Kong for 17.3 million dollars a few months ago." The auctioneer surveyed the room. "The opening bid is nine million dollars. Bids, please."

This was the sixth lot of the day, and the opening price had risen from two hundred thousand to nine million. Lu Mingfei had not raised his paddle once, because Anjou had not given the order. Anjou himself, however, had bid on and won the great Nanyang Dushan jade vessel depicting Vairocana Buddha with lowered hands. Seated in the VIP section up front, he bid while whispering to the graceful young married woman beside him, looking perfectly content.

Now that was a pompous badass: bleeding money by the bucket while acting as if cash meant nothing, as if he'd come only for the love of art and to flirt with women! Lu Mingfei was impressed.

As opening prices climbed, the circle of competition narrowed to the VIP section. The earlier little pieces had been appetizers; this gourd vase was the main course, and several parties were fighting fiercely for it.

Anjou bid a few times, but he seemed merely bored and interested in driving up the price for others. Once it passed twenty million he withdrew and began telling jokes that made the young woman smile behind pursed lips.

Lu Mingfei grew bored. There was nothing special about this auction except that the participants were all hybrids. Everyone followed the rules, and so far no one had lost a bid, flown into a rage, and

started blasting the others with Yanling. The game had gone beyond what he could play anyway: his mission budget was only two million.

"Twenty-three million one hundred thousand, going once!"

"Twenty-three million one hundred thousand, going twice! Last chance, please bid now."

"Twenty-three million one hundred thousand, going three times! Sold!" The auctioneer brought down the hammer.

Polite applause filled the hall. The sale made a fine ending: the vase had been listed last in the catalog, the day's grand finale.

"Now for today's special segment, as always: 'An Unexpected Encounter.'" The auctioneer smiled.

Lu Mingfei looked up in surprise and saw Townsend's eyes brighten.

"What encounter?" Lu Mingfei asked.

"An Unexpected Encounter is a fun part of the evening." Townsend had taken a liking to him and explained patiently. "After the main auction ends, they offer some unconventional lots for amusement. Usually they're little things, but occasionally a superb piece fetches an astronomical price, or you can acquire something promising very cheaply. Recently someone bought an old Renaissance painting there. The brushwork was rather immature, the condition poor, and the signature belonged to one of Leonardo da Vinci's students. Insiders considered it an entry-level piece, so the hammer price was low. But when the buyer examined it under ultraviolet light, he found another painting beneath it: a genuine da Vinci, signature and all."

"He hit the jackpot!" Lu Mingfei said.

"Exactly. Once the top layer of paint was removed, the price increased fivefold! Oil painters in those days reused canvases, painting over old pictures, but who would have expected a student to cover up his teacher's work?"

"What incredible luck!" Lu Mingfei exclaimed.

"Your assignment today is a lot in An Unexpected Encounter. According to certain information, it's extremely important to us." Anjou's voice sounded in his ear. "Get it, whatever the cost."

Lu Mingfei started and came alert. Was it his turn to take the stage?

The auctioneer's assistant wheeled out a huge black hard-shell case. The auctioneer rested a white-gloved hand on the lid and smiled around the room without hurrying to open it. It was rather like an old street salesman hawking strength pills: before smashing a stone on his chest, he had to boast and build suspense.

"This is an extraordinary lot. Every auctioneer who saw it was astonished. It is exceptionally beautiful, the pinnacle of craftsmanship, but regrettably we know nothing of its provenance, not even its age, so we cannot set an appropriate opening price. With the seller's permission, this will be one of our rare zero-reserve auctions. Each increment may be as little as one dollar." The auctioneer raised one finger. "An opportunity not to be missed. Only... one dollar!"

A stir ran through the room. This was new and had aroused everyone's curiosity. The auctioneer was pleased with the atmosphere: the first step of his sales pitch had succeeded.

He slowly lifted the lid, his voice full of mysterious temptation. "Weapons out of myth... a set of alchemical blades!"

Sharp, dark-golden light flowed through the widening gap. Lu Mingfei froze. Suddenly he felt that the object in the case was alive; he could hear familiar breathing inside.

The lid opened. Alchemical blades? The Seven Deadly Sins! It was like meeting an old acquaintance again.

Lu Mingfei had used one of them to stab the Dragon King Norton to death, yet Norton himself had forged the weapons to slaughter dragons. Lu Mingfei had lost them in the Three Gorges Reservoir and never expected to see them again.

Someone was willing to sell a treasure on the level of a divine artifact? And it had fallen to an auction with a zero opening price? It was like an emperor getting so carried away selling offices that he began auctioning his own throne! Lu Mingfei was stunned.

"Familiar, isn't it? The Seven Deadly Sins. Both your report and Nono's said you'd found the set but lost it during the ascent." Anjou spoke with quiet admiration. "An alchemical creation beyond its age, of incalculable value!"

Lu Mingfei shivered silently. He knew its value. He had drawn only the shortest blade, yet the metal's roar had sounded like a dragon. Holding it meant holding the power over life and death. But he didn't like the set, and hadn't much regretted losing it, because of a shadow in his heart... Once these blades were grasped, killing would begin, and even the person holding them would have no choice.

Lu Mingfei had never been able to say whether the one he'd stabbed underwater was the Dragon King Norton or his friend Old Tang, who had taught him interview techniques.

Yet here it was again, like a restless ghost returning to haunt him.

"Superb workmanship, perfectly preserved, edges as sharp as new. Their forms imitate Chinese horse-chopping sabers, Tang sabers, Japanese swords, wakizashi, Damascus blades, and so on. They're housed in a single box opened by a concealed catch..." The auctioneer spoke eloquently.

Meanwhile assistants demonstrated quick cucumber slicing, cutting rolled bamboo mats, severing iron nails and metal sheets... Apparently the auction house had no way to explain the set's origins and could only demonstrate its sharpness. Lu Mingfei knew the style: Chinese TV shopping channels used the same enthusiasm to sell whitening or waist-slimming products.

"Replicas, surely? However well preserved, they couldn't be completely flawless," someone in the VIP seats objected. "They look like Swiss Army knives made this year!"

"As I said, we can't confirm their age or provenance, so the price depends entirely on your interest. In any case they're a fine set of blades; at the very least you can use them in the kitchen." The auctioneer shrugged and deflected the question with a joke.

"All right, one dollar!" Someone raised a paddle.

"Two dollars!" another followed immediately. The guests smiled indulgently.

"Three dollars!"

"Four dollars!"

The auctioneer looked embarrassed. The guests were teasing him. "Ladies and gentlemen, even a set of Damascus-steel kitchen knives costs hundreds of dollars. Might we have some competitive bids?" He spread his hands with a helpless smile.

"Certainly. Two hundred thousand."

The moment the voice came from the box on the right, every eye turned toward it. Besides the startling jump in price, there was that remarkable voice: no one could explain why such a casual woman's voice should be so enchanting. Behind a deep-red velvet curtain sat a young woman in an embroidered Islamic robe, holding paddle 88. A golden veil covered her entire face; only her lovely eyes were exposed, a trace of crimson at their corners. A bright red cord tied her high-styled hair.

She sat with her eyes lowered, yet looked like a queen presiding over the gathering.

"Two hundred and five thousand." After a few seconds, someone raised the bid.

This was no longer a joke. Someone clearly thought the set worth more.

"Two hundred and ten thousand!" Lu Mingfei raised his paddle. The principal had said they must have it, so this was unquestionably the time to act. It wasn't his money anyway.

"Three hundred thousand." Without hesitation, the veiled young woman raised her paddle again.

What magnificent bidding! Every raise was a leap, every leap measured in hundreds of thousands of dollars. Number 88 was clearly even more determined than Lu Mingfei.

"Three hundred thousand to the lady with eighty-eight, going once!" The auctioneer happily raised his hammer.

"Three hundred and fifty thousand." This bidder was seated among the VIPs.

"Four hundred thousand!" Someone followed. The VIP's bid had stirred the room.

"Damn, it's heating up. They're driving up the price." Anjou's voice remained calm. "But don't hurry, and don't leave the field. Keep bidding, without making the jumps too obvious. It isn't time to exert ourselves yet."

"Four hundred and ten thousand." Lu Mingfei raised his paddle. Though he wasn't fond of the set, completing the assignment would excuse him from two makeup exams, so he was willing to try.

"One million." Number 88 again.

The veiled girl's momentum was irresistible. Anjou didn't need to remind Lu Mingfei: however hard he tried, his biggest jumps were not even half hers.

"One million?" Even the auctioneer questioned the figure.

"One and a half million." Number 88's voice was icy.

"One moment, madam. No one has bid against you since your last offer. Is your bid one million or one and a half?" the auctioneer asked carefully.

"What it was doesn't matter. Now it's one and a half million."

The room erupted. This was madness: Number 88 was driving up the price of the blades by bidding against herself.

"One point six million." Before the astonished murmurs had died away, a fresh price came from the VIP seats.

"Someone is paying close attention now," Anjou murmured, raising his own paddle. "One point seven million."

"Principal, didn't you say you weren't bidding?" Lu Mingfei was bewildered.

In the blink of an eye, one of their own had driven the price up another hundred thousand. Did these people have any idea what a hundred thousand dollars could do? In Lu Mingfei's hometown, fifty

thousand would buy a small house, and the other fifty thousand could buy enough pirated game discs to fill it!

"Someone paying close attention means they've realized this might be extraordinary. They know me; with my temperament, I'd certainly try for something unusual, or I wouldn't be myself," Anjou said quietly. "But you're still our trump card."

"Two million." Number 88's queenly presence surged again.

"Keep bidding," Anjou ordered.

"Two... million and ten thousand!" Lu Mingfei gritted his teeth and raised his paddle. His smallholder instincts said a thousand-dollar raise was still a raise, so why not save money? But in this situation he felt he couldn't embarrass himself too badly.

"Two point one million." Number 72 raised a paddle, apparently an ambusher who had kept hidden until now.

"Two point one million, the gentleman with seventy-two!" The auctioneer's face flushed with excitement. Apparently the auction house had struck lucky. They hadn't expected much from this unusual lot, yet the competition was now as fierce as for the gourd-shaped vase that had closed the main sale.

"Continue," Anjou murmured.

"But I only have two million," Lu Mingfei reminded him quietly.

"Don't worry. Once you've successfully bought it, the college will transfer the money. The two million was only your deposit to get a seat here."

"Two point two million!" Lu Mingfei threw caution aside.

"Three." Number 88 spoke lightly, not even bothering to say "million."

The price rose back and forth, the air growing hot. Bidding gentlemen loosened their ties to breathe. Lu Mingfei gasped, the hand holding his cigar trembling slightly. He was caught in a torrent of money and couldn't stop. A few seconds after his bid of 5.2 million, someone raised it again. Hybrids truly were passionate lovers of fine craftsmanship: once their blood was hot, cost no longer mattered.

But Number 88 remained the focus. She held everyone down so firmly that, however they struggled, they seemed only to make her eventual victory more glorious.

What did it mean to be determined to win? This! It took both resources and nerve. A mongrel like Lu Mingfei could never summon the aura of a queen arriving. He felt he was losing, unable to hold on.

"Ten million." Number 88 spoke casually, this time adding an entire digit.

Should he just give up? At worst he could work harder for the makeup exams next semester. This sort of assignment had never suited him. The principal must have read the mission report Chu Zihang had written for him and thought he'd been heroic in China. In truth his expressionless senior had protected him... while Senior was bleeding, Lu Mingfei had only been mooning over Chen Wenwen. Thoughts flashed through his mind.

"Ten million, going once, number eighty-eight." The auctioneer's voice filled the room.

Yet he couldn't quite accept defeat. The old principal really did seem good to him, saying such poignant things, promising to give him a chance to learn. But please: a circus gorilla might sometimes

appear to do addition, but it would never learn calculus, just as Lu Mingfei would never become Chu Zihang. He wrestled with himself.

"Ten million, going twice. Ladies and gentlemen, seize your last chance."

Why didn't he dare fight? The principal had beaten his chest and promised to back him. Yet the enormous numbers seemed to crush him, leaving him breathless, hands and feet cold. He really couldn't do it... He'd tried hard to hold on until now... Perhaps he should let it go... Though he hated to lose.

"Mingfei, I believe in you. You must believe in yourself too. You are the one I chose; wherever you go, you will shine." Anjou's voice seemed both near and far. "Giving up? You'll regret it, won't you?"

Lu Mingfei shuddered, as though an electric current had passed through him.

Yes, he hated to lose. Though he wanted desperately to give up, he couldn't suppress that little spark of unwillingness deep in his heart, a flame that not all the rain in the world could extinguish.

So he still had that inside him...

"Twenty million!" Number 17 raised his paddle.

Lu Mingfei's voice filled the hall, and everyone fell silent. Could it get any crazier? This young, nouveau-riche-looking big kid still trembled slightly as he raised his paddle, yet he had jumped ten million!

The auctioneer hesitated; it was the second time that day he'd wondered whether he'd heard correctly. An assistant hurried onstage and whispered to him. The auctioneer nodded slightly, his face grave. "Ladies and gentlemen, thank you for your interest in this lot. The intensity of the bidding has greatly exceeded our expectations. We must prevent false bids that result in a successful sale without payment, so we must ask Mr. Lu, number seventeen, to accompany us to the finance office. The auction will be suspended in the meantime."

Lu Mingfei's face changed at once.

In the finance office the auctioneer's assistant and the finance manager gathered around Lu Mingfei. They were perfectly courteous, but to him they seemed full of murderous intent.

"We're very sorry, but the manner of your bidding was truly extraordinary. To safeguard the auction, we had to ask you here." The manager patted a black briefcase. "You gave us only a Zurich bank account containing two million dollars as a deposit. Ordinarily that would be persuasive, but your bid this round is twenty million, ten times your deposit. This is your first visit, and you haven't established sufficient credit. Unless you can demonstrate that you really can pay, we must revoke your bidding privileges."

"How could that be? Is that all?" Sweat poured down Lu Mingfei's face, but he forced himself to bluster. "Two million is just what I spend on a new Bugatti!"

The manager seemed to see through the boy's bravado and smiled discreetly. "Please cooperate and temporarily remove your earpiece and microphone. Your financial security and our reputation are at stake, so our conversation must remain confidential."

Lu Mingfei had no choice but to remove them. Now he was fighting alone.

"In the past, malicious clients have placed newcomers in the room to drive up prices. They had no ability to pay, but affected the fairness of the auction." The manager spoke patiently. "You only need to demonstrate your ability to pay, for example by providing us with another account."

"Two million is only my account balance." Lu Mingfei did his best to avoid the man's gaze.

The manager smiled and opened the briefcase. Unfolded, it became an electronic device with a red LCD screen and black keyboard, like an enormous calculator.

"Please enter the password for your Zurich bank account." He pushed the case toward Lu Mingfei.

Lu Mingfei couldn't refuse. With stiff fingers he pressed the keys; Anjou had given him the password. A few seconds later the screen displayed "$2,000,000.00." He stared blankly at the number that had once seemed a vast fortune, but heard quiet, derisive laughter. At this feast of dragons, the sum was insignificant.

"We have considerable access at the Zurich bank and can check your balance. It really is only two million dollars." The manager smiled.

Laugh, laugh. These people had been laughing at him ever since he got out of the car, until he no longer knew what to do with his hands and feet. Lu Mingfei lowered his head like a suspect being questioned.

In the opera-house hall, guests murmured to one another, voices rising and falling.

Someone cleared her throat in the box on the right. Even that sound was seductive, and everyone looked up together.

"When the auction resumes, my next bid will be fifty million." Every word from Number 88 was as heavy as a gold bar.

The auctioneer was dumbfounded. Was this a declaration of war? Was the veiled girl's fighting spirit so fierce she wouldn't even wait for the auction to resume before bidding? She was no longer a queen; she was an army at the gates!

"Number eighty-eight says she'll raise it to fifty million!" Another assistant hurried into the finance office and whispered to the manager.

"Did you hear right? Fifty million?" The manager stared, lowering his own voice. "There's nobody left bidding against her!"

"Who says there isn't?" Lu Mingfei slowly raised his head.

The manager frowned. "Sir, unless you can provide a new account with funds to prove yourself..."

Lu Mingfei looked at the balding man. Did hybrids go bald too? He looked like a washed-up middle-aged loser. A man who admitted defeat... would become a useless middle-aged uncle like that!

That little fire in his heart was so annoying... burning slowly.

"I really hate the way you look at me. It's like my high-school teacher reading my grades aloud to the whole class," Lu Mingfei said. "And I hate the way you all laugh. Let me enter the password again."

The strange characters shone in his mind. "Show me the money": that cheat code would bring him ten thousand dollars, but he needed more, far more. He had no way out. If he retreated, he'd lose, and he couldn't bear it. As if possessed, he added "×10000" after the code. Ten thousand times: he would borrow a hundred million!

He tapped the confirmation key and pushed the remote device connected directly to the Zurich bank back to the manager. Crossing his legs, he smoked the Cohiba cigar, which had looked like a ridiculous grilled sausage between his fingers moments ago.

"What?" The manager smiled. "Still two million..."

He stopped suddenly, the tail of his words twisting. The number had begun to change, leaping rapidly like ultraviolet readings from the sky during a solar flare. Every digit rolled—no, flashed! Had the device used old-fashioned numerical wheels instead of an LCD, their furious rotation would have thrown sparks.

The manager involuntarily reached out to slap the device. Either it had gone mad or his eyes were wrong. A vast flood of money was pouring into this unknown boy's account.

At last the number settled at "$10,200,000.00." In ten seconds, a hundred million dollars had poured into the account!

Lu Mingfei tilted his head back and drew a deep breath, as though he would take all the air in the world into his lungs. Then he exhaled softly. "One hundred million."

"Yes... your account... has increased by a hundred million." The manager stammered.

"I can see that. What I mean is, when the auction resumes, I'll bid a hundred million dollars. I like to show my hand," Lu Mingfei said evenly. "Competitive bidding is too tedious; it wastes everyone's time. I think this set is worth a hundred million, so that's what I'll offer. There's no need to economize on something I want. If anyone bids higher, I'll let it go."

"All right, I'm going to the restroom. Take care of this. You have my authorization; this paddle is now worth a hundred million." Lu Mingfei tossed number 17 in front of the manager, stood, and went out.

The auctioneer was back onstage, his voice trembling, eyes bright. "The auction is now resumed. We have received authorization from the lady with number eighty-eight to bid fifty million, and authorization from Mr. Lu, number seventeen, to bid... one hundred million."

Silence filled the hall. Everyone watched the box on the right, waiting for Number 88. The price had become utterly insane; nobody else wanted to join this contest between madmen. Whether Number 88 would fight back was the only uncertainty.

"One hundred million dollars, going once." The auctioneer raised his hammer.

"One hundred million dollars, going twice..."

The veiled girl stood, turned without a word, and left. Suddenly she discarded the set as though it were worthless.

"Sold for one hundred million dollars!" As she walked out of the hall, the auctioneer brought down the hammer as if driving a nail hard into wood.

In the lounge outside the opera-house hall, Lu Mingfei paced in circles, thinking. The once-magnificent cigar had become a grilled sausage again between his limp fingers, seemingly a little wilted itself.

He tried to recall what had happened. For an instant an exhilarating force had surged through him, like a martial-arts master unleashing power from his dantian, or someone who had just eaten a bowl of hot, spicy tofu pudding. He had stopped caring about anything, overflowing with heroic passion and grand words. As he tossed out the paddle and that hundred million, he had been full of thoughts like, What's a hundred million to a magnificent fellow like me? I'm the man who will shatter heaven! Like a Hong Kong comic hero bursting with power and shouting, "You useless fool, don't think your Hell King's World-Splitting Fist lets you rule the world! Dare you face my hundred-thousand-horsepower Star-Shattering Divine Sword?"

Only when he happily relieved himself in the restroom did that domineering spirit flow away with his urine. He suddenly came to his senses, and his entire body went cold.

A hundred million... Holy crap, he'd actually spent a hundred million without the principal's authorization. He had thrown away a hundred million for something as insubstantial as a surge of bravado?

Had he gone mad, or just awakened from a dream? His memory tangled for a moment as he stood blankly before the urinal.

"Hey, friend, you're already finished..." a man beside him reminded him kindly.

"Can't I savor the moment?" Lu Mingfei snapped.

But after leaving the restroom he didn't dare enter the hall. He only hoped everything had been an illusion, that nothing had happened, that he hadn't spent a hundred million, that he had merely stepped out to use the restroom and after a short rest everything would return to normal.

High heels clicked crisply against the floor.

"Mr. Lu," someone said behind him.

He spun around. The veiled Number 88 stood only a foot behind him, her eyes cold, the alluring crimson at their corners touched with menace. Lu Mingfei hopped back, nearly blurting, Let's talk this out! I didn't mean to make trouble; gentlemen use words, not fists! Her fierce aura always made him feel she might draw an Arabian scimitar from beneath her robe at any moment.

"A fine display of nerve with that final bid. I liked the blades too, but I don't have Mr. Lu's resources, so I had to let them go." The girl actually smiled.

She leaned forward slightly and did something wonderful beyond Lu Mingfei's imagining: she kissed him lightly on the cheek! A girl's warm body heat and faint floral fragrance enveloped him.

Huh? Was this the first time a girl had kissed him? What unscrupulous person had stolen his first kiss like that? Did she have no conscience or morals? If she was going to kiss him, why not on the mouth? Why not warn him so he could prepare? If possible, he'd really hoped to make the first move himself... Countless voices echoed in his head. The whole world blurred before his eyes. Were shining red hearts rising above his head?

"You're handsome, young man... Hear the applause? They're applauding you. Perhaps one day... the whole world will applaud you." The girl brushed past the motionless Lu Mingfei.

Applause poured from the opera-house hall like a surging tide.

A Bordeaux-red Cadillac DTS waited at the opera house's rear entrance, a Japanese flag mounted on its side. The veiled girl went straight to it and sped away.

"Wait, madam! Please wait!" The auctioneer's assistant rushed out of the opera house, only to see the DTS disappearing into the distance.

"Why didn't you stop her? Didn't I call you?" The assistant turned on the silent attendant, furious.

"It's a Japanese embassy car. Under diplomatic custom, even an embassy car flies the flag only when the ambassador or consul is aboard or when on official business," the attendant said quietly. "She has powerful backing. It wouldn't be easy to stop her."

The assistant paused and nodded slightly. "She's a new face. Did you check who sponsored her?"

"The Mint Club. We couldn't find anything more."

"More and more new faces, and they're playing more and more extravagantly." The assistant murmured, "It's unsettling..."

A partition separated the DTS's front and rear seats, and black privacy glass shut out outside eyes. On the broad sofa seat, the veiled girl curled into a ball and wriggled out of the spacious robe like a rabbit. All her bones seemed soft, every joint able to turn like a universal coupling. Only a rigorously trained yoga practitioner, contortionist, or... Japanese ninja could do that. She stretched her figure with pride. Hiding something so good beneath an Arabian robe was depressing.

The clothes she liked had been prepared: black leather top and pants, a wine-red short jacket, and red lace-up sandals with three-inch heels. Even with help, such an extremely fashionable outfit would take several minutes to put on, but for a ninja it was as easy as a hermit crab slipping into a shell. Mai Sakatoku removed the golden veil, revealing a breathtakingly beautiful face, the bright blush lending her a touch of ferocity.

A woman who always carried two ninja swords in her bag could never look harmless, however she wore her makeup. Her striking figure was even more conspicuous than her face, so she had to wrap herself from head to toe in a robe.

"As you said, a hundred million." Reclining in the seat, she crossed her long legs and connected the car phone.

"Beautifully done. I can already see a hundred million dollars added to the account. Subtracting the salvage expenses, our net profit is ninety-eight point six million. Cassell College is rich; they only need a few dozen seconds to move that much cash." Chips could be heard crunching on the other end.

"Their Board of Trustees is richer. Those people control trusts and syndicates; even a billion is no problem. Aren't you worried about getting fat, eating chips all the time?"

"I don't have your figure, so I won't be so demanding. As long as Levi's doesn't suggest the loose fit when I try on jeans, I'm happy." Chips Girl was as carefree as ever.

"A woman worth that much still wears Levi's... Why pretend to be the girl next door?" Mai Sakatoku muttered. She frequented luxury boutiques, happily dividing her time off between shopping, parties, and ninja training that involved hanging from a roof by two fingers...

"Miss High-and-Mighty, without all my hard work, how would you lot live so well?"

"Tell me, wasn't a hundred million too cheap for the Seven Deadly Sins? A treasure forged by the King of Bronze and Fire himself, deadly blades capable of killing the other Dragon Kings. There'll never be another set in the world."

"Can't be helped. The strongest weapons need the strongest wielder; they're no use to us. Would you risk being consumed by them? When their 'Crime and Punishment' domain expands to its limit, people of our bloodline can't even touch the hilts, can we? Actually, as long as they return to Lu Mingfei's hands, I'd gladly give them away, never mind paying the one-point-four-million salvage fee ourselves! But a gift would make Anjou suspicious, so we charged him a hundred million to help with household expenses... The economy's bad lately..." Chips Girl began rambling.

"You sound like a bookkeeper! No, a maid who keeps the accounts."

"What do you think my role is? I'm an accounting maid!" Chips Girl sounded aggrieved. "Besides me, who among you can be relied on? Managing this whole operation isn't easy. Thousands of mouths

to feed! You and that cold-faced girl know nothing about saving. Every mission you're like vandals, sweeping through and wrecking everything. The compensation bills afterward are terrifying..."

"Shut up, shut up!" Mai dreaded this routine more than anything. "Has the boss contacted you lately?"

"Once."

"What about?" Mai grew serious.

Her boss was elusive. Usually the woman who always had chips in her mouth managed the organization's affairs single-handedly; only on matters of exceptional importance did the boss give orders personally, and every time the move was fierce, overwhelming, and violent.

"Do you know a company called Square Enix?"

"Obviously. Square, Japan's most famous game-software company, known for Final Fantasy. It's practically the national company of Japanese gaming obsessives, and I'm Japanese." Mai was a loyal Square player herself, fond of the Valkyrie Profile series, and had completed every installment with every item.

"They recently released their newest title, Final Fantasy XIV, but the reviews were terrible. Longtime players reacted strongly. One posted passionately on the official forum: 'Final Fantasy XIV no longer appeals to me at all. The people making games have lost their way, so there's no reason for me to keep my eighty-five million dollars in Square Enix stock. I've decided to sell.' Just as everyone was laughing and assuming it was a joke, news came that the share price had instantly fallen 0.15 percent," Chips Girl said lazily.

"Hey, your train of thought has wandered way too far. Is this what you Chinese call a 'god-tier plot twist'?"

"I posted it using the boss's ID, then sold all eighty-five million dollars of his Square Enix shares on the Tokyo Stock Exchange within fifteen seconds." The other woman hung up.

Mai stared at the receiver's busy signal... It sounded like something out of a fantasy, but it was certainly the boss's style—that supremely powerful, supremely violent... gaming nerd.